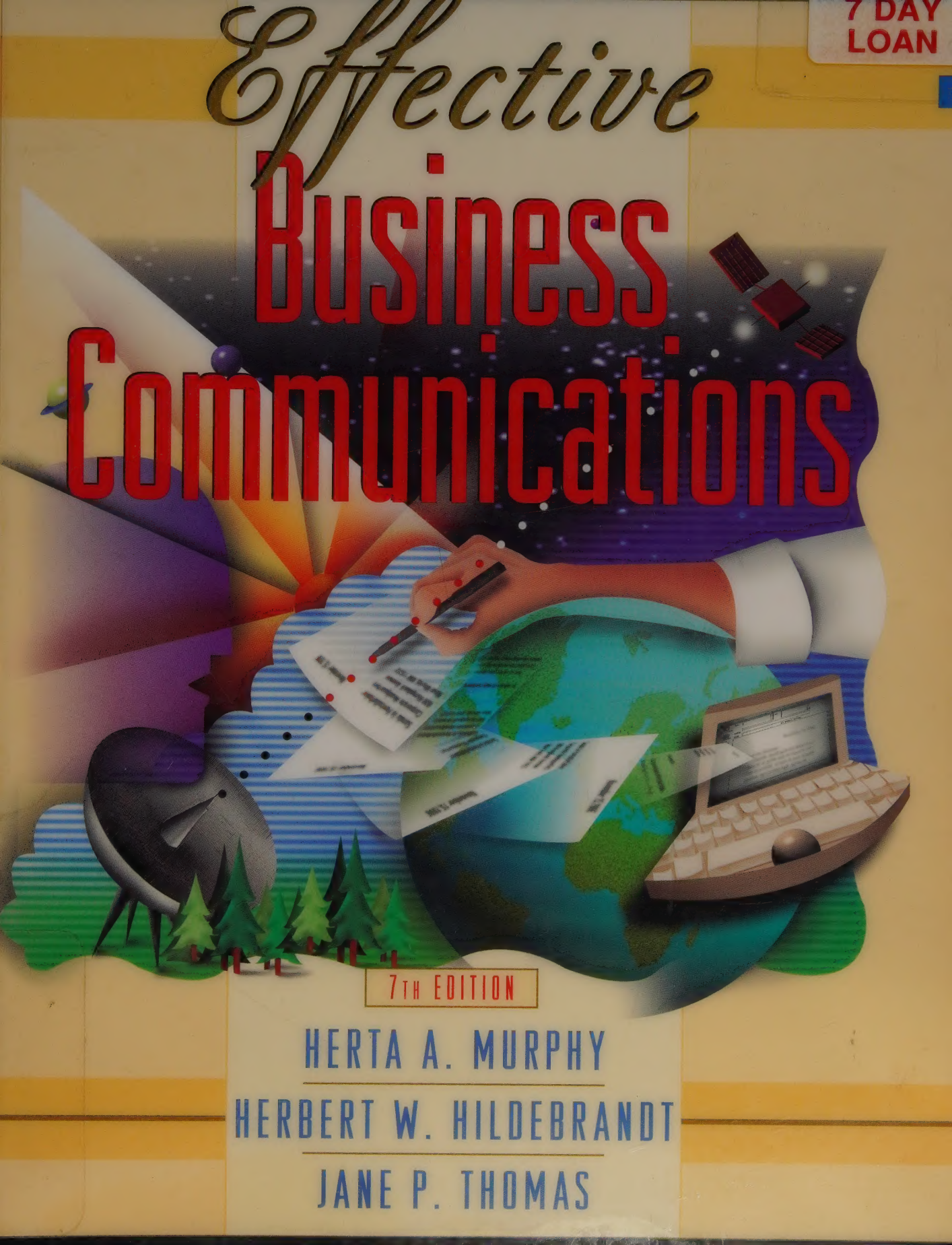


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7TH EDITION

HERTA A. MURPHY
HERBERT W. HILDEBRANDT
JANE P. THOMAS

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Effective

Business

Communications

Effective **Business Communications**

7TH EDITION

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To my husband, Gene,
with love and remembrance
—H. M.

To my wife, Dee
—H. H.

To my husband, Hugh
—J. T.

Preface

Pick up any newspaper, read scholarly research studies, look at personnel want ads; invariably the term *communication* is used. Thus this seventh edition continues the main thrust of the past six editions: Managers and executives—indeed, all employees of organizations—must possess excellence in written and oral communication. Our term for communication in the business world is *business communication*; that is, we are concerned with the movement of ideas via either the written or oral word, in both for-profit or nonprofit organizations.

This book seeks to develop communication skills needed by those preparing for, or who are already in, a business or management position. The seventh edition strengthens the research orientation and solid academic base of the previous editions. This fact, along with the authors' combined total of more than 75 years of teaching undergraduate, graduate, and executive students at major American and foreign universities, means that extensive pragmatic teaching in the classroom adds to the academic base.

We maintained flexibility in the text; it can be adapted to either a one- or two-semester or a quarter-length course at both two- and four-year colleges and universities. Additionally, we have used the book in many continuing education and executive programs in the United States and abroad. Finally, *Effective Business Communications* has proved valuable as a handy reference guide long after the course has been completed.

NEW MATERIALS AND CHANGES

- **This textbook is more than 200 pages shorter than previous editions.** Accomplishing that task was not easy because both authors and readers become quite comfortable with familiar examples and topics. Regardless, we omitted repetitious explanations but retained and added new examples; decreased theoretical underpinnings but kept pragmatic advice; combined related topics and replaced long illustrations with shorter examples; omitted involved research discussions and inserted concise Communication Probes.
- **We omitted the obvious, shortened the familiar.** All the core business topics of the past six editions are there; they are simply in brief form, along with concise research probes and more checklists, the latter to verify that students have adequately covered the topic. Even long-used exercises have been omitted from the text, but these tested and true exercises are folded into the *Instructor's Manual*.

- **We are in paperback.** When the three authors were in school, they too had to purchase textbooks for classroom use while on a limited budget. This edition is less expensive than a hardcover book.
- **Communication Probes.** To acknowledge the source of related information, numerous research Communication Probes are included in each chapter, rather than an inordinate number of footnotes. These probes are succinct summaries of research statements relating to communication issues discussed within the chapter. Scholarly journals are the dominate source of these statements, but pragmatic and popular business-related journals are also cited.

We underpin many pragmatic suggestions with research-oriented statements. Perceptive readers will quickly see that the 1960s and 1970s were the heyday for much communication research; we recognize that fact, but we also added recent communication studies that are new or are built upon previously completed efforts.

- **New Chapters.** *Chapter 4, "Business Communication and the Ethical Context."* One cannot avoid the term *ethics* in the business world: Newspapers report daily on unethical activity; at annual meetings stockholders raise questions that challenge company policies; and foreign governments scrutinize the behavior of nondomestic firms. Thus one chapter is devoted to ethical concerns, focusing on backgrounds to ethical contexts, influences on personal ethics, and communication and ethical issues.

Chapter 5, "Business Communication and the Technology Context." Three-year-olds play games on their computers. High school students—and students even younger—surf the Internet. Dual telephone lines (fax and phone) are hooked to many American homes. Instant worldwide communication is common. Interviews are conducted via computer. CD-ROMs make data instantly available. Communicating via satellite is the norm. All these tools recognize that students, and the world of business, increasingly depend on linking technology with central business communication principles. Thus Chapter 5 merges technology with both internal and external communication. We touch the future but do not omit the past.

- **New Appendix.** *Appendix A, "Visual Aids in Business Communication."* Visuals are so dominant in both written and oral communication that an entire appendix is devoted to their discussion. Increasingly, boards of directors demand consistency in all visuals; managers demand that reports avoid drab black and white visuals that contain no color; instructors demand that the familiar three visual categories of pie charts, bar graphs, and line graphs no longer be options in business communication but mandatory. Long columns and rows of figures can be made more vivid. Appendix A suggests ways in which to add vividness to either oral or written business communication.
- **International Examples.** Business is no longer insular. It is not limited to the continental United States, nor are employees or you as a potential executive confined to domestic concerns. Thus, about a third of our examples are from outside the United States. Because one of the authors lived nearly 20 summers in Asia and because that part of the world is turning eagerly to capitalism, many foreign examples are from Asia. But those examples are not relevant to Asia alone; they are applicable to other sections of the world as well.

- **Sidenotes.** Whereas the Communication Probes are research-oriented statements embedded in the text, the sidenotes in the margins are brief summary statements that isolate significant points in the text that should not be ignored. Occasionally we draw an inference or offer an opinion: to reinforce the statements in the text, and possibly show our bias.
- **Exercises and Problems.** Every chapter's exercises begin with two questions demanding an international awareness. As businesses become more global, students—and instructors—must become familiar with differences and similarities in culture and global business communication. We often link the frequent in-class foreign students (with their own communication perceptions) with native class members. Both groups learn from the assignments; both learn about each other's culture; both improve their current and future communication skills as they begin jobs in global corporations. All the exercises are based on the instructors' involvement in or awareness of the international business environment.

Long-time users of previous editions are adamant that we retain “old chestnut” exercises. We did remove some from this edition, but those we moved—along with our suggested responses—to our new *Instructor's Manual*. This compromise allowed us to add many new examples and exercises yet keep popular questions from previous editions.

- **Streamlined Prose.** Each chapter that was retained from the sixth edition was rewritten for the seventh. As stated earlier, this book is 200-plus pages shorter than previous editions, yet it includes the core of business communication principles. The authors, and other instructors, often supplement those central ideas by turning to innumerable other articles and research studies that relate to the topics in this text. That is the intent behind our more concise writing: to lay the foundation for effective business communication. Then through Communication Probes, new examples and illustrations, new topics, and an increased emphasis on international issues, students and instructors can supplement the information provided here.

SPECIAL LEARNING FEATURES AND BENEFITS

Principles of the Seven C's

No one knows the original source of the seven Cs; emphasis on these principles of completeness, conciseness, consideration, concreteness, clearness, courteousness, and correctness is present in the works of Greek and Roman writers and affirmed in the Renaissance. We simply—as in the previous six editions—continue to give the principles luster, in mnemonic form, to guide readers in choosing the content and style of presentation adapted to the purpose and recipient of each message.

Examples

Exemplary pedagogy moves on the wheels of good examples. As we mentioned, at least a third of the examples are international in nature. More than 400 examples are directly from actual business and professional organizations. Classroom-

tested, the examples have benefited from comments received from thousands of students and instructors over the years.

Checklists

Previous editions were known for their usable and workable checklists. In this seventh edition, Chapters 8, 9, and 10 have detailed capsule checklists; Chapter 7 is an entire chapter of examples acting as visual checklist; and all other chapters have checklists embedded within. In fact, each checklist lets readers review their progress, their homework, or even their understanding of the text. More than 100 checklists are now part of the text.

Cases

Most chapters include minicases—some people call them incidents—and problems that quickly lend themselves to in-class analysis and impromptu evaluations via either written or oral assignments. We continue the tradition of including as many real instances as possible, omitting of course any reference to identifiable companies or individuals.

Visuals

With today's PC software for graphics, it is a simple task to include illustrations, graphs, charts, and tables to enhance prose and text discussion of a report or oral presentation. Whenever we could visually enhance our prose, we did so, even including an entire appendix devoted to visuals.

References and Explanatory Notes

Previous editions included numerous source citations as further support for the text discussion. We omitted many of these citations in this edition, except in Chapter 4, "Business Communication and the Ethical Context," which depends heavily on outside examples and citations. Only when necessary is a citation included to which either the student or the instructor can turn for additional reading. We used a modified version of the American Psychological Association (APA) citation format.

Outlines and Summaries

We live in a visual world. Thus, each chapter opens with an outline of the main topics followed by our traditional **PAL**: *P*orch (*brief opening remarks*), *A*im (*core purpose of the chapter*), and *L*ayout (*major topic divisions of the chapter*). A summary of the most important concepts discussed ends each chapter.

Databases

Technology's footprint is obvious in this seventh edition. No longer can anyone avoid the increasing use of databases in law, the social sciences, business, and a host of other areas. References to CD-ROMs and the proliferating visual world

of information are included where appropriate. Our intent is to awaken students and encourage them to pursue the increasing numbers of electronic sources—as supplements to this text—useful for well-documented written or oral forms of business communication.

Appendixes

Positioning the following topics in the appendixes does not diminish their importance; it stresses their centrality in business communication:

- Appendix A, “Visual Aids in Business Communication,” focuses on six common forms of visual support: outline charts, tables, bar graphs, pie charts, line graphs, and area graphs, along with examples of each.
- Appendix B, “Grammar, Punctuation, and Style,” includes more than 60 examples that illustrate the common mechanical problems facing communicators.
- Appendix C, “Business Communication and Legal Issues,” looks at five areas each businessperson will face in the future: defamation; invasion of privacy; misrepresentation and fraud; laws regarding employment, credit, and collections; and copyrights and computer data security.

SUPPLEMENTS

Instructor's Manual

To help fellow teachers do a better job of instructing, the *Instructor's Manual* includes our suggestions, comments, and assistance for each chapter:

- Background information, including possible course content and organization; suggestions for conducting various courses using this textbook; longer, unique cases with simulation exercises.
- Possible answers and suggestions for each of the exercises, problems, and cases in the text chapters.
- Transparency masters. Some illustrate significant text concepts; others extend the textual material; several display possible answers to chapter exercises and problems.

Microsoft PowerPoint™ for Checklists

Each of the shorter checklists (all those but the longer capsule checklists in Chapters 8, 9, and 10) is available on a disk for instructors to project via computer. We found in our classes that each checklist is a superior discussion starter.

Test Bank

A test bank is available, prepared by Betty Pritchett of Kennesaw State University. Each chapter contains a variety of questions, with answers.

Computerized Test Bank

The test bank is also available in Microtest III™, a computerized test-preparation system in DOS, Windows, and Macintosh platforms.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

No one writes alone. Over many years unnamed students and fellow instructors have given advice—often with firmness—about many issues covered in the book. To these people we are grateful.

Foremost, the two senior authors—Herta Murphy and Herb Hildebrandt—welcome Jane Thomas, our junior coauthor. Her long hours and dedication and justifiable demands for rewrites and amendments are obvious throughout the book. Jane is a distinguished teacher and Director of the BBA writing program at the University of Michigan Business School.

Initial reviewers were exceptionally thorough, and we tried to meet all their expectations and demands. Our appreciation is extended to each of the following reviewers:

J. Doug Andrews, University of South California
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Three secretaries especially deserve our thanks. Joanne Ripple of the University of Michigan Business School has for many years made sense out of poorly formatted disks and visuals for Herb Hildebrandt; Margaret Oberle and Marilyn Bernhardt, also of the Business School, exerted efforts for Jane Thomas far beyond the usual. Michelle Chiu and Carla LaPointe of the Business School also offered additional help. To all, we are sincerely grateful.

McGraw-Hill has been our publisher since 1972, which is a lengthy relationship. We would like to acknowledge the efforts of Bonnie Binkert, former senior editor, as our motivator and inspiration who got us going on this seventh edition. Her insights over the years are not overlooked. Our new editor, Karen Westover, continues the tradition of able adviser. To her, and the many other staff members of McGraw-Hill, we are grateful.

To Mary Farrell, a not-behind-the-scenes copyeditor, we also owe much appreciation. Her semantic and grammatical hoe forced us to cultivate the words we planted in the text. We may not be entirely weed-free, but if there are any unwelcome plants, the fault is with the original gardeners, the authors.

With consummate sincerity we continue to affectionately dedicate this book to three persons who endured out of love our affairs with modern office technol-

ogy, and the seemingly endless hours staring into a computer screen. Sadly, Gene Murphy recently died, and so we honor him in remembrance.

Our public dedication is to our students: They—you—are the future. We give you our support, our affection, our wish for you to be successful in written and oral communication.

Herta A. Murphy
Herbert W. Hildebrandt
Jane P. Thomas

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If you can communicate effectively in speaking and writing, you have a highly valued skill. In numerous surveys, business executives rank the ability to communicate first among the personal factors necessary for promotion.

Communicating effectively in speaking and writing extends across all areas of business, including management, technical, clerical, and social positions. And now in the nineties, the phenomenal growth of internal trade creates the need for you to also understand intercultural communication—the ability to speak and write in ways that are sensitive to and cognizant of the factors in different cultural contexts.

This chapter discusses the importance and benefits of effective communication to you and to your organization. It also reviews the basic components of a message, including concepts and problems in communicating and facets of non-verbal communication. The need for greater cultural sensitivity and knowledge of international issues is also stressed.

IMPORTANCE AND BENEFITS OF EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

The ability to communicate well has always provided advantages to those who possess it. Communication has a rich history, and its traditions can still be seen in modern-day communication concepts.

Ancient Heritage for Communication Principles

Western principles of communication developed in ancient Greece and Rome, with an emphasis on oral rhetorical traditions.

The ancient world, both the East and the West, depended heavily on oral communication. For example, in ancient Greece and Rome, it was necessary to communicate well on one's feet when dealing with matters in government assemblies and the law courts. During the Medieval and Renaissance periods, the oral tradition continued. As writing became more important as a permanent record of communication, authors and books on written communication principles appeared.

Communication principles originating in the East, particularly China, are based on and connected with the importance of bureaucratic traditions. For centuries, Chinese political theorists were concerned with the problems of communicating within the vast government bureaucracy as well as between the government and the people. As early as the fourth century, these theorists were advising rulers and government officials. Their advice stated that information should flow smoothly upward and downward. The theorists also encouraged rulers and officials to minimize bias and falsification of sources and to resist the influence of cliques and opportunists.¹

Hence, some of today's principles of writing are founded on a mixture of ancient oral and written traditions. Business communication is one offshoot from an earlier world where communicating well was a foundation of learning.

"Lifeblood" of Every Organization

Organizations cannot function without open and effective communication.

An *organization* is a group of people associated for business, political, professional, religious, athletic, social, or other purposes. Its activities require human beings to interact and react, that is, to communicate. They exchange informa-

■ Communication Probe

Many language historians believe that writing developed as a means of communicating business matters. Archaeological evidence shows numerals and letters written on products and goods traded by ancient tribes, and for centuries, writing appears to be limited to commercial and administrative concerns. Wills from England and Europe during the Middle Ages list few books of literature. Even Bibles, psalters, and religious books are rare. Business accounts from that period, however, are common and are the basis of much of our historical knowledge. Although some researchers believe that priests first developed writing, many others think that merchants were the first to use written symbols because of the necessities of trade and keeping accounts. Historical studies of literacy have often ignored the role played by merchants and others involved in the development of commerce.

Gorlach, M. (1991). *Introduction to Early Modern English*. Cambridge and New York: Cambridge University Press. Pyles, T. (1982). *The origins and development of the English language* (3rd ed). New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich; Thomas, J. (1994). *The language of the Celts* (pp. 175–200). Dissertation, University of Michigan; Ann Arbor.

tion, ideas, plans; order needed supplies; make decisions, rules, proposals, contracts, and agreements. Communication is the “lifeblood” of every organization.

Because this book is concerned primarily with effective *business* communication, the discussions and illustrations you will read focus mainly on business messages. However, you can apply these principles to other organizations, to the professions, and to your personal communications.

Internal Communication

A vital means of attending to company concerns is through effective internal communication—*downward*, *upward*, and *horizontal*. It helps increase job satisfaction, safety, productivity, and profits and decreases absenteeism, grievances, and turnover.

When employees receive appropriate *downward* communication from management, they can be better motivated and more efficient. They need not only clear job directions and safety rules but also facts about organizational strategy, products, and viewpoints on important controversial issues. They are concerned about employee benefits—health care, insurance, promotions, pensions, training, work environment, retirement. In all, the many pressures from employees force employers to be accountable for their decisions through effective downward communication. Employers who communicate effectively have more productive employees.

Likewise, *upward* internal communication has become increasingly more significant. Many executives sincerely seek frank comments from employees, in addition to the usual periodic reports. Successful managers listen closely to opin-

ions, complaints, problems, and suggestions, especially when these are clearly and effectively stated. As a response to increasing global competition, some companies are developing new management styles, which make input from employees an integral part of important decisions affecting the company.

Effective *horizontal* communication between peers is also essential in organizations in order to solve problems, perform job duties, prepare for meetings, and cooperate on important projects. For example, if you think about the time spent listening to and making requests, writing notes and memos, and discussing and writing about projects, you soon realize that communication is the medium through which an organization accomplishes its goals.

Among various ways of communicating within companies are memos, reports, meetings, face-to-face discussions, teleconferences, video conferences, and electronic mail. This book includes suggestions that may be applied to these communications.

External Communication

Messages to persons outside the company can have a far-reaching effect on its reputation and ultimate success. The right letter, proposal, report, telephone call, or personal conversation can win back a disgruntled customer, create a desire for a firm's product or service, help negotiate a profitable sale, encourage collections, motivate performance, and in general, create goodwill.

Furthermore, communications to the *public* regarding social accountability have become significantly more important during the past two decades. Because of demands by many special interest groups (labor unions, environmental groups, government agencies, political action committees, and others), the media, business organizations, and political groups are seriously concerned about enhancing their public image. Important are well-planned public speeches, tactful replies to comments and criticisms, free informative pamphlets, annual reports, 10-K reports, and image-building interviews with the news media. All these messages should be transmitted with an emphasis on honesty, openness, and concern for the public.²

Overall Communication Costs

In multinational corporations, thousands of hours are devoted daily to interviews, conferences, memos, reports, employee manuals, letters, advertising, new articles, bulletins, newsletters, and other messages. Time is the chief element in the overall cost of written and oral communications. For example, the time spent just in written tasks can occupy much of the working day. In a survey of four professional areas, a substantial number of respondents, none of whom was employed as a writer, indicated that they spent from 29 to more than 50 percent of their time writing.³

Managers	Technical Workers	Clerical Staff	Social Service Workers
49.4%	40.7%	29.1%	51.6%

Among other costs of communication in organizations are materials (stationery, office supplies, postage, computer disks, software), equipment, and fixed

Effective communication to people outside the organization can help create a good reputation and have a positive impact on its ultimate success.

Time is a major factor in overall communication costs.

Poor communication can cost an organization time and money.

charges, such as heat, rent, light, and depreciation. Important developments and adaptations of office technology, such as computers, electronic mail, and video conferences can help in various ways to reduce the time and costs of communicating efficiently.

Consider also the wasteful cost of unclear, incomplete, inaccurate, inconsiderate, and unduly long or late communications. Ineffective messages that alienate customers are more expensive than effective ones because they destroy goodwill. Poor messages often require several additional messages. Furthermore, in fields such as aviation, construction, medicine, mining, oil drilling, and others, poor instructions can result in loss of life and loss of money.

Benefits of Effective Communication in Your Career

Your job, promotion, and professional reputation often depend on doing well in written and oral communication. Also, your ability to communicate effectively is a valuable asset for many activities in your personal life.

A Valuable Job Requirement

If your career requires mainly mental rather than manual labor, your progress will be strongly influenced by how effectively you communicate your knowledge, proposals, and ideas to others who need or should receive them.

Strong communication skills were found in the job descriptions listed by numerous companies advertising positions. For example, Francis W. Weeks, executive director emeritus of the Association for Business Communication,⁴ found in a 6-year study of job listings at the University of Illinois Coordinating Placement Office that 340 jobs in 30 fields required communication ability. In addition, Vanessa Dean Arnold's analysis of communication requirements listed in the job descriptions of only one issue of the *National Business Employment Weekly*, a publication of the *Wall Street Journal*, found that of 120 listings, 85 emphasized communication skills and described the specific skills needed.⁵ Among the job descriptions found in this study were requirements like the following:

Job Title	Communication Skills
Finance Associate	Must be able to communicate clearly to clients and other finance professionals
Fiscal Officer	Superior writing and presentation skills
Product Manager	Develop and communicate product objectives and strategies
Senior Sales Representative	Excellent communication and follow-up skills; ability to write proposals and quotations
Contracts Administrator	General knowledge of proposal preparation: good oral/written communication skills

Communication is a primary responsibility in many careers, such as customer relations, labor relations, marketing, personnel, public relations, sales, and

Communication is a major responsibility in many areas, including government and nonprofit organizations.

teaching. Also, technical and scientific fields need editors, producers, researchers, and writers. Advancement can be made to management, research, training, and consulting positions.

Communication skills play a major role in congressional and senatorial offices at the state and national level. For instance, some senators in Washington, from their chiefs of staff on down, have in excess of 60 people handling correspondence, preparing speeches, meeting with constituents, assisting with fundraising, helping write legislation, communicating with business. Other governmental departments are equally full-staffed to handle communication issues, each department seeking to communicate clearly internally and externally. Searching for competent communication people to decrease fuzzy double-talk from government offices is ongoing. As you know, government is the country's biggest business.

Even if your work is mainly with figures, as in the accounting profession, the ability to communicate to those who read your financial reports is essential. The *Journal of Accountancy*, in a study cited in *Horizons for a Profession*, emphasized the importance of writing. A group of accountants who were considered the “most knowledgeable and forward-looking segment of the accounting profession” ranked 53 subjects that a beginning CPA should be familiar with. First place went indisputably to written and oral English—even over accounting theory and practice!⁶ In addition, a study done by Hiemstra, Schmidt, and Madison in the December 1990 *Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication* showed that the Certified Management Accountants surveyed believe that the importance of communication skills has increased significantly since they first began their accounting careers.⁷ The federal government's Defense Contract Audit Agency (DCAA) has a two-volume manual that accountants must follow in auditing government contracts. While instructions are detailed as to which material should be audited, one chapter is devoted entirely to writing.⁸

An Essential for Promotion

The prime requisite of a promotable executive is “ability to communicate.” Notice that it is at the top of the mountain in Figure 1.1. Too often those who cannot communicate effectively in either oral or written communications remain “buried” in lower, dead-end jobs. Members of management spend 60 to 90 percent of their working days communicating—speaking, writing, and listening.

Over the past 40 years, many surveys and articles have confirmed the idea that effective communication is essential for success and promotion in business. They have included responses from thousands of top-level executives, middle managers, and university business graduates across the United States and in foreign countries. When the respondents were asked to answer the question “What has been the most valuable subject you studied in college?”, such titles as Business Communications, Business Letter and Report Writing, and Written and Oral Expression were consistently among the top three responses. Respondents, including top, middle, and operations managers, have repeatedly asserted that business communication skills significantly influenced their advancement to executive positions.⁹

Many people rate communication as one of the most important aspects of business leadership.

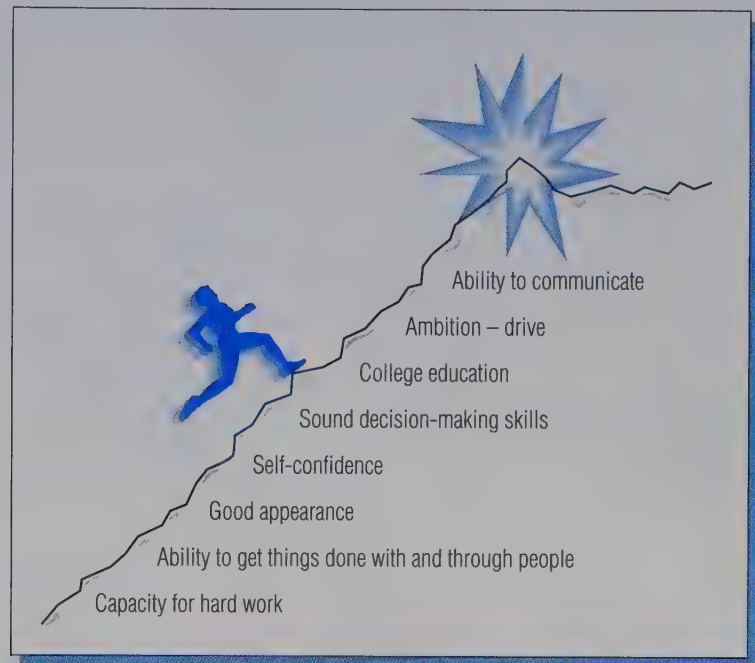


Figure 1.1 Requisites for a promotable executive.

Challenge of Communication in the Global Market

The way you communicate both within and outside your own country will affect everything you accomplish. Your ability to speak and write effectively will also make a difference to your organization. Developing the right attitude and

■ Communication Probe

Although many business students believe that a secretary will write most of their day-to-day documents for them, studies show that this is not the case. In a study of types of writing done by managers, respondents indicated that they wrote letters, memos, and short reports most frequently and that they, not their secretaries, did the actual writing.

In the same study, the managers indicated that they spent little time on the more formal, long reports. Information on how to prepare a formal, documented report is necessary, but this study suggests that instruction should focus on the more common, shorter documents. Many business schools now offer courses on memo and letter writing, emphasizing strategies for efficiency and effectiveness.

Kirtz, M. K., Reep, D. C. (1990). A survey of the frequency, types, and importance of writing tasks in four career areas. *Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication*, 8(4), 3.

preparing adequately are crucial to effective communication in the international marketplace. These qualities will help you to be effective in dealing with international business people outside your organization. In addition, becoming flexible in attitude and methods of communicating will help you to be effective in dealing with issues within your organization.

Developing the Right Attitude

“To the customer, you are the company.” This good advice comes from public relations experts. Your attitude when dealing with customers, clients, and the public reflect on the company you represent. When you deal with international business people, your attitude will reflect your country and your culture.

Your ability to communicate orally and in writing affects your company's public image.

You may realize that special and important communications can make millions of dollars of difference to your company. But you should also be aware that the daily routine messages are just as important. Each message communicates the essential quality and culture of your company and can either build goodwill or destroy it.

Doing an honest job enthusiastically and competently helps both the doer and the receiver. Answering even routine inquiries should and can be an interesting challenge. For example, an insurance company correspondent may often receive similar questions from policyholders who have lost their insurance policies. Though lost-policy cases are familiar to the insurance staff member, they certainly are not routine to the reader. Thus a good approach is to send a personalized, helpful message, sensitive to the reader's viewpoint.

Messages written to international clients, customers, suppliers, and other business contacts must be especially sensitive to audience concerns. Goodwill toward your organization is at stake as well as goodwill toward you as a representative of your country.

Preparing Adequately

Most people can learn to communicate effectively for business if they are willing to devote whatever effort is necessary to prepare themselves adequately. In addition to the proper goodwill-building attitude, the following qualities are desirable:

- Careful, sound judgment when choosing ideas and facts for each message
- Patience and understanding, even with unjustly insulting persons
- Integrity, backed up by a valid code of ethics
- Reasonable facility with the English language
- Applied knowledge of the communication process and principles and of successful methods for sending and receiving messages
- Knowledge of the cultural conventions of your audience

Becoming Flexible

Today's workplace is increasingly diverse in age, gender, and national origin. Diversity has brought problems to organizations, but it has also brought strengths. Changing demographics have contributed to changes in management styles,

making effective communication central to success in carrying out the organization's business.

Many companies now offer seminars or other kinds of classes in handling diversity issues in the workplace. Today's managers and workers need to be flexible in the way they deal with others; problems can be avoided by keeping an open mind and being willing to make extra efforts in communication.

One of the most sensitive issues is language. Although English currently appears to be the international language of business, many workers in U.S. companies do not speak English as their first language. Effective communication in organizations with a multinational workforce takes flexibility and an awareness of the important components of language use. These components involve the major issues of communication, including how to effectively address various audiences and how to choose effective communication channels and information. To focus on errors in speaking or writing standard English is to risk failure of your communication objectives.

COMPONENTS OF COMMUNICATION

Communication is a process of transmitting and receiving verbal and nonverbal messages. Communication is considered effective when it achieves the desired reaction or response from the receiver. Simply stated, communication is a two-way process of exchanging ideas or information.

Communication includes six components: context, sender-encoder, message, medium, receiver-decoder, and feedback. Figure 1.2 illustrates in part how these factors interact in the communication processes, affected by various contextual conditions and decisions.

Context

Every message, whether oral or written, begins with context. Context is a broad field that includes country, culture, organization, and external and internal stim-

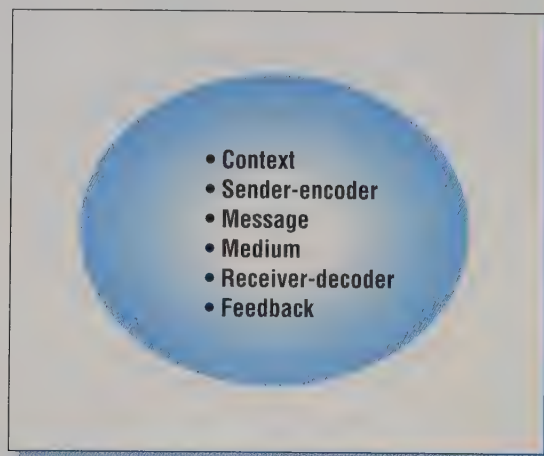


Figure 1.2 The components of communication.

uli. Every country, every culture, and every company or organization has its own conventions for processing and communicating information. This aspect of context is the playing field on which you must plan, design, and communicate your message successfully.

Another aspect of context is the external stimulus that prompts you to send a message. The source of this prompt may be a letter, memo, note, electronic mail, fax, telex, telephone call, a meeting, or even a casual conversation. Your response to this prompt may be oral or written.

Next, internal stimuli have a complex influence on how you translate ideas into a message. When you encode, your own view of the world affects the choices you make in language. Your attitudes, opinions, emotions, past experiences, likes and dislikes, education, job status, and confidence in your communication skills all influence the way you communicate your ideas. Especially important is your ability to analyze your receiver's culture, viewpoint, needs, skills, status, mental ability, experience, and expectations. You must consider all these aspects of context in order to communicate a message effectively.

Sender-Encoder

As a sender-encoder, you use symbols that express your message and create the desired response.

When you send a message, you are the “encoder,” the writer or speaker, depending on whether your message is written or oral. You try to choose symbols—usually words (and sometimes also graphics or pictures)—that express your message so that the receiver(s) will understand it and react with the response you desire. After considering all the factors mentioned above, you decide which symbols best convey your message and which message channel will be most effective among the oral and written media.

Message

You must first decide what the main point of your message is and what other information to include.

The message is the core idea you wish to communicate; it consists of both *verbal* (written or spoken) symbols and *nonverbal* (unspoken) symbols. Examples are discussed later in this chapter and others.

Your first task is to decide exactly *what* your message is and what content to include. You must consider your context and especially the receiver of your message—how the receiver will interpret it and how it may affect your relationship. A simple answer to a request for information may be relatively easy. In contrast, a message explaining why a company is moving some of its manufacturing to Mexico or a proposal to build a new headquarters for a governmental agency will require more complex, carefully planned communication strategies.

Medium

Your medium can be the printed word, electronic mail, or sound.

Your message channel depends on all the contextual factors discussed above and the nature of the message itself. Your choices include electronic mail, the printed word, or sound. Briefly, should you write or speak?

Like message content, the choice of medium is influenced by the relationship between the sender and the receiver. Some research suggests that the urgency of a message is a primary factor in whether to use the written or spoken medium. You may also consider factors such as importance, number of receivers, costs, and amount of information. If the message goes to an international audience, you must also consider which medium is preferred in the receiver's culture.

Based on research, the following describe some of the characteristics found in oral and written media:

Oral

Immediate feedback
Shorter sentences; shorter words
Conversational
Focus on interpersonal relations
Prompt action
Less detailed technical information
More personal pronouns
More colloquial language
Simpler constructions
More imperative, interrogative, and exclamatory sentences

Written

Delayed feedback
Longer sentences; longer words
More formal
Focus on content
Delayed action
More detailed technical information
Fewer personal pronouns
More complex constructions
Useful for permanent record; detailed documentation
Possibility of review

The written channel is often preferred when the message is long, technical, or formal in nature, and when the message must be documented. The oral channel is effective when the message is urgent or personal or when immediate feedback is important. These guidelines can change when your receiver is from another country. For example, in many countries in Europe and Asia, complex messages are often dealt with orally, with written documents provided only later, if necessary.

Inside Your Organization

Internal communication consists of sending messages inside your organization; external communication consists of sending messages outside your organization.

For internal communication, written media may be memos, reports, bulletins, job descriptions, posters, notes, employee manuals, electronic bulletin boards, even internal faxes. Oral communication may take the form of staff meeting reports, face-to-face discussions, presentations, audio tapes, telephone chats, teleconferences, or videotapes. Another oral channel, usually unplanned by the sender, is the “grapevine,” through which news and rumors travel quickly—often quite accurately.

Outside Your Organization

External written communication media may be letters, reports, proposals, telegrams, cablegrams, mailgrams, faxes, telexes, postcards, contracts, ads, brochures, catalogs, news releases, and a host of other things. You may also communicate orally in face-to-face discussions, by telephone, or by presentations in solo or panel situations. You may speak to groups in live presentations or through teleconferences, video conferences, or television.

Receiver-Decoder

The receiver-decoder is influenced by context and by his or her mental filter.

The message receiver is your reader or listener, also known as the *decoder*. Many of your messages may have more than one decoder.

As Figure 1.3 indicates, the receiver as well as the sender are influenced by the context and by the external and internal stimuli. Both receive messages through the eyes and ears but are also influenced by nonverbal factors such as

touch, taste, and smell. All factors of a message are filtered through the receiver(s) view of and experiences in the world.

But one problem is that we do not all undergo identical experiences with the subject or the symbols that the sender has chosen. Even within the United States, attitudes, abilities, opinions, communication skills, and cultural customs vary. Add another country into the communication process and the problems increase. Therefore, miscommunication can occur when personal biases and individual values cause the receiver to misinterpret the sender's intended message.

Feedback

Feedback can be an oral or a written message, an action, or simply silence.

Ultimately the receiver reacts with either the desired response based on a clear understanding of the symbols or with an undesired response because of miscommunication. Feedback can be oral or written. It can also be an action, such as receiving in the mail an item you ordered. Sometimes silence is used as feedback, though it is almost always ineffective. Senders need feedback in order to determine the success or failure of the communication.

The components described above represent what happens in communication. A context exists in which a sender chooses a message to communicate; the sender must also choose the medium for the message; a receiver decodes the message and provides feedback. Although this linear description seems relatively simple, problems can occur at any point on the continuum.

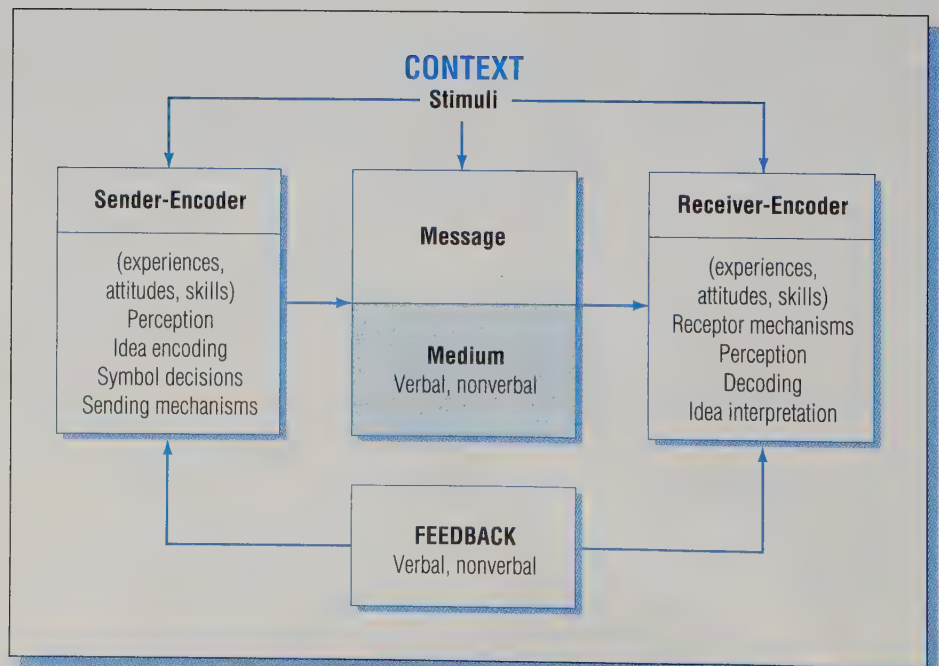


Figure 1.3 A communication model.

■ Checklist 1.1 Components of Communication

1. Context

- a. Have you considered the cultural and organizational convention concerning the environment of your message?
- b. Have you thought about the specific reasons for and objectives of your message?

2. Sender-encoder

- a. Recognize that internal attitudes can influence your message
- b. Realize that the words you are using reveal something about you

3. Message

- a. Is central purpose clear?
- b. Is thought given to both verbal and nonverbal elements of communication?

4. Medium

- a. Ask yourself: Which medium should I use? The more urgent suggests oral; the less urgent suggests written
- b. Ask yourself: Are the symbols clear in the medium I have chosen?

5. Receiver-decoder

- a. Are you, as the sender, aware of the attitudes and perceptions of your receiver?
- b. Are there physical, emotional, mental, or cultural factors in the receiver that could affect your message?

6. Feedback

- a. Have you allowed for feedback to your message?
- b. Have you been precise about when you desire the feedback?

CONCEPTS AND PROBLEMS OF COMMUNICATION

No two people in the world are exactly alike, and no two cultures or countries are the same. For example, decision making in Japan is inordinately slow by western standards. Americans also wonder why Germans are so thorough in their reports, why the French are so polite in letter writing, and why middle eastern business people are less concerned with time. The reason is that in those cultures, these different attitudes are acceptable and appropriate. All these differences, however, can cause problems in conveying intended meanings.

Each person's mind is a unique filter. Problems with communication are more likely to occur when the communicators' filters are sharply different. The

message sender's meanings and the receiver's response are affected by numerous factors, such as individual

- Conventions of meaning
- Perceptions of reality
- Values, attitudes, and opinions

Conventions of Meaning

A fundamental principle of communication is that the symbols the sender uses to communicate messages must have essentially the same meaning in both the sender's and receiver's minds. You can never assume that the message in your mind will be perfectly transmitted to your receiver. The world is littered with errors, sometimes humorous, often costly, as a result of differences in semantic understanding.

A way of clarifying semantic problems is to view the semantic triangle (Figure 1.4). In this view, a symbol is a sign for something that exists in reality. Thus your name—really a symbol or word—represents you. Only through common experience is a connection made between the symbol or word attached to you and the person you are in reality. The closer the common experiences surrounding the symbols and their things (referents) in the minds of the sender and receiver, the closer the level of understanding.

For example, many acronyms have become accepted into Standard English and are generally understood by most people, such as *laser* (light amplification by stimulated emission of radiation) and *sonar* (sound navigation ranging). Others, however, are particular to certain fields, such as FIFO (first in, first out) and LIFO (last in, first out) in accounting. Such acronyms are not understood by people who are not accountants.

Communication Problems in Conventions of Meaning

Symbols are signs for things that exist. Connections between signs and their referents are unique to each individual.

The meanings of words (semantics) are constructed within each person's experience of reality. The knowledge we each have about a subject or word affects the meanings we attach to it. Different word interpretations are especially notable in *miscommunicated instructions* and in reactions to *denotations*, *connotations*, and *euphemisms*.

Miscommunication occurs when the sender and receiver have different meanings for the symbols used.

Miscommunicated Instructions. When the message sender and receiver attribute different meanings to the same words or use different words though intending the same meanings, miscommunication occurs. Many English and foreign words have several dictionary definitions; a few have over 100. In one abridged dictionary, the word *run* has 71 meanings as a verb, another 35 as a noun, and 4 more as an adjective. Moreover, for certain words many people have their own unique meanings, based on their experiences, and such personal meanings are not in a dictionary. Thus, confusion sometimes arises, as these "listening" incidents illustrate:

1. A legislator hired a new office manager with the instructions to turn in a bimonthly report on all the activities that occurred in the previous pe-

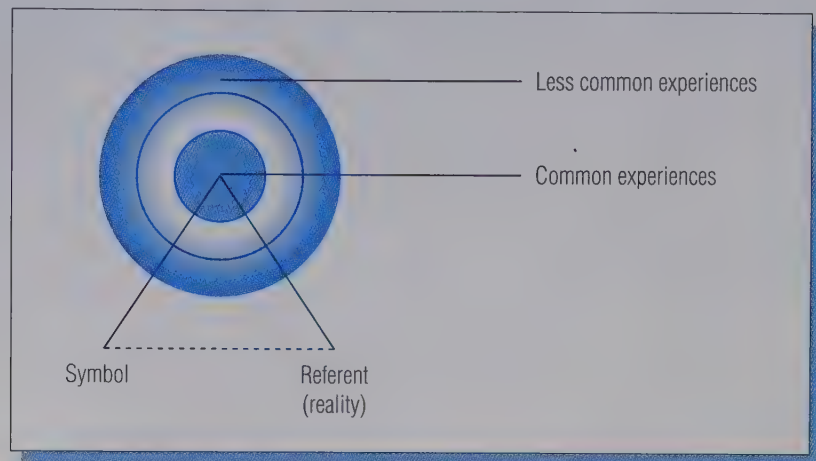


Figure 1.4 Communication triangle.

riod. After a month went by with no report, the legislator asked the office manager why he had not turned in the report as requested. The office manager replied that he thought the legislator wanted the report only every 2 months. After a short discussion on the definition of bimonthly, the two looked the word up in the dictionary. They discovered that *bimonthly* means both “twice a month” and “every two months.”

2. A woman sold a piece of property and asked her attorney to draw up a contract of sale. When she received the document for her signature, she read that “the party of the first part agrees to sell to the party of the second part the tenement located at the southeast corner First Ave. and Drysdale Blvd.” She quickly telephoned her attorney to point out that the land she was selling had no “tenement” on it and, in fact, had no building at all. Her attorney had to point out that the word *tenement* in the law means only “a holding of land.”
3. A British manager of a large retail conglomerate was working in the United States for the first time. In order to bring himself up to date on his department’s activities, he looked over the minutes from the last staff meeting, which he had not attended. He saw with satisfaction that the group had tabled his proposal to decrease allowable travel expenses. He was upset later, however, when he found that his staff had put the proposal off until the next meeting. In Britain, *to table a proposal* means to act on it.

Miscommunication occurs not only in business and industrial offices but also among government officials, military leaders, professionals, and all of us in our everyday contacts. To avoid communication errors when you give instructions or discuss issues, be sure your words convey the intended meaning to the recipient. When you are the recipient of unclear instructions, before acting on them, ask questions to determine the sender’s intended meaning.

Reactions to Denotations, Connotations, and Euphemisms. On occasion many of us have been surprised that a remark intended as a compliment, a matter-of-fact statement, or a joke was interpreted as an insult. Because words have both denotative and connotative meanings and because the sender has not considered the receiver's probable interpretations and reactions, miscommunication can occur.

A denotation is usually the dictionary definition of a word.

A connotation is an implication of a word or a suggestion separate from the usual definition.

1. **Denotations.** Most people agree on denotative meanings. It often is the dictionary definition. Denotative meanings inform the receiver, naming objects, people, or events without indicating positive or negative qualities. Such words as *car*, *desk*, *book*, *house*, and *water* convey denotative meanings, provided, of course, that the communicators are using the same language and provided that the receiver has a similar understanding of the context in which the word is used.
2. **Connotations.** In addition to the more literal denotative meanings, some words have connotative meanings that arouse qualitative judgments and personal reactions. The term *house* is denotative. *Mansion*, *villa*, *home*, *cottage*, *firetrap*, *shack*—though they all denote a place of residence—also have connotative meanings. The word *student* is denotative; *bookworm*, *scholar*, *dropout*, *gunner* are connotative. They reveal how the sender evaluates the subject. Some words, such as *efficient*, *gentle*, *prompt*, usually have favorable connotations. Others, such as *lazy*, *cowardly*, *rotten*, *delinquent*, usually have unfavorable connotations. Some words have positive connotations in some contexts and negative meanings in others. Compare, for example, *fat check* and *fat girl*; *free enterprise* and *free* (rude, bold) *manners*; *sucker* (customer) and *sucker* (candy); *cheap product* and *cheap price*. In common usage, words that usually have opposite meanings can sometimes have the same meaning, as in the two expressions *slim chance* and *fat chance*. One word that can now mean its opposite in colloquial language is the term *bad*, such as “Woodstock ’94 was *bad*!”

The connotative meanings for words are also affected by the communicators' different backgrounds and interests. Words such as *amnesty*, *speed*, *grass*, *crack*, *coke*, *gay*, *feminist* may arouse mixed feelings and arguments, depending on people's associations with them.

To communicate effectively, you must be aware of the connotative meanings of your words, and you must realize that some people have their own idiosyncratic meanings because of their experiences and background. Thus, choose your language carefully and consider both its denotations and its connotations to convey the exact idea you want and to achieve your desired results.

Perceptions of Reality

Complex, infinite, and continuously changing, the material world provides a special reality to each individual. Also, human beings' sensory perceptions—touch, sight, hearing, smell, taste—are limited, and each person's mental filter is

unique. We make various *abstractions*, *inferences*, and *evaluations* of the world around us.

Communication Problems in Perceptions of Reality

When you select some facts and omit others, you are abstracting.

Abstracting. Focusing on some details and omitting others is a process called *abstracting*. In countless instances, abstracting is necessary. However, you should be cautious about “slanted” statements.

1. *Necessary, desirable abstracts.* Whether you write or speak, you are usually limited by time, expense, space, or purpose. You need to select facts that are pertinent to accomplish your purpose and to omit the rest (as you do, for example, in a one-page application letter about yourself).

The chapter you are now reading is also necessarily an abstract; it condenses into a few pages highlights of numerous studies relating to communication and miscommunication. You must anticipate the likelihood that others may not be abstracting as you are. Their points may be as important as yours, though they select differently from the infinite number of details in reality. Differences in abstracting occur not only when persons describe events but also when they describe people, equipment, projects, animals, objects.

2. *Slanted statements.* Conscientious communicators, both senders and receivers of messages, should try to determine whether the facts they are acquainted with are truly representative of the whole. Slanting is unfair in factual reporting. For example, the news reporter is taught to include quoted statements in context and to avoid expressions of personal approval or disapproval of the persons, objects, or occurrences being described.

A reputable news reporter would not write, “A small crowd of suckers came to hear the Governor’s plan for 1997 yesterday noon in that rundown hotel that disfigures Hong Kong central.” Instead, the write-up might state that “between 200 and 350 people heard an address yesterday noon by Governor Patton in the auditorium at the Conrad Hotel at Pacific Place.”

Not only the language you use but also the type of information you include and exclude can result in slanting, revealing your own biases. Although total objectivity is not possible, you should try to not let personal preferences influence your factual reporting of information.

Inferences are conclusions drawn from evidence.

Inferring. Conclusions made by reasoning from evidence or premises are called *inferences*. Every day most of us find it necessary to act on some inferences. We make assumptions and draw conclusions even though we are not able to immediately verify the evidence. Some inferences are both necessary and desirable; others are risky, even dangerous.

Necessary, Desirable Inferences. For business and professional people, inferences are essential in analyzing materials, solving problems, and planning procedures. Systems analysts, marketing specialists, advertisers, architects, engineers, designers, and numerous others all must work on various premises and make inferences after they have gathered as much factual data as possible. Even our legal procedures allow inferences from experts as acceptable evidence. In our everyday activities, we make inferences that are necessary and usually fairly reliable.

- When we land at a foreign airport, we assume we will be treated hospitably.
- When we send a fax to Frankfurt, Germany, we assume it will reach the intended receiver.
- When we drop a letter into the mailbox, we infer that it will be delivered to our intended reader.
- When we enter an elevator in our building, we hope it will take us to the desired floor.

When we base our inferences on direct observation or on reasonable evidence, they are likely to be quite dependable; but even so, there are disappointing exceptions. Conclusions we make about things we have not observed directly can often be untrue.

Risks of Inferences. As intelligent communicators, we must realize that inferences may be incorrect or unreliable and anticipate the risks before acting on them.

Suppose a personnel manager notices that John Edwards, a new management trainee, has been staggering into his office every day for the past week. The manager might infer that the trainee has a drinking problem. But if the reason for the unsteady movement is the presence of Ménière's Syndrome (a disease of the inner ear), the manager would be wrong to assume a drinking problem. Always get the facts before taking action!

Tell those who may be acting on your inferences which portions of your statements are mere assumptions. If you are presenting a report on which an important executive decision may rest, be careful to distinguish clearly among verifiable facts, inferences based on facts, and mere "guesstimates."

Values, Attitudes, and Opinions

A receiver's attitude toward a message can determine whether it is accepted, rejected, distorted, or avoided.

Communication effectiveness is influenced also by the values, attitudes, and opinions the communicators have in their mental filters. People react favorably when the message they receive agrees with their views toward the information, the facts, and the sender.

Communication Problems Involving Values, Attitudes, Opinions

Receivers' views of the information presented will affect their response, which could be what the sender desires or just the opposite.

Favorable or Unfavorable Information. The effective communicator considers the receivers, and whenever possible, emphasizes the points the receivers will regard as favorable or beneficial. Receivers often react to unfavorable information by rejecting, distorting, or avoiding it.

Inadequate or Incorrect Information. Occasionally people react according to their attitudes toward a situation rather than to the facts. For instance, a customer may be happy over an adjustment that a company extended, but angry when learning that someone else received a better deal for what the customer assumed (perhaps wrongly) to be the same circumstances. This customer may have incomplete or incorrect information.

Closed Minds. Some people hold rigid views on certain subjects. These people do not consider facts or additional information and maintain their rigid views regardless of the circumstances. Such a closed-minded person is very difficult to communicate with, and often you can't communicate with that person at all. Dealing with such a person, you may have to resort to a mediator or a court of law to resolve disputes.

Credibility in the sender is important in getting a favorable reaction.

Sender's Credibility. Often people react more according to their attitude toward the *source* of information than to the information itself. A strong Democrat will more likely accept an idea from another Democrat than the same idea from a Republican; a Whig (Great Britain) would do the same with a Tory. In general, people react more favorably to a communicator who has credibility—someone whom they trust and respect. An effective communicator builds credibility by writing and speaking in a fair and just manner and by considering receivers' points of view.

Other Circumstances Affecting Attitudes, Opinions, Responses. When personal, business, or environmental stresses occur, attitudes toward messages may be affected. On a day when personal problems seem overwhelming, a communicator's messages may seem gruff, gloomy, or uncooperative. Life's stresses affect our ability to send effective messages and color our responses when we receive them. Sensitivity to your own state of mind as well as to that of your receiver helps you communicate your messages in a positive way.

NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION

Nonverbal messages often contradict the verbal.

The preceding sections about the communication process focused on *verbal* communication—written or spoken syllables, usually *words*. As Figure 1.3 indicates, we also communicate *nonverbally*—*without words*. Sometimes nonverbal messages contradict the verbal; often they express feelings more accurately than the spoken or written language.

■ Checklist 1.2 Aids in Overcoming Communication Problems

1. Meanings
 - a. Choose, if possible, the denotative word over the connotative word.
 - b. Through audience analysis, select the term with which the audience has had the most experience and understanding.
2. Perceptions of reality
 - a. Be sure to provide sufficient information.
 - b. Be careful with *allness* terms; not all people will agree.
 - c. Choose wisely when *inferring*; enough data must be used to draw a valid conclusion.
3. Values and opinions
 - a. Realize that some audiences do not desire information at odds with their own biases and limited information.
 - b. Spend sufficient time collecting information that is valid and credible.

Numerous articles and books have been written on the importance of non-verbal messages. Some studies suggest that from 60 to 90 percent of a message's effect comes from nonverbal cues. This section presents a brief overview of non-verbal communication:

- Appearance
- Body language
- Silence, time, and space

How Appearance Communicates

Appearance conveys nonverbal impressions that affect receivers' attitudes toward the verbal message even before they read or hear them.

Effect on Written Messages

The format, neatness, and language of a written message sends a nonverbal message to the reader.

An envelope's appearance—size, color, weight, postage—may impress the receiver as “important,” “routine,” or “junk” mail. Telegrams, Mailgrams, Express Mail, and private courier mail also have distinctive envelopes that signal urgency and importance. Next, the letter, report, or title page communicates nonverbally before its contents are read by the kind of paper used, its length, format, and neatness. Finally, the language itself, aside from its content, communicates something about the sender. Is it carefully worded and generally correct in mechanics such as spelling, grammar, and punctuation?

■ Communication Probe

Deborah Tannen, a prominent researcher in the differences in communication styles of men and women, suggests that the two sexes use language in entirely different ways, creating miscommunication on a regular basis. For women, language is the glue that holds relationships together; for men, activities hold relationships together, and language is used to negotiate their position. According to Tannen's research, women suggest and men command. Women react to commands with feelings of being bullied; men perceive women's indirect requests as manipulative. An additional finding is that American men in business settings like to discuss business and not waste time on personal talk. Women, like business people in certain other cultures, feel that personal talk establishes a comfortable relationship that can provide the basis for working together. These differences in style cause confusion and resentment in many cases.

Tannen, D. (1994). *Talking from 9 to 5: How women's and men's conversation styles affect who gets heard, who gets credit, and what's done at work*. New York: Morrow.

One company's "ding" or rejection letter consists of a postcard with various categories listed on the back, such as "insufficient experience," "inferior credentials," and "wouldn't be a good fit in the company." Checks are placed before each relevant category; the postcard is then mailed to the recipient. What does this rejection format suggest about this company?

Effect on Oral Messages

Whether you are speaking to one person face to face or to a group in a meeting, personal appearance and the appearance of your surroundings convey nonverbal stimuli that affect attitudes toward your spoken words. Chapters 14 and 15 discuss nonverbal stimuli in more detail.

Personal Appearance. Clothing, hairstyles, neatness, jewelry, cosmetics, posture, stature are part of personal appearance. They convey impressions regarding occupation, age, nationality, social and economic level, job status, and good or poor judgment, depending on circumstances.

Appearance of Surroundings. Aspects of surroundings include room size, location, furnishings, machines, architecture, wall decorations, floor (carpeted or bare?), lighting, windows, view, and other related features wherever people communicate orally. Surroundings will vary according to status and according to country and culture.

How Body Language Communicates

Included under body language are facial expressions, gestures, posture and movement, smell and touch, and voice and sounds. Chapter 14 has a more developed discussion.

Conventions of eye contact are specific to each culture. Eye contact and facial expression can help or hinder your verbal message.

Facial Expressions

The eyes and face are especially helpful means of communicating nonverbally. They can reveal hidden emotions, including anger, confusion, enthusiasm, fear, joy, surprise, uncertainty, and others. They can also contradict verbal statements.

Because he was embarrassed, a new employee answered “yes” when asked by his supervisor if he understood his instructions. Yet, the supervisor should have noticed the employee’s bewildered expression and hesitant voice and restated the instructions more clearly.

In the United States, direct eye contact (but not staring) is considered desirable when two people converse. The person whose eyes droop or shift away from the listener is thought to be either shy or dishonest and untrustworthy. But because people differ, we must be careful not to make a false inference about eye contact.

A Puerto Rican student in a New York City High School was thought to be guilty of stealing a backpack because when she was questioned by the principal, she kept her eyes lowered. The truth, however, was that the student was innocent and was merely showing respect to an elder by not looking directly at her questioner.

Always get additional facts before judging a person’s facial expressions conclusively.

Posture, gestures, and body movement convey a message and add to or subtract from your oral message.

Gestures, Posture, and Movement

In some occupations, actions speak louder than words. Employees who direct traffic in crowded streets or in noisy stadiums or who guide trucks when backing up in narrow places effectively communicate by pointing arms or fingers or by tapping on the side of the vehicle to indicate the desired direction. Deaf people communicate with a language primarily composed of hand, finger, and eye movements.

Gestures and movements are culture-specific. The meaning of a gesture in the United States may be completely different in Europe or Asia. In the United States, a clenched fist pounding on the table can indicate either anger or emphasis. Such a display in Asia would be unacceptable. Continual gestures and movement such as pacing back and forth may signal nervousness and may be distracting to listeners. Handshakes reveal attitudes (and sometimes handicaps) by their firmness or limpness.

Legs, too, communicate nonverbal messages. Consider, for example, a man sitting with his legs stretched out on top of his desk during an interview; a person shifting from one leg to the other in rhythmic motion; a woman pacing back and forth while speaking. Posture and movement can convey self-confidence, status, or interest. A confident executive may have a relaxed posture, and yet may stand more erect than a timid subordinate. An interested listener may lean forward toward the speaker; one who is bored may lean away, slump, or glance at the clock.

Smell and Touch

Various odors and fragrances sometimes convey the emotions of the sender and sometimes affect the reactions of the receiver, especially if the receiver is sensitive to scents. Also, touching people can communicate friendship, love, approval, hatred, anger, or other feelings. A kiss on the cheek, pat on the shoulder, or slap on the back is prompted by various emotions. On the other hand, touching in a crowded Japanese train or being pushed at the Tsimshatsui MTR (mass transit railway) in which passengers are squeezed together may be offensive to many North Americans.

Voice and Sounds

Your voice quality and the extra sounds you make while speaking are also a part of nonverbal communication called *paralanguage*. Paralanguage includes voice volume, rate, articulation, pitch, and the other sounds you may make, such as throat clearing and sighing.

The words "You did a great job on this project!" could be a compliment. But if the tone of voice is sarcastic and said in the context of criticism, the true meaning is anger.

A loud voice often communicates urgency while a soft one is sometimes calming. Speaking fast may suggest nervousness or haste. A lazy articulation, slurring sounds or skipping over syllables or words, may reduce credibility. A lack of pitch variation becomes a monotone, while too much variation can sound artificial or overly dramatic. Throat clearing can distract from the spoken words. Emphasizing certain words in a sentence can purposely indicate your feelings about what is important.

■ Communication Probe

Many writers on business communication emphasize the increasing importance of nonverbal communication in dealing with business people in the international marketplace. One writer's research suggests that, in spoken communication, the words alone are less than 10 percent of the message another person receives. Inflection, tone, emphasis, and other voice qualities account for 28 percent, and the remaining 62 percent is visual. In presentations, rather than using slides with words (often little more than cue cards for the presenter), he advocates replacing words with pictures, charts, and graphs. In international settings, the fewer words a message contains, the less there is to translate and the faster a receiver can respond to information.

Dibble, J. A. (1990, Spring). Communication skills: what they really are, why they matter. *Careers and the MBA* (pp. 47–50). Holbrook, MA: Bob Adams.

How Silence, Time, and Space Communicate

Silence, time, and space can communicate more than you may think, even causing hard feelings, loss of business, and profits. It pays to know these differences across cultures, as you will see in Chapter 3.

Silence

Consider how you feel when you make an oral request that is met with silence. Or think about the confusion you feel when your written message generates no response.

Suppose you wrote a request to your supervisor for additional funds for a project you are developing. If you receive no answer for several weeks, what is your reaction? Do you assume that the answer is negative? Do you wonder if your supervisor is merely very busy at the moment and hasn't been able to answer your request? Do you think your supervisor is rude or considers your request unworthy of an answer?

Time

Concepts of time and space are culture-specific. Effective communicators adapt to senders' and receivers' expectations.

Waiting when an important request is ignored causes problems and attitude changes. In the preceding example, after the long silence, should you ask again? Time is important in many ways. How do you feel when you are kept waiting two hours after the scheduled time for an interview? In U.S. culture, being on time for appointments, for work each day, and for deadlines communicates favorable nonverbal messages.

Concepts of time, however, vary across cultures and even in the United States. Americans and Germans, for example, are quite punctual. Middle eastern business people think little of arriving after an agreed-upon time, not out of discourtesy, but rather a feeling that the task will be accomplished regardless of time. If you arrived on time for a meeting in Portugal, your host might wonder why you came so early. Cultural differences are noted in more detail in Chapter 3.

Space

If you step into an empty elevator, where do you stand? If the elevator then fills up with people, where do you move? The need for personal space decreases as the number of people increases. In the United States, the need for personal space in a two-person conversation is about 18 inches. The need for space is less in many middle eastern countries and more in most Scandinavian countries.

Consider the common "dance of the diplomats" in which an American and a Saudi Arabian fall into conversation. The Saudi takes a step forward; the American edges backward; the Saudi advances; the American retreats. By the end of the conversation, the American feels bullied, and the Saudi feels insulted.

Effective communicators must learn to adapt to both senders' and receivers' expectations regarding space. The key to success is to be aware of the differences.

SUMMARY

Effective business communication is the lifeblood of every organization, a key to success in your career and help in your personal life. The volume and costs of business communication are great; so are challenges and opportunities for those with the right attitude and preparation. When you combine the principles of effective business communication with common sense, you excel in your dealings with others.

Effective communication depends to a large extent on insights into human nature and on the ability to get desirable responses by meeting expectations. It is a complex process that involves context, sender-encoder, message, medium, receiver-decoder, and feedback. This chapter is merely an introduction to the process of communication; it gives you helpful ideas as to why miscommunication problems occur.

To be an effective communicator, realize that human beings' mental filters and experiences differ. Each brings different attitudes, abilities, skills, and cultural customs to the meanings of the words we use. Your message may not always be understood. You may have problems of miscommunicated instructions, with denotations, connotations, and euphemisms, which all interfere with messages between sender and receiver.

Remember also the importance of nonverbal communication—appearance, body language, silence, time, and space. Above all, try to understand your audience, the receiver of your message, and keep an open mind in order to get as many accurate facts as possible. Your ability to do these things will help you communicate effectively.

In the following chapters and appendixes, you will study various principles and strategies. You will find examples and cautions in dealing with typical business situations. You will be asked to think, analyze, solve problems, gather facts, plan, and organize messages according to acceptable procedures for effective business communication.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. **Deciding on the Medium: Oral or Written?** Symbols such as flags, songs, religious artifacts, and school insignia stand for something else. How important are symbols to you in your daily life? How far should we go to protect them or to control them? What exactly do they communicate? Discuss the following incident from a communication perspective and answer the above questions.

You are the American manager for a division of an American company that produces medical products. Your division is located in a small town in southern Germany. The supervisor of the day shift has been with the company for 6 years and is respected and liked by the management of the company. However, he is known to have strong opinions, some of which are unpopular in Germany. One day he brought in an old Nazi flag and tacked it

on the bulletin board. Most of his coworkers were incensed. Some demanded his immediate dismissal. What would you do?

2. **A Short Informative Report on the Nonverbal Customs of an Asian Country.** You are the assistant to an architect for an American firm that has been contracted to build a new hospital in Bangkok. Your boss will be spending 2 months in Bangkok supervising the project until it gets under way. He has asked you to prepare a short report outlining the nonverbal customs of Thailand and specifically of Bangkok. Include in your report Thai conventions of time and space, gestures and body language, dress, eating customs, and any other pertinent information.
3. **Miscommunicating in Translations.** See if you can interpret the following letter sent from a Japanese supplier to an American company:

We are glad to inform you that hand-made samples.
 My apology for this belated hand-made samples.
 Trial hand-made sample the point at issue.
 1. The pump sample is no good. Thickness no equality. By reason of machine is out of order. But directly be mended of machine, it is no trouble.
 2. This is plate sample no clear and stained with grain of good. But no trouble in case of mass production.
 You may be well assured we shall exert ourselves to the utmost to prove ourselves deserving of your recommendation.
 Yours sincerely,

Exercises of a General Nature

4. **Investigation.** Pick up a copy of a recent *Wall Street Journal* and look at the classified ad section. Conduct a mini-investigation as to how many job positions require communication abilities.
5. **Handling a Personnel Problem.** You are the manager of the accounting department in a medium-sized company. One of your accountants has missed 2 weeks of work in the past 2 months, and her work is not being done on a timely basis. How would you handle the situation? Would you speak to her or write a memo? Would you do both: speak and write? If you would speak and write, which would you do first and why?
6. **Denotative Versus Connotative Words.** Choose an editorial from the opinion page of a daily newspaper. Underline the words that are denotative; circle the words that are connotative. Discuss the impact of the connotative words and whether the combination of denotative and connotative words is effective.
7. **Communication Principles.** What general communication principles do the following statements and incidents illustrate? Discuss each briefly.

- a. A friend states: "I'll never buy groceries from Tiptop Market. Haven't been there since the first week they opened 4 years ago. Their produce department is a mess, and prices are too high."
 - b. A colleague wants more money for a project. He states: "I know our manager is strongly opposed to this project, but I'm just going to barrage him with my reasons until he agrees!"
 - c. An article in the newspaper states that negotiations in the baseball strike are not making any progress. But the chief negotiator for the owners said he couldn't imagine "how what we offered them was a provocation to continue the strike."
- 8. Inferences Versus Facts.** Discuss whether each of the following statements is an inference or a verifiable fact based on observation:
- a. The boss is a "swinger."
 - b. Employees over 65 are inefficient.
 - c. The union requested double pay for each hour of overtime.
 - d. The union requested too much money.
 - e. XYZ skis are no good.

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The Seven C's of Effective Communication

I. Completeness

- A. Provide All Necessary Information
- B. Answer All Questions Asked
- C. Give Something Extra, When Desirable

II. Conciseness

- A. Eliminate Wordy Expressions
- B. Include Only Relevant Material
- C. Avoid Unnecessary Repetition

III. Consideration

- A. Focus on "You" Instead of "I" or "We"
- B. Show Audience Benefit or Interest in the Receiver
- C. Emphasize Positive, Pleasant Facts

IV. Concreteness

- A. Use Specific Facts and Figures
- B. Put Action in Your Verbs
- C. Choose Vivid, Image-Building Words

V. Clarity

- A. Choose Precise, Concrete, and Familiar Words
- B. Construct Effective Sentences and Paragraphs

VI. Courtesy

- A. Be Sincerely Tactful, Thoughtful, and Appreciative
- B. Use Expressions That Show Respect
- C. Choose Nondiscriminatory Expressions

VII. Correctness

- A. Use the Right Level of Language
- B. Check Accuracy of Figures, Facts, and Words
- C. Maintain Acceptable Writing Mechanics

VIII. Summary

IX. Exercises and Problems

To compose effective written or oral messages, you must apply certain communication principles. These principles provide guidelines for choice of content and style of presentation, adapted to the purpose and receiver of your message. Called the “seven C’s,” they are *completeness*, *conciseness*, *consideration*, *concreteness*, *clarity*, *courtesy*, and *correctness*, discussed in that order in this chapter.

All seven C’s can apply to both oral and written communication.

Although we deal here with these principles on the sentence level, they are applicable to all forms of communication, from mere utterances and sentences to complete documents or presentations. To some extent the principles overlap because they are based on a common concern for the audience, whether that audience consists of listeners or readers.

COMPLETENESS

Message receivers—either listeners or readers—desire complete information to their questions.

Your business message is *complete* when it contains all facts the reader or listener needs for the reaction you desire. Remember that communicators—senders and receivers—differ in their mental filters; they are influenced by their backgrounds, viewpoints, needs, experiences, attitudes, status, and emotions. Because of these differences, communication senders need to assess their messages through the eyes of receivers to be sure they have included all relevant information.

Completeness offers numerous benefits. First, complete messages are more likely to bring the desired results without the expense of additional messages. Second, they can do a better job of building goodwill. Messages that contain information the receiver needs show concern for others. Third, complete messages can help avert costly lawsuits that may result if important information is missing. Last, communications that seem inconsequential can be surprisingly important if the information they contain is complete and effective.

As you strive for completeness, keep the following guidelines in mind:

- Provide all necessary information.
- Answer all questions asked.
- Give something extra, when desirable.

Provide All Necessary Information

Answering the five W’s helps make messages clear: who, what, when, where, and why.

When you initiate a message, check to make sure you have provided all the information the reader needs for thorough, accurate understanding. One way to help make your message complete is to answer the five W questions—*who*, *what*, *when*, *where*, *why*—and any other essentials, such as *how*. The five-question method is especially useful when you write requests, announcements, or other informative messages. For instance, to order (request) merchandise, make clear *what* you want, *when* you need it, to *whom* and *where* it is to be sent, and *how* payment will be made. To reserve a hotel banquet room, specify the accommodations needed (*what*), location (*where*), sponsoring organization (*who*), date and time (*when*), event (*why*), and other necessary details (*how*).

Answer All Questions Asked

Look for questions: some may even appear buried within a paragraph. Locate them and then answer precisely.

Whenever you reply to an inquiry, try to answer all questions—stated and implied. A colleague or prospective customer's reaction to an incomplete reply is likely to be unfavorable. The customer may think the respondent is careless or is purposely trying to conceal a weak spot. In general, "omissions cast suspicions," whether you are answering an inquiry about your product or recommending a former employee for a new job. If you have no information on a particular question, say so clearly. If you have unfavorable information in answer to certain questions, handle your reply with both tact and honesty.

In one example, a software distributor, when replying to a dealer's letter, answered only four of seven questions. Because the original questions were unnumbered and somewhat buried in five long paragraphs, the respondent apparently overlooked or disregarded three of them. The reply, incomplete and unfriendly, caused the distributor to lose the business and goodwill of a potential customer.

Sometimes before you can answer an inquiry, you need certain specific information from the inquirer. If so it is a good idea to list the needed details on a reply form that the inquirer can fill out and return to you. In this way both your answer and that of your respondent will be complete.

Give Something Extra, When Desirable

The words "when desirable," in the above heading, are essential. Sometimes you must do more than answer the customers' specific questions. They may not

■ Communication Probe

Credibility of the communicator has been systematically analyzed over the years, often as relating to the speaker. Several classic, but still relevant, studies suggest that five decisions are made regarding a communication source:

- Competence: Does the sender of the message know his or her message?
- Character: Does the audience perceive the message sender as communicating honestly?
- Composure: Does the sender give the impression of being calm and collected, particularly in a stressful situation?
- Sociability: Does the sender come across as a likable individual?
- Extroversion: Does the source exhibit outgoing tendencies rather than timidity?

McCroskey, J. C., Holridge, W. & Toomb, J. K. (1974). An instrument for measuring the source credibility of basic speech communication instructors. *Speech Teacher*, 23, 26–33; McCroskey, H. C., Jensen, T. & Todd, C. (1972). The generalizability of source credibility scales for public figures. *Paper, Speech Communication Association*, Chicago; McCroskey, J. C., Jensen, T., Todd, C. & Toomb, J. K. (1972), and many others.

know what they need, or their questions may be inadequate. For example, suppose you are president of your local Rotary Club and receive the following inquiry from an out-of-town member:

I'm new to the city and would like to consider joining your club. As I will be visiting your club within the month, will you please tell me where the next meeting will be held?

Use your good judgment in offering additional material if the sender's message was incomplete.

If you answered only this one question, your letter would be incomplete. Realizing that your reader is a newcomer to your city and to your Rotary Club, you should include in your reply a welcome plus such needed details as directions for reaching the building; parking facilities; day, date, and time of meeting; and perhaps also the program for the next meeting. Your message will then have the “something extra” that a reader really needs and appreciates. In most cases the reason the communicator includes something extra will be obvious; whenever it is not completely clear, explain why you are including the additional information.

Here are some additional examples of incomplete questions in faxes and one letter.

FAX 1 *Incomplete question.*

Please fax me in return the departures from Singapore to Hong Kong on the 8th.

In responding to the above you would have to “give something extra” as to times of day, airlines flying that route, costs, and departure and arrival times.

FAX 2 *Incomplete question.*

How come my request for an interview letter did not receive a response?

When was letter sent? Who sent it? To whom was it sent? In other words, to answer fax 2 would require a return letter or fax seeking answers to the above questions.

LETTER 1 *Incomplete letter to a new savings depositor.*

Thank you for the confidence you have shown us by the account you recently opened.

All our facilities are at your disposal, and anytime we can be of service, please call on us. Our appreciation is best expressed by our being of service to you.

LETTER 1 *Revised, complete letter to the new savings depositor.*

Thank you for the confidence you have shown in First Federal by the savings account you recently opened. Our goal is to make all our services to you both pleasant and helpful.

Among the conveniences and services available to you at First Federal, you may be especially interested in these:

YOUR PASSBOOK DEPOSITS earn $6\frac{1}{2}\%$ interest compounded monthly.

BETTER-THAN-CHECKING service helps you pay bills by phone, earns interest on your money, and permits using our 24-hour cash machines.

MORTGAGE LOANS help you to buy, build, or refinance a home or to borrow for property repairs and improvements.

With our MONEY MARKET CERTIFICATES you can earn interest at various current high rates, depending on time and amount of your investment. The enclosed leaflet gives you more details about these and other services available to you at First Federal.

FREE CUSTOMER PARKING is provided in the lot north of our office. The teller stamps your parking slip, entitling you to free parking while doing business here. Office hours are 9:30 A.M. to 4:30 P.M. weekdays except for Friday, when the doors remain open until 6:00 P.M.

You are most welcome to come in whenever we can assist you. Please consider this association your financial headquarters for your savings and borrowing needs.

■ Checklist 2.1 Completeness

1. Remember the five W's:
Who? What? When? Where? Why?
2. Answer all questions:
 - a. Stated questions from questioner.
 - b. Implied questions from questioner.
3. Give extra information, when desirable.

■ Communication Probe

Completeness means that you tell your reader what he or she wants to know about your service or product. It involves laying out the benefits of what you are selling; it means imagining every reader to have a “show me” attitude. Readers must be convinced; they have to be shown results from simple reading. Therefore writers must be thorough. Informative selling will give the buyer confidence and increase later satisfaction with the purchased product or service. Such completeness will also reduce the number of goods returned to the firm.

On writing a sales letter. (ND). *Royal Bank of Canada*, 43, 3.

CONCISENESS

Conciseness is saying what you have to say in the fewest possible words without sacrificing the other C qualities. A concise message is complete without being wordy.

Conciseness is a prerequisite to effective business communication. A concise message saves time and expense for both sender and receiver. Conciseness contributes to emphasis; by eliminating unnecessary words, you let important ideas stand out. When combined with a “you-view,” concise messages are inherently more interesting to recipients. Finally, concise messages show respect for recipients by not cluttering their professional lives with unnecessary information.

To achieve conciseness, observe the following suggestions:

- Eliminate wordy expressions.
- Include only relevant material.
- Avoid unnecessary repetition.

Eliminate Wordy Expressions

The following are some concrete suggestions you can use to reduce wordiness in your communication.

1. Use single-word substitutes instead of phrases whenever possible without changing meanings.

Use single words in place of phrases. Even Winston Churchill made extensive use of simple, one syllable words.

Wordy: At this time
Concise: Now

Wordy: Due to the fact that
Concise: Because

Wordy: Have need for
Concise: Need

Wordy: In due course
Concise: Soon

2. Omit trite, unnecessary expressions.

Wordy: Please be advised that your admission statement was received.
Concise: Your admission statement has been received.

Wordy: Allow me to say how helpful your response was.
Concise: Your last response was helpful.

3. Replace wordy conventional statements with concise versions.

Wordy: Please find attached the list you requested.
Concise: The list you requested is attached.

Wordy: Such refreshing comments are few and far between.
Concise: Such refreshing comments are scarce.

4. Avoid overusing empty phrases.

Wordy: It was known by Mr. Smith that we must reduce inventory.
Concise: Mr. Smith knew we must reduce inventory.

Wordy: There are four rules that should be observed.
Concise: Four rules should be observed.

5. Omit “which” and “that” clauses whenever possible.

Wordy: She bought desks that are of the executive type.
Concise: She bought executive-type desks.

Wordy: The receipt that is enclosed documents your purchase.
Concise: The enclosed receipt documents your purchase.

Use your computer grammar check or let someone else check whether you have overused certain words; dullness may result from the same word or idea being repeated too often.

6. Eliminate unnecessary prepositional phrases.

Wordy: The issue of most relevance is teamwork.

Concise: The most relevant issue is teamwork.

Wordy: In most cases the date of the policy is indicated in the upper right corner.

Concise: The policy date is in the upper right corner.

7. Limit use of the passive voice.

Wordy: The total balance due will be found on page 2 of this report.

Concise: The balance due is on page 2 of this report.

Wordy: The reports are to be submitted by employees prior to 5:00, at which time they will be received by Mr. Jones.

Concise: Please submit your reports to Mr. Jones by 5:00.

In all attempts to reduce wordiness, you must be careful to not distort meaning. Conciseness reflects the thoughtful elimination of unnecessary words.

Include Only Relevant Material

The effective, concise message should omit not only unnecessarily wordy expressions but also irrelevant statements. To be sure you include only relevant facts, observe the following suggestions.

1. Stick to the purpose of the message.
2. Delete irrelevant words and rambling sentences.

Communication Probe

Wordiness has been the bane of writers—and speakers—since humans began to communicate. The word used to describe such circumlocution is *tautology*, or using two or more words to express a simple and single thought. Often we have implied that business communication can be dull: it tends to lack modifiers, it avoids excessive use of superfluous—or should—words. Yet, writers of reports or other forms of communication should follow the maxim, “once is often enough.”

Alexander, D. & Rivett, A. (1995, Spring). Once is often enough. *Journal of Management Consulting*, 8, 32.

3. Omit information obvious to the receiver; do not repeat at length what that person has already told you. If you feel it is important to remind the audience of known information, subordinate the familiar information.
4. Avoid long introductions, unnecessary explanations, excessive adjectives and prepositions, pompous words, gushy politeness.
5. Get to the important point tactfully and concisely.

Wordy: We hereby wish to let you know that our company is pleased with the confidence you have reposed in us.

Concise: We appreciate your confidence.

Wordy: At this time I am writing to you to enclose an interview card, which has been post-paid, for the purpose of arranging a convenient time when we might get together for a personal interview.

Concise: Please return the enclosed interview card to set up a convenient time for an interview.

Avoid Unnecessary Repetition

Unnecessary repetition leads to dullness.

Sometimes repetition is necessary for emphasis. But when the same thing is said two or three times without reason, the message becomes wordy and boring. Here are three ways to eliminate unnecessary repetition:

1. Use a shorter name after you have mentioned the long one once. Instead of the "North Central Company," use "North Central."
2. Use pronouns or initials rather than repeat long names. Instead of citing "American Association of Technical Analysts" again and again, use "it" or "they" or AATA. When using well-known initials or acronyms, give the full reference first with the initials in parentheses: The North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) is being debated in Congress.
3. Cut out all needless repetition of phrases and sentences. Sometimes it is possible to combine two or even more sentences by using subordinate clauses or phrases.

The following letter from a business executive to a firm the company had dealt with for 5 years shows unnecessary repetition at its worst.

Wordy: Will you ship us sometime, anytime during the month of October would be fine, or even November if you are rushed (November would suit us just as well, in fact a little bit better) 300 of the regular 3- by 15-inch blue felt arm-bands with white sewn letters in the center.

■ Checklist 2.2 Conciseness

1. Use one word in place of phrases; one sentence in place of two. Read out loud to “listen” for wordiness.
2. Omit outdated trite expressions.
3. Ask yourself: What material is really relevant?
4. Look for unnecessary repetition: Does the same word or idea appear too often?

Thank you in advance for sending these along to us by parcel post, and not express, as express is too expensive.

Concise: Please ship parcel post, before the end of November, 300 regular 3- by 15-inch blue felt armbands with white sewn letters in the center.

CONSIDERATION

Consideration means preparing every message with the message receivers in mind; try to put yourself in their place: You are considerate, you do not lose your temper, you do not accuse, you do not charge them without facts. You are, foremost, aware of their desires, problems, circumstances, emotions, and probable reactions to your request. Then handle the matter from their point of view. This thoughtful consideration is also called “you-attitude,” empathy, the human touch, and understanding of human nature.

In a broad but true sense, consideration underlies the other six C’s of good business communication. You adapt your language and message content to your receiver’s needs when you make your message complete. Three specific ways to indicate consideration are:

- Focus on “you” instead of “I” and “we.”
- Show audience benefit or interest in the receiver.
- Emphasize positive, pleasant facts.

Focus on “You” Instead of “I” or “We”

Using “you” does help project a you-attitude. But overuse can lead to a negative reaction.

To create considerate, audience-oriented messages, focus on how message receivers will benefit, what they will receive, and what they want or need to know. In some cases, this can be accomplished by emphasis; you might downplay your own feelings and emphasize a point, make an explicit reference, or use a direct quotation in responding to the request of another individual. Creating a you-attitude may require avoiding telling others how they feel, assuming you know their needs.

We-Attitude: I am delighted to announce that we will be extending our hours to make shopping more convenient.

You-Attitude: You will be able to shop evenings with the extended hours.

We-Attitude: We're sure you must be frustrated by the length of time it has taken to ship your order for Polish gargoyles.

You-Attitude: The Polish gargoyles you ordered will reach you within a week.

Showing consideration for the audience involves more than just using “you” instead of “I” or “we.” Messages that use “we” can be receiver-oriented if “we” includes the recipient of the message. Messages that use “you” can be insensitive in negative situations. In fact, sometimes avoiding “you” can reduce potential defensiveness or allow the recipient to save face. An extreme example of a negative situation is the collection letter with “you” or “your” in almost every sentence; if those sentences are insulting, sarcastic, tactless, or untrue accusations and threats against the debtor, the letter surely lacks a you-attitude. The use of “you” in negative situations can be avoided by employing the passive voice, making the receiver part of a group, or depersonalizing the situation.

Insensitive: You failed to enclose your check in the envelope.

Considerate: The check was not enclosed. [*passive voice*]

Considerate: The envelope we received did not have a check in it. [*depersonalized*]

Insensitive: Your contract tells you plainly that . . .

Considerate: I'm always happy to discuss the contract terms with new employees. [*receiver as part of group*]

Insensitive: You are completely off base in your proposal.

Considerate: We have differing interpretations of the utility of the proposal. [*sender-oriented with acceptance of responsibility*]

Considerate: The proposed plan has three aspects that need clarification. [*depersonalized*]

Show Audience Benefit or Interest in the Receiver

Readers may react positively when benefits are shown them.

Whenever possible and true, show how your receivers will benefit from whatever the message asks or announces. Benefits must meet recipients' needs, address their concerns, or offer them rewards. Most important, they must be perceived as benefits by the receivers. This means that you must identify the

legitimate benefits of your position, policy, or product and then put yourself in the place of the receivers to assess their perspectives.

Receivers will be more likely to react favorably and do what you suggest if you show that benefits are worth the effort and cost you ask of them. In situations where actual direct benefit is impossible or irrelevant to the subject matter, the message should at least show interest in and concern for the recipient's needs or viewpoints.

Merely inserting the word "you" does not ensure you-attitude, as shown in this sentence: "You will be glad to know that we now have a walk-up window open 7–9 A.M. and 3–8 P.M. every weekday." Some readers wonder, "So what?" The following revised sentence includes reader benefit: "You can now take care of your banking needs at our new Walk-Up Window. It is open with a capable teller to serve you 7–9 A.M. and 3–8 P.M. Monday through Friday."

Reader-benefit appeals help collect payments on bills, soften the blow in a turndown, and sell products. Such appeals are desirable also in job applications, favor requests, and announcements to your customers, prospective buyers, stockholders, and employees. Whether you are writing to one person or to large numbers, try to personalize the reader benefits instead of stating them in a general way. Benefits that are realistic, inherent, and tailored to individuals help communicators achieve goals in effective, ethical ways.

Emphasize Positive, Pleasant Facts

A third way to show consideration for your receivers is to accent the positive. This means stressing what can be done instead of what cannot be done, and focusing on words your recipient can consider favorably.

Negative—Unpleasant

It is impossible to open an account for you today.

We don't refund if the returned item is soiled and unsalable.

When you travel on company expense, you will not receive approval for first-class fare.

Positive—Pleasant

As soon as your signature card reaches us, we will gladly open an . . .

We refund when the returned item is clean and resalable.

When you travel on company expense, your approved fare is for tourist class.

Because of past connections with words, readers will react positively or negatively to certain words.

Among the *positive* words to which people react *favorably* are *benefit, cordial, happy, help, generous, loyal, pleasure, thanks, thoughtful*. Words with *negative* connotations that often arouse *unfavorable* reactions include *blame, complaint, failed, fault, negligence, regret, reject, trouble, unfair*, and many others. For example, in the following opening of a letter the negative words (underlined) focus on ideas you'd rather not have the reader think about.

We regret that, since you closed your account, your name will be missing from our long list of satis-

Checklist 2.3 Consideration

1. See your material from your reader's point of view.
2. "You" is more desirable than "I" or "we" in most instances.
3. Readers like to see benefits. Be sure benefits are a prominent part of the message.
4. Consciously use positive words; readers will react more favorably.

fied customers. We sincerely hope that, despite the best efforts of our fine staff, there were no occasions on which you felt we failed to serve you properly.

As a final note, true consideration is a result of integrity and ethics in communication. Because the topic of ethics and communication is so important, we treat it in a separate chapter.

CONCRETENESS

Misunderstandings of words have produced tragedies in both war and peace, in business and nonbusiness situations.

Communicating *concretely* means being specific, definite, and vivid rather than vague and general. Often it means using denotative (direct, explicit, often dictionary-based) rather than connotative words (ideas or notions suggested by or associated with a word or phrase). Thus the term *female* may appear in a personnel folder as a part of a job description, yet widely different connotations may occur when using terms as *wife*, *mother*, *spinster*, *widow*, *maiden*, *matron*, or *dowager*. Each of these latter terms also refers to *female* but with wide-ranging associations.

Communication Probe

Some letter writers are completely absorbed in the things about which they are writing, about quantities and qualities, about dollars and delivery. To become intelligible and effective, they need to enrich their thoughts by spreading them out to include people. At the core of good writing is audience analysis, audience adaptation.

Some persons will say that business is objective, mechanical, dealing with commodities and services rather than with people. How absurd it is to say so when every businessperson knows that every sale, every purchase, every contact, every financial deal, depends upon the word "yes" or "no" from some human being.

On Writing Clearly. (ND). *Royal Bank of Canada Letter*, 38, 7.

The benefits to business professionals of using concrete facts and figures are obvious: your receivers know exactly what is required or desired. Using concrete language has some additional, less obvious advantages. When you supply specifics for the reader or listener, you increase the likelihood that your message will be interpreted the way you intended. Moreover, concrete messages are more richly textured than general or vague messages; thus, they tend to be more vivid, dynamic, and interesting. The following guidelines should help you compose concrete, convincing messages.

- Use specific facts and figures.
- Put action in your verbs.
- Choose vivid, image-building words.

Use Specific Facts and Figures

It is desirable to be precise and concrete in both written and oral business communication.

Whenever possible, use an exact, precise statement or a figure in place of a general word to make your message more concrete.

Vague, General, Indefinite

Student GMAT scores are higher.

Eastern Europe is making progress in obtaining investments.

She's a brain.

Concrete, Precise

In 1996 the GMAT scores averaged 600; by 1997 they had risen to 610.

In 1990 investments in Eastern Europe were about US \$30 million; today that figure has increased by 12%.

Her grade-point average in 1996 was 3.9 on a four-point scale.

Note in the above examples that some of the vague words are opinion words. What is *higher*? What do we mean by *progress*? What does being a *brain* mean?

For example, the following words can also lead to uncertainty, confusion:

slightly	small	soon	early	high	about
most	a few	slow	very	almost	several

Of course it is permissible—even desirable—to use general expressions. But note some exceptions to the “facts and figures” rule:

1. When it is not possible to be specific: “You may not have the precise figures or facts.”
2. When you wish to be diplomatic (considerate): “You have missed three invitations to my office” is harsh; you may be more tactful by saying “I’ve sent you several reminders to see me in my office.”
3. When exact figures are unimportant, as in “more than half the committee was present.”

Put Action in Your Verbs

Verbs can activate other words and help make your sentences alive, more vigorous. That is, to have dynamic sentences (1) use active rather than passive verbs and (2) put action in your verbs rather than in nouns and infinitives.

Use the Active Voice

When the subject performs the action described by the verb, the verb is said to be in the active voice. Usually the active voice puts the verb up front. “The financial officer *reported* to the Board.” Here the subject (the financial officer) reported; the verb “reported” is active, is up front in the sentence.

Conversely, when the subject receives the action of the verb, the verb is in the passive voice: (“The report by the financial officer was heard by the Board.”) A passive verb has three characteristics:

- The subject does not do the acting in a sentence.
- The verb consists of two or more words, one of which is in some form of “to be” (is, is being, am, are, was, were, will be, has, or have been, had been, or will have been).
- The word “by” is expressed or implied (by whom or what).

Passive (Subject Receives the Action)

The tests were administered by the professors.

Grades of students will be sent to you by the school.

Active (Subject Performs the Action)

Professors administered the tests.

The school will send students their grades.

When the subject acts there is more life, vividness.

Active verbs help make your sentences more

1. *Specific.* “The dean decided” is more explicit than “A decision has been made.”
2. *Personal.* “You will note” is both personal and specific; “It will be noted” is impersonal.
3. *Concise.* The passive requires more words and thus slows both writing and reading. Compare “Figures show” with “It is shown by figures.”
4. *Emphatic.* Passive verbs dull action. Compare “The students held a contest” with “A contest was held by the students.”

Sometimes, however, you may prefer the passive voice instead of the active, as in the following situations:

1. *When you want to avoid personal, blunt accusations or comments.* “The October check was not included” is more tactful than “You failed to include. . . .” “Attendance at the meeting is required” is less harsh than “You must attend. . . .”

2. *When you want to stress the object of the action.* In “Your savings account is insured up to \$100,000,” you have intentionally stressed “your account”—not the firm that does the insuring. Also, “You are invited” is better than “We invite you.”
3. *When the doer isn’t important in the sentence.* In “Three announcements were made before the meeting started,” the emphasis is on the announcements, not on who gave them.

Put Action in Verbs, Not in Nouns

Verbs propel thought; they move ideas in place of slower-moving nouns.

Seven verbs—*be, give, have, hold, make, put, and take*—(in any tense) might be designated as “deadly” when the action they introduce is hidden in a “quiet noun.” The examples below show how each deadly verb with the noun and preposition (all underlined) can be changed to an action verb that shortens the sentence.

Action Hiding in a “Quiet” Noun

The function of this office is the collection of payments and the compilation of statements.

Professor H. will give consideration to the report.

The proposal has a requirement for . . .

Students held the meeting in the office.

Action in the Verb

This office collects payments and compiles statements.

Professor H. will consider the report.

The proposal requires that . . .

Students met in the office.

Put Action in Verbs, Not in Infinitives

Action Hiding in Infinitive

The duty of a secretary is to check all incoming mail and to record it. In addition, it is his or her responsibility to keep the assignment book up to date.

Action in the Verb

A secretary checks and records all incoming mail and keeps the assignment book up to date.

Choose Vivid, Image-Building Words

Business writing uses less figurative language than does the world of fiction.

Among the devices you can use to make your messages forceful, vivid, and specific are sensory appeals, comparisons, figurative language, concrete nouns, and well-chosen adjectives and adverbs. But use these devices with caution: business writing uses fewer descriptors than does a magazine article or fictional writing.

■ Checklist 2.4 Concreteness

- 1. Were you precise in using facts and figures wherever possible?
- 2. Did you use the active voice more than the passive?
- 3. Is there action in verbs rather than in nouns or infinitives?
- 4. Did you try to occasionally use vivid, image-building words? But in business writing, use them sparingly.

Sensory Appeal

Concrete language often evokes a sensory response in people; it appeals to one or more of the five senses. Such language tends to be more descriptive than conventional business language. For example, instead of saying “It was hot in the factory,” you might appeal to both sight and touch by saying “Sweat trickled down the arms of the line workers”; or “The secretary’s face was wrinkled after squinting into the computer the entire day.” Although sensory appeals are used primarily in marketing products, they also have a limited place in providing color and specificity in other forms of business communication.

Comparisons

Analogies (either figurative or literal) or comparisons can make an unclear idea clear or make an idea more vivid. Compare the bland images in the left column with those in the right column:

Bland Image

Proposals submitted
this quarter were
uninteresting.

This is a long letter.

More Vivid Image

Too many simple sentences,
too many simplistic ideas
gave the impression of
the writing of a first-
year student.

This letter is three times
as long as you said it
would be.

Figurative Language

Use figures of speech with caution. When used sparingly they do make an idea more vivid. Consider the following three examples.

Literal (and Dull)

Her work in groups was
exemplary.

Some women were stopped
in their promotions.

More Vivid, Figurative

She could be called “the
spark plug of the group.”

Many women faced the
“glass ceiling” in their
company.

■ Communication Probe

In the ancient world, rhetoricians (teachers of oral communication) suggested that ornateness in language was a significant part of communication. Indeed, there were communication practitioners and theorists who argued that ornateness in words and their use within a sentence were core to effective communication.

Such heavy emphasis on ornate communication slowly disappeared in communication texts in the Renaissance and later. Organization of ideas, support for those ideas replaced the micro divisions and subdivisions of how to be more ornate in communication. Today ornateness in communication is more characteristic of honorary degree citations or keynote speeches at political conventions. Metaphors (implied comparisons between two things) are modern day uses of figures of speech thoroughly discussed in ancient communication texts. Business communication today uses few forms of ornateness.

Hildebrandt, H. W. (1988). Some influences of Greek and Roman rhetoric on early letter writing. *The Journal of Business Communication*, 25(3), 7–26.

Literal (and Dull)

Our budget analysis will begin soon.

More Vivid, Figurative

This is the first shot across your bow as we begin to review your budget for next year.

CLARITY

Getting the meaning from your head into the head of your reader—*accurately*—is the purpose of *clarity*. Of course, you know this is not simple. We all carry around our own unique interpretations, ideas, experiences associated with words.

- Choose precise, concrete and familiar words.
- Construct effective sentences and paragraphs.

Choose Precise, Concrete, and Familiar Words

Clarity is achieved in part through a balance between precise language and familiar language. When you use precise or concrete language, you select exactly the right word to convey your meaning. Precise words need not be pretentious. When you use familiar language, you select a word that is part of your personal repertoire, familiar to the audience, and appropriate for the situation. Familiar words, as between two good friends, for example, are often conversational, and occasionally may be part of a speech or written communication.

When you have a choice between a long word and a short one, use the short, familiar word that your reader or listener will quickly understand. Also, use synonyms instead of Latin terms (L) if they, though short, may be unfamiliar to your audience.

When in doubt, use more familiar words; audiences will understand them better.

Familiar

about
after
home
for example
pay
invoice

Pretentious

circa (L)
subsequent
domicile
e.g. (L)
remuneration
statement for payment

Notice how the following statement with unfamiliar words is expressed clearly in the revision using familiar words.

Unfamiliar: After our perusal of pertinent data, the conclusion is that a lucrative market exists for the subject property.

Familiar: The data we studied show that your property is profitable and in high demand.

Although it is appropriate to use technical terms and business jargon in some professional situations, avoid it when you communicate with a person who is not acquainted with the terminology. If you must use such terms, define them briefly and clearly. If you don't, you'll confuse, embarrass, or irritate the reader. You may even be forced to explain later, as in the following classic story:

A plumber wrote the National Bureau of Standards to tell them hydrochloric acid is good for cleaning out clogged drains. (Before you go any further into the story, visualize the plumber. Assume you don't know him and have never exchanged correspondence. It is a pretty good guess he isn't a college graduate—maybe he didn't finish high school. But he probably is a good plumber—at least conscientious—because he's writing to the bureau to tell them something he thinks will help other people.)

In reply to the plumber's message, a technical specialist of the bureau wrote:

The efficacy of hydrochloric acid is indisputable, but the corrosive residue is incompatible with metallic permanence.

The plumber then wrote to thank the bureau for agreeing with him—when, of course, the bureau was actually disagreeing with him. Sensing the plumber didn't understand, another member tried to set the man straight by writing:

We cannot assume responsibility for the production of toxic and noxious residue with hydrochloric acid, and suggest you use an alternative procedure.

Again the plumber thanked the bureau. Then, in desperation, the department manager wrote:

Don't use hydrochloric acid. It eats hell out of the pipes.

As we have said and will say throughout the book, understanding the audience helps writers choose familiar words: those known by the speaker and the listener. Here are just a few examples.

Possibly Unfamiliar

assessed valuation
charge to your principal
easement for ingress and egress
buyouts
scribbler's compacts

Familiar to the Layperson

property value for tax purposes
increase the balance of your loan
allows passage in and out
purchased by another company
letters passed along to which readers
added comments

With the increased use of E-mail there is the tendency to be concise. The danger is that you must know the meaning of the E-mail acronyms which aid conciseness. For instance how many of the following abbreviations do you know? IMO, FAQ, LOL, MOTOS. Respectively: in my opinion, frequently asked question, laughing out loud, member of the opposite sex.

Construct Effective Sentences and Paragraphs

At the core of clarity is the sentence. This grammatical statement, when clearly expressed, moves thoughts within a paragraph. Important characteristics to consider are length, unity, coherence, and emphasis.

Length

Try for an average sentence length of between 17 and 20 words.

Generally, short sentences are preferred. The suggested average sentence length should be about 17 to 20 words. Because variety in sentence length adds interest to writing, adopt a range of from 3 to 30 or more words. But when a sentence exceeds 40 words, try to rewrite it into more than one sentence. Also, if all sentences are short (under 10 words), the result is primerlike language—choppy and overly simple.

Unity

In a sentence—whether simple, compound, or complex—unity means that you have one main idea, and any other ideas in the sentence must be closely related to it. “I like Jim, and the Eiffel Tower is in Paris” obviously is not a unified sentence.

Coherence

In a coherent sentence the words are correctly arranged so that the ideas clearly express the intended meaning. Place the correct modifier as close as possible to the word it is supposed to modify. In the following examples notice why each “unclear” sentence conveys a wrong meaning, and how it is corrected in the “clear” sentence.

■ Communication Probe

A former assistant managing editor of the *New York Times*, Theodore Bernstein, summarized a series of studies in his classic book—*Watch Your Language*—concerned with one question: Why were some newspaper writers considered more understandable than their colleagues? On review of the newspaper stories, one fact stood out: The more understandable writer used more short sentences. One study compared a journal article with few sentences with the same story with many sentences.

Longer Sentence Version		Shorter Sentence Version
Number of words	271	265
Total sentences	5	21
Average words per sentence	54	12

After two groups of students took comprehension tests on what they had read, the shorter sentence version resulted in a comprehension level of 64 percent as against 9 percent in the longer sentence version.

Bernstein, T. (1958). *Watch your language* (p. 112). New York: Channel Press.

- Unclear:** Being an excellent lawyer, I am sure you can help us.
- Clear:** Being an excellent lawyer, you can surely help us.
- Clear:** As you are an excellent lawyer, I am sure you . . .
- Unclear:** His report was about managers, broken down by age and gender.
- Clear:** His report focused on age and gender of managers.
- Clear:** His report about managers focused on . . .
- Unclear:** After planting 10,000 berry plants, the deer came into our botanist's farm and crushed them.
- Clear:** After our botanist had planted 10,0000 berry plants, the deer came into his farm and crushed them.

Emphasis

Most often, put main ideas up front within a sentence.

The quality that gives force to important parts of sentences and paragraphs is emphasis. Writers must decide what needs emphasis, and then choose correct sentence structure. In a complex sentence the main idea should be placed in the

■ Checklist 2.5 Clarity

1. Choose as precise or as concrete a word as possible.
2. Select words that have a high sense of appropriateness for the reader.
3. Opt for the familiar word, the one that is not pretentious.
4. Limit average sentence length to 17 to 20 words.
5. Insert no more than one main idea into a sentence.
6. Arrange words so that the main idea occurs early in a sentence.

main clause; the less important points are in subordinate (dependent) clauses or phrases.

For instance, in the first sentence below, the two ideas appear to be of equal value. In contrast, if the important idea is that the “airplane was difficult to control,” the second sentence would be more meaningful and emphatic; its main idea is in the main clause.

Little emphasis: The airplane finally approached the speed of sound, and it became very difficult to control.

Better emphasis: As it finally approached the speed of sound, the airplane became very difficult to control.

Little emphasis: Candidates should be motivated and have interest in static and dynamic testing of material, and have those prerequisites and others.

Better emphasis: Prerequisites in candidates should include expertise in static and dynamic testing of material.

In addition to using the above methods for emphasis, the PCs of today—and related software—allow innumerable ways to visually add emphasis to words. Though it is impossible to list all of them, some visual procedures include: headings, tabulations, itemizations, graphs, line charts, pie charts, underlinings, italics, indentations, colored capitals or italics, or even wide or short margins. The visual innovations are endless.

COURTESY

Knowing your audience allows you to use statements of courtesy; be aware of your message receiver.

True *courtesy* involves being aware not only of the perspective of others, but also their feelings. Courtesy stems from a sincere you-attitude. It is not merely politeness with mechanical insertions of “please” and “thank you,” although applying socially accepted manners is a form of courtesy. Rather, it is politeness that grows out of respect and concern for others.

In addition to following the guidelines discussed under “Consideration,” courteous communicators generate a special tone in their writing and speaking. The following are suggestions for generating a courteous tone:

- Be sincerely tactful, thoughtful, and appreciative.
- Use expressions that show respect.
- Choose nondiscriminatory expressions.

Be Sincerely Tactful, Thoughtful, and Appreciative

Tact

Though few people are intentionally abrupt or blunt, these negative traits are a common cause of discourtesy. Sometimes they stem from a mistaken idea of conciseness, sometimes from negative personal attitudes, sometimes from not knowing the culture of a country or even groups of people. Avoid expressions like those in the left-hand column below; rephrase them as shown in the right-hand column.

Tactless, Blunt

Stupid letter; I can't understand any of it.

Clearly, you did not read my latest fax.

I rewrote that letter three times; the point was clear.

More Tactful

It's my understanding . . .

Sometimes my wording is not precise; let me try again.

I'm sorry the point was not clear; here is another version.

E-mail messages are short and often informal.

Writing a letter to a customer outside the company requires more “niceties” than writing an E-mail within your company. A one-sentence internal E-mail to a colleague could be this short:

Phil, give me a call at #41279 and give me the number of the report you're sending along to the VP.

A fax or letter to a foreign company would not be as short, or blunt; instead, add a few more tactful words:

It was kind of you to write and extend holiday greetings. Here in the States the Christmas season is a high point of the year. Thank you for your regards.

Because our company receives many reports from China and your company, we need the number of the report you sent us in October. We need this in order that our electronic files can easily find it

in the system. We then wish to send the report along to our Vice President of Marketing.

Thoughtfulness and Appreciation

Writers who send cordial, courteous messages of deserved congratulations and appreciation (to persons both inside and outside the firm) help build goodwill. The value of goodwill or public esteem for the firm may be worth thousands (or millions) of dollars. Be especially thoughtful and courteous when communicating with Asian cultures: they like the soft, more polite approach in both oral and written communication.

Use Expressions That Show Respect

No reader wants to receive messages that offend. Such expressions are discussed in two groups: irritating expressions and questionable humor.

Omit Irritating Expressions

Following is a consensus list; that is, it includes a list of expressions many people find irritating. Avoid these expressions, particularly used with “you” or “your”:

contrary to your inference	you are delinquent
delinquency (delinquent)	you are probably ignorant of
I do not agree with you	the fact that
if you care	you claim that
I'm sure you must realize	you did not tell us
inexcusable	you failed to
irresponsible	you forgot to
obnoxious	you have to
obviously you overlooked	you leave us no choice
owing to your questionable	you neglected to (overlooked)
credit we are unable to	you say
simply nonsense	you should know
surely you don't expect	you surely don't expect
we are amazed you can't	your apparent disregard of our
we don't believe	previous request leaves us
we expect you to	no alternative
we find it difficult to believe	your complaint
that	your failure to
we must insist	your insinuation
we take issue	your neglect
why have you ignored	your stubborn silence

Omit Questionable Humor

When in doubt as to the relevance of humor, leave it out.

Laughter to one person is disgust for another; each of us has a different sense of humor. A flippant attitude can be in poor taste, as seen in the following note. When in doubt be more formal. The second note is also informal, but courteous.

NOTE 1 *Offensive*

Hey man, what's this I hear about the good news? You sure pulled a fast one this past weekend—and then didn't tell any of us about it.

Give my regards to the little lady. And wish her the best; she'll need it.

NOTE 2 *More courteous*

Warm congratulations on your wedding!

Well, you certainly took us by surprise. In fact, just a few of us even suspected you were taking off to get married. But even though we didn't hear about it until later, we—my wife and I—wish you the best.

Give our warm regards to your new partner.

Choose Nondiscriminatory Expressions

Another requirement for courtesy is the use of nondiscriminatory language that reflects equal treatment of people regardless of gender, race, ethnic origin, and physical features. The suggestions selected here can be particularly useful for your written and oral business communication.

Sexist Terms: “Man” Words

In western culture there is more concern than in other cultures about using the term *man* as part of a compound noun.

For a long period of time *man* was accepted to denote not only a male person but, generically, humanity at large. Today many people in the United States connect *man* with a “male human being.” Thus the English language—more so than other languages—uses alternative expressions for *man* that are neuter in form. Some examples are:

Questionable

freshman

manpower

man-made

the best man for the position

More Desirable

entering students; first-year students

workers; employees; work force; personnel

manufactured; constructed; built
the best person; the best
candidate for the position

Singular Pronouns

English lacks a neuter singular pronoun signifying “he” or “she.” Previously we accepted—and some persons still do—masculine pronouns in expressions as “anyone . . . he” or “each customer . . . his bill.” The trend today is to avoid using *he*, *him*, and *his* when referring to the hypothetical person or humanity in general.

Questionable

Anyone who comes to class late will get his grade reduced.

Each customer will have the new changes noted on his bill.

"Our criteria are firm: he is to be a scholar; he is to be a good teacher."

"You guys should all be concerned about the issue."

The executives may benefit from the stock options. He will . . .

Each manager has an assigned parking place. He should park his car . . .

More Desirable

Students who come late to class will have their grade reduced.
[Reworded to omit unnecessary pronouns.]

Customers will have the new changes noted on their bills.
[Reworded into the plural.]

Our criteria suggest he or she is to be a good scholar and a good teacher.
[Reworded to include both genders.]

Both men and women, all of you should be concerned about the issue.
[Reworded to include both genders.]

The executives may benefit from the stock options. Each executive may . . .
[Reworded to repeat the noun or a similar noun if a few words intervene.]

Every manager has been assigned a parking place. Each car should be parked in . . .
[Reworded into the passive.]

In sum, use good judgment. Some companies use the masculine *he* quite freely; know the culture of the company before making a final decision when writing.

Recognize that the emphasis on gender neutrality is more common in the United States than in other countries.

Names

When using names, treat each gender with respect: use names in parallel form.

Undesirable

Ted Aprill and Ruth
Mrs. Aprill and Ted

More Desirable

Ted and Ruth Aprill
Ms. Aprill [*she desires this*] and Mr. Aprill

Checklist 2.6 Courtesy

1. Ask yourself: Does the communication have a sincere you-attitude?
2. Have someone else look at your statement if you have doubts about whether it is tactful. Another opinion may cause you to reconsider making a statement.
3. Be cautious in using humor in communication. Here too it pays to have someone else review your words.
4. Be careful in using discriminatory language; this means being aware of gender, race, age, color, creed, sexual preferences, or ethnic origins.

CORRECTNESS

At the core of *correctness* is proper grammar, punctuation, and spelling. Major principles relating to each of these qualities are in Appendix A.

However, a message may be perfect grammatically and mechanically but still insult or lose a customer. The term *correctness*, as applied to business messages, also means the following three characteristics:

- Use the right level of language.
- Check accuracy of figures, facts, and words.
- Maintain acceptable writing mechanics.

Use the Right Level of Language

We suggest that there are three levels of language: formal, informal, and sub-standard. Take a quick guess: What kind of writing is associated with each level? What is the style of each?

Formal writing is often associated with scholarly writing: doctoral dissertations, scholarly articles, legal documents, top-level government agreements, and other materials where formality in style is demanded. The style is unconversational, usually impersonal, and often contains long and involved sentences.

Informal writing is more characteristic of business writing. Here you use words that are short, well-known, and conversational, as in this comparison list:

Informal writing is more characteristic of business writing—even more so if that writing occurs in an E-mail message.

More Formal

participate
procure
endeavor
ascertain
deem
edifice
utilize
interrogate

Less Formal

join
get
try
find out
think (believe)
building
use
question

In the following poem, Enid C. Stickel offers a humorous example of how people try to formalize their language.

Readability Gap

Colleges aren't schools,
They are learning institutions;
Problems don't have answers,
They have viable solutions.
People don't spend money,
They re-allocate resources.
Newsmen don't use tipsters,
They rely on informed sources.

Speakers don't make speeches,
They give oral presentations.
Bosses don't set quotas,
They just indicate objectives.
Workers don't take orders,
Though they implement directives.

Machinery can't break down,
But components can malfunction.
A court does not command
It just issues an injunction.
Programs don't have failures,
They have qualified successes.
And jargon doesn't hurt you—
It just constantly distresses!

Avoid *substandard* language. Using incorrect words, incorrect grammar, faulty pronunciation all suggest an inability to use good English. Some examples follow:

Substandard

ain't
can't hardly
aim at proving
desirous to
irregardless
stoled
brung
should of

More Acceptable

isn't, aren't
can hardly
aim to prove
desirous of
regardless
stolen
brought
should have

Check Accuracy of Figures, Facts, and Words

It is impossible to convey meaning precisely, through words, from the head of the sender to a receiver. Our goal is to be as precise as possible, which means checking and double-checking to ensure that the figures, facts, and words you use are correct.

Figures and Facts

- Verify your statistical data.
- Double-check your totals.
- Avoid guessing at laws that have an impact on you, the sender, and your message receiver.

A good check of your data is to have another person read and comment on the validity of the material.

- Have someone else read your message if the topic involves data.
- Determine whether a “fact” has changed over time.

In other words, there are accepted measures for statistical analysis just as there are rules for good grammar. At the bottom of all our suggestions, however, is this prescription: Be alert to accuracy because of changing rates, regulations, laws, and conditions locally and even internationally.

Words That Confuse

Our English language is constantly changing. In fact, even dictionaries cannot keep up with the rapid change in our language. But the dictionary is still a major source for locating correct words and their intended meanings. The following list includes only a sample of the many words often confused in usage:

a, an	Use <i>a</i> before consonants and consonant sounds or a long “u” sound. Use <i>an</i> before vowels or a silent “h.”
accept, except	<i>Accept</i> is a verb and means to receive. <i>Except</i> is a verb or a preposition and relates to omitting or leaving out.
anxious, eager	<i>Anxious</i> implies worry; <i>eager</i> conveys keen desire.
between, among	<i>Between</i> involves two people or two groups; <i>among</i> , three or more.
biannually, biennially	<i>Biannually</i> means “two times a year” or “every 2 years”; <i>biennially</i> , “every 2 years.”
continual, continuous	<i>Continual</i> means “recurring regularly” (like lapping ocean waves). <i>Continuous</i> means “without stopping.”
counsel, council	<i>Counsel</i> means (as a verb) “to advise” and (as a noun) “lawyer,” “advice.” <i>Council</i> (noun) is an advisory or governing group.
effect, affect	In business usage only, <i>effect</i> is a noun; it means “result,” “condition,” or “influence.” Both words are verbs—to <i>effect</i> is “to bring about”; to <i>affect</i> is “to influence.”
eminent, imminent	<i>Eminent</i> means “high in station, merit, esteem,” “prominent.” <i>Imminent</i> means “about to happen,” “threatening” (said especially of a danger or catastrophe).
farther, further	<i>Farther</i> is more used to express distance in space; <i>further</i> for distance in time, quality, or degree.

■ Checklist 2.7 Correctness

1. Select the right level of language for your communication: either formal or informal.
2. Realize that informal language is most often used in business communication.
3. Check—often by letting another person read your material—for correct figures, facts, and words.
4. Apply the principles of accepted mechanics to your writing.

imply, infer

Imply means “to insinuate” or “suggest”; *infer* means “to conclude.” A writer *implies*; the reader *infers*.

lay, laid, laid
lie, lay, lain

A person or a sheet *lies* (rests) on the bed, but a person *lays* the book on the table or *lays* himself or herself on the bed. If you can substitute *place(s)* and answer *what?* use the proper tense of *lay*.

principal, principle

Principal, as an adjective, means “chief,” “main”; as a noun, it means “sum of money” or “head of a school.” *Principle* means “rule” or “basic truth.”

which, that, who

That refers to persons or things; *who*, to people; *which*, only to things.

who, whom

Use *who* as the subject of a verb—“*Who* will win?” Use *whom* as the object of a verb or a preposition—“*Whom* can you trust?” (You can trust *him* or *her*, not *he* or *she*.) “For *whom* will you vote?”

Maintain Acceptable Writing Mechanics

All the material discussed in Appendix A relating to mechanics, word processing, and appearance of business messages is relevant here. With the various packages available for computers, both grammar-checks and spell-checks have made your editing tasks easier. Yet we recommend careful attention to the mechanical part of every well-written document.

SUMMARY

Knowing the seven C's, and using them, will help you become a better communicator; the principles for these seven criteria for good communication are core

to this book, and we hope will be your criteria for good communication in the future.

Be *complete* in giving your message receiver all necessary information. One way to remember this suggestion is to think of the five W's: *who*, *what*, *when*, *where*, and *why*.

Apply the second C, *conciseness*, through eliminating wordy expressions, including only relevant material, and avoiding unnecessary repetition. Consistently ask this question: Which word, sentence, or paragraph may be eliminated without omitting relevant material?

Prepare your messages with the audience in mind. *Consideration* means putting yourself in their place. Focus on "you" in place of "I" or "we." Stress the positive in your messages.

Insert specific, definite, and vivid words to make your messages *concrete*, the fourth C principle. Use specific facts and figures; put action in your verbs; and choose vivid, image-building words.

Think of *clarity* as using words that are familiar to the message receiver. Additionally, use sentences that average 17 to 20 words, contain one main idea, are coherent, and give emphasis to ideas more often in the beginning of a sentence.

Respect your message receiver. The sixth C principle, *courtesy*, means being tactful, thoughtful, and appreciative. Such writing also implies using expressions that show respect and use nondiscriminatory language.

Review all your communication for *correctness*. This last of the seven C's focuses on correctness in grammar, punctuation, and spelling. Additionally, give thought to the right level of language and the checking of figures, facts, and words.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. *Understanding a Foreign Country Through Viewing Its Newspapers.*

One of the better ways of understanding a foreign country is to spend time viewing one of their newspapers, written in English of course. Foreign students in class may wish to read a paper in their native language. Your task is this: Set up a list of criteria for good English writing and then apply those criteria to the foreign paper. Some criteria you may wish to consider are these:

- a. Use of headings to the stories
- b. Tendency to overuse certain words, such as the article *the*
- c. Control over prepositions
- d. Difficulty with using tenses

2. *Analysis of Foreign Form of Written Communication.* Here is an interesting assignment for the foreign students in class: Have each of them analyze a form of writing (letter, memorandum, report, E-mail, or other) as completed in their native language. Their task is to write an analysis of dif-

ferences between their native format and those practiced in their native country. Each student should feel free to select his or her own criteria for the comparative statement.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Comparative Report on a Current Periodical.** Apply two or three of the Seven C's discussed in this chapter as criteria for evaluating several different kinds of publications. (1) Do your analysis of one of the following documents. (2) Have another member of the class analyze the same document. (3) Compare results before reporting to the class on where you agree and where you disagree. You may select your analysis document from the following list or select one on your own:
 - a. The *Wall Street Journal*, the *New York Times*, the *Washington Post*, or a local newspaper in your area
 - b. An annual report
 - c. Periodicals such as the *Economist*, *Business Week*, *Readers Digest*, *Fortune*, or a journal of your choice
 - d. A story from a popular magazine
 - e. The letter from the chairperson in a company's annual report
 - f. This textbook, or another textbook selected from your major
4. **Restatement of Long Thoughts into Shorter Thoughts.** Translate the following gobbledygook into the original proverbs. Then compare sentence length (total words) in each concise proverb with the total words in the gobbledygook counterpart.
 - a. All's well that is finalized effectively.
 - b. Be it a minimal dwelling in a depressed socioeconomic area, there is no place like home.
 - c. All programmed activity and nonutilization of recreational outlets make Jack a less than fully realized personality.
 - d. Do not attempt statistical estimates of your chickens before it is feasible to correlate volume variances with projected expectations.
 - e. The utilization of a superfluity of culinary personnel maximizes disorganization and has a deleterious effect on the broth.
5. **Assignment to Move a Thought from Formal to Informal Writing.** Rewrite the following example of formal writing into a more informal business style:

On behalf of the committee investigating the issue of sex discrimination in the hallowed halls of academia, we respectfully request, indeed implore, that we earnestly seek your recommendation for cri-

teria to remove such discrimination. Furthermore, it is the intent of the committee that you use all means available to you, including via our approval additional measures, to submit no later than the 6th of October 199- those criteria to us. Finally, be it known that your information be made available to the committee in both hard-copy form and computer disk, the latter compatible with MS-DOS machines.

6. Exercises on Choice of Words. Choose the correct word or words that should be used in each sentence listed below.

- a. This act will not (effect, affect) my confidence in you.
- b. I am (anxious, eager) to (tell, advise) you that you are right.
- c. (Continuous, continual) rains are drenching the fields.
- d. We assure you (its, it's) a pleasure to do as you suggest.
- e. Enclosed (please find, is) my check for (\$100.00, \$100).
- f. RXZ College employs 10 (imminent, eminent) scholars.
- g. The dissension (between, among) the five departments has been settled by a (well known, well-known) authority.
- h. The man (who, which, that) was crossing the street was struck by a car (who, which, that) Mr. Smith was driving.
- i. (A, An) university regent held (a, an) one-hour meeting with (a, an) honor society (council, counsel).
- j. We sold (fewer, less) fans last month.
- k. We had (already, all ready) received the suit when your letter arrived. I am (already, all ready) to write this customer.
- l. Your rug should (lie, lay) (smooth, smoothly) on the floor.
- m. The (principal, principle) of honesty should be evident here.
- n. Be courteous to (whomever, whoever) comes to your desk.
- o. A large number of bills (is, are) outstanding.
- p. Do you know (who, whom) the manager promoted yesterday?
- q. The decision is a secret between Ron and (I, me).
- r. We have a large (quantity, amount, number) of suits here.
- s. Either Ellen or (myself, I, me) will call you Monday.

7. Substitution of Simpler for More Complex Word. Assume that you are writing to the average citizen who has contacted your company. Offer appropriate synonyms for the following words in order to improve understanding:

accelerate	allegation	default
aggregating	contingent	discrepancy
rescind	accord	cunning
validity	censure	hoi polloi
modus operandi	de facto	de jure
circumvent	paucity	archaic

8. ***Suggestions for Gender-Neutral Terms.*** Suggest some gender-neutral alternatives for the following terms:

freshman	man-hours	workmanship
repairman	layman	showmanship
manmade	chairlady	checkroom girl
girl	womankind	man the desk

9. ***Rewriting a Document into Nongender Terms.*** For the following interdepartmental memo, (a) number the paragraphs (1 to 4), (b) under every paragraph number, list all nongender, neutral statements—each on a separate line—and (c) opposite each statement write an appropriate nonsexist version.

TO: Mrs. Erica Cosmos DATE: May 10, 199-
 FROM: Tom Grant
 SUBJECT: CPC Staffing Requirements

I would like your support along with that of Charles to serve as cochairman of our Staffing Requirements Committee for the Communications Planning Centers. As you know, the CPCs are a most important sales tool, and we need highly qualified manpower with top salesmen.

The other committeemen I have appointed to work with you are Scott Durke, Fred Picker, Miss Helen Jaynes, and Mrs. Thoms.

One of the important jobs at the centers is that of professional sales demonstrator, which requires many man-hours of work. This man will be an entry-level group manager, responsible for all equipment sales demonstrations. He must of course be extremely knowledgeable about all our products and services. Currently this assignment is being handled by Miss Carolyn Mayer at our II Center and by Kermit Smith at ABC Center. Both are doing a superior job.

We would like this task to be a one-year rotational assignment and be filled with the best available candidate—man or lady. This job experience can greatly benefit the assigned individual

and make him more valuable to our company on future reassignments. Please get your committee together this week to begin an extensive search for good people who are available for these assignments. If you need help typing announcements or other materials, I've asked the gals in the typing pool to be available.

Business Communication in Context

- Chapter 3** Business Communication and the Global Context
- Chapter 4** Business Communication and the Ethical Context
- Chapter 5** Business Communication and the Technology Context

Business Communication and the Global Context

I. Background to Intercultural Communication

- A. A Concept of Culture
- B. An Intercultural Communication Model

II. National Cultural Variables

- A. Education
- B. Law and Regulations
- C. Economics
- D. Politics
- E. Religion
- F. Social Norms
- G. Language

III. Individual Cultural Variables

- A. Time (Chronemics)
- B. Space (Proxemics)
- C. Food
- D. Acceptable Dress
- E. Manners
- F. Decision Making
- G. Verbal and Nonverbal Communication

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

VI. References

Throughout the business world the term *globalization* is well-known. Globalization means that for a company to survive, it must establish markets not only in its own country but also in many foreign countries. Thus employees—and you as a potential international communicator—must understand others' cultures and variables. Additionally, you must be aware of your own country's ethnic diversity in order to communicate effectively with global companies.

This chapter introduces you to three fundamental topics as a basis for communicating effectively with people from other countries.

- Background to intercultural communication
- National cultural variables
- Individual cultural variables

BACKGROUND TO INTERCULTURAL COMMUNICATION

Communicating with persons from other countries is not easy, as suggested in the following examples:

Many personal and national variables affect both senders and receivers of messages.

You've got a choice: either you're on the plane with me this evening or I return home alone. [Actual statement from a spouse after one day visiting a foreign country.]

I get to work at 9:00 and leave at 8:00 in the evening. [Actual statement from Hong Kong worker.]

A few American companies have attempted to take their uniquely American approach to management and transplant it to Japan. Without exception, every attempt has been a complete and total disaster.¹

What the above statements imply is that throughout the world there is a large mix of nationalities and people. And central to improving and understanding one another is communication training, captured in a statement made by a scholar in South Africa: "Stress is placed upon the concept of background which we believe is necessary to an understanding of the total communication process. By background we mean those aspects that can either impede or aid effective communication: language, culture, status, education, and age."²

Thus each person, each country has its own written and unwritten rules of behavior, including instruction in communication. Surely it is more comfortable to work with persons of your own culture, your own language, your own communication norms. But international communication demands work with many foreign countries and people. Let us begin by looking at culture.

A Concept of Culture

As the term *communication* is difficult to define, so too is the term *culture*. Two authors' research suggests that at least 164 definitions exist, with at least 6 cate-

Cultural generalizations applicable to an entire nation are impossible. Knowing core characteristics of a country are basic to better international communication

gories predominating.³ For our purposes, *culture* refers to the behavioral characteristics typical of a group. This definition implies that communications, oral and nonverbal, within a group also are typical of that group and are often unique. Thus, to assume that all the suggestions for improving your written and oral communication as noted in this book are valid throughout the world is incorrect.

Another term you should know is *ethnocentrism*, that is, judging other groups or countries by the cultural standards of your group. While the focus in this chapter is primarily on communication, you must understand the many other factors that make up a culture, discussed later in this chapter. Try to guess in which countries the following communication and cultural habits exist.

1. What do you think of a culture in which people sign their last names first?
2. What is your reaction when two signatures appear at the bottom of a business letter?
3. Why don't people put the month first, then the day, rather than day first, then the month?
4. What is your impression of a foreign letter that is intentionally not concise?
5. Some salutations are overly formal; so are endings. Is that a concern when your letters have been more casual?
6. How do you react to long sentences in letters when you were taught to write shorter sentences?
7. What's your reaction when a letter ends without a clear statement of purpose or action?
8. What is your feeling toward a meeting in which there is little discussion and little comment until the senior and usually older person speaks and recommends an answer?
9. How do you react when writing problems such as errors in choice of verb tense, prepositions, and articles frequently occur in writing?

All the above are, respectively, dominant characteristics of communication for the following nationalities: (1) Chinese, (2) German, (3) Europeans and others, (4) French and German, (5) French and German, (6) French and German, (7) Chinese, (8) Chinese, and (9) many Asian countries. If you reacted negatively toward any of the different communication styles in the above questions, you tended to judge them in light of your own cultural standards.

Each time you hold up your standards of what is good when judging written or oral communication from another culture, you must be careful. To say, as did one American manager, "German reports begin with Adam and Eve" misses the point: Germans are usually more thorough in submitting reports than are writers in the United States. Withhold evaluative statements on foreign communication styles until you recognize that different cultures use different communication methods.

■ Communication Probe

Innumerable articles and studies confirm that as companies expand internationally, they will face cultural issues that could lead to unintended hostility. Cultural errors abound; business deals are lost worldwide because of unintended slights. Two international experts suggest the following:

- Get as close as possible to all stakeholders.
- Focus on social protocol as much as business protocol.
- Remain calm in the face of unrelenting frustration.
- Develop multifaceted communication with all levels of government in addition to company contacts.
- Identify, early, opinion leaders and acquire their support.
- Avoid arrogance; practice humility.

These suggestions apply worldwide. Central is this underlying inference: One must be aware of both business communication practices and cultural protocols.

Kohut, J. (1995, January 7). The art of wooing Chinese officials. *The South China Morning Post*, 19; Ward, S. (1993). Managing hostile local interests. *Business Asia*, 25 (19), 12.

An Intercultural Communication Model

Studies have long determined that all of us are more comfortable with persons we know and who hold similar beliefs.

A core cultural value comes close to being fixed in stone. Know the basic ethical and moral concepts to which different ethnic and cultural groups subscribe.

We assert that all of us are more comfortable with familiar people and surroundings. That makes sense. As a basis for understanding that assertion, look at Figures 3.1 and 3.2 on pp. 74 and 75.

Examine *carefully* the exact center of the daisy wheel petals: Directly in the middle are located basic human characteristics common to all of us. Thus a doctor in Stockholm, Sweden, understands the workings of the human body of an American, a fellow Swede, a Malaysian, or a Russian. In other words, certain physical, anatomical traits are common to humankind, regardless of race or cultural differences. So are the acts of walking, or love of family, or shaking hands in most cultures.

Note that in Figure 3.1 countries I and II have a major cultural overlap. That is, people of those two countries might speak English, dress in a similar fashion, and use common forms of address—all in addition to basic core areas of agreement. Countries III and IV have the same core values but have less commonality with the other two countries.

Thus at the international level you probably would be more comfortable working in countries I and II than in countries III and IV.

Look at the end of each petal. All four cultures in Figure 3.1 would have major differences: Religions might be different, as could be values, beliefs, attitudes, and verbal and nonverbal means of communication.

Consider your own country. Within the United States, or within the former Soviet Union, for example, one finds diverse cultures. Ethnic groups within those countries still maintain an allegiance to core principles, and yet they hold on to traditions and habits peculiar to their own ethnic group. In other words, within

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Europe has for years included English as the second language requirement in its schools; younger persons recognize the importance of English as a world business language. But that fluency varies—as does that fluency in the rapidly growing region of Asia. Americans feel the world speaks English; perhaps, but with varying degrees of competence.

Thus a study of English fluency, particularly for English-language television, was conducted in the following countries: China, Indonesia, Japan, the Philippines, Thailand, South Korea, Taiwan, Malaysia, Hong Kong, and Singapore. Of the 10 countries, the Philippines have more people who speak English, or 49 percent. Based on a percentage of the population, 47 percent of the population is fluent in English. Singapore is second in percentage of their people speaking English, at 47 percent. So concerned are the other countries that both in national newspapers and journals a consistent series of statements seeking to improve daily and business English appear.

Nation, J. (1995, January 6). Mind your language—tempus fugit and other Latin traps. *Asia Magazine*, 33, k-7, 23; Lehner, U. (1994, March 20). Fewer Asians speak English than thought, study says. *Asian Wall Street Journal*, 6.

each country many individuals belong to different ethnic groups. Thus, while Americans accept certain underlying principles, attitudes, ideals, and values of their own culture, there exists diversity between persons of the same country.

Political parties, for instance, support democracy, yet wish to improve the system from different points of view. So do Hispanics and Europeans and Asians and a host of other ethnic groups within the United States. Each group supports core values, yet retains its basic diversity. Recognize that speech patterns will be different, nonverbal behaviors will vary, dress will be different, foods will taste different, holidays will assume varying degrees of importance, and even language usage will vary. Understanding the diversity of your own country is as necessary as understanding the cultural differences of foreign countries.

Note in Figure 3.2 that countries I, II, and IV are highly similar; each to a high degree overlaps the other. Thus it may be that Christianity is the dominant religion, the language is the same, letter sizes are identical, formality in dress dominates, cars drive on the same side of the road—even first names are used often.

Ask the foreign students in your class if they see additional differences between their native countries and the United States. In the past some foreign students have made the following responses:

United States

Concern with diversity
Tendency to be obsessed with time

Other Cultures

Less tolerance for diversity
Time is flexible

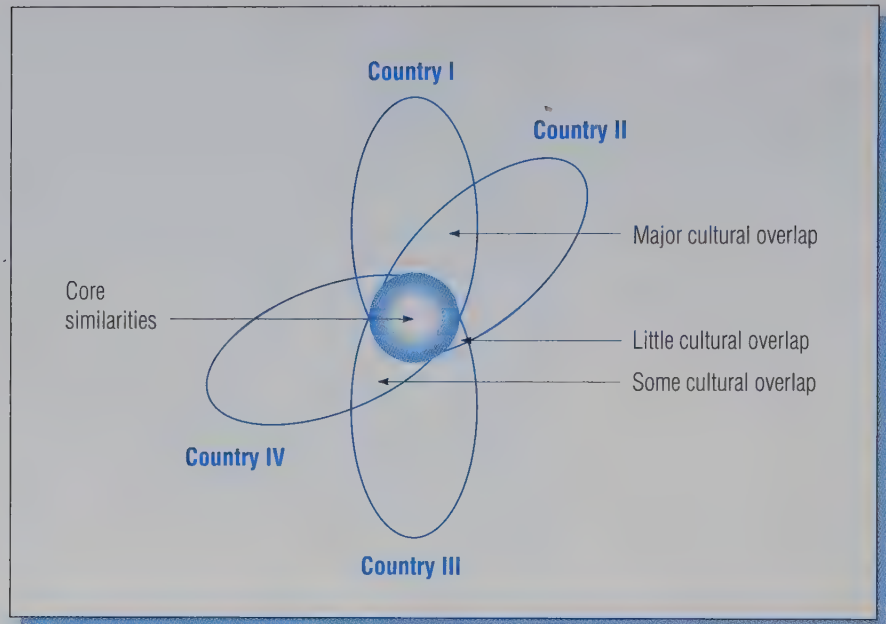


Figure 3.1 Cultural overlap.

United States

Expect answers quickly to faxes, letters, or E-mail
Few vacation periods

Legalistic letters

Early starting time for work
Much use of slang
Prefer deductive: It gets to the point more quickly
Prefer paragraph headings and visual divisions
Rank is less important

Other Cultures

Faxes and E-mail slowly increasing in developing countries
Many vacation days (about 17 in some countries)
More informal; a handshake is as good as a letter
Start working later in the day
Less use of slang
Prefer inductive: It is less arrogant
Prefer bullets or numbers
Rank is important

These comparisons lay the foundation for basic discussion of international or intercultural communication, but there are more specific variables that should be recognized in order to communicate effectively. This means understanding the seven national cultural factors.

Look at Figure 3.2: What does the configuration of Country III suggest? A quick inference is that the country has little in common with the other three. As one moves outward from a core sameness, each culture represented by the petals begins to change—some more than others. Why? Ethnic diversity within a country plays a part. So do such factors as habit, attitudes, and tradition.

Some of the thorny issues countries face politically are direct results of not communicating or of not knowing their own country's ethnic diversity.

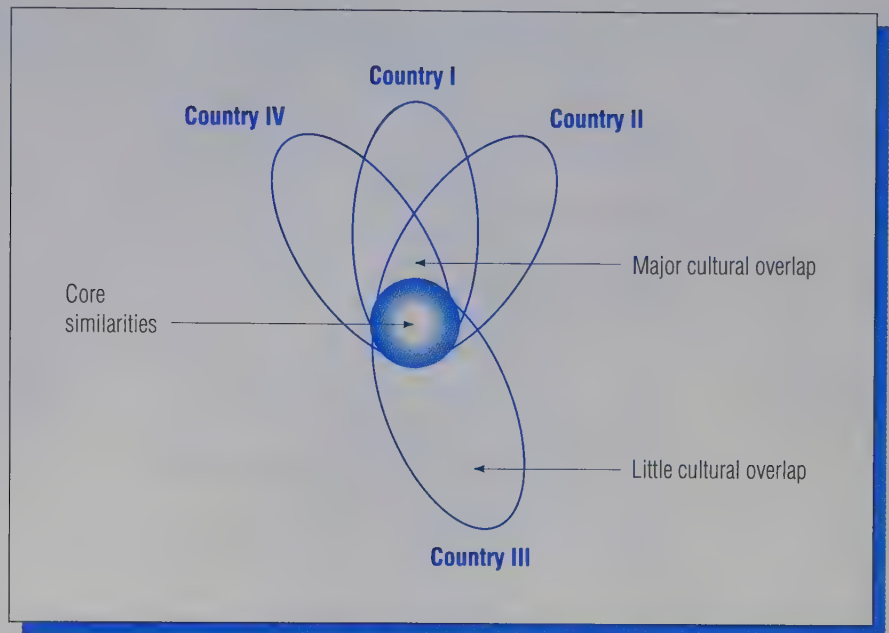


Figure 3.2 Cultural similarity and dissimilarity.

Notice that at some points the petals overlap where certain traditions (eating with chopsticks, celebrating the lunar new year, wearing the chador) are commonalities while others are not.

Assume you are in Country III. Although you possess the core attributes of other cultures, it is difficult for you to accept their differences. The following brief list cites some typical traits of American culture and compares them with possible alternatives you might find abroad.⁴

■ Communication Probe

There is support for the assertion that adaptation of foreigners to a host culture is related to length of time spent in that culture. Also relevant is the issue of communication over time between the host and foreigner. Thus adaptation—or the lack of it—of the two sides can lead to alienation. Conclusion: When Americans were perceived as hostile, the higher the social isolation of foreign students in the United States. Additionally, when Americans were perceived as avoiding interaction, the greater the social isolation. Conversely, when Americans showed a liking of foreign students, there was less social isolation.

McDermott, S. (1992). Communication factors in alienation among foreign students. *World Communication*, 21, 41–49.

Traits of U.S. Culture

- Individuals can influence the future.
- Diversity days recognized on campuses.
- First names should come first.
- Punctuality is important.
- Get to the point quickly.
- Slow to offer business cards.
- Write from left to right.
- Day is divided into two 12-hour segments.
- Consensus makes the decision.

Possible Alternatives Abroad

- Life’s path is preordained.
- Diversity days infrequently observed.
- Last names are used first.
- There is much time available; we’ll get there.
- Get to know the individual first; then conduct business.
- Quick to offer business cards.
- Write from right to left.
- Day is continuous; hours numbered from 1 to 24.
- The senior member makes the decision.

NATIONAL CULTURAL VARIABLES

An entire country may have a series of cultural norms; individual ethnic groups within that country may accept most of those norms as well as adding their own.

As the communication model in Chapter 1 shows, the message sender and the receiver are both affected by external and internal stimuli. When communicating with business people in a foreign country, you must realize that overall national and individual cultural differences within the cultures further affect those stimuli. Figure 3.3 suggests the macro, or global, constraints and variables that communicators must face when working with foreign receivers of their messages. The items in the left-hand column are mainly national cultural variables. You should understand them, know they exist; we begin our discussion there.

Education

Management education—including training in business communication—is more prevalent in the United States than in other countries. Some countries have no academic courses in communication training.

One of the conclusions students draw from visiting companies in other countries is that many managers in foreign factories are not very well educated. For example, if your future work takes you to Asia, you will find that most Asian and Chinese managers have had a less formal education than you.⁵

EDUCATION LEVELS OF CHINESE, ASIAN, AND U.S. MANAGERS

Highest Level of Education	Chinese, %	Asian, %	U.S., %
Less than high school	5.4	2.5	0.1
High school graduate	31.8	12.4	3.2
Some college	34.6	19.4	16.9
Undergraduate degree	27.6	65.4	79.8
Postgraduate degree	0.7	25.0	30.0

Because this book focuses on business communication, it is interesting to note the high importance of communication courses as preparation for a career

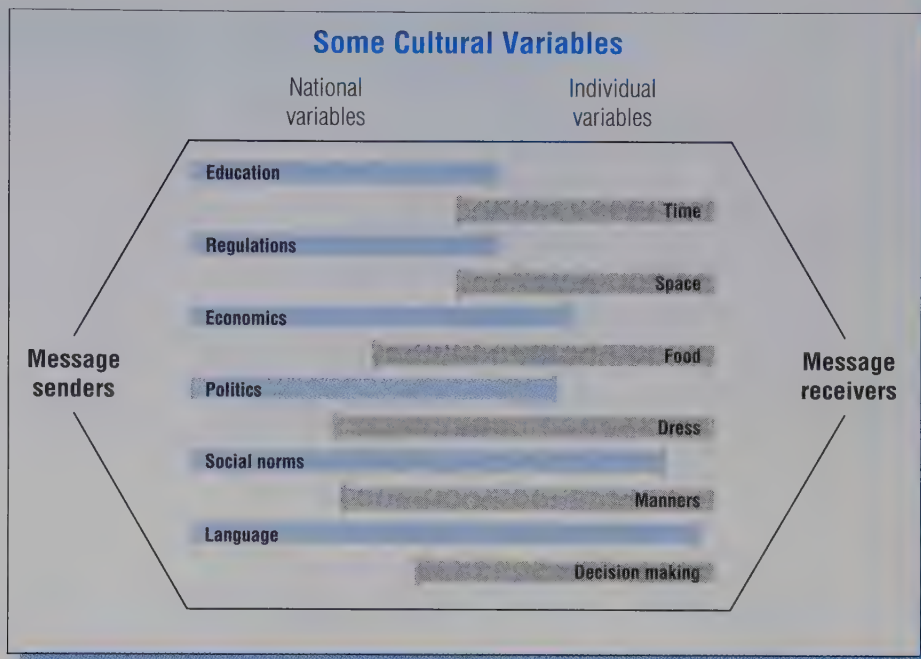


Figure 3.3 Overlapping cultural variables.

in general management. In the table on the next page, data are included for middle managers in the United States, Asia in general, and China.⁶

A quick assumption might be that Asians, particularly the Chinese, are less interested in education, that the nation is ill-equipped to hold its own with other

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As Eastern Europe opens itself to western capitalistic influences, it is beginning to search for contacts with Western universities and academic programs. Such contacts seek ways of linking both student and professorial interchanges: Both Eastern Europe—read “former Communist countries”—and Asian students suggest that when pursuing an M.B.A. degree they are introduced, in their mind, to some of the most radical and innovative business ideas they have experienced.

Bridging cultural gaps to the mind of the eastern European and Asian is half the battle; the other half is understanding the business protocols—and western forms of business communication. Thus, regardless of changes in current political thought, eastern European and Asian M.B.A. candidates and current degree holders are eager to combine and understand western management strategies with their own cultures.

Retaining managers. (1993, October 4). *Business China*, 5–6.

■ PERCENT OF MANAGERS RECOMMENDING SPECIFIC COURSES AS "VERY IMPORTANT" PREPARATION FOR GENERAL MANAGEMENT

Course	U.S.	Asia	China
Oral Communication	79.5%	71.8%	8.6%
Written Communication	78.0	69.7	8.0
Computer/Information Systems	53.4	27.0	21.1
Business Policy/Planning	47.5	48.2	14.1
Finance	39.9	38.5	30.9
Accounting	37.4	30.2	45.9
Personnel/Industrial Relations	36.0	36.1	37.7
Marketing	36.9	40.2	20.2
Business Economics/Public Policy	31.9	34.2	14.2
Business Law	26.0	19.1	8.5
Production/Operations	25.3	11.7	30.7
Statistics	18.1	10.8	16.9
Advertising/Sales	14.5	10.3	22.4
International Business	10.3	21.5	10.5

Before drawing conclusions from cultural data, it is necessary to consider many factors: A single cause rarely produces a valid conclusion.

parts of the world. If you made such an assumption, you would be wrong. You must go beyond your initial inference and assess the reasons that Chinese managers lack extensive education. You must go beyond surface conclusions:

1. In relation to its size, China does not have many institutions of higher education—in contrast to the United States. In 1980 there were only 675 institutions of higher education, increasing to 902 in 1984, and by 1985—the latest figures—the number had reached 1,016.
2. China is an agrarian economy. Over 800 million people still live in the countryside; 69 percent of the labor force is agricultural. Education, some early Chinese leaders felt, was not needed in such an environment.

■ Communication Probe

One should not get the idea that education means that all business courses receive the same emphasis throughout the world. Consequently, as our business schools and junior colleges offer basic business courses, including business communication, this latter course infrequently appears in college curriculums in Europe, for instance.

In a major study of German universities and junior colleges, the term *Kommunikation* as a criterion for excellence referred to the kind of communication between the universities and business managers outside the school. Few major schools in Germany offer classes in business or managerial communication—as we view the term in the United States. Often *Kommunikation* training occurs outside the university, in private and public seminars frequently taught by nonacademics.

Novizen aus der Provinz (Novices in [business education] located in the provinces). (1995). *Manager Magazine*, 1, 126–144.

3. Most universities were closed during the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976).
4. Self-study and private tutoring occurred during the Cultural Revolution, but for most young, college-aged people, education was not available.
5. A less educated Chinese manager—except between 1977–1980—faced an age maximum (age 25) for taking a college entrance examination.

Interpreting the above list demands an understanding of the political structure of China before concluding that communication is less important to the Chinese. In short, in a country rapidly opening its borders to capitalistic enterprises, communication continues to increase in importance: People today have more of an opportunity to express themselves than formerly.

Law and Regulations

Making mistakes in communication is easy in a foreign country. You or your legal department must be aware of strictness to the law or simply meeting the letter of the law.

In both the developed and developing nations, various government regulations affect business communications and the sale of products. For example, advertising directed at children is restricted in the United States, Canada, and Scandinavia. The type of product to be advertised—for instance, cigarettes—is restricted in Europe; also, money spent on advertising is limited. Other countries, such as France, Mexico, and the Province of Quebec, also have a restriction on the use of foreign languages in advertisements. In Iran it was difficult to show the World Cup tournaments held in the United States because American women who participated in the games exposed more of their bodies than is permitted in Iran; moreover, the sale of western publications showing unveiled women is forbidden. No fashion magazines are allowed into the country, and cosmetic makeup—including perfume—is prohibited. Women must wear either a *chador* (a head-to-toe veil) or a *manteau* (a loose smock worn over pants) with a scarf on the head. Men cannot wear short sleeves or T-shirts.

Economics

Availability of capital and transportation and the standard of living per capita vary from nation to nation. The opportunity to borrow money, the rate of inflation, and the exchange rates influence business and a country's ability to communicate concerning that business.

Under the U.S. free-enterprise system, competitors usually set their own prices. In contrast, OPEC (Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries), as a cartel, sets oil prices. Israeli agricultural competitors mutually agree on a price. Some Japanese businesses check with the government before initiating major production and trading changes. And only recently have freedoms associated with capitalism made inroads in Eastern Europe and the southern part of China.

Politics

Even concepts of democracy will vary as interpreted in Korea, the Philippines, or Great Britain. Indeed, the sweeping political changes in Eastern Europe and its altered concepts of government will affect future business relations. Even the

■ Checklist 3.1 National Cultural Variables Between Your Country and Your Host Country

1. Attitudes toward education
 - a. What is the level of education of middle managers?
 - b. To what degree is education of women supported in the country?
 - c. Does education constitute a significant portion of the national budget?
2. Laws and regulations: Degree of formality
 - a. To what extent are the laws of the country codified?
 - b. Is there uniform enforcement for the laws and regulations of the country?
 - c. Are the laws and regulations of your country accepted and enforced?
3. Economics: Past history and projections
 - a. Which economic changes have occurred within the past 5 years that will affect the future?
 - b. Is the government supportive of the economic changes occurring?
 - c. How welcome are outside investors in your host country?
 - d. May funds be removed easily from your host country?
4. Politics: Past history and projections for the future
 - a. Which political changes have occurred within the past 5 years?
 - b. How supportive is the government of outside investors? of joint ventures?
 - c. What are the protocols, the conventions individuals must respect in the host country?
5. Religion: Homogeneity and diversity of belief structure
 - a. Are you aware of the major religious beliefs that could affect your business relationships?
 - b. Will the religious holidays affect your rhythm of conducting business?
 - c. What personal behavior is acceptable and unacceptable?
6. Social norms: Importance of family, influence of past colonial influences
 - a. Are you aware of the social hierarchies of the country?
 - b. Is there a rank order of importance for participants at meetings?
 - c. Who will really make the business decision?
 - d. Which country's influence is still evident after previous colonial control?
7. Languages: Use of English and other languages used in business relationships
 - a. Is it necessary to have an interpreter at business sessions?
 - b. Is English understood at the oral or written level?
 - c. Is there a protocol to follow for formal and informal communication?

events in Tiananmen Square affected individual and business contacts with China; more changes will certainly occur in the future.

All such events affect communication, understanding of a country, and a company's willingness to do business in an unclear political environment.

For the measurement of potential political instability, there are classic indices and research studies⁷ that monitor events—such as antigovernment demonstrations, arrests, assassinations, elections, exile, general strikes, guerrilla warfare, government crises, purges, revolutions, and riots—in determining the stability of a country.

Religion

Be especially careful of religious beliefs within foreign countries. Although some basic beliefs overlap, there are major differences that, if not understood, can result even in personal harm.

In the United States we accept religious diversity; we are tolerant of Protestant, Catholic, Jewish, Buddhist, Hindu, Moslem, and many other personal beliefs. Other foreign countries are less tolerant—Iran, for instance—of diversity in religion.

In connection with religion there is great need for tolerance. Buddhism, Hinduism, and Moslem religions are found in many parts of the world, affecting the values (and attire) of people professing these faiths. For instance, these three religions forbid consumption of alcohol; thus no liquor is served at business affairs.

Religious holidays affect international communication, interrupting work schedules or delaying responses to requests. The *International Herald Tribune* is the excellent international newspaper that lists the current and upcoming holidays around the world.

Be aware too that religion can affect the status of women: their positions within an economy and even their buying patterns and habits of dress. Fortunately, many of the above middle eastern, European, South American, and Asian ethnic groups are present in the United States. To communicate well internationally, it also pays to understand the diversity patterns within one's own country.

Social Norms

In various ways any national environmental constraints—education, law and regulations, economics, politics, religion—affect a nation's social norms. In many countries a male line of the family profoundly influences some business decisions. Then the family and how its members relate to one another—decisions, buying patterns, pooling of resources, special interests—affect behavior and business communication.

Beyond the immediate family a bond may exist between persons, based on caste, class, age, or even special interests. Be aware of a nation's social norms.

Language

All agree: Knowing the language of your host country is the most significant contributor to improved communication, on a personal and a business level.

An important constraint that undergirds all the preceding variables is language. Obviously, unless both sender and receiver understand a common language, the opportunities for successful business communication are significantly limited.

English is a world language—and to a major extent the language of business. But, you will do a better job overseas if you know some basic vocabulary of

■ Communication Probe

Government decrees banning television receiving disks and even intended legislation against English words and programs are not uncommon. Underlying such prohibitions against English is the fear that a nation or ethnic group will diminish its cultural heritage. A further argument is that through learning another nation's language or being exposed to others' customs, literature, and people, nationalities will weaken their own identity.

Few countries question that English is the language of international communication. Knowing English is to master the political and economic realities for the future. However, in learning English and being exposed to western ideas, there is little doubt in this admonition outside the United States: Learn English for modern living and modern business, but do not replace core cultural qualities.

Bond, M. (1991). *Beyond the Chinese face*. Hong Kong: Oxford University Press.

your host country. Your informal contacts and your off-the-road visits and travels will take you to places where “no speak the English” will be heard. Younger people overseas often know English; fewer older people do. Yet interpersonal bonds are forged between you and your hosts by your trying to learn the language—with all your errors. Each language has its own sentence patterns and vocabulary. Thus, writing and speaking in a second language are more prone to errors.

It is an easy task to find support for this assertion: Language problems are often core to communication misunderstandings. Published support—in a study of international business communication—appears for the countries of England, Belgium, Germany, France, Poland, India, Japan, Hong Kong, Canada, Brazil, Peru, and South Africa. Undoubtedly businesspersons and scholars from other countries would also agree.⁸

INDIVIDUAL CULTURAL VARIABLES

All people value their individual freedom. Often this freedom is expressed in one's own ethnic diversity.

Think of the preceding discussion as noting the macro national characteristics affecting communication—both intranational and international. These are the overriding sections of the cultural petals discussed earlier. Yet living within that overall cultural petal is the individual person; he or she exhibits a unique lifestyle of personal habits and ethnic diversity. Thus, within each culture, on the micro and more personal level, are differences in verbal and nonverbal cues expressed through varying concepts of time, individual speech, food, acceptable dress, manners at home and at work, decision-making patterns, and other nonverbal variations.

Time (Chronemics)

Persons in Latin America and the Middle East treat time more casually than do Americans, who usually prefer promptness. Germans are time-precise; rarely do

you wait for an appointment in Germany. In Latin America—and in Buddhist cultures—you may wait an hour; your host is not showing disrespect thereby, just reflecting a different concept of time; arriving late is a socially accepted custom.

In some cultures business people take afternoon naps, close shops, and postpone times for business meetings and dinner. German law specifies definite opening and closing hours for business and dictates which evening(s) retail stores may be open.

Even when referring to seasons of a year, countries differ. Some speak of the rainy and the dry season; Americans and Europeans think of spring, summer, fall, and winter.

Briefly, people in the United States think of time as linear: Journeys begin, journeys end; days begin, days end; seasons start, seasons stop. Others think of time as circular: “all in good time” for some cultures is precise enough.

Culture I

“Let’s get on with it.”
 “Time-saving devices”
 “In how many minutes can you get here?”
 “Let’s set a phone appointment for 8:15.”
 “The future is now.”
 “Live for today.”
 “8:15”
 “You’re late.”
 “Dinner at eight.”

Culture II

“Mañana” (*tomorrow*)
 “Efficient devices”
 “What will be will be.”
 “We’ll give you a call.”
 “The old way is a good way.”
 “Traditions should be honored.”
 “Some time tomorrow”
 “Oh? Didn’t know I was.”
 “See you when we get there.”

In addition to different concepts of time, other factors—such as space restraints, lack of individual computers, and electric current interruptions—affect prompt communication.

It should not take you long to recognize which is the time-conscious culture and which is the one less concerned with precision in time. Knowing cultural perceptions of time helps you understand why some responses are slow—by your standards.

Space (Proxemics)

How close may strangers stand to you? What does it feel like when you are in a crowded elevator? Most Americans feel uncomfortable if a stranger comes closer than 18 inches.

- How do you react in Saudi Arabia when someone’s breath intentionally brushes you in conversation?
- How do you like being literally pushed into a train in Tokyo?
- How would you react hanging onto the outside of a bus in India?
- How do you react to the cold stare of a German as your eyes invade the privacy of his or her yard?

Americans demand more room—buffer space—between themselves and others when speaking. To some cultures (Arabs, Latin Americans), Americans who do not stand close seem cold and aloof. Conversely, some cultures consider those who stand close to you as intrusive, rude, pushy, overbearing.

Concepts of office space differ. In third-world countries, several people occupy the same office, even the same desk. Furniture is arranged according to alleged mystic powers. In Germany one's door is often closed; you knock before entering the room. You cannot assume that a western concept of space is accepted and understood throughout the world.

Food

It may be a good idea prior to visiting your host country to visit various ethnic restaurants in your home country. Then you'll have an initial idea as to the kinds of foods available: how they are served, fixed, or eaten.

It used to be that only the tourists in London or Tokyo would rush off to the ubiquitous McDonald's or that those in Beijing would order a Domino's pizza or a meal at Kentucky Fried Chicken. But now the natives in those countries also frequent such places. When we get off the beaten path, however, food—and its preparation—will vary. Pork is forbidden in middle eastern countries but is a part of the Asian diet and that of many other countries; beef is hard to find in India; veal is plentiful in Europe; rice is ever-present in Hong Kong and China.

In Asia, dark and light tea are national drinks—they also have good beer. In Europe, French workers enjoy a glass of wine with lunch, often a stated codicil in a labor contract. Alcohol, as stated in the preceding section under "Religion," is forbidden for Buddhists, Moslems, and Hindus. You can get into trouble by carrying liquor into some countries.

Cheese may be dessert in France, part of a sandwich in Denmark, or an hors d'oeuvre in Germany. Your palate must adapt as well as your view of time and space.

Or how do you react to how food is served, or what is served? Do you like to have food offered you from a rolling cart, as in eating *dim sum* in Hong Kong? Do you like eating with your fingers, as in an Ethiopian restaurant? How about soup so hot in taste that cold water is a necessary and efficient chaser in Thailand? Or, how proficient are you with chopsticks in picking up a peanut, as natives in many Asian countries can do? Not all the world eats the same, and that's what makes international travel and business so interesting.

Acceptable Dress

It is better to ask about the mode of dress for an occasion in your host country than to risk making an embarrassing mistake.

In most American businesses males wear the business suit whereas women wear dresses or tailored suits. And in great measure that "uniform" is common throughout the world, even in Eastern Europe as it adopts more capitalistic methods. Some of our British friends might still wear the bowler along with a dark suit and carry an umbrella; in India a Nehru jacket; in Singapore a long-sleeved shirt with a tie.

In the Middle East long cotton coats are acceptable. In some situations you may see the Hawaiian muumu, the Polynesian sarong, the Japanese kimono, the Iranian chador, or the Mao dark-blue jacket and pants.

Manners

Some cultural anthropologists suggest that you observe children in foreign cultures because by watching them you learn the behavioral habits of elders. Children shake your hand in Germany, hug you in Italy, and often stay in the background in India. In fact, the ritual of the greeting and the farewell is more formal

overseas with children and adults. You bring a gift when visiting most homes in Europe. If you bring flowers, you avoid gifts of red roses in Germany or white chrysanthemums in France, Belgium, and Japan. Adopting the manners of a country may mean a 2- to 3-hour lunch in Europe is acceptable, if you can call up your patience. Be prepared to sit close together in Asia: 12 people at a rather small round table, eating with chopsticks, is not unusual.

In Saudi Arabia, you will learn that sons defer to their fathers, that age is paramount, that a junior prince is silent when a senior enters. At the heart of their system is the family, the House of Saud. To know even these few cultural manners is to begin understanding this country in the Middle East.

Decision Making

Patience—above all—is needed in intercultural communication, in doing business with other countries. Americans are typecast as moving too quickly in asking for a decision. Give more thought to inductive communication.

Americans are accused of being brusque; we wish to get to the point—fast. “Getting down to business” is a trait of our western culture. The Germans, Singaporeans, Swiss, Dutch, and Scandinavians are similar, quickly getting to the issue. In contrast, the Chinese, Italians, French, and British prefer more leisuring social amenities.

When one reaches Japan, decision time is held back as group consensus moves toward a decision. Participation, by many people, is the touchstone. As you can imagine, much time is spent in reaching an answer. That is what frustrates Americans; that is where we throw up our hands. Unhappily, we do not try to understand that for the Japanese the system of participative decision making works, that the *ringi* process (stamps of approval by many people on a proposal) means that underlying agreement is obtained in advance of beginning an action.

One of your authors lectured, visited, consulted, and entertained in an Asian country for 8 years before his hosts felt comfortable enough to offer assistance with some research projects. At the end of a dinner in the eighth year, a senior member declared: *We now know you!* We’re ready to help with your research projects.” Eight years—8 *years*—to gain approval of the projects and interpersonal acceptance by the hosts.

Thus patience—and your understanding of the decision process—add to your success in dealing with a foreign environment.

Verbal and Nonverbal Communication

Although verbal and nonverbal forms of communication occur throughout this book, a separate section is required to point up additional differences across cultures.

Verbal

Regardless of culture, a kind of verbal sparring occurs when strangers meet, each seeking to determine which topics are acceptable and noncontroversial. Additionally, the tone of voice of one’s initial words can influence your initial perception of whether the meeting is positive or negative.

Even the oral phrase “how would you like to” can have either a direct or an indirect meaning; it could be a command or a question. In Australia it is taken as a request and not a question; in the United States it is a question. “See you later” can mean the same day to some Asian workers or some indefinite time in the fu-

We judge people to a great extent by their voice. Some native languages demand many tonal variations, giving the impression to a non-native of loudness, even arrogance.

■ Checklist 3.2 Individual Cultural Variables Between Your Country and Your Host Country

1. Perceptions of time
 - a. Is the concept of time considered linear or circular?
 - b. What impact will time have upon business decisions?
 - c. Is time considered valuable or an intangible asset?
2. Perceptions of space—What is the average acceptable personal space between natives of the host country?
3. Perceptions of food
 - a. Are you aware of the eating habits of your hosts?
 - b. Are there table conventions you should be aware of?
 - c. Are there foods you might find disagreeable?
4. Perception of dress
 - a. How much skin may be exposed in both an informal and in a formal situation?
 - b. Are certain colors disturbing?
 - c. Will western attire be accepted?
5. Perceptions of manners
 - a. What is the protocol regarding the introduction of persons in a business situation?
 - b. What are the “rules” of gift giving?
6. Perceptions of decision making
 - a. Is the pattern for making decisions consistent from one company to another?
 - b. Is placement of the major decision maker consistent in a meeting situation?
 - c. Is an inductive or a deductive pattern of decision making preferred?

ture to Americans. A response of “Yes” from an Asian may mean “yes” or “no.” “Anytime” to a Greek means he or she would welcome you with no time limit. In China you may utter the Chinese expression “*she-she*” (“thank you”) for your tea, or tap your fingers on the tablecloth, nonverbally indicating gratitude.

If you traveled abroad or flew on foreign airlines, you may have been surprised at the volume level of some person’s speech. What to us is loud and raucous, perhaps sounding like a fight, is considered normal and accepted by Arabs. Some Japanese use little volume, again accepted and part of a cultural heritage. Tonal languages, such as Cantonese, demand more volume to suggest changes in word meanings, English less so.

■ Communication Probe

When people communicate, their verbal and nonverbal signals are influenced by their experiences and by their cultural backgrounds.

Obviously, people from the same culture—who, by definition, are more likely to have similar backgrounds and experiences—are more likely to interpret one another's words and actions accurately. However, even under ideal conditions, the message the receiver decodes is never identical to the message the sender transmits. And cultural differences greatly increase the chances that the message received will differ from the message sent.

Hulbert, J. (1994, March). Overcoming intercultural communication barriers. *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication*, 57(1) 41–44.

A myriad of nonverbal symbols exist for every culture, even in subcultures. Knowing the major desirable and undesirable cues helps knowing both intended and unintended communication errors.

Nonverbal

A handshake is a traditional form of greeting in the West. In Polynesia, the traditional greeting is embracing and rubbing each other's back. Eskimos rub noses as a form of greeting; a kiss on the cheek or lips signifies the same thing in many western cultures. In China and Japan public kissing is frowned on, an action reserved for one's private life. Touch as a form of behavior varies and is limited to certain persons.

Facial expressions vary across cultures. You could get the wrong impression when some Filipinos smile and laugh, when underneath this behavior they are angry. Or, the inscrutable facial expression of the Japanese does not suggest disinterest, rather an unwillingness to make public one's inner thoughts.

■ Checklist 3.3 Verbal Communication: Differences Between Your Country and Your Host Country

1. Volume of the voice
 - a. Are you aware if the language is tonal; i.e., does the language require variations in volume and pitch in order for the word to be understood?
 - b. Is meaning dependent upon major tonal variations?
2. Pitch of the voice
 - a. Are you aware of the need for pitch variation for meaning to occur between two people?
 - b. Are emotional states communicated via variations in pitch?
3. Rate of the voice—Is the culture known for speech delivered rapidly?

■ Checklist 3.4 Nonverbal Communication: Differences Between Your Country and Your Host Country

1. Gestures in communicating
 - a. Are you aware of any undesirable gestures that may affront?
 - b. To what extent should the hands be used in communicating?
 - c. What is a desirable posture when sitting at a meeting?
 - d. Is it desirable to bow, or should that be left to the host country persons?
2. Eye contact in communicating
 - a. Is it desirable to maintain direct eye contact during conversations?
 - b. Are you aware of the visual cues that suggest the conversation is ended or that it is your turn to speak?

The meaning of gestures varies. What we think is an innocent gesture (the “O.K.” sign with thumb and forefinger together) may be obscene in parts of Italy; a thumbs up is a positive sign in the United States; in Greece it is negative, suggesting “sit on this.” This is not the place to review the hundreds of gestures and body motions used in different cultures; several good books are devoted solely to this topic.⁹

You can see that it is not safe to assume that gestures used in all innocence in the United States are accepted in the same manner throughout the world. Be aware; be cautious; know the variations that could cause failures in communication or complete distrust of you as a communicator.

SUMMARY

It is difficult to assert that definite behaviors will consistently be used throughout a country by *all* persons. Times change. Cultures change. Ethnic diversities change. Yet, consider the following maxims on intercultural communication:

- Recognize that one’s own country is a mixture of various ethnic groups; understanding the diversity of one’s own country is fundamental before looking abroad.
- Avoid drawing conclusions for an entire cultural group based on only a few examples.
- Understand that communication breakdowns are more the result of misunderstandings in culture than grammatical or stylistic issues.
- Avoid judging others on the basis of your own culture; each country has

its long-established traditions. The United States does not have a monopoly on preferred business communication principles or procedures.

With those four maxims as background, this chapter suggested that each culture, each ethnic group within a culture, has a generally accepted, recognizable behavior. If most of that behavior is familiar to us, we are comfortable. If there are major differences, we feel uncomfortable. Time is needed to adapt to and understand another culture.

Basic to any country are certain national variables—those mega principles that indirectly affect its population. Thus we learn something about a country's culture by knowing the educational levels of the population, the legal and regulatory restraints affecting business, the economic philosophies or national and foreign trade practices, the political attitudes, the religion as practiced by the state or the individual, the social norms of the state, and the language. Each of the above affects international communication.

Within each country are individual people—all with their own personal behaviors involving how they handle time, what a comfortable distance for interpersonal communication is, what foods are wholly acceptable, what is considered appropriate dress, what the unwritten personal manners within a home or office are, what procedures and speed are followed in arriving at personal and business decisions. Finally, cultures have both verbal and nonverbal communication characteristics; what is acceptable in one culture may be entirely unacceptable in another.

Your effectiveness in communicating well and succeeding overseas requires adapting to many factors. Knowing even the polite forms of a foreign language is helpful, as is knowing some differences in writing and speaking. Do some research into various organizations and journals interested in international business and communication. Finally, ask questions, in both personal and business areas. Then you are on the way to successful intercultural communication.

■ Communication Probe

Japan, as a major force in Asia, is no different from other Asian countries: All—just like the European nations—face similar communication problems. “Being misunderstood” is a loud complaint—around the world. And as this chapter notes, historical, political, economic, social, cultural, and psychological differences between Americans and Japanese impede effective communication. Fukushima notes five communication problems, to which your authors add, these problems are common with other countries as well: Unintentional misunderstandings, use of intentionally ambiguous statements, lack of an English or a Japanese equivalent word, meaning errors when translating material, and Japanese desire for pretense rather than observed reality.

Fukushima, G. (1995, March). “Misunderstanding” Japan. *Tokyo Business Today*, 63, 48.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

All Exercises and Questions for This Chapter Are International in Nature

1. **Significant and Representative Issues of a Country's Culture.** Choose any country you wish. Then complete a brief memorandum that summarizes major cultural issues that you feel could affect business and communication with that country. You may wish to select headings from the following list:

- Basic principles for doing business
- Forms of address
- Courtesies in formal and informal settings
- Language
- Religion
- Entertainment
- Nonverbal and verbal behaviors
- Principles of negotiation, decision-making patterns.

2. **Oral Team Reports on a Country's Variables That May Affect Business and Communication.** Appoint several teams within the class. Each team is responsible for selecting a single country and then orally reporting to the class some of that country's national environmental variables and individual environmental variables that may affect business and communication. A possible outline might include the following points:

The Country

Land and climate
History and government
Economy
Education
Transportation
Health

Lifestyles of the Country

Position of the family
Social and economic levels
Business hours
Food

The People of the Country

Population
Language
Religion
Holidays
Attitudes

Cultural Customs

Methods of greeting one another
Nonverbal behavior

Words and Phrases

3. **Comparison of U.S. and Chinese Idioms.** While numerous differences exist between cultures, there are also high degrees of commonality. One sees this commonness when comparing idioms or sayings between two cultures. We in the United States are familiar with the idioms in the left col-

umn. Match them with their Chinese counterparts in the right column. (Answers are in the Instructor's Manual.)

Familiar to Americans

- a. It's the bad apple that spoils the barrel.
- b. It takes two to tango.
- c. Speak of the devil.
- d. It's like building castles in the air.
- e. Don't bite off more than you can chew
- f. A drop in the bucket.
- g. As ye sow, so shall ye reap.
- h. To lock the barn door after the horse is gone.
- i. It's water over the dam.
- j. Where there's smoke, there's fire.
- k. Like comparing apples and oranges.
- l. On pins and needles.
- m. Picky, picky, picky.
- n. The truth will out.

Familiar to Chinese

- _____ The head of the cow does not fit the mouth of the horse.
- _____ It's impossible to clap with only one hand.
- _____ Paper cannot wrap up fire.
- _____ One hair from nine oxen.
- _____ The wood has already been used in making the boat.
- _____ You ride a tiger and find it hard to get off.
- _____ To dig a well only after one is thirsty.
- _____ Like ants on top of hot cooking pot.
- _____ If one plants melons, one gets melons.
- _____ Like climbing a tree to catch a fish.
- _____ The horse that leads the herd astray.
- _____ Blow on the hair and search for tiny sores.
- _____ When you speak of Ts'ao Ts'ao, Ts'ao Ts'ao arrives.
- _____ There are no waves if there is no wind.

4. *Written Memo Report and Oral Presentation on a Foreign Country Investment.* Combine both an oral and a written assignment according to the following structure.

- | | |
|---------------------|--|
| Subject: | Present an Individual Research Memorandum and Oral Presentation on a Foreign Country Investment |
| Action requested: | Recommend whether a company—of your choice—should expand, establish a subsidiary, permit franchising, or locate an overseas office in a named foreign country. |
| Goal of assignment: | <ol style="list-style-type: none"> 1. To bring together (a) original work and (b) secondary information in a memorandum that includes a clear recommendation on whether a company—selected by you—should or should not invest resources in that country. 2. To present the results of your research in an oral briefing, attempting to persuade the class on a course of action. |

Procedure: 1. Each class member may select from the list at the end of this exercise a foreign country for analysis, setting his or her own criteria as to whether investing resources in that country is desirable or undesirable.

2. Your instructor should receive two copies of your memorandum on the day of your oral presentation. All class members will on the day of your presentation also receive copies of your memorandum. Example of headings you may wish to include:

TO: International Review Committee (your class)

FROM: Your name and the group or division you represent.

SUBJECT: Include a clear, definite statement of purpose. Include a verb to give a sense of direction.

DATE:

Introduction: (1) Opening paragraph important. Here restate what is being recommended or will be discussed. Why is topic important? What is previous to discussion? What are criteria?

(2) Supply definitions if needed.

(3) Layout of position you wish accepted or will discuss; *divisio* (agenda) of how material will be developed.

Body: (1) Entire body of memorandum includes (a) background discussion and (b) rationale for your recommended action.

(2) Evidence for your recommendation should include findings, examples, statistics, analogies, quotations, charts. (An appendix may be added for visual supports or other related material.)

(3) Usually use one paragraph for each major issue or conclusion.

(4) Transitions may be used to clearly move ideas along.

Conclusion: (1) Restate recommendation you wish accepted.

(2) Look into the future—visualize what will occur if proposal or conclusions are or are not accepted.

3. Class procedure:

- a. Proper grammatical form, proper footnote and bibliographic form should be used throughout.
- b. Distribute your memorandum to each member of the class.
- c. The class will challenge or question you *during* your oral presentation.
- d. You will receive a written critique of your memo and presentation from your instructor.

Possible macro sources for background research include the following:

The Economist Intelligence Unit (EIU), Country Profile (country reports on over 180 countries).

Area Handbook Series, Foreign Area Studies, The American University (country reports on over 100 countries).

United States Department of State, *Background Notes*, Washington, D.C. (country reports on about 180 countries).

5. Foreign Student Perceptions of Differences or Similarities Between Their Native Language and Native English Speakers. The major sections of this assignment depend on the individual foreign student: He or she should report on at least two or three areas of difference between their native language and English. For example:

Spanish:	Complexity of Spanish grammar, particularly tenses How Spanish vowels differ from English vowels Accents and their use in Spanish
Portuguese:	Spoken Portuguese: differences in sounds Written Portuguese: use of the inductive method
German:	Problems of positioning the verb Problems connected with gender
Japanese:	Differences between Japanese vowels and English vowels Vowel sound differences between Japanese and English

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Business Communication and the Ethical Context*

I. Background to Ethical Contexts

- A. Ethical Situations
- B. Ethics As a Communication Issue
- C. Ethics in Corporations—An Historical View

II. Influences on Personal Ethics

- A. People
- B. Culture
- C. Philosophy
- D. Law
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III. Communication and Ethical Issues

- A. Legal Issues
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IV. Summary

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On Nov. 1, 1993, the U.S. Department of Transportation fined Continental Airlines \$20,000 for not selling enough seats at the advertised discount fare. Continental had advertised an attractive fare from Newark, N.J., to Europe and sold about 8 percent of the seats at the advertised price. The Department of Transportation argued that at least 10 percent of the seats had to be sold at the discount fare. “We felt there were a sufficient number of seats available and the DOT felt otherwise,” replied a Continental spokesperson. “In order to avoid costly litigation, we chose to pay the fine.”¹

*A Chinese manager of a luxury hotel in Beijing could not find his watch and an expensive pen that had been given to him as gifts. He went through the desk drawers of his subordinates looking for the missing items. A lower-level manager observed this behavior and called it unethical.*²

Did Continental Airlines mislead the public with its advertising? Is offering 8 percent of a product at the advertised price sufficient? Did Continental behave unethically? Was the Chinese manager’s behavior unethical? These questions are not easily answered; ethical issues are complex and challenging areas of decision making.

This chapter views ethical issues arising in communication contexts. Specifically, we focus on some ethical contexts affecting communication, consider how your own personal ethics were formed and continue to be influenced, and examine ethical motives in your personal, cross-cultural, and advertising messages. Finally, we consider ethics in organizations and look at how organizations institutionalize and communicate ethical values.

BACKGROUND TO ETHICAL CONTEXTS

Making ethical decisions is relatively easy when all the facts of a situation are known.

Making ethical decisions is easy when you know the facts, the events are unambiguous, and the choices are clear. But it is different when evidence is missing, and multiple points of view conflict. How should one handle ambiguities and make the right ethical decisions when the issues are unclear? Ethics is about making right and wrong decisions. Ethical principles, the focus of this chapter, assist in making those decisions. These principles center around fairness, service, quality, integrity, excellence, compassion, honesty, and dignity.

Ethical Situations

You make ethical decisions every day; you build on a concept of right and wrong; you establish certain ethical principles. Consider the following situations. How would you react?

1. During an on-campus interview, a recruiter asks you why he should hire you over another candidate (a classmate of yours). You have some negative information about this person. Do you share it with the recruiter?
2. You witness another student cheating during an important accounting exam. Do you confront the student? Do you tell other students or a professor about the incident?

3. A firm invites you for a second interview at its corporate office. You are not especially interested in this company, but you are considering taking the trip because you have a good friend you would like to visit in a distant city and you could use the frequent-flyer mileage. Do you accept the interview?

A quick response to the above three incidents is that you would always make the right and moral decision: Friendship should take precedence over personal gain. Cheating is wrong and should not go unchallenged. If a job does not interest you, do not pretend that it does and accept the plane ticket and hotel room.

But *are* these the right and moral decisions? Are there circumstances when you would act differently? Why not tell the recruiter damaging information about the other candidate? After all, it's a competitive world. Perhaps you would ask the person cheating why he or she had done it. The answer may put the unethical act into a different context. Should you take the recruiting trip even though you are not interested? Why not give the company a chance to change your mind? Putting ethical events into different contexts changes the way we perceive the event. The *right* answer is not always clear.

As a manager you will face similar ethical dilemmas; you will be tested as to what is right and wrong. Consider two scenarios, part of a study in which 1,500 club, accounting, and hotel managers gave their responses.³ How would you react in each situation?

1. A hotel food and beverage manager recently purchased 20 cases of wine from a new beverage purveyor. Without the manager's advance knowledge, the purveyor delivers a free case to the manager's residence. The manager decides to keep the free case for his personal use since the free case did not influence his purchase of the 20 cases for the hotel.
2. A restaurant manager contracts with Spotters, Inc., to provide "customers" to spy on the bartenders to determine whether they are preparing drinks according to the standard recipe and whether they are charging customers properly for all drinks served.

Do you agree with the hospitality manager in incident 1? Would you accept the wine under certain conditions? Would you hire professionals to spy on your employees, as in incident 2?

Study results indicated that most managers believed it was wrong to accept the wine; however, they had no problem with spying on employees and even indicated that this was an accepted practice. This same group of managers also did not object to testing a cashier's integrity by slipping \$50 into the cash drawer to see if it was reported as an overage at the end of the shift. The practices of spying and testing honesty are common in the hospitality industry.

Context of a situation influences the ethicality of a decision.

Ethics As a Communication Issue

"We are not human beings having a spiritual experience. We are spiritual beings having a human experience."
Pierre Teilhard de Chardin.

We communicate our values and beliefs to others via verbal and nonverbal behavior. We are defined in the eyes of others according to the way we behave. It follows, then, that we have a responsibility to act in ways that promote honesty and fairness to maximize the personal worth of each person in the organization.

We also need to communicate to others the importance and necessity of good ethics.

Foremost, corporate leaders and managers set a corporation's ethical tone. Leaders' actions demonstrate corporate values, whether the organization is corrosive, manipulative, and prone to deviousness or whether it is honest, open, and willing to admit possible failures.

In 1987 the Chrysler Corporation was indicted for mail and wire fraud and conspiracy after it was learned that Chrysler had disconnected the odometers on new cars so that assembly plant managers could take them home for test drives. Managers were to keep them only one night, but some drove the cars for a few weeks; some even had minor accidents. Later, the cars were sold as new. In both print and television, Lee Iacocca said, "America, we apologize. Testing cars is a good idea. Disconnecting odometers is a lousy idea. That's a mistake we won't make again at Chrysler. Period."⁴

Although some say that Chrysler attorneys dragged their feet in identifying and compensating people who had purchased these cars, Lee Iacocca nevertheless made the right ethical decision regarding corporate wrongdoing.

A major conclusion is this: Ethical leaders speak out when something is wrong; ethical people influence others by acting in line with their personal values. Often we know what is right, but we lack the impetus or collective feeling that reinforces our acting ethically in the face of other choices. Observing other people making the right choices inspires us and supports others to do the same.

Ethics in Corporations—An Historical View

The American public, historically, has not viewed business favorably. Nineteenth century "robber barons" were ruthless in driving out competition to build monopolies. They often exploited immigrant laborers, children, and minority workers as cheap labor. So it is not surprising that the integrity of corporate America has been questioned repeatedly over the years.

- The 1960s—In 1966, Lewis Harris conducted a poll indicating that 42 percent of Americans agreed with the statement "Most businessmen will do anything—honest or not—for a buck."⁵
- The 1970s—Many perceived business as profiting from the Vietnam War and the defense budget. Protests occurred on college campuses when the CIA and corporations linked to the defense industry tried to recruit on campus.
- The 1980s—One poll showed that 55 percent of the public thought most executives were dishonest. Another mutually conducted poll by the *New York Times* and CBS found that 56 percent of the respondents rated businesses "fair" or "poor" in terms of their contributions to the well-being of the communities where their plants were located.⁶

Rightly or wrongly, the public has doubts about the ethics of corporate America.

A 1992 Gallup Poll indicated that only about 20 percent of the respondents rated the honesty and ethical standards of businesspeople "high" or "very high."⁷ And in 1993, from a list of 25 professions, the ethical standards of businesspeople were rated thirteenth—lower than journalists, reporters, and lawyers but higher than U.S. senators, representatives, and used-car salesmen.⁸

Publicity via the news media often alerts the public to corporate ethical crises.

Ethics is a concern for American business. When crises occur, such as Exxon's Alaskan oil spill or Union Carbide's chemical leak in Bhopal, India, the press, the public, and the stakeholders scrutinize an organization's actions. Considerable damage was done to Exxon's reputation; eventually the firm was assessed a considerable fine.⁹

However, corporations are only as good as the people working within them. Stephen R. Covey, author of *The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People*, notes that "organizational behavior is individual behavior collectivized."¹⁰ In other words, the ethics of an organization are only as good as the integrity of the people who belong to it.

We are constantly faced with ethical issues. You will find it difficult to study, work, or live in an environment free of ethical decisions. How you handle each ethical issue reflects your values and communicates critical messages to others. Our organizations, both profit and nonprofit, need individuals with strong ethical values to lead us into the twenty-first century.

INFLUENCES ON PERSONAL ETHICS

Everyone—young students, older teachers—makes ethical decisions. Have you returned everything you found? Have you kept information from someone who would also benefit from the knowledge? Were you quiet when you were aware that facts were omitted? Reflect for a moment: How did you react to the above questions; what influenced your final decision?

Your personal ethics are shaped by five major influences: (1) influential people in your life (family, close friends, or a role model); (2) cultural norms; (3) philosophical positions; (4) local, state, and federal laws that govern individual behavior; and (5) your personal religious views. Figure 4.1 illustrates how these five areas influence your personal ethics.

People

Your family played a large part in shaping your personal ethics.

Your family members and friends exert strong influence on your ethics; Your parents and other family members shaped your ethical value system early on.

■ Communication Probe

Do shareholders want their companies to act ethically, or are they primarily interested in profits?

One study revealed that 42 percent of shareholders do not expect a high level of ethical behavior from either corporate leaders or employees. But 58 percent said they would be willing to sacrifice corporate for ethical behavior. Although this is not a strong mandate for ethics over profits, it is clear that the majority of shareholders place ethics first. Further, over 70 percent of the shareholders surveyed said they would like to see disclosure about ethics in the annual report.

Damatito, S., & Schmidgall, R. (1993). Hospitality professionals' responses to ethical situations. *The Cornell HRA Quarterly*, 34(4), 40–43.

■ Communication Probe

Research indicates that we perceive ourselves to be more ethical than other people with whom we compare ourselves. This means that most of us think we are more ethical than everyone else. One study examined both college students' and practicing accountants' perceptions of their personal ethics and found that both groups saw themselves as acting more ethically than other people. Are we really as ethical as we think we are?

Tyson, T. (1992). Does believing that everyone else is less ethical have an impact on work behavior? *Journal of Business Ethics*, 11, 707–717.

Teachers, especially when you were younger, may have laid the foundation for ethical decisions.

Conditioning has shaped your conscience; your parents have left an imprint on you as to what is right and wrong. Values we gleaned from family members and influential people tend to stay with us throughout our lives.

Teachers are also influential. You were likely taught a number of values in school that reinforced your parents' teaching. Later, you may have admired a close friend, relative, or teacher; you may have made a deliberate choice to emulate this person's behavior, modeling your own actions after him or her. Your peers also influence your ethics. And you, in turn, choose people to be close to you who share your same value system.

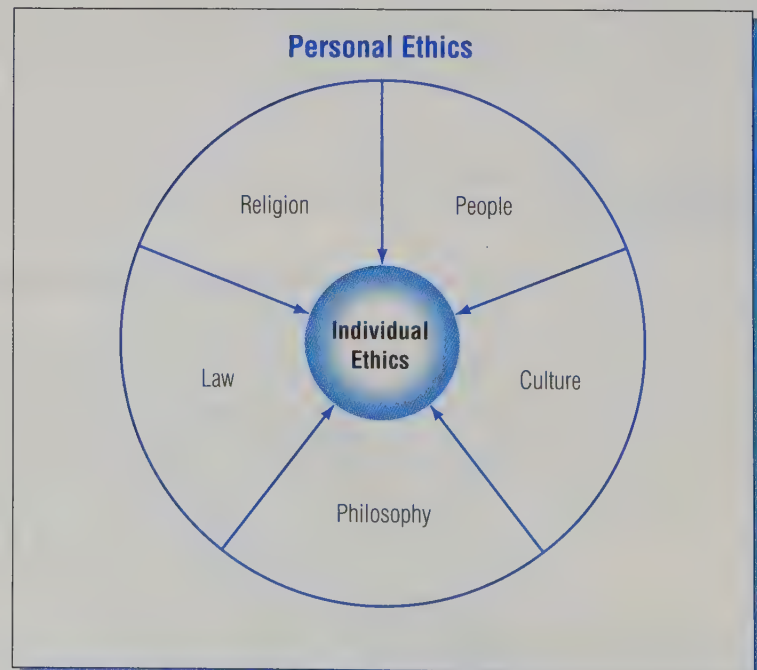


Figure 4.1 Influences on personal ethics.

Culture

Each culture, over time, acquires its own set of values.

Your culture taught you certain ethical values. If you grew up in a city, you may have different values from someone who was raised in a small town. Similarly, those of you not raised in the United States have values determined by your own country and culture. Americans have been influenced primarily by Judeo-Christian ethics along with myths, stories, and legends that explain our past. Children growing up in the United States learned, for example, that George Washington chopped down his father's cherry tree; young Washington then confessed, saying he could not tell a lie. We also learned that Abraham Lincoln, as a young man clerking in a store, walked several miles to return a penny that he had overcharged a customer. Expected cultural behaviors are taught in these stories.

Children growing up in China learn a song about a child who finds a penny on the street, turns it in to an officer, and then is praised by the officer for performing a good act. The symbolism is transparent. In America, if we find a penny, our culture says we can keep it for "good luck"; in China, it belongs to the government. But if you find more than a penny, what are you supposed to do? If you find something of considerable value, what does the culture in which you live expect of you?

Philosophy

Theories of philosophy have long been concerned with ethical and moral issues.

Descriptive ethics and normative ethics are names for two major types of philosophical inquiry. Descriptive ethics reflect facts about the moral judgments or beliefs of a person or group of people. Normative ethics, on the other hand, involve discovering, formulating, and defining fundamental moral principles. This latter concept asks what actions are good and right, and thus which should be performed. With business ethics, we are primarily concerned with normative ethics and with what is moral and right, and contributes positively to the human experience. A number of these normative philosophical perspectives exist, but four important ones that can affect business and personal decisions are cited here:

1. *Theologism*: A moral perspective that attempts to pattern actions according to God's will. The theologist asks "What would God have me do in this situation?"
2. *Deontology*: The study of moral obligations or duty. The deontologist considers moral obligations to be knowable by intuition and without reference to the concept of good. Deontologists evaluate acts regardless of their consequences. The pure deontologist, for example, believes that you should always tell the truth.
3. *Teleology*: The study of evidence of design in nature. Events can be explained by final causes. Teleologists morally evaluate actions by examining consequences. The pure teleologist for example, believes that the singular duty is to maximize good consequences.
4. *Utilitarianism*: A form of teleology that argues that an act is morally right if it maximizes utility—that is, if the number of people helped is

greater than the number of people harmed. Utilitarians believe in the greatest good for the greatest number.

Your actions in a situation depend on which philosophical perspective or perspectives reflect your personal beliefs. Suppose a deranged gunman is holding five people hostage at gunpoint in the lobby of a bank. He asks if any other customers or employees are in the bank. You know that three customers escaped to the backroom along with a teller. Do you tell him the truth? The theologist would consider what God would want and whether a lie in this circumstance would be God's will. An extreme deontologist would tell the gunman about the other people, for he or she would believe that a lie is never justified. The teleologist, to maximize good consequences, and the utilitarian, for the good of the majority, probably would not tell. The utilitarian would also be the least troubled if a police sniper killed the gunman. One life would be sacrificed for a group of innocent hostages; thus a greater good would be achieved as a number of innocent lives would be saved.

These philosophical views are by no means a full representation of viewpoints; rather they help us identify some of the important questions. Do the ends justify the means? Should individuals always tell the truth? What does it mean to maximize good consequences? What is "good"? The answers to these and other important questions depend on your philosophical perspective.

Law

Laws, some argue, represent the minimum standard of behavior.

Some individuals view ethics from a legal perspective: Acting ethically means following the law. Is a legal definition of ethics too simplistic? Perhaps the law represents a minimum standard of behavior. Codes of ethics for various professions, such as accounting, law, and medicine, require standards of behavior that exceed the law.

But what if you consider a law to be wrong—unethical or unjust? Henry David Thoreau addressed this viewpoint in his essay "Civil Disobedience," as did Martin Luther King in his "Letter from the Birmingham Jail." Thoreau did not want to pay taxes to support war, and King argued that because segregation laws were unjust, no one had a moral obligation to follow them.

Religion

Religions throughout the world are major foundations for ethical behavior among followers.

Sanctity of life is a predominant characteristic of the major religions of the world.

Using religion as the grounding for your ethical behavior means you act according to what you believe God wants you to do. Christians take advice from the Bible and the teachings of Jesus Christ; Muslims follow the teaching of Mohammed, the Arab prophet and founder of Islam; Buddhists adhere to the writings of Gautama Buddha; Confucianists follow the teachings of the ancient Chinese philosopher, Confucius. Many other religions and sects of these mainstream religions provide moral guidance as to one's duty to God, other human beings, and all the living things on the earth. Underlying nearly all the major religions is the concept of a supreme being and respect for the sanctity of life.

Different ethical decisions usually require input from multiple perspectives. When doctors face a difficult ethical dilemma regarding a seriously ill patient,

they may convene the medical ethics committee: Other physicians, a rabbi or priest or minister, a hospital administrator, a psychologist or social worker, and a person with specialized training in medical ethics. A manager looking at a serious dilemma would also consult experts.

In sum, your approach to ethical problem solving is shaped by other people, culture, philosophy, laws, and religion. These perspectives create tensions between themselves and between you and other people. Values frequently conflict and compete with one another. Arriving at the right decision involves examining your beliefs in each area, deciding where your values lie, and acting accordingly.

COMMUNICATION AND ETHICAL ISSUES

Communicating ethically in the business arena challenges you on several levels. Legal issues have an impact on you personally and on the organization to which you belong. Organizational challenges include constructing a productive company culture with employees who have diverse backgrounds, values, and beliefs. In all these challenges, your personal system of values will influence yours and others' behavior in business.

Legal Issues

Legal considerations such as defamation and privacy are concerns in all organizations (see Appendix C). Statements that damage a person's name or reputation, are communicated to others, and involve false and malicious statements that may be defamatory. Written defamation is libel; oral defamation is slander. Individuals or companies can be sued for defamation of character. Although these are legal issues, they are also ethical issues because slander and libel violated basic principles of honesty, respect, and human dignity.

Our laws protect individual privacy. Of major concern are the large databases credit, marketing research firms, and medical companies collect (see Chapter 5). The proliferation of computerized data has greatly increased the chances that our private information can become public. For example, confidential medical data collected by health care institutions and HMOs must be protected. When organizations or individuals violate the privacy of a person by passing information to a third party, they can be found guilty of invasion of privacy.

You may wonder why a recruiting firm or potential employer asks you to sign a release so they can obtain a copy of your college transcript. Educational institutions may not disclose information about your performance or activities without your permission. They may, however, reveal to a third party the number of semesters you attended and whether you received a degree.

Other issues with both ethical and legal implications are discrimination and harassment. Discrimination involves deliberate actions to exclude certain groups of people. Legislation has been passed to prevent this from occurring in housing, education, and employment. Discrimination is unethical because it seeks to segregate individuals on the basis of race, sex, ethnic group, or national origin.

Harassment involves irritating or tormenting another person on a repeated basis. It can occur between coworkers, between supervisor and subordinate, between persons of different cultures, or between people who have grown up together. In 1986, the Supreme Court ruled that sexual harassment is a form of

Databases, unless carefully controlled, can become vast resources of information on your private matters.

Harassment and stalking laws are increasingly appearing on the books of various states.

■ Communication Probe

Is there equal opportunity for all people? Evidence of continuing racial and gender bias surfaced recently in a 1993 *Industry Week* survey of 1,300 middle managers from medium-sized companies in the United States. Ten percent said they preferred to hire a white male, and 92 percent reported a preference of working for a man rather than a woman. Acting on these preferences through discriminatory hiring is both illegal and unethical.

Altany, D. R. (1993). Torn between halo & horns. *Industry Week*, 242(6), 10–14.

sexual discrimination, and thus employees are granted legal protection from it. Harassment is both illegal and unethical. Harassing another person is also a poor way of communicating feelings and violates the principles of fairness, dignity, and respect for other people.

Plagiarism is also an ethical issue. It involves taking the ideas or written material of another person and using it as one's own. When you quote material from a source without acknowledging that source or when you copy material directly, you cause the reader to believe that the thoughts and ideas are your own. Such behavior is unethical because it involves misrepresentation and denies the original author proper acknowledgment. Students engaging in plagiarism may suffer academic integrity penalties and face possible expulsion from school. Worse, you could be sued for monetary and other damages.

Copyrighting affords legal protection for one's creative efforts. A copyright is granted to an author, publisher, or distributor for the exclusive publication, sale, and distribution of an original work. Violating copyrights is both unethical and illegal; originators of work may sue to reclaim any losses caused by copyright violations. However, not all countries share the same attitudes and respect for a copyright. The Russian computer market is growing very rapidly—an estimated 30 to 50 percent annually, but software companies say that more than 90 percent of the programs used are pirated; a similar situation exists in some Asian countries.

When in doubt, check with a legal representative regarding the latest copyright laws.

Key Areas for Ethical Communication

Ethical treatment of a subject takes time, thought, and preparation. As a manager, it is important for you to focus on ethical communication in three key areas:

■ Communication Probe

Pirated software has been a problem for American, Japanese, and European computer companies. The software industry estimates that Russian counterfeiting alone cost it \$75 million in 1993. Wherever the concept of private ownership is not developed, copyright issues can be viewed as unimportant.

Krantz, P. (1994). Taking on the "Superpower of Privacy." *Business Week*, 340(4), 166b.

Your personal written and spoken messages, cross-cultural messages, and the advertising your company creates. The latter area is important because our work is becoming increasingly international, and sensitivity to diversity is now an important managerial skill.

Personal Written and Spoken Messages

Your messages, both written and spoken, demonstrate not only the message you intend but also a message regarding your values and integrity. Use the guidelines in Checklist 4.1 to evaluate your purpose and motives in each situation.

■ Checklist 4.1 Guidelines for Ethical Spoken and Written Messages¹¹

1. *Message purpose.* If my purpose is accomplished, will it be in the best interests of my listeners? Will a small group benefit, or will the larger organization/society be served? Do I have any hidden agendas that affect my purpose and/or thesis?
2. *Research methods.* Are my sources recent, reliable, and unbiased? Was my research thorough? Have I explored all avenues in gathering information pertinent to my subject and purpose?
3. *Selection of material.* Have I chosen information that will communicate my ideas fairly and accurately? Are my sources representative of the information available on my topic? Have I avoided the propaganda technique of card stacking (omitting relevant opposing information)?
4. *Development of ideas.* Have I relied too heavily on emotional appeals? Is my logic and reasoning sound? Have I avoided propaganda techniques that omit, exaggerate, or otherwise distort information? Is my information accurate and relevant?
5. *Use of language.* Am I easily understood by my listeners? Is my language appropriately concrete and specific, or have I relied on ambiguities, abstractions, and loaded words? Does my language show respect for my listeners?
6. *Ethical context.* Have I considered my listener's values, feelings, and attitudes in designing my presentation? Have I avoided using communication strategies that would take advantage of their role, status, or background?
7. *Self-analysis.* Do I feel comfortable with the purpose and development of my presentation? Do I sincerely believe that what I have to communicate is important and true? Have I done everything possible to prepare a message that is within my ethical comfort zone?

Cross-Cultural Messages

Never before have so many people from different cultures lived and worked together. Our world has become a global village, and our work force reflects that diversity. Because we have such different customs and ways of communicating, it is natural that misunderstandings occur in the workplace.

Ethical communicators anticipate and avoid cross-cultural miscommunication whenever possible and avoid gaining an advantage based on misunderstanding. The cross-cultural ethical outline in Checklist 4.2 will help you assess your ethicality in multicultural situations.

Advertising Messages

Gaining customers through false advertising is both unlawful and unethical.

It is ethically wrong to advertise products in ways that confuse. Whether promoting a college jazz event, a getaway weekend, or a line of products for a multimillion dollar company, the rule for ethical advertising is consistent: *Tell the truth, don't misrepresent, and don't manipulate language to create a false impression.* The small gain realized by misrepresentation is not worth the loss of company reputation and customer trust. A recent issue of "Consumer Reports" noted an advertisement from Travel Consulting Inc. offering an 8-day "White Christmas in Russia" package for \$599. But you could not go at Christmas time. Small print

■ Checklist 4.2 Cross-Cultural Ethical Guidelines

1. *Cultural context.* Have I considered the other individual's values, feelings, and attitudes from his or her cultural point of view? Have I attempted to understand the context of the transaction from the other person's position? Do I believe that all the other people involved fully understand the context of the transaction and all its implications?
2. *Misunderstandings.* Have I anticipated and tried to correct any possible misunderstandings that might occur? Have I attempted to gain an understanding of the other party's culture and what their expectations might be?
3. *Language.* Have I used language that can be clearly understood by others? Am I taking care not to use language and expressions that might be offensive to another culture? Am I aware of the nonverbal aspects of my message and the ways they might change the message in a different culture?
4. *Accountability.* Have I completely fulfilled my own standard for cross-cultural ethics? How would I feel if my family and friends knew all the details of the transaction? Am I being fair to all involved? How would I feel if the events were published on the front page of the newspaper?

explained that the price was good to December 16 or after January 10. If you wanted to be in Russia during Christmas, it would cost \$200 more.¹²

Recently, consumers have complained about confusing food label advertising. Claims about “healthy,” “low fat,” “reduced fat,” and “fat-free” (yet often with considerable cholesterol) products have befuddled consumers trying to eat sensibly. When Veryfine Company prints the phrase “100% natural juice drink” on the side of a juice can, does that mean the majority of the product is juice or sweetened water? In this case, the product is 25 percent juice.

Minute Maid, a division of Coca Cola, also prints “100% natural” on cans of its “juice drink.” If we don’t read the smaller print on the side of the can, or we don’t understand that the insertion of the word *drink* after the word *juice* means sweetened water was added, we might think we are buying pure “natural” juice. “Consumer Reports” chastised Minute Maid for printing “New Easy-to Mix Instructions” on newly designed cans of raspberry lemonade.¹³ In reality, the older cans called for 4½ cans of water, yielding 64 ounces of lemonade, while the newer can called for only 3 cans of water, resulting of course in less lemonade (48 ounces, or 25 percent less).

Advertisers should also consider the moral consequences of impressions created by advertising. The media, particularly television, plays a major role in shaping our ideas and opinions of events. Is it ethical to depict stereotypes or to portray a group of people in a negative light? Consider the results of the study in the Communication Probe.

Questions you should ask yourself regarding ethical advertising are cited in Checklist 4.3.

Ethics and Organizational Responsibility

Workplaces are mixes of many ethical values; each person brings a personal view of what is ethical.

Organizations dominate our life and workplace. These organizations typically attempt to create a corporate culture. But the task is difficult: Our individual ethical beliefs are extremely complex and diverse. How can an organization with employees from different ethnic backgrounds, religious perspectives, and family values have a common set of beliefs? Think of the organizations in which you have worked. Did you share the same beliefs about work and personal commitment as others in the organization? What about values such as honesty, commit-

■ Communication Probe

Social learning theory tells us that children learn appropriate social behavior by imitating modeled behavior. Advertising in magazines and television offers children many such models. Should we be concerned about the content of advertising? One study of magazine advertising revealed that children are primarily depicted in nonscholarly roles (such as athletics). When children were shown in school-related roles, they were frequently portrayed as “eggheads” or “nerds.”

Peterson, R. T. (1994). Depiction of idealized youth lifestyles in magazine advertisements: A content analysis. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 13, 259–269.

■ Checklist 4.3 Ethical Guidelines for Advertising

1. *Language.* Have I represented the product or event using clear, straightforward language, taking care not to make exaggerated claims? Is the language truthful? Can the product be taken at face value?
2. *Graphics/print.* Do the graphics used in the advertising depict the product accurately? Is any of the significant information in small print, or is it placed in an unobtrusive spot? If so, does this slant the customer's perception of the product?
3. *Omission.* Have I omitted any key details that may affect the way the customer views the advertised product? Is significant information unstated? Would it change the customer's perception of the product if this information were included?
4. *Truth.* Does the product or event live up to the claims made in the advertising? Is it a quality product that can fulfill all the expectations of the customer?
5. *Accountability.* Would I be comfortable if my advertising techniques were scrutinized by a customer products magazine and the results printed for the public to read? Would I want to have a face-to-face meeting with a group of consumers who purchased my product?

ment, and concern for others? Were your views different from others? Did you fully accept the values and standards of the organization as you came to understand them?

Organizations are stronger than individuals; organizations have access to money, which gives them the power to influence others. Money purchases both power and influence: One need only look at the hundreds of lobby groups in Washington, D.C., to understand the scope of their influence. Corporations must think carefully about the extent to which they use money to purchase influence.

Formal Versus Informal Ways of Communicating Ethics

Should managers decide the values of an organization—much like strategic policy—and communicate them downward to individual members? Or should ethical statements and values emerge from the ranks of employees themselves? Are ethics more effective when members are *told* what to do? Or are organizational values stronger if created from the middle and lower ranks of organizations, thus reflecting what the majority of workers believe? How do people in an organization come to know and understand the beliefs others hold? These are questions

Companies must determine whether it is better to suggest ethical values from the top down or the bottom up.

companies must answer as they seek to define and make ethics part of the organization's culture.

Formal. An example of using ethics formally, as strategic policy, can be found in the Ben and Jerry's ice cream company, a leader among socially responsible companies. A percentage of their company profits is channeled into charitable organizations that support environmental concerns and the homeless. Even though other companies do this to some extent, Ben and Jerry's has made social responsibility and ethics a part of its corporate culture. To ensure salary equity between employees and managers, the company has a salary ratio formula in which the highest-paid employee makes no more than seven times the salary of the lowest-paid employee.¹⁴ When organizations use a top-down approach to communicate ethical standards, they typically express ethical values in the following three ways:

1. *Public messages.* Formal statements of organizational values and ethics appear in speeches by CEOs and in public statements such as press releases and annual reports. Speeches and press releases frequently follow an organizational crisis, and when the crisis calls the organization's values into question, high-level executives usually attempt to explain the company's position. Ethical statements are also found in the body of the annual report or the chairperson's letter preceding the report. Executives use these channels to formally communicate the ethics and values of the organization to employees, stockholders, and other constituencies.
2. *Employee manuals and policy statements.* Ethical statements appear in employee policy books and manuals, which typically contain the rules and regulations of the organization. Many courts view the employee manual as a contract between the employee and employer; language used in these manuals must be carefully constructed. Organizations publishing their ethical statements in manuals need to make sure the statements are communicated in other ways in addition to the manual. Many employees do not read the employee manual or merely consult sections on a need-to-know basis. The organization's ethical statements may not receive much attention unless they are reinforced and communicated through other channels in the organization.
3. *Mission statements and ethical codes.* Mission statements attempt to address fundamental strategic issues that distinguish the business from others. Product and market are often core to identifying the business. Although they differ from corporate ethical codes by more directly addressing strategic planning and bottom-line issues, mission statements may contain statements of values and ideals. To avoid confusion, however, it is better to keep strategy in the mission statement and place value statements in the ethical code.

Ethical codes are written documents that state the ethics and values of an organization. Firms frequently attempt to manage ethics through these codes, often intending the code for both internal and external au-

Inherent in any public statement from a company is an ethical message.

Ethical codes are becoming more prominent in written documents of organizations.

diences. A code may be part of a personnel policy manual, or it may be a separately issued document. Some have affidavits of understanding that require the employee's signature. Most important, they are messages by which organizations shape employee behavior and effect change through explicit statements of desired behavior.

If ethics are not part of a formal strategic policy and communicated as such, values and ethics will generally emerge from day-to-day expectations and will be communicated informally throughout the organization. Here are three ways in which that might happen.

Over time, through workers and managers or through the organization itself, a corporation creates its ethical structure.

Informal. First, culture and values are imported into organizations through membership; that is, individual organizational members bring their attitudes and values into the organization. Second, organizations themselves are social instruments producing their own value systems. Besides creating values systems, organizations frequently produce symbols of these values, such as rituals, customs, and legends, that reinforce their meaning. Awards for safety, outstanding customer service, or honesty may symbolize organizational ethics. Third, symbolic acts of managers can create culture and corporate values. When managers act in organizations, others in the organization observe and model their behavior, and their actions are interpreted symbolically. Thus, managers, as seen in their behavior, shape and influence the direction of organizational values.

Organizations that want to manage their ethics better should explore both formal and informal ways of establishing and communicating ethics. Both ways are useful in creating an ethical culture, and managers may want to use both paths simultaneously.

SUMMARY

As a manager, some of your ethical dilemmas will be an easy call: The ethical concerns will be obvious; you can quickly make the right decision. Others will be more difficult. Ethics is often a communication issue. Your employees and coworkers learn about your ethics and values by observing your actions. Modeling ethical behavior is an important managerial tool.

■ Communication Probe

Corporate ethical codes address many different subjects, ranging from what type of gift may be accepted to respecting the rights and opinions of those with whom you work. A study in the *Journal of Business Ethics* showed that the five most common subjects found in corporate ethical codes are (1) conflict of interest, (2) gifts, bribery, and kickbacks, (3) misuse of confidential information, (4) violation of laws, and (5) personal character issues.

Stevens, B. (1994). An analysis of corporate ethical code studies: Where do we go from here? *Journal of Business Ethics*, 13, 63–69.

Your family and peers influence your personal ethics, as well as your culture, philosophy, local, state, and federal laws, and even your religious perspective. Managers need to be aware of these influences, especially monitoring their ethics in written and spoken messages, in cross-cultural communication, and in advertising. Three checklists in this chapter help you focus on key ethical areas.

Finally, this chapter examined how ethics are communicated in organizations using downward communication and how ethical values and statements also emerge from the lower and middle echelons of the organization. Both are viable ways by which organizations create ethical values.

As we move into the twenty-first century, most of us will be producing and analyzing information rather than manufacturing goods. Because the quality and integrity of this information permeate the entire product, ethics plays an increasingly important role in these new organizations. Defects in durable goods are more easily spotted than defects in the culture of an organization. Our dependence on accurate, uncompromised, quality information increases daily as does our need for a stronger, unwavering sense of ethics in the workplace.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. **Teams of 3 to 5 Assess a Current Ethical Situation.** In March 1995, Nicholas Leeson, a 28-year-old trader in Singapore, allegedly helped precipitate bankruptcy of the 232-year-old British merchant banking firm of Barings P.L.C. While it was not one of the prime players of the British financial scene, Barings was a venerable banking firm, perhaps best known for overseeing the financial aspects of the Louisiana Purchase. Leeson got involved in mortgage derivatives and purchased an extraordinary number of futures contracts on the Nikkei stock exchange resulting in losses of over \$1 billion. In December 1995, a Singapore court sentenced Leeson to 6 years and 6 months.

Activity: Teams research different aspects of the Barings P.L.C. bankruptcy and report the results of their research orally to the class.

Team 1—The background of the problem: Present facts about Barings and Leeson.

Team 2—The event: Describe the event that allegedly bankrupted the firm.

Team 3—The ethical dilemma: Identify the ethical issues in this case.

Team 4—The future: Explore ways of preventing a recurrence of this type of event.

Team 5—(in collaboration with Team 4) The decision: Choose one of the team's suggestions and defend why it would be effective.

2. **Panel Discussion.** Business transactions with other countries are sometimes difficult because of the different cultural expectations. However, since the passage of NAFTA and markets in China and Russia opening up, the

volume of worldwide business has increased dramatically, but not without new problems. Foreign banks have recently learned that doing business in China is far more complex than originally thought. A credit crunch in 1989 caused loan defaults on several shaky hotel projects, and foreign banks learned that Beijing does not always honor the commitments provincial governments or state-owned banks made. Forty-five percent of China's state-owned enterprises lose money, so not paying on loans is a way of life.¹⁵

Are the Chinese being unethical? Research this situation in more depth and discuss the pros and cons of investing. What ethical issues impact on this scenario?

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **An Ethical Dilemma for Discussion.** Most American hotel companies will *not* contact you if you leave a valuable item behind in one of their rooms. This is done not out of a desire to keep the item (assuming the person who found it turned it in) but to protect your privacy in case you were not where you were supposed to be or in case you were with someone who was not your spouse or family member. Is it ethical for a hotel to act in this manner? Is the hotel engaging in complicity for clandestine meetings?
4. **Teams of Two Debate Ethical Issues.** Argue the affirmative side of one of the following issues and find an opponent to take the opposite side of the issue. The first speaker defends the statement with an 8-minute presentation and then is followed by the negative speaker, who also speaks for 8 minutes. The affirmative side then gives a 4-minute rebuttal, followed by the negative speaker.
 - a. Americans should place greater trust in corporate America.
 - b. U.S. firms should not advertise products on the television show *Beavis and Butthead*.
 - c. Employees should be allowed to keep the frequent-flyer miles they earn during corporate travel.
 - d. Business ethics should be a required course in the M.B.A. curriculum.
 - e. Business should be primarily concerned with making a profit and less with social responsibility.
 - f. Sexually explicit uniforms are acceptable in certain occupations.
 - g. Affirmative action laws have accomplished their purpose and should be abolished.
 - h. Copying/sharing software programs is an acceptable practice for college students.
 - i. Americans have become too concerned about being "politically correct."

- j. It is unethical for colleges and universities to draft legislation limiting free speech even if it involves hate language and racism.
 - k. A businessperson should refuse all gifts valued over \$25 from clients or customers.
 - l. Food labels confuse the consumers and should be further legislated.
 - m. Every company should have a policy on AIDS in the workplace.
 - n. All organizations should allow opportunities for indoor smoking on their premises.
 - o. The public has a right to know if their doctor or dentist has tested HIV-positive.
 - p. Mandatory retirement at age 70 should be abolished.
5. **Case Discussion: Sexual Harassment.** Read the case “Incident on the Cruise Ship *Princess Maria*.” Discuss the questions at the end of the case.

Incident on the Cruise Ship *Princess Maria*

The S.S. *Princess Maria* is a 65,000-ton cruise ship, offering first-class and luxury accommodations to 1,525 passengers. The ship is 700 feet long, with a beam of 110 feet and a cruising speed of 19 knots. The ship features a deck of suites, a number of cabins with verandas, two show lounges, three dining rooms, and two outdoor swimming pools in addition to a number of other excellent features. You feel fortunate to have landed a position on this ship and have been enjoying the sights of Acapulco, Puerto Vallarta, the Islas Marias, and Mazatlán during your time off.

As assistant director of human resources, you are responsible, along with the director, for the policies and procedures aboard the ship, administering benefits, and processing requests for leave for the 800 crew members. You report to the director of human resources, Ron Adams, who is not aboard for this 6-day cruise because of an illness in his family. Ron is planning to return next week.

Employee relations aboard ship are fairly good. This is an affable crew with seemingly few problems. You’ve made several good friends during your 6-month tenure and are enjoying working with the rest of the people. A “hot spot,” however, seems to be the ship’s galley. A few minor incidents have occurred—mostly people shouting at one another—since you have been aboard. Ron filled you in on the details but generally expressed no real concerns.

“You know how galleys are—they’re like a lot of restaurant kitchens—a free-wheeling atmosphere and some “blue” language. It goes with the pressure of producing volumes of high-quality food under pressure,” Ron exclaimed, in a discussion you had before he left. Ron also expressed the opinion that most of the individuals involved were just “blowing off steam.” Estebán Phillipe, a first cook, and one of the pot washers, Tomás, seemed to get into it more than others.

This morning, however, one of the salad makers, Miranda, and a desserts-preparation woman, Carlina, came to your office to register a complaint. “I’ve been sexually harassed,” claimed Miranda. “Tomás has been coming on to me.” When you asked what he said, Miranda replied, “Last week he patted me on the fanny when I walked by, and this week he asked me to have a drink with him after work.” You look at Mi-

randá, an obviously attractive woman with long dark hair. Miranda's issued uniform is unusually short. She has apparently shortened the hem so that the skirt is about 5 inches above her knees. Someone else in the gallery had mentioned this fact to you earlier in the week.

Then Carlina, a married woman who lives with her husband in Puerto Vallarta during her times off, chimed in. "Yes, Tomás is a problem. He winked at me last week when I walked by. But the real problem is Estebán Phillipe. Do you know what he said to me last week?" Carlina's face was flushed with anger. "He said, 'I hope your husband appreciates what he's getting at home,' I am highly offended by that remark." Carlina looked even more upset.

The phone rings. Your secretary reminds you of an executive meeting in 5 minutes on the Texas Deck. You express your concerns to Miranda and Carlina, telling them you will look into the matter *and* talk with them both at greater length.

After the women leave, you have just a few minutes, but it is enough time to quickly scan the policies and procedures manual. Your company's sexual harassment policy warns that such behavior will not be tolerated. It also cautions against creating a "hostile climate" in the workplace. The policy regarding uniforms states that employees must wear their issued uniforms while on duty but says nothing about a prescribed skirt length or altering a uniform.

At this point you need to decide whether sexual harassment has occurred and whether the policies of the organization have been violated. You also want to identify and analyze the communication problems that your galley employees are experiencing.

Activity: Role-play the events in this case, adding any nonverbal communication that the actors think is appropriate. Next, role-play an informational interview between you and Tomás, in which your purpose is to listen to his side of the story. Do the same thing with Estebán Phillipe.

Policy Book of the Princess Cruise Lines, Inc.

Sexual harrassment will not be tolerated by any employee of the Princess Maria.

Definition

Sexual harassment includes unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, and other verbal or physical conduct or communication of a sexual nature when:

1. Submission to such conduct or communication is made a term or condition either explicitly or implicitly to obtain employment.
2. Submission to or rejection of such conduct or communication by an individual is used as a factor in decisions affecting such individual's employment.
3. Such conduct or communication has the purpose or effect of substantially interfering with an individual's employment.

4. Such conduct is repeated and creates a hostile climate for the employee.

Management of the Princess Maria expressly forbids all employees from harassing any other employee. A violation of this policy will result in appropriate disciplinary action, up to and including termination.

Any employee who believes (s)he is being sexually harassed should report the incident or situation to the Director of Human Resources. As an employer, the management cannot remedy situations in which harassment is alleged unless it has prompt notice of it. All complaints of sexual harassment from any individual will be investigated thoroughly and prompt remedial action will be taken. Sometimes, however, the perceived harassment may simply result from misunderstanding. An off-hand remark or off-color joke may be offensive to some but not to others. If the situation is reported promptly, appropriate corrective action can be taken.

Dress Code Policy

Personal appearance and dress are especially important on board the Princess Maria, as most employees are in constant contact with our guests. All employees, even those in nonpublic areas, are expected to dress in a professional manner.

Employees must wear their issued uniforms while on duty and are expected to be neat, clean, and tidy at all times.

Questions for discussion:

1. Identify the problems you need to address.
 2. What should be your next step?
 3. Have Tomás and Estebán Phillipe behaved offensively toward these women?
 4. Does Miranda's short skirt justify Tomás' actions?
 5. What cross-cultural problems may exist here?
 6. What actions, if any, do you plan to take?
-
6. Business intelligence has become a booming business. Spying on other companies is on the increase as firms try to become more competitive. American and foreign firms appear to be adopting the military model of intelligence gathering. Increasingly, firms specializing in espionage are using military intelligence tactics to gather information from competing firms. They generate \$500 million in revenue annually.¹⁶

Write a short (1- or 2-page) position paper on the ethics of company espionage.

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Business Communication and the Technology Context

I. Managing Information Within Organizations

- A. History of Technological Developments
- B. Challenges to the Organization Made by New Technologies

II. E-Mail

- A. Defining E-Mail
- B. Using E-Mail
- C. Understanding How E-Mail Works
- D. Understanding the Internet
- E. Establishing Security

III. Other Communication Technologies

- A. Voice Mail
- B. Groupware
- C. CD-ROM Databases
- D. Teleconferences
- E. Faxes

IV. Managing Information Outside Organizations

- A. Managing the News Media
- B. Managing Corporate News
- C. Managing Information Through Company Spokespersons
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You are sitting at your computer when you hear the familiar musical chord that announces an incoming message. You activate your interview line, and the communication manager of your company appears in the corner of your screen. “Thought you would be interested in this memo from headquarters,” she says, “regarding the new communication system we’re installing. Soon we’ll be completely wireless, and you’ll be able to receive and transmit images that can fill your screen rather than sit in the corner of it.” She chuckles. “That’s assuming you *want* a larger image of whoever you’re talking to!” You chat for a few minutes while the copy of the memo is being sent. Within a minute or two, your printer gives you a copy of the memo. You say goodbye and deactivate your interview line.

The growth of information technology over the past 30 years has transformed the way business is transacted throughout the world. Obvious effects of the new technologies include a marked increase in the amount and availability of information and greater speed in sending and receiving it. Other, less obvious effects are changes in organizational structure from the diminishing importance of physical location in running a business. Additional changes involve requirements in computer literacy even for entry-level positions and changes in individuals’ work demand and expectations. All these factors may generate more stress as the amount and speed of available information eliminates the time for reflection that older, slower systems allowed. Information technology is also changing the conventions of written communication, favoring more direct and informal styles and promoting more collaborative types of communication.

Internationally, the instantaneous availability of information has communicated and influenced social, political, and economic events, such as the detailed coverage of the Persian Gulf War and the earthquake in Kobe, Japan. Information technology has generated a new international economy. Each day throughout the world, more than \$1 trillion is transferred electronically, and more than \$300 billion by foreign exchange transactions. To put these numbers in perspective, the total world trade in physical goods is about \$4 trillion *a year*.¹

This chapter presents information on managing information within organizations, using the new and developing technologies with special emphasis on E-mail—its systems, uses, etiquette, costs and benefits, and security. Other communication technologies, such as groupware, faxes, and telexes, are also briefly described. We also include material on managing information outside your organization, such as how to deal with the news media, how to be a good company spokesperson, and how to prevent and control corporate crises.

MANAGING INFORMATION WITHIN ORGANIZATIONS

Because of rapidly changing technological developments, you, as business managers, now have to know something about information technology in order to manage it as effectively as you manage people and products. In the beginning of the information explosion, this was not true; technical specialists and consultants handled all the necessary details and problems. But with the changes brought about by personal computers and individual access to information anywhere in the world, information technology is now everyone’s business.

History of Technological Developments

Nineteenth century developments such as the telegraph and telephone marked the beginning of the rapid growth in information technology.

All methods of communication beginning with the development of language itself can be considered technological developments. However, the inventions toward the end of the nineteenth century and the beginning of the twentieth, such as the telegraph and the telephone, marked the beginning of the rapid growth leading to today's ever-changing information technology. Telex machines, the direct ancestor of E-mail, are not used much anymore. Faxes are widely used, and their use increases daily. Faxes are also precursors of today's E-mail and networking systems.

In the 1960s, some companies became attracted to computer technology to handle data processing. The computers used by these progressive companies were huge mainframes, with tubes and reels of storage tape; they were so big that they often filled a large room. Terminals—video screens with keyboards—were hooked up to the mainframe. Programming had to be done from scratch because there was no packaged software, and computer programmers, often people with no expertise in business or management, owned the technology.

By the 1970s, more people had computer terminals that had access to central information on large mainframes. Some packaged software was developed so that certain tasks did not have to be programmed from scratch. However, computers were expensive, and costs rose as companies without clear needs for them were persuaded to invest in information technology.

The transformation of telecommunications in the 1980s, with the development of fiber optics, local area networks, and satellite technology, along with the new, more powerful personal computers, facilitated the growth of information technology in organizations. Organizations now have laptop computers, desktop publishing capabilities, electronic spreadsheets, and word processing programs to gather, store, and communicate information. Turmoil and change are the norm for information technology, and they reflect and influence the concurrent changes in business organizations on structure, profits, people, and society.

Developments in information technology that led to more powerful and less expensive personal computers have facilitated the growth of electronic information in today's businesses.

■ Communication Probe

In the 1960s, E-mail was called computer-based messaging system (CBMS). Western Union first registered the trademark "Electronic Mail" in 1974. It was also during the sixties that most of the stereotypes of computers and computer people developed. Computer "nerds" were thought to be antisocial, interested only in bits and bytes. Many of these early information systems professionals were, however, resistant to the development of personal computers. Not only did they not want amateurs playing around with information systems, but they also had justifiable worries regarding the security of confidential information.

Keen, P. G. (1995). *Every manager's guide to information technology* (p. 17). Boston: Harvard Business School Press; Gibbons, D., Fox, D., Westenbroek, A., Cravens, D., & Shafran, A. (1994). *Using e-mail* (p. 9). Indianapolis, IN: Ewing.

Challenges to the Organization Made by New Technologies

As future business leaders, you will need to understand and manage the transitions facing you in business operations. According to some researchers, the problem is not so much technical since the technology itself has become increasingly easier to use, but rather organizational because new structures must be set up to manage information in a world forever changed by it.² Those of you who can enter the global marketplace with a knowledge of information technology and an ability to manage change will be the successful business leaders of the twenty-first century.

Additionally, there is the question of control over content. During the time of carbon copies, it was relatively easy to oversee who received what and when. Those days are gone. With computer hackers invading electronic databases, and even employers eavesdropping, control over that data is becoming increasingly difficult. What we thought was secure is, sadly, now easier to access. All these issues affect both the form and the content of messages.

E-MAIL

Although E-mail used to be limited to major universities with computing resources, it is now growing in use in companies throughout the world. With the development of PCs that can be networked worldwide, software programs that make communicating easy, and less expensive hardware and software, E-mail is beginning to dominate day-to-day communications in business organizations.

Defining E-Mail

E-mail refers to messages sent over computers and includes everything from casual notes to friends to multimedia presentations sent across the world.

Electronic mail (E-mail) lets you send a message to a person without your making direct contact or knowing where that person is located. Subscribers to electronic mail services are called *users*, and as a user, you can access messages on your system from your home, office, hotel, or anywhere you happen to be.

Several basic components make up E-mail systems, including users, messages, senders' and recipients' addresses, protocols, messaging transports, gateways, value-added networks, and directory systems. Users are often people, but users can also be other computer application programs. A message is the actual information sent by one user to another. Part of the E-mail information included in a message is the addresses of both sender and receiver, which include their unique identification codes along with another identifier such as the E-mail system, the mailbox number, or the organization. Each E-mail system uses a protocol that describes the structure of the message, generally with a header of TO:, FROM:, and SUBJECT:, followed by the body, which may include text, images, graphics, video, and audio.

The software that moves the message from one system to another is called the transport. If the message sent from one system must get to a user on another system, it must pass through a gateway to be delivered. A gateway is an application program that translates between two protocols of different E-mail systems. Value-added networks (VANs) are public telecommunication companies, such as AT&T or MCI, that handle E-mail services to users for a fee. As a user, you can

■ Communication Probe

In 1994, an estimated 30 million people were users of E-mail in the United States alone, with growth averaging 30 percent a year. For comparison, the number of users in 1983 was only about 1 million. Much of the interest in E-mail has come from academic communities, whose researchers have seen the possibilities of the Internet for information access. As software companies continue to make this complex exchange of information increasingly user-friendly, more business organizations and individuals are jumping on the E-mail bandwagon.

Keen, P. G. (1995). *Every manager's guide to information technology* (p. 134). Boston: Harvard Business School Press.

access a directory that contains names, addresses, and sometimes other information about each user to find the E-mail address you need to send a message.

Using E-Mail

With E-mail, you can reach individuals, groups, or other computers anywhere in the world to share information, files of data, spreadsheets, videos, music, and anything else that can be stored on a computer.

E-mail combines some of the characteristics of writing and speaking. As a user, you have the immediacy of communicating directly to your receiver along with the advantages of being able to compose and revise a written message. E-mail can save you time in printing, copying, and distributing your messages. You can use E-mail to send and receive faxes and telexes. You can reach groups as well as individuals and share files of data, spreadsheets, videos, music, and anything else you can store on a computer. Computer programs themselves can use E-mail to monitor such things as inventory levels and communicate to a person or another computer the information. For example, a computer at Hughes Aircraft Company in Los Angeles recently sent a short memo to a computer several hundred miles away at the Boeing Company. With only the press of a button, the message left a Hughes IBM computer, was picked up by MCI Mail, transferred to Tele-mail, and finally deposited in a Digital Equipment computer at Boeing.³

E-mail is also useful in your personal communications. You can communicate with friends and family anywhere in the world. And because many universities give free E-mail accounts to their students, you can keep in touch with your college-age children without having to make an appointment for a telephone call.

E-mail writing conventions tend to be less rather than more formal.

Writing conventions for E-mail are still developing, but one characteristic appears to be a more informal approach. Most business people handle their own E-mail, and because most of their messages are read only and not printed on paper, they tend to drop the formalities of traditional correspondence. Punctuation and capitalization can vary from one E-mail user to another, with some people omitting *all* punctuation and capitalization except for periods at the ends of sentences. The immediacy and perceived informality of E-mail tempts many people into composing rambling messages. Effective communicators, however, will analyze the situation to determine the degree of formality needed in the message and will often put the important information “up front.”

Understanding How E-Mail Works

To send an E-mail message, you do the following:

- Log on. This means connecting to a computer, network, or E-mail program. It requires the user's name and a password.
- Choose the receivers of your message. For this step, you need to know the E-mail addresses of your recipients.
- Compose the message.
- Instruct the program to send the message.

To read your E-mail messages, you do the following:

- Log on.
- Look at a list of your new mail.
- Choose the message you want to read.
- Handle the current message by deleting, storing, printing, forwarding, or replying.
- Continue to read your messages.

What you see and the commands you use in sending and receiving messages is the front end of your E-mail system. The back end of the system consists of the message store, where received messages are kept before they are read, the transport agent, which determines how mail is moved from one mailbox to another, and the directory agent, which contains the names of users and allows mail to be routed to the proper person.

In the beginning, each E-mail user had an individual mailbox. All messages were saved in that mailbox. However, the private mailbox system wasted a lot of space, and so new ways were developed to handle messages. A modern E-mail package stores one copy of each message and sets up pointers that show to whom the message was sent. When a person has new mail, the pointer is active. Most E-mail programs do not store messages in individual files; they hold them in large data packages, which saves room and makes locating messages easier.

Understanding the Internet

Internet is a large group of computer networks connecting individuals and groups to services and information throughout the world.

CompuServe and America Online are two commercial services that offer access to Internet information as well as other services, such as shopping services, ticket services for sports and other events, and many others.

Called the "Net" by many people, the Internet is a wide-ranging group of computer networks that connect government, the military, educational institutions, companies, and individuals to services and information throughout the world. E-mail on the Net can be either person to person or person to group. You may have access to the Internet through school, your workplace, a commercial provider, or a freenet. Commercial providers include CompuServe and America Online; a freenet is a publicly available Internet access site provided by some communities and usually free to residents.

CompuServe, or the CompuServe Information Service (CIS) is the largest commercial on-line service, with millions of subscribers throughout the world.⁴ With CompuServe, you can get tickets to shows and sports events, shop for clothes and jewelry, hire a financial analyst or a computer consultant, subscribe to magazines, watch an all-news television channel, get current stock prices, and review the weather anywhere in the world. America Online, although smaller

■ Communication Probe

E-Mail Addresses of Interest

president@whitehouse.gov (Gets you to the President)
 vice-president@whitehouse.gov (Gets you to the Vice President)
 congress@hr.house.gov (U.S. House of Representatives. Many representatives have E-mail services; this address can tell you which ones.)
 abcnews@class.org (ABC News research center)
 cnnglobal@aol.com (CNN Global News)
 cspanguest@aol.com (C-SPAN call in)
 nightly@news.nbc.com (NBC Nightly News)
 foxnet@delphi.com (Fox Television Network)
 voa-europe@voa.gov (Voice of America, Europe)
 iac@bbc-ibar.deamon.co.uk (BBC World Service)
 lateshow@pipeline.com (*The Late Show with David Letterman*)
 herb_hildebrandt@umich.edu (one of the authors of this book)
 thomasej@umich.edu (one of the authors of this book)

Thousands of additional E-mail addresses are listed in almost all reference books on electronic mail.

Gibbons, D., Fox, D., Westenbroek, A., Cravens, D., & Shafran, A. (1994). *Using e-mail* (pp. 354–365). Indianapolis, IN: Ewing.

than CompuServe, is one of the fastest-growing companies in the country. It offers subscribers a wide range of information and services as well as ease of use and affordability.

The Internet originally grew out of a network funded by the Defense Department in the 1960s for use in civilian research. Later the National Science Foundation funded a new, high-speed network to provide communication between supercomputers. Most users have traditionally been academics, researchers, and engineers, although with the growth in the types of information and services available, more and more businesses are getting on the “information superhighway.” Among the almost limitless Internet services available on E-mail are such resources as File Transfer Protocol (FTP), a way of transferring files and software to your computer; Archie, a way of locating files on the Internet; Gopher, a way of accessing archives of documents and information; and an on-line dictionary. As a base for an Information Superhighway in the United States, the Internet will provide a national public data network for all subscribers.

E-Mail Etiquette

Because E-mail is fairly immediate and generally less formal than other forms of written communication, you may be tempted to relax the tone, organization, and content of your message. However, most of the advice applicable to your printed messages is relevant to your electronic messages. Remember the following:

Be clear, concise, and polite when you send an E-mail message; the same general guidelines for good business writing should always apply.

- Watch your tone. Because of the conversational aspect of E-mail and the fact that you are sitting in privacy, you may be tempted to be too casual. Your formality will depend on your relationship with your receiver.
- Be concise. Long, rambling messages are just as ineffective on E-mail as they are in print.
- Send a message only if you have something important to say. It can be daunting to come back to your office from lunch and see 75 messages waiting for you on E-mail.
- Forward the mail to the appropriate address if you receive a message that was not meant for you. You may want to alert the sender that the message was sent to the wrong address.
- Be polite. Even when you are communicating with a group of users you have never met, you should not get involved in a “flame” war. “Flaming” is an E-mail term meaning to insult, provoke, or comment too much about something that is irrelevant or tasteless.

E-Mail Signs and Symbols

Because of the limitations of language in E-mail systems, users have developed some interesting conventions to show emotion. For example, consider the following message:

WHEN DID YOU SAY YOU WERE DOING THAT JOB?

I CAN'T BELIEVE IT'S TAKING SO LONG!

This message is the E-mail equivalent of shouting. The following addition puts it in perspective:

Just kidding. :-)

Checklist 5.1 lists some common acronyms and abbreviations that you may find in electronic messages.

E-mail messages may also contain *emoticons*, or representations of emotions using keyboard characters. To interpret an emoticon, you must look at the symbol from the side because the expression is “lying down.” For example, the common expression for a smiley face is :-), which you can see if you turn your head 90 degrees to the left. Checklist 5.2 lists a few of the more common emoticons.

Establishing Security

Security is one major problem of E-mail due to conflicts between access and control.

Lack of security of information on computer networks is one of the major problems facing business today. Most of today's systems are about as secure as a house with simple locks; they can stop amateurs but are easy for professionals to break into. On-line services are especially vulnerable to credit card and telephone card fraud. And automatic teller machine (ATM) thefts are now costing billions of dollars a year.⁵

Conflicts between access and control are at the bottom of the security prob-

■ Checklist 5.1 E-Mail Acronyms and Abbreviations

BBL	Be back later	LOL	Laughing out loud
BFN	Bye for now	NBD	No big deal
BRB	Be right back	ROFL	Rolling on floor laughing
BTW	By the way	TIA	Thanks in advance
FYI	For your information	TIC	Tongue in cheek
<g>	Grin	TTFN	Ta ta for now
<G>	Big grin	TTYL	Talk to you later
HSIK	How should I know?	WYSIWYG	What you see is what you get
IAE	In any event		
IMO	In my opinion		
IOW	In other words		

lem. Making network services easy and convenient to use also makes control of the information difficult. The most common method of restricting access is by the use of passwords, which let only authorized users into the system. However, hackers can generally break into passwords quickly and easily. Encryption, a technique that scrambles information to make it unintelligible during transmission, is another level of security. A third strategy some large financial services and telecommunications companies use scans for patterns of activity that suggest misuse.⁵

The problem of security has not yet received the attention it deserves. One reason is that the managers of many companies do not realize how vulnerable their information is and how much damage and loss their company can incur. So far there seems to be little willingness to spend money on this kind of protection. However, as electronic communication develops, so will ways to protect the system and increase security.

■ Checklist 5.2 Emoticons

: - (	Sad	: - o	Surprised
: -	Indifferent	: - @	Screaming
: -)	Winking	: - X	Big kiss
: - (	Crying	: : -)	Wearing glasses
: - D	Laughing	8 -)	Wearing sunglasses
: - \	Undecided	: - C	Really sad
: - P	Tongue hanging out	: - &	Tongue-tied

OTHER COMMUNICATION TECHNOLOGIES

E-mail developments and the popularity of E-mail use have led to additional communication technologies, including *voice mail*, *groupware*, *CD-Rom databases*, and *teleconferencing*. *Faxes*, which have been around for several decades, are also still common in business communication.

Voice Mail

Voice mail has become popular in many offices because it eliminates "telephone tag."

Voice mail records messages on a computer disk for later retrieval by the receiver. When an incoming call is not answered, the system responds by telling the caller how to leave a message or how to reach someone else. The receiver of the call can then either listen to the machine upon returning to the office or access the message via telephone. This process eliminates the problem of telephone tag, which can be so frustrating.

Groupware

Groupware allows a supervisor to manage the workflow of a department via computer.

Groupware allows several people to use software at the same time to create documents, keep track of projects, route messages, and manage deadlines. Groupware enables a supervisor to manage work flow via individual computers instead of physically moving people from place to place or having face-to-face meetings.

Groupware is a primary force in the growth of the global marketplace. It is central to the current theories of team-based organizations in which hierarchies are breaking down, allowing teams to work interactively from their individual locations. Groupware represents a basic shift in business culture and can be threatening to those brought up with the norms of privacy, hierarchy, face-to-face meetings, reports, and memos.⁶

Lotus Notes is the leading product in the groupware market, although Microsoft and Novell are also working on software of this type. Lotus Notes allows users to work together as if they were in the same room, creating transactions, schedules, and reports. Although it may take many companies a few more years to become comfortable with this new development, companies that remain viable and continue to grow will make the effort. By 1944, there were nearly 750,000 users of Lotus Notes in 3,000 organizations; but that figure represents only 3 percent of networked personal computers.⁷

CD-ROM Databases

Because of their massive storage ability, CD-ROM disks offer multimedia applications, directories, encyclopedias, and other useful information.

Compact Disk–Read Only Memory (CD-ROM) has been available for several years and is becoming more popular. It is a powerful tool for putting masses of information in a form that is easy to digest. Some kinds of information typically found on CD-ROMs are encyclopedias, dictionaries, telephone directories, and articles and abstracts on various subjects.

Storage ability for only one CD-ROM disk far surpasses the 60 to 100 megabytes of disk space on a PC. A CD-ROM disk can store more than 100,000 pages of text as well as high-resolution photos and other graphics. Multimedia applications, including video, audio, graphics, and text, are making CD-ROM storage of information essential; CD-ROMs will continue to grow in popularity.

■ Communication Probe

Hackers are people who bypass security controls, guess passwords, and enter databases that often contain valuable data. Although many people think of hackers as brilliant renegades, hackers are often thieves who can do a lot of damage to company data and personal information. Hackers can get your credit card number from several company files and make purchases using it. Your social security number is also at risk.

So much of the American economy is now on computer files that the possibilities for quick money are attracting big-time criminals. Balancing the need for easy access of information with security needs is a continuing problem.

Keen, P. G. (1995). *Every manager's guide to information technology* (p. 156). Boston: Harvard Business School Press.

Teleconferences

Teleconferencing is a rapidly developing technology that will eventually change the way companies do business.

Telecommunications is the electronic exchange of information. This term used to refer to telephones, telexes, and faxes, but now it comprises a rapidly developing technology that will soon allow high-quality video images and personal conferencing systems that operate on individual PCs.

Currently, video conferencing has problems, including a high price tag and poor-quality video images on the computer screen. However, some companies are making strides in solving the problems. For example, Intel plans an overhaul of PCs that will make videoconferencing and other multimedia an integral part of the machine.⁸ With the aid of special software, the new approach will allow powerful microprocessors to handle data compression instead of the added circuit boards now needed.

Faxes

Faxes have been available for many years and are popular in business offices; newer fax machines are digital, allowing communication via computer, and are much faster than the old ones.

A facsimile machine scans a printed page, converts it to a signal, and transmits the signal over a telephone line to a receiving fax machine. Although faxes have been available for many years, until recently they were slow and expensive.

The oldest type of fax machine had to be connected to a machine of the same type, and the transmission took several minutes. Today's fax machines do not require the same kind of machine at the receiving end, and they can transmit a page in less than 1 minute. The newest fax machines use digital transmission, which makes it possible to use a computer program as a receiver. These new faxes are also much faster.

E-mail and the technologies it has generated are changing the landscape of business communication. Our discussion is only an overview of a complex subject. Several problems need to be addressed as we continue to explore these new technologies. In addition to the problems of expense and quality of electronic messages, there are problems of security, of the transformation of culture the technology requires, and of the very nature of information itself. Certainly the

day is over when only information systems specialists know about and can operate electronic communication systems. Communication technology is something we all need to be comfortable with.

MANAGING INFORMATION OUTSIDE ORGANIZATIONS

In 1982, Johnson and Johnson's Tylenol brand of analgesics outsold the next four leading analgesics combined and contributed about 7 percent of 1981 sales and 15 to 20 percent of profits. Johnson and Johnson executives expected Tylenol to take 50 percent of the market by 1986.⁹ However, sometime in the fall of 1982, someone replaced some of the Tylenol Extra-Strength capsules with cyanide-laced capsules, resealed the packages, and put them back on the shelves of at least a half dozen pharmacies and grocery stores in the Chicago area. On September 29, the first of seven people died of cyanide poisoning after taking an Extra-Strength Tylenol capsule. With no warning, McNeil Consumer Products Company, which makes Tylenol, and its parent company, Johnson and Johnson, were plunged into a crisis that could have destroyed not only the product but the company as well.

McNeil and Johnson and Johnson executives took aggressive steps to handle the crisis, and as a result, the ensuing damage did not destroy either product or company. However, the easy access and transmission of information by the news media put Johnson and Johnson executives in a spotlight in which almost every step they took was known and scrutinized by the public. In fact, it was a reporter from the *Chicago Tribune* who first alerted company officials of the problem.

This discussion focuses on how to manage information outside the organization, how to deal with the news media, how to create tools for managing corporate news, what to do if you're a company spokesperson, and how to control a public company crisis. Managing corporate news involves not only knowing how to deal with crises but more often involves handling the day-to-day information that is disseminated to the public through interviews, press releases, conferences, and other channels of communication.

Managing the News Media

News organizations are responsible for most of our knowledge of what goes on in the world.

What we refer to as "the media" are simply channels of information, everything from newspapers, radio, television, magazines, journals, and newsletters. Almost everything we know about what goes on in the world comes from the news media. To professional media people, news is generally categorized into two types: hard news versus soft news. Hard news is out of the ordinary, is timely, and is most often something the public needs to know. Plane crashes and fires are hard news. The Tylenol crisis was hard news. Soft news often includes "feel-good" stories about the kindness of a stranger, the opening of a new art gallery, or a company's new program to help children. Soft news stories are timeless; that is, they can be used within a wider framework of time, and most often they have a positive rather than a negative slant.

Within business organizations, hard news includes such things as annual meetings results, quarterly earnings, or announcement of a new product. Soft news includes material that can inform or educate readers or viewers about the

company, its vision in the world, and its community activities. Often a company manager in charge of media relations will ignore the soft news of the organization, believing that the dedication of a new park sponsored by the company or a piece on its child care facility is not newsworthy. However, soft news can present a company's message effectively and build a foundation of goodwill for its customers.

Managing Corporate News

Several useful tools for communicating to the media are available to you as a company media manager. The most commonly used tools are press releases, interviews, conferences, op-ed pieces, letters to the editor, and talk shows.

Press Releases

A press release is an informational memo from your organization to the news media to get your message to the public.

A press release is simply an information statement made available to any number of sources. So important are the statements that even universities and other non-profit organizations have public relations departments to distribute newsworthy statements. Some organizations—witness the large number of releases from the White House alone—do so daily. Your problem is often how to get editors, journalists, ad agencies, TV and radio stations to consider your information newsworthy. Checklist 5.3 suggests which questions you should ask when deciding whether your story is newsworthy. If the answers to these questions are “yes,” your story is probably a good example of soft news.

When getting your message to the media, personal contacts are mandatory, as are short, clearly written statements. When writing your press release, be sure to do the following:

- Include precise organizational information: contact person, name of the organization, phone number.
- Suggest a subject line; if well done, such a statement could be part of the headline for a newspaper story.
- Be precise about when the information may be released.

Releases directed toward TV stations may also include film footage, or for radio, segments of interviews. Central, however, is the written statement that summarizes the major point you want to get across.

Checklist 5.3 Questions to Determine Whether Your Story Is Newsworthy

1. Does the story have a local aspect to it, making it interesting to a local audience?
2. Is your story unusual or unique in any way?
3. Is the story timely?
4. Does the story concern people? Create human interest?

The pitfalls of interviewing can be avoided by careful preparation and knowledge.

Press conferences are often the result of a crisis; however, you handle them the same way you handle other forms of communication: with careful preparation.

Opinion articles by private organizations can often be found opposite the editorial page in a newspaper.

Interviews

Weekends are noted for national TV interviews. Major political figures often appear on these shows as do, on occasion, people closely related to business or related fields. Your selected spokesperson for these occasions must be briefed and prepared for a multitude of possible questions. Dry-run the interview; take time to rehearse major themes you can bring into the conversation. Rarely, for example, does any political candidate not have a dress rehearsal prior to a major interview. Businesspeople should do no less. Be precise, be accurate, be timely.

Conferences

Press conferences offer good opportunities for you and your company to communicate your message. Unfortunately, most often in business, press conferences are the result of some kind of crisis. Preparation is key to running a good press conference, and you should begin as much in advance as possible. Formats for press conferences are generally (1) a few minutes for an opening statement, (2) distribution of the spokesperson's opening statement, and (3) questions from persons present. You can end your conference yourself by announcing that you will take one more question, or you may have someone else in your organization end it for you. Remember that everything you say during the conference and afterward in chats with reporters is considered "on the record." So be careful.

When you hold a press conference or host any kind of special news event for your company, you are expected to give the news media a package of materials called a *press kit*. What goes into a press kit can vary according to the type of news event; however, certain basic information should always be included in your packet of materials. Checklist 5.4 recommends what should be included.

Op-Ed Pieces

Some newspapers or TV stations alert company public relations departments in advance that they will be making an editorial statement on a controversial company-related issue. Such a contact often asks for an op-ed statement, that is, a statement contrary (possibly opposite) to the one that will appear on the editorial page or during the editorial portion of a TV newscast. Thus your company can prepare a response—thoughtfully, carefully, truthfully.

■ Checklist 5.4 Press Kits

1. Main press release
2. Related feature stories, if applicable
3. Photos, films, or videotapes of relevant information
4. List of names, titles, and affiliations of people involved in the event
5. Photos and biographies of main people
6. Fact sheet on your organization
7. Annual report or other information about your organization
8. Name and phone number of a contact person for additional information

If you have no advance notice of an unflattering editorial, you can respond later with an op-ed piece, stating your position and interpreting the events surrounding the controversial issue. Above all: Be truthful, concise, straightforward. It is usual to have such statements read by your legal counsel before releasing them to the media.

Letters to the Editor

Letters to the Editor must always be short, clearly written, and signed.

Pick up the *Wall Street Journal*, the *New York Times*, national magazines, or your local paper. Several columns are devoted to letters submitted by interested readers. Many letters try to clarify an issue, refute a charge, correct a mistake, point out a needed change, offer an opinion, or react to a situation. You, as a business manager or the manager's representative, can use a letter to the editor as an opportunity to comment and even correct a statement made in the publication. Sign the letter. Surely the higher in the organization the signer of the letter, the more seriously the letter will be considered for publication. Use a method similar to the op-ed piece: State the situation, provide a short background, and offer a solution.

Talk Shows

Call-in talk shows, whether on radio or television, can offer your organization a positive channel for communicating your message to the public. Radio and TV producers are always looking for interesting programming, and they are required to provide some public service programs to keep their licenses.

General guidelines for talk shows are similar to those for press conferences. Preparation is the key to a good presentation. Talk shows, however, are less predictable than any other kind of media, and your spokesperson should be someone who is comfortable in dealing with potentially hostile questioners. You should watch or listen to several segments of the talk show in order to know the format and the kind of people who make up its audience.

Managing Information Through Company Spokespersons

A company spokesperson must be knowledgeable, comfortable with oral communication, and well-prepared to discuss all aspects of the issue under consideration.

Companies (and universities for that matter), often select one person to be the main spokesperson. This strategy allows for a consistent answer, a single contact, and a decrease in response variances. Certainly the CEO or president is the obvious choice. However, he or she may not be verbally articulate or comfortable in the rough give and take of the media world. Whoever is chosen to be the contact between the organization and the media should be

- Knowledgeable about the company's overall objectives and strategies
- Well-prepared to speak on the issue under consideration
- Comfortable speaking in public and to groups and fielding questions deftly
- Assured of the full confidence of the company's management

Preparation is the most important factor in being a successful spokesperson. If you are a company spokesperson, you must know before every interview (1) the date, time, place, and length of the interview; (2) the issue under discussion;

(3) what kinds of questions the reporter may ask; and (4) what message the company wants you to deliver. If possible, it is also helpful to know the background of the reporter doing the interview, the kinds of stories he or she usually writes, and the general slant of the newspaper or radio/TV program where your interview will appear. You should also provide background information materials so that the reporter knows what has already been said on the issue and can expand on it. (See Checklist 5.5.)

Managing Crisis Communication

When emergency situations occur in business, the worst thing you can do is take a closed, “no comment” attitude toward the media. Bad news will not go away, and in fact, the worse it is, the more sensational the coverage in the media. Environmental issues, nuclear energy, falling profits, employee layoffs, and disasters and other catastrophes can cause problems for your company. How your company manages the crisis can have a long-term effect on profits.

Although Johnson and Johnson had no formal crisis contingency plan when the Tylenol incident occurred, the general opinion is that company management did a good job of handling the situation. The strategy of openness to the press helped the company get its message across and portray itself as willing to do what was right regardless of cost. After the immediate shock was over, the *Washington Post* wrote: “Johnson and Johnson has effectively demonstrated how a major business ought to handle a disaster.”¹⁰

As the result of the Tylenol crisis and other disasters that have marked the past 15 to 20 years, many organizations have developed permanent crisis contin-

■ Checklist 5.5 Guidelines for a Company Spokesperson

1. Know what message your company wants to deliver.
2. Know as much about the issue under discussion as possible.
3. Prepare desirable statements and practice them before the interview.
4. Anticipate questions and prepare answers for them.
5. Tape-record your interview.
6. Realize that your interview will be edited; in some cases, for radio and television, a live interview can be better than one that is taped.
7. Do not worry if you do not know the answer to a question.

Simply state that you will get the answer as soon as possible.

8. Do not let a reporter put words in your mouth. Be wary when you hear the words “Aren’t you really saying that . . . ?” or “Do you mean that . . . ?” Simply restate the message the way you want it; do not repeat the reporter’s words.
9. Avoid jargon.
10. Avoid using negatives.
11. Do not speak “off the record.”
12. Know your real audience—not the reporter but rather the people who read the publication or watch the program.

agency plans. These plans vary according to the organization, but each group generally has a permanent, recognized crisis team designated to handle the public and the media in the event of a crisis as well as a set of procedures in place to handle negative news. Part of this strategy may be to cultivate relationships with the media during ordinary periods so that if a crisis occurs, the company has a point of contact. It takes time to position yourself as a credible person in the eyes of the media, but this credibility is necessary when a crisis strikes. As in all other forms of communication, being prepared is the key to success.

SUMMARY

Managing information inside and outside organizations has become one of the major concerns of business. Technological developments are, to a large extent, responsible for the transformation of today's world into a global village with all its accompanying problems. Effective communication has never been more important on a national, organizational, and personal level.

This chapter was an overview of the challenges that businesses face in handling new technologies, in managing their information for greatest productivity inside the organization, and in communicating with the media outside. E-mail will continue to grow in use and in utility as new ways of exchanging information become accessible. The Internet will continue to grow, and although the information superhighway is so far only an idea, it will soon be a reality. Each person who joins a company in the next few years will find himself or herself in a world of groupware communication, teleconferencing, and information gathering and sharing via computer. The person who is comfortable with these new technologies will have an advantage.

Organizations will always have to deal with the public, and when the news is bad, it will always be underlined by the news media. But this channel of information goes both ways: You can deliver your message while responding to public concerns. Careful preparation is imperative when your company is facing a crisis. Choosing your company spokesperson and preparing that person to communicate your message can help your company deal with crises. Your organization may want to implement a crisis contingency plan in order to be prepared should a negative event occur.

All companies must take into consideration the current access of information and realize that nothing will go unnoticed. Because of the growth in information and in the media interest in organizations, companies must be concerned not only with how things are but also how they will appear. Effective communication is your key to dealing with these issues.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. **International Communication Styles.** Working in teams, conduct an in-depth interview of a student or professor in your school who is from another country. Find out what information technology is used and how written and

oral communication styles differ from U.S. business styles. Write an informational memo relating your findings.

2. **Library Research.** Do a search of information in your school library on the Internet as it is used in one of the following areas: Southeast Asia, Central Europe, Eastern Europe, South America, Scandinavia. Write a short report on your findings.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Uses for the Internet.** Write a memo to your instructor arguing for or against your school's hooking up to the Internet. Be sure to take a position either for or against, and provide support for each of your points.
4. **Discussion/Debate.** Consider the proposition, or one similar to it, arising out of this statement: "When I write memos or letters, I'm careful to use correct grammar; I edit and proofread carefully as I prepare the final copy. But when I write a message on E-mail, I don't think it's necessary to be so careful." Select persons who agree with this statement and those who disagree. Then have those persons go before the group using this pro and con procedure: pro speakers 2 minutes each; con speakers 2 minutes each; one pro speaker 2-minute final statement; one con speaker 2-minute final statement; questions from the audience to any of the speakers.
5. **Persuasive Memo.** You are a copywriter in the public relations department of a large medical supply company. Your company is moving its headquarters from the city, where you live, to the suburbs. You do not want to move, and you do not want the long commute that will be necessary when the company move is completed. Write a memo to your department manager asking to work in your home, linked to the company by way of computer, fax, and modem. Include the advantages to the company of this arrangement, but do not ignore reader concerns. Be explicit about what equipment you will need, and how it will be used.
6. **Voice Mail Discussion.** You have just called your bank to speak to your loan officer, and you get the following message: "You have just reached International Bank 2000. Hours are 9:30 A.M. to 3:30 P.M. Monday through Friday; 9:30 A.M. to 1 P.M. Saturday. If you want information, press 1; if you want to speak to the credit department, press 2; if you want to speak to the mortgage department, press 3" and so on for 16 additional numbers. As a customer, how do you like this system? What are its advantages to you? What are its disadvantages?
7. **Press Release.** Your company has organized a huge charity event to benefit underprivileged children in the city. Write a press release to the local newspaper, explaining the event and its objectives. Make the information interesting and relevant to the community. How would you change your press release if it were for the local radio or TV station?

8. **Dealing with a Crisis.** Your college or university recently has been cited by the Environmental Protection Agency for groundwater pollution, and you are beginning to receive negative press on the issue. In teams, prepare a press kit of information for the local news media. Decide what information you will include, and write up the information. Make up details to make your press kit realistic.
9. **Crisis Prevention.** If you were the president of your university, what would you do to prepare for dealing with a crisis? In teams, create a crisis contingency plan, naming people who should be on the crisis team and what roles they should play. What will be your overall approach to the news media in the crisis? Include procedures for dealing with the emergency.
10. **Response to an Upcoming Disturbing Announcement.** You are the public relations manager of a medium-sized company that manufactures cleaning fluid used for fabrics in clothing and other materials. Your company moved its primary manufacturing plant to Monterrey, Mexico, 10 years ago to save on labor costs. Up to now, there have never been any problems with either the manufacturing process or the product. However, today you have received a disturbing E-mail message on your computer from the assistant manager of the Monterrey plant. He says that the Mexican government has discovered massive pollution in the groundwater around the plant and is planning to make the discovery public. He wants advice immediately on how to handle the situation. You now must decide what to do. Think about who you should tell this information to and what steps you should take to control the damage. You should draft the following messages:
 - a. An E-mail response to the assistant manager's message telling him to wait until he hears from headquarters before talking to the government or the media
 - b. A message to the president of your company describing the problem

When you have drafted those messages, create a plan to deal with the crisis that will control the damage, show goodwill to the area residents, and save your company from a public relations disaster.
11. **Discussion of Privacy.** Because the laws concerning electronic information are still developing, there are no clear guidelines for privacy in E-mail messages. Some companies monitor employees' E-mail messages. Discuss the pros and cons of this issue, analyzing what company needs are served by monitoring E-mail and whether monitoring E-mail is an invasion of privacy.
12. **To Censor or Not to Censor.** Your school has hooked up to the Internet and is eagerly exploring the many uses found there. One popular innovation has been the setting up of a schoolwide public bulletin board on which anyone in the school can post messages. You have been chosen administrator of this bulletin board. It is your responsibility to review all the messages and alert school administrators of any potential problems. Early this morning when you looked at the new messages, you saw one that was clearly racist in

content and language. As administrator, you have the authority to delete this message, but if you do, will you be breaking a First Amendment right? Or will you be protecting the school from scandal? Should the sender of the message be identified and/or punished in some way? Discuss the issues in this situation and how you would handle the problem.

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Message Design

Chapter 6 The Process of Preparing Effective Business Messages

Chapter 7 The Appearance and Design of Business Messages

Chapter 8 Good-News and Neutral Messages

The Process of Preparing Effective Business Messages

I. Five Planning Steps

- A. Identify Your Purpose
- B. Analyze Your Audience
- C. Choose Your Ideas
- D. Collect Your Data
- E. Organize Your Message

II. Basic Organizational Plans

- A. Direct (Deductive) Approach
- B. Indirect (Inductive) Approach

III. Beginnings and Endings

- A. Opening Paragraphs
- B. Closing Paragraphs

IV. Composing the Message

- A. Drafting Your Message
- B. Revising Your Message
- C. Editing and Proofreading Your Message

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

Whether you are preparing a written or an oral business message, to be effective you need to plan, organize, draft, revise, edit, and proofread. Essential also is thoughtful adherence to communication principles—the seven C qualities discussed in Chapter 2—and awareness of legal and ethical aspects.

Even with the most advanced office technology, the need for careful preparation of either written or oral messages demands effort. Add to this precept the idea that companies are becoming more global and international, and the argument for thoughtful preparation receives even more emphasis.

This chapter presents planning steps, basic organizational patterns, suggestions for openings and closings, and composing procedures. Letters, domestic and international, are the focus of the discussion and exercises. Later chapters include details about specific kinds of letters and memos and suggestions for preparing proposals and reports.

FIVE PLANNING STEPS

To communicate effectively, consider the following steps before you write your message:

- Identify your purpose.
- Analyze your audience.
- Choose your ideas.
- Collect data to support your ideas.
- Organize your message.

Identify Your Purpose

The objective of your message is almost always twofold: the reason for the message itself and the creation of goodwill.

Your first step when planning your communication is to determine your specific purpose. Is your message mainly informational, such as announcing your firm's new location? Is it mainly persuasive, such as asking customers to buy your product? Are you trying to negotiate a contract with a parts supplier in South America? Or must you explain why you are not granting a customer's request for credit?

All messages have an underlying "relational" purpose—to create goodwill. For example, in a credit refusal letter, your purpose is twofold: to refuse the request while encouraging the customer's continued business. Creating goodwill is especially important when communicating with foreign companies, including the governments of those companies. Courtesy and patience in waiting for a response are especially necessary.

Analyze Your Audience

See your message from your receivers' point of view: their needs, interests, attitudes, even their culture.

After reading about the communication process and principles in both national and international contexts in Chapter 3, you realize how important it is to adapt your messages to your receivers' *views, mental filters, needs, and culture*. If you are acquainted with your readers or listeners, you can actually visualize individuals. Much of your writing, however, will be directed to people you have never met. Additionally, when communicating for the first time with a foreign com-

pany or government, you cannot be too cautious. Take care even with the salutation of the letter, paying attention to the proper placement of first and last names and correct titles. Take time to become knowledgeable about the basic communication principles of the country to which you are writing.

If you are sending a message to one person, try to see that person as a member of a group, such as business or professional person or laborer; superior, colleague, or subordinate; woman or man; new or longtime customer; young, middle-aged, or elderly. Consider also the person's educational level, attitudes, and probable values (often culture-specific). Finally, consider your message and decide whether your readers or listeners are informed or uninformed on the subject and whether they will react positively or negatively, with interest or disinterest.

Choose Your Ideas

The ideas you include depend on the type of message you are sending, the situation, and the cultural context.

With your purpose and receiver in mind, the next step is to choose the ideas for your message. If you are answering a letter, underline the main points to discuss and jot your ideas in the margin. If you are writing an unsolicited or a complex message, begin by listing ideas as they come to you—brainstorming—and then choosing the best ideas for your receiver.

The ideas you include depend on the type of message you are sending and the background and location of your receiver (national or international). For example, in a response from a large resort hotel to a person who has asked about rates, you might send a brief list of in- and out-of-season prices. But if you limited your response to this list, you would miss an opportunity to sell the other services you have to offer. In this kind of response, the following ideas should be included:

- Thank the reader for the letter asking about rates.
- Mention the services the hotel provides.

■ Communication Probe

Analyzing your audience is important for more reasons than simply determining the content and approach of your message. In a study of communication channel choice, Sitkin, Sutcliffe, and Barrio-Choplin found that the recipient of your message should influence even the medium you choose for delivering it. "Effective media choice depends significantly on a variety of factors that influence recipient response, including educational level, physical capabilities, media familiarity and comfort, interaction history with the communicator, and knowledge of the communication context." As an example, this study suggests that sometimes holding a meeting with line employees can be more effective than trying to persuade them to read instruction manuals.

Sitkin, S. B., Sutcliffe, K. M., & Barrio-Choplin, J. R. (1992, June). A dual-capacity model of communication media choice in organizations. *Human Communication Research*, 18(4), 563–598.

- Include information regarding the place where the hotel is located.
- Describe the facilities.
- List the rates.

You might also include a brochure of your hotel along with small brochures of popular sights in your area.

Collect Your Data

Be sure to collect enough data to support your ideas; check names, dates, addresses, and statistics for precision.

After you have decided what ideas to include, you must determine whether you need specific facts, figures, quotations, or other forms of evidence to support your points. Be sure you know your company policies, procedures, and product details if your message requires them. Always check your data on names of individuals, dates, addresses, and statistics. Sometimes, you may need to enclose a brochure, table, picture, or product sample.

Organize Your Message

Organizing your material before writing your first draft can prevent rambling and unclear messages.

Before you write your first draft, outline your message (mentally or on paper). The order in which you present your ideas is as important as the ideas themselves. Disorganized, rambling messages often seem careless, confusing, and unimportant. However, different approaches are necessary for different cultures. While the direct style is often preferred by U.S. businesspeople, the indirect plan is often more effective in South American, middle eastern, and Asian countries. Europeans most often prefer the direct approach. Choose your organizational plan after you have worked through your initial planning steps.

BASIC ORGANIZATIONAL PLANS

Your choice of organizational plan depends on a number of factors: how you expect your reader or listener to react to your message, how much this person knows about the topic or situation, and what his or her cultural conventions are.

For letters and memos, you can choose one of four basic organizational plans: the *direct-request*, *good-news*, *bad-news*, or *persuasive-request plan*. The first two plans use the direct approach, which begins with the main idea; the last two plans use the indirect approach, which states the main idea later.

All these plans are flexible guides only, not rigid rules. Your own judgment must help you decide the best organization and content of your message, taking into consideration your audience's views, conventions, knowledge, and culture. Other chapters discuss and illustrate various ways you can use these four basic plans.

Direct (Deductive) Approach

Use the direct approach when the audience is receptive to your message.

When you think your reader or listener will have a favorable or neutral reaction to your message, you can use the direct approach. You *begin with the main idea*

or best news. After the opening, you include all necessary explanatory details in one or several paragraphs and end with an appropriate, friendly closing.

Use the direct-request plan when the main purpose of your message is to make a request that requires less persuasion; use the good-news plan to grant requests, announce favorable or neutral information, and exchange routine information within or between companies. The direct-request and good-news plans have three basic parts. Notice their similarities as you compare the brief outlines side by side in Checklist 6.1.

Indirect (Inductive) Approach

When you expect resistance to your message, choose the indirect approach, such as in a bad-news message or a persuasive request.

If you think your readers or listeners might react negatively to your message, generally you should not present the main idea in the first paragraph. Instead consider beginning with a buffer—a relevant pleasant, neutral, or receiver-benefit statement; then give an explanation *before* you introduce your idea. Chapter 15 calls this pleasant and neutral opening the “Porch,” or the initial remarks to an audience.

Checklist 6.1 Direct (Deductive) Organizational Plans

Direct-Request Plan

1. Main idea
 - a. Request, main statement, assertion, recommendation, question
 - b. Reasons, if desirable
2. Explanation
 - a. All necessary and desirable details and data
 - b. Numbered questions, if helpful
 - c. Easy reading devices
3. Courteous close, with motivation to action
 - a. Clear statement of action desired
 - b. Easy action, dated when desirable
 - c. Appreciation and goodwill

Good-News Plan

1. Best news or main idea
2. Explanation
 - a. All necessary and desirable details and data
 - b. Resale material*
 - c. Educational material
 - d. Sales promotion material
3. Positive, friendly close, including, if appropriate:
 - a. Appreciation
 - b. Clear statement of action
 - c. Appreciation and desired, if any
 - c. Easy action, dated when desirable
 - d. Offer of further help, reader benefits

**Resale material* is usually favorable information about a product or service that the reader (customer) has already bought or is planning to buy. The customer made the selection. *Sales promotion material* usually includes the vendor's suggestions for additional products or services.

Many bad-news and persuasive-request plans use the indirect approach. Notice in Checklist 6.2 that each plan has four instead of three parts. Bad news and persuasion take a little longer to present.

The bad-news message is one of the most difficult to prepare because your reader may react negatively. Likewise, in the persuasive request you may face resistance. Even in good-news and neutral messages, some cultural communication conventions require an indirect approach. Goodwill and reader benefits are essential to these messages.

BEGINNINGS AND ENDINGS

Two of the most important positions in any business message are the opening and closing paragraphs. You have probably heard the old sayings “First impressions are lasting” and “We remember best what we read last.” Whenever possi-

■ Checklist 6.2 Indirect (Inductive) Organizational Plans

Bad-News Plan

1. Buffer (pleasant or neutral statements, reader-oriented)
2. Explanation
 - a. Necessary data, tactfully stated
 - b. Pertinent favorable, then unfavorable acts
 - c. Reader benefit reasons
3. Decision (implied or expressed) along with offer of additional help or suggestions
4. Positive, friendly close
 - a. Appreciation
 - b. Invitation to future action desired
 - c. Easy action, dated when desirable
 - d. Willingness to help further
 - e. Reader benefit and goodwill

Persuasive Request Plan

1. Attention
 - a. Reader benefit
 - b. Reader-interest theme
2. Interest
 - a. Descriptive details and data
 - b. Psychological appeals
 - c. Reader benefits
3. Desire
 - a. Statement of request
 - b. Supporting data to help create reader's desire to grant request
4. Action
 - a. Clear statement of action
 - b. Easy action, dated when desirable
 - c. Special inducement
 - d. Reader benefit

■ Communication Probe

In an article exploring expository writing in Japanese, Korean, Chinese, and Thai, John Hinds describes an alternate organizational pattern that sometimes confuses western readers. This pattern is not deductive nor completely inductive, but rather what Hinds calls “quasi-inductive.” It follows a more circular progression of points rather than the linear progression common in western writing. The purpose of this organizational pattern is often to persuade readers to think for themselves, to reflect and come to their own conclusions. Persuasive writing in the West always has the purpose of offering conclusions to readers and persuading them to act. Recognizing these different expectations and purposes can help the western reader to correctly interpret many written messages from other cultures.

Hinds, J. (1990). Inductive, deductive, quasi-inductive: Expository writing in Japanese, Korean, Chinese, and Thai. In U. Connor & A. Johns (eds.), *Coherence in writing: Research and pedagogical perspectives* (pp. 80–100). Alexandria, VA: Teachers of English to Speakers of Other Languages, Inc.

ble, place the main favorable ideas at the beginning and ending of a message. This advice also applies to paragraphs.

Opening Paragraphs

The opening of a message determines whether the reader continues reading, puts the message aside, or discards it.

Often the opening of a written message determines whether the reader continues reading, puts the message aside for later, or discards it. Checklist 6.3 and the following examples offer suggestions for good openings that help make favorable impressions:

1. Choose Openings Appropriate for Message Purpose and Reader

Main Idea or Good-News Subject First. Begin with the main idea or good-news subject when you are sure the reader will consider the information favorable or neutral. It is also easier for the reader to understand the main idea if it is in the first paragraph. These openings are desirable in direct-request, neutral, and good-news messages.

Request:

So that your CD funds, which have matured, can be transferred to your IRA account as you have requested, please return to us the following:

Good news:

Enclosed is a cash refund for the defective wristwatch that you sent to us recently.

■ Checklist 6.3 Opening Paragraphs

1. Choose an opening appropriate for the message purpose and for the reader.
 - a. Main idea or good-news first for direct-request, neutral, and good-news messages.
 - b. Buffer first for bad-news messages.
 - c. Attention-getting statements first for persuasive requests.
2. Make the opening considerate, courteous, concise, clear.
 - a. Get reader into opening.
 - b. Keep first paragraph relatively short.
 - c. Focus on the positive.
 - d. Use courteous, conversational language.
 - e. Avoid unnecessary repetition.
3. Check for completeness regarding:
 - a. Sentence structure.
 - b. Date of letter you are answering.

Announcement:
(who, what,
when, where,
why)

As a representative of [company name], you are invited to attend a free seminar on Negotiating Environmental Issues in the International Marketplace to be held in the Richelieu ballroom, Opera Hotel, 8 rue de Sèvres, Paris, on May 1. The purpose of this seminar is to explain the new national environmental laws affecting international business.

Advertising writing seeks to get reader attention immediately; such writing often breaks the rules of proper grammar.

Buffer First. When you have bad news for the reader, begin with a buffer—a statement that you can agree on which sets a neutral tone. (Chapter 9 discusses buffers in greater detail.)

Poor: Your application to the [name] Executive Skills Program has been rejected due to the following reasons:

Good: Because of the large number of applications we received for our [name] Executive Skills Program, we have had to turn away many persons. We obviously underestimated the interest in our current subject. A new program is already being planned, and we will send you information as soon as it's available.

Attention-Getting Statements First. When you write a persuasive request (sales letter), begin with relevant statements that will induce the recipient to read further, as in this opening:

Did you know that up to half of all lower back pain is caused by sleeping on a too-soft mattress? In addition, back pain due to other causes can be made worse by sleeping on a poor mattress. We remedy that. Our company has developed a new mattress and foundation that provides the kind of support your back needs!

So we blew it! That happens. But our wish is to meet your concerns immediately. Like within the next two weeks. Please read the enclosed flyer; we hope it responds to all your questions.

In both examples above, the sentences are varied. Some are even incomplete. Attention-getting marketing statements seek first to get attention of the reader and then worry about the precision of the language.

2. Make the Opening Considerate, Courteous, Concise, Clear

Immediately get your reader into the opening thought whether your message is good or bad news, a direct or a persuasive request. Emphasize the reader, and focus on the positive aspects of your message. Use courteous language, and avoid anything that might anger the reader.

Keep the first paragraph relatively short—five typewritten lines or less. As in all the paragraphs, use conversational language in clear and concise sentences. Avoid unnecessary repetition of what the reader has told you.

3. Check for Completeness

Avoid opening with an incomplete sentence like:

Reference your letter [or per your letter] of May 9, concerning Helen Smith's request for a transfer of funds.

Usually you should subordinate the date of the letter you are answering unless including it is beneficial to the reader or to you or unless you need it for record keeping.

Poor: As per your recent letter, we have shipped your order today by Federal Express.

Good: Three bolts of Thai silk, which you ordered on July 6, were shipped to you today by DHL.

Closing Paragraphs

Your closing is more likely to motivate the reader to act as requested if it is appropriately strong, clear, and polite. Here you have the opportunity to bring final

Closings should be strong, clear, and polite; they should leave a sense of closure and goodwill with the receiver.

focus on the desired action and leave a sense of goodwill with the reader. What you say in the closing should reinforce the central purpose of your message.

Checklist 6.4 and the following examples focus on ways to apply the seven C qualities in closings for various letter and memo situations.

1. Make Action Request Clear and Complete with the Five W's and the H

Whenever you are requesting action by your reader or by someone else, your closing paragraph will usually be more effective if you make clear *what*, *who*, *how*, *where*, *when*, and if appropriate, *why*.

What and Who? *Clear statement of the action you desire your reader (or someone else) to take.* Should the reader phone your office for an appointment? Sign a card or a document? Return it? If so, to whom? Come to your office in person? Send your certain information or payment?

How and Where? *Easy action.*

- Include your phone number and extension if you want the reader to phone you.
- Enclose a form (card, order, blank, or questionnaire) and an addressed reply envelope (perhaps with postage paid) if you want the reader to furnish something.
- Give complete instructions regarding *how* and *where* if you do not include a form and envelope.
- State your office hours and location if you want the reader to come to you in person. Do you have a free parking lot? Where?

Be careful when setting precise deadlines with foreign companies; some will consider a deadline only after extensive discussion.

When and Why? *Dated action; special inducement to act by a specified time.* Name the date (and the exact hour, if pertinent) whenever you need the reply by

■ Communication Probe

“Practice precedes theory” is a supportable axiom; it means that businesses often accept a communication procedure far in advance of its appearance in textbooks or articles. For example, for years Great Britain, with its extensive empire, influenced business communication throughout the world. The memorandum, in various formats on all continents, was accepted and used. Today E-mail is used as part of the technological revolution; this media channel preceded theories about it, theories that are only now developing. Textbooks and scholars seek to keep up with the accelerated changes occurring in the business world as firms grow and become more global.

Yates, J. (1989, May). The emergence of the memo as a managerial genre. *Management Communication Quarterly*, 2(4), 485–510.

■ Checklist 6.4 Closing Paragraphs

1. Make your action request clear and complete with the five W's and the H (how) if you want your reader to do something.
 - a. *What and who*: Clearly state what action you desire and who should do it.
 - b. *How and where*: Make action easy.
 - c. *When*: Date the action, if desirable.
 - d. *Why*: Show reader benefit, if possible.
2. End on a positive, courteous thought.
 - a. Include any apologies and negatives before the last paragraph.
 - b. Be friendly.
 - c. Show appreciation.
 - d. Occasionally add a personal note.
3. Keep the last paragraph concise and correct.
 - a. Avoid trite expressions.
 - b. Omit discussion of trivial details.
 - c. Use relatively short and complete sentences.

a certain time. Tactfully state the reason you need it then—perhaps to meet a report or printer's deadline or to use in a speech you are giving at a certain meeting.

When appropriate, mention some benefits the reader will gain by prompt action. In the following example, notice how the vague action request is improved by inserting some or all of the W's and the H:

Vague: I look forward to hearing from you regarding this matter.

Better: So that we can make appropriate arrangements for your visit, please call me at 555-4567, ext. 11, before Friday, November 16, anytime between 9 A.M. and 5 P.M.

2. End on a Positive, Courteous Thought

Include Any Apologies and Negatives Before Last Paragraph. Study these examples:

Negative: I'm sorry we can't be more encouraging at this time.

Positive: We wish you success in your search for a position.

Be Friendly. Offer to help the reader further, if that is appropriate. Words like *please* or *will you* help soften commands.

Good: If there is any further way we can assist you, please call (222) 555-4567 Monday through Friday between 9 A.M. and 5 P.M.

Poor: Send us your check today.

Good: To keep your credit in good standing, please send us your check for \$595.95 today.

Show Appreciation. Everyone likes sincere praise when earned. But do not thank people for doing something before they have agreed to do it.

Avoid: Thank you in advance for distributing these questionnaires to your employees.

Say: I will appreciate your distributing these questionnaires to your employees.

Occasionally Add a Personal Note. When unrelated to the subject discussed in the message, a personal note is appropriate, sometimes added as a last paragraph, often handwritten.

Give my regards to your lovely family. I enjoyed meeting them during the October conference.

3. Keep Last Paragraph Concise and Correct

Trim your last paragraph to five or fewer lines of complete sentences. Avoid trite expressions and unnecessary repetition.

Poor: Again, we thank you for your inquiry. Enclosed you will find a self-addressed, stamped envelope. Hoping to hear from you soon about your preference, I remain . . .

Better: Please fill out this form and return it in the enclosed envelope by [date]. Then you can soon begin to enjoy the comfort at . . .

COMPOSING THE MESSAGE

Drafting Your Message

Your first draft is often the most difficult to write. The important thing is to get the most important information in your message on paper early.

When you have completed the five planning steps and considered your openings and closings, you are ready for your first draft.

No two people prepare their first drafts the same way. Some people write first drafts in a linear style, following their mental or written outline and moving from one point to the next. Others use a more circular style, putting their ideas down with a less fixed progression of points, data, and organization. Regardless of your style, the important thing is to get on paper (or cassette recorder or word processor) the information you want included in your message. The next step is to polish the document. Some of the world's best writers believe their strength lies in revising and editing, the next two steps in writing.

Revising Your Message

Revision means adding necessary and deleting unnecessary information, making sure your points are adequately supported, checking your organizational approach, and reviewing your language in terms of the seven Cs.

After you finish the first draft of a message, you must evaluate its content, organization, and style. The following are suggestions for revising:

- Does your message accomplish its purpose?
- Have you chosen the most effective organizational plan?
- Are your points supported by adequate material?
- Is your language complete, concise, considerate, concrete, clear, courteous, and correct?
- Have you used variety in sentence structure?

If you included unnecessary material, delete it. If you need additional information, get it. Change, move, add, and delete as much information as you need to create an effective message. The best writers confirm again and again that revision is the key to good writing. Tolstoy revised *War and Peace* 5 times; James Thurber rewrote his stories as many as 15 times; Franklin D. Roosevelt's speeches often went to 18 drafts; James Mitchener feels that his strength is in rewriting.

Editing and Proofreading Your Message

Editing and proofreading are important to ensure that your document has no mistakes in grammar, spelling, punctuation, or word choice.

Persons writing in a second language will find it helpful to read their written material aloud.

Editing your message involves checking all paragraphs for good topic sentences, examining sentences for sound structure, and watching language for correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation. When you have edited your message and found it to be effective, you are ready for final proofreading. Sometimes you will proofread your document several times to be sure that you have not missed any errors. Even minor mistakes, such as typographical errors, can reduce the effectiveness of your message and undermine your credibility.

Those writing in a second language can take one more step in proofreading material. Read your written material aloud. Most people who speak a second language are more competent in oral communication in their second language than in written, which is why an American writing in German will more easily sense through *Sprachgefühl* (feel of the language) which of the 12 German

■ Communication Probe

Drafting and revising is important in business writing not only to produce the best, most effective product but also to increase a writer's understanding of issues. Many researchers suggest that writing is itself a tool for learning, that the process of putting thoughts on paper or on a word processor helps develop a writer's understanding of complex issues, which can then be incorporated into subsequent drafts. Some writers say "I don't know what I think about the topic until I've written it down." Writing can be a legitimate method of discovery.

Schwom, B. L., & Hirsch, P. L. (1994, June). Managing the drafting process: Creating a new model for the workplace. *The Bulletin for the Association for Business Communication*, 1-10. Gere, A. R. (1988). *Writing and learning*. New York: Macmillan.

prepositions is most correct if he or she reads the document aloud, and a native Spaniard who writes in English can better sense which tense, which article, and which preposition is best when reading aloud. In fact, pronouncing written material out loud is a good idea for everyone.

SUMMARY

Five planning steps are basic to effective writing: (1) identify your purpose, (2) analyze your audience, (3) choose your ideas, (4) collect your data, and (5) organize your message. Although this chapter discusses these steps in sequence, several steps may occur simultaneously.

Western countries prefer the direct (deductive) approach; they like to state the main idea, the main purpose early. It is the preferred organizational approach in business. Yet, be conscious of your message receiver and know whether he or she will be receptive to your message.

Other countries, such as those in South America, Asia, or the Middle East, prefer the indirect (inductive) approach, in which more prefatory material is provided before arriving at the conclusion, recommendation, or action step.

Certainly opening paragraphs and closing paragraphs are singularly important. Opening statements attempt to gain reader attention; ending statements provide easy action or precise steps to take.

Revising and editing are central to good writing. Here you verify the existence of the seven C's; here you read for sentence structure, language clarity, and correct grammar, spelling, and punctuation. Second language writers should read their material aloud, because a person's oral language recognition is often better than written language recognition.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. **Evaluations of Openings.** Following are the first sentences of three messages to a Japanese business executive. What are their differences, and which would be effective or ineffective. Why?
 - a. Per our conversation on March 4, we would like to negotiate a contract with you to distribute your products in the Chicago area.
 - b. Would you like to sell your products in a totally new market?
 - c. We respect our relationship with you.
2. **Request for Support.** Discuss the features of the following letter from a Japanese MBA student to his company, which is paying for his graduate program.

Dear Sir and Madam:

I am delighted to hear that you are continuing to prosper.

By the way, I have been chosen to study for an M.B.A. degree at [university name] in the United States.

The care and help that you provided me while I was working in the Osaka branch of the Mitsui Trust and Banking Company has been appreciated.

During my stay abroad, I will do my very best and study hard. I ask for your continued support in the future.

Sincerely,

Exercises of a General Nature

3. Evaluations of Closings. Rewrite the following closings to show a more reader-oriented approach and a friendlier tone.

- a. I wish to thank you very much for opening an account with our store. We will do our best to serve you well, and we hope that you will use your account as soon as possible.
- b. Fill out the enclosed questionnaire and mail it to us right away so that we can send your prize.
- c. You must send your payment by October 15 or risk your account being turned over to a credit agency.
- d. Payment is due on delivery.

4. Revision of a Wordy and Inappropriate Memo. Revise the following memo from the manager of a small office to salaried employees regarding donations for holiday gifts for the office secretaries.

Once again, the time of year has rolled around that we have to think about giving something to the gals that slave for us. Trying to think of things to give that really show our appreciation (and don't break the bank!) gets harder and harder each year. You all know how difficult this is because we go through it every year, and every year we have the same problem, which is trying to please 7 women. And you all know how impossible that is! If any of you have some good ideas-or even bad ideas, come to think of it-I'm all ears. I'd like for us all to go in together and get something they can all use, although I haven't been able to come up with anything yet. We could get a big tin of popcorn

for the office or maybe a plant. I'm not sure how much money we should each give-maybe a buck apiece would cover it. At any rate, let me know any ideas you come up with, and give me the buck as soon as you can.

5. **Evaluation of Three Replies.** The sales manager of Right Fit Hanger, Inc., recently wrote to three television stations asking if they would handle her product on a commission basis. She had heard that some stations occasionally used their open time in this manner. Which of the three replies below do you think best adheres to business communication principles? Why?

REPLY A

I don't know where you got your information as stated in the opening sentence of your letter: "I have been informed that your station occasionally promotes items on a commission basis." We don't appreciate your assumption. If you want to do business with us, buy; if you don't, don't write us.

REPLY B

This will acknowledge your recent letter offering your all-plastic clothes hanger on a commission basis.

I am quite sure that you did not run your advertisement in the Sunday newspaper supplement on a commission basis. By the same token, we will not accept business on a percentage or per inquiry basis.

For your information, I am attaching our rate card.

REPLY C

Your information must have been somewhat misleading inasmuch as NUTZ has never promoted items on a commission basis.

We would be delighted to handle the Right Fit hanger, and I personally think it is an item in great demand.

Enclosed is our rate card so that you can choose the time, frequency, and length of message that will promote your product as you wish it. As soon as your reply to these points reaches us, we will be glad to put all our resources at your disposal.

6. **Revision of a Memo.** Revise the following memo announcement so that it has a better you-attitude and more active than passive verbs. Correct any other errors and problems.

TO: Customer Service Personnel
FROM: Tom S. Powers
SUBJECT: Deposit and Cash Receipt Books
DATE: March 1, 199-

Effective March 1, 199-, the following changes will be made in the use and care of deposit and cash receipt books by our salesmen:

1. The deposit and/or cash receipt book(s) issued to a salesman will be used only by the client to whom the book is issued.
2. Whenever a deposit or other monies are collected, the salesman will remove from the receipt book(s) the customer's copy(s) and give this to the customer as is now done. In addition, at the end of his shift, each salesman will no longer turn in the receipt book(s) with the money and tickets for those transactions.
3. Deposit and receipt books are not to be left laying around in a vehicle or other places. They are to be under the strict control of the individual the book(s) is issued to.

Normally a salesman will have one deposit book and one cash receipt book. Additional books may be issued by a service supervisor. All used up books are to be returned to the supervisor for forwarding to the accounting department.

7. **Searching for Overall Organizational Pattern.** This exercise requires you to determine whether a piece of writing is inductive (indirect) or deductive (direct). Remember the admonition of this chapter: When the purpose or aim is up-front or immediate, the structure is deductive; when the purpose, aim, or main conclusion comes later or last, the movement is inductive. Certainly, some forms of communication will be unclear as to purpose or aim. Apply those principles to the following kinds of communication:

- An article in the *Wall Street Journal* or other national newspaper
- An abstract of a business article or a lengthy report
- A research article in a business communication journal
- A television commercial
- A poem
- A song
- An advertisement sent through the mail

The Appearance and Design of Business Messages

I. Business Letters

- A. Stationery and Envelopes
- B. Standard Parts of the Letter
- C. Optional Parts of the Letter
- D. Letter Layout

II. Memorandums

- A. Stationery
- B. Parts of the Memorandum
- C. Layout of the Memorandum Body
- D. Envelopes and Electronic Mail

III. Special Timesaving Message Media

- A. Electronic Mail
- B. Facsimiles (Faxes)
- C. Telegrams, Mailgrams, Telexes
- D. Teleconferencing

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

In the workplace of the future, you may send and receive dozens of messages, interview a candidate for a position in your company through a videoconference, write a report to your manager regarding a new initiative, and download several company files for analysis—all from a PC in your home office or from your laptop if you are not at home. The electronic revolution is changing the way we communicate, and these changes include formats and conventions of written communication.

In the more traditional forms of written communication, your receiver will form an impression of you based on the overall appearance and format of the message. Your cover letter enclosed with your resume when you apply for a job will communicate something about you even before your receiver reads a word of it. This chapter is a brief overview of both the traditional formats of written communication, such as letters and memos, and the newer communication styles developing as a result of the exploding technology.

BUSINESS LETTERS

The medium used most often for written messages to persons outside your organization is the business letter. Your letter's appearance conveys nonverbal impressions that affect a reader's attitude even before that person reads the letter. The many type styles and formats of modern word processing systems and printers can enhance the appearance of your message and create a positive impression.

Elements of appearance that help produce favorable reactions are appropriate stationery and correct letter parts and layouts.

Stationery and Envelopes

Keep the following guidelines in mind if you have an opportunity to suggest or change your organization's stationery.

Good company stationery is most often at least 25 percent cotton content, 20-pound weight, and white, cream, or light gray in color.

Quality, Size, Color

To help build an image of quality, the paper for general business correspondence should have at least 25 percent cotton content; cotton does not turn yellow in time as does wood pulp. Paper quality is usually 20-pound weight, based on the actual weight of 4 reams (2,000 sheets) of standard-sized paper. Other types of paper used are 16- and 24-pound weight. Most letters are the standard size 8½ by 11 inches, with some legal firms using 8½ by 14 inches. White is the most common color, although cream and light gray are also popular. With the new possibilities generated by computer graphics, some messages are written on dark or bright-colored paper. These colors should be used only in special circumstances, however, as when the design of the message is as important as the substance.

Letterhead

Modern letterheads (see Figure 7.1) usually occupy no more than 2 inches at the top of the page. The firm's name, address, ZIP code, and sometimes telephone number, cable address, fax number, Internet address, nature of business, and

Letterhead information should include the name, address, ZIP, and telephone number. Sometimes fax numbers, nature of business, and name of department are also included.

name of the department or branch office sending the correspondence are printed, embossed, or engraved.

Optional details are names of officers and directors, trademark, slogan, and the firm's starting date. Many firms include the extended ZIP code—four figures beyond the ZIP. Benefits of including the extended ZIP are high-speed sorting of your outgoing mail and improved delivery services.

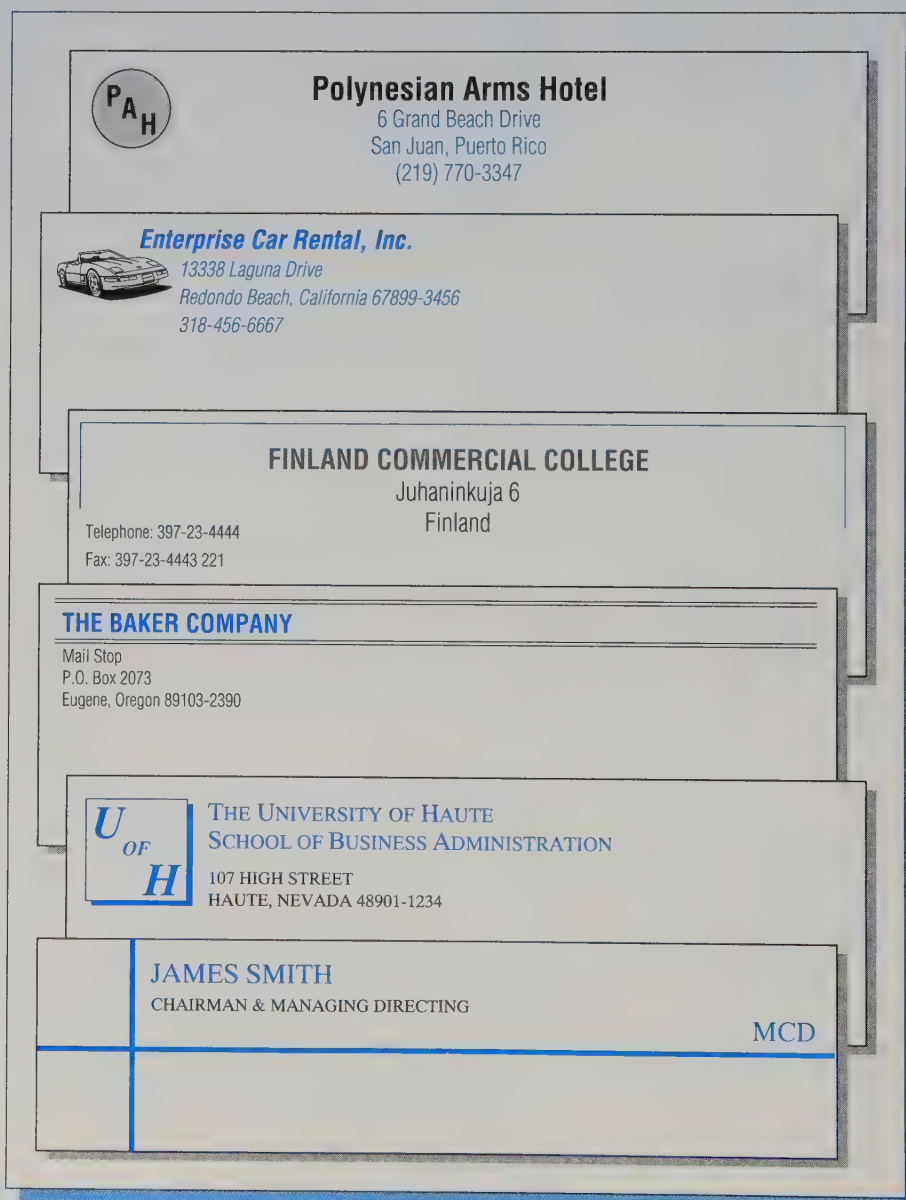


Figure 7.1 Illustration of letterheads. (MCD's address, fax, and telephone numbers are printed on two lines at the bottom of the page.)

Envelopes

Return addresses of the senders, often printed like the letterhead or, if necessary, typewritten, should be in the upper left corner of the envelope. The addressee's address, which is the inside address of the letter, should be placed on the envelope according to U.S. Postal Service published guidelines for location, legibility, abbreviations, and format. Addresses should always be typed in block form, with all lines aligned on the left (see Figure 7.2). Information in the address should be listed in the following order:

1. Name and title of receiver
2. Name of department
3. Name of organization
4. Name of building (if relevant)
5. Street address and suite number or post office box number
6. City, state, and ZIP code (U.S.) or city, province, and postal code (Canada)
7. Country (if letter is being sent out of the country)

Mail notations such as REGISTERED or SPECIAL DELIVERY should be typed in all capitals below the postal area. Any on-arrival instructions, such as CONFIDENTIAL, PLEASE FORWARD, or ACCOUNT NUMBER, should be

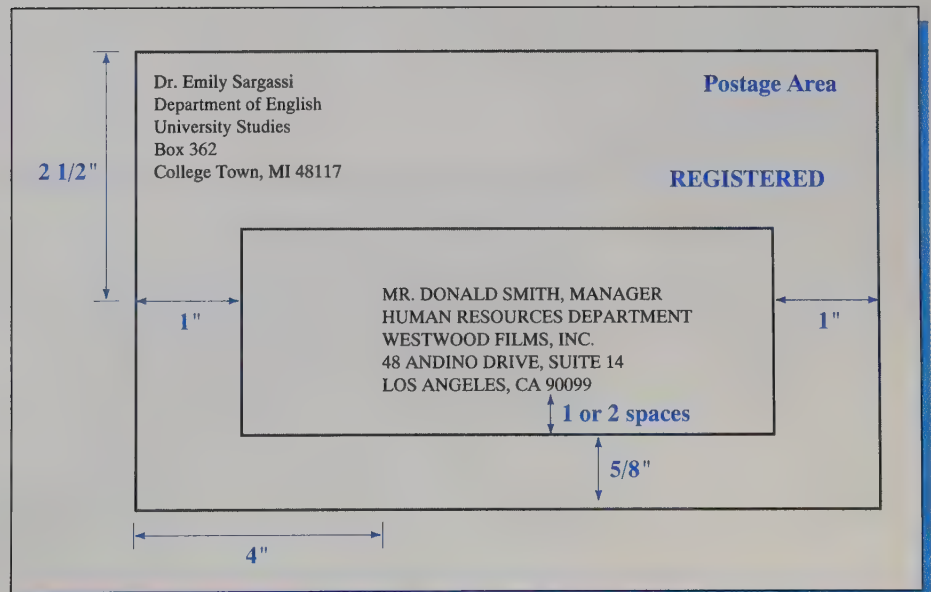


Figure 7.2 Large business envelope (no. 10 size—9 1/2 by 4 1/8 inches) properly addressed for optical character recognition.

typed in all capitals below the return address near the left upper edge of the envelope, as shown in Figure 7.2. Business correspondence should follow the prescribed guidelines because the Postal Service uses scanners to speed operations. The U.S. Postal Service extended ZIP codes can identify a floor in a large building or even a department in an organization.

To speed machine sorting and processing while holding down postal operating costs and postage fees, the Postal Service continues to make minor changes in published preferences wherever possible and desirable. They also have, in every large city, a joint Mailer/Postal Service organization that deals with mailer problems and suggestions. A free monthly pamphlet and various guidelines for successful envelope addressing are available from your local post office.

Standard Parts of the Letter

Most business letters have the following parts: (1) heading; letterhead and date, (2) inside address, (3) salutation, (4) body, (5) complimentary close, (6) signature area, and (7) reference section, as shown in Figure 7.3.

1. Heading—Letterhead and Date

A heading shows where the letter comes from, and if it is letterhead stationery, it is usually at the top center of the letter. If you are not using letterhead stationery, your return address, but not your name, is typed directly above the date about 2 inches from the top, as in Figure 7.4, p. 165.

Usually the date is typewritten two to six lines below the last line of the letterhead—at the left margin, centered, begun at the center, or placed so it ends with the right margin. Date sequence preferred in American business is month, day, year—March 5, 1997—with the month spelled out. If you use the figures 3/5/97, the meaning in Europe, Latin America, and Asia would be day, month,

Headings—either letterhead or your own address—should be at the top of the letter before the date and before the name and address of the receiver of your message.

■ Communication Probe

The kind of stationery a company chooses, its quality, and any graphic designs or letterhead formats it chooses can communicate a strong message to clients and consumers. If a company has no consistent graphics, letterheads, or quality of stationery, the message can be one of visual chaos, suggesting an absence of attention, organization, and effective management. A lack of quality and consistency can also be costly, with each division and department designing and funding its own stationery, letterheads, and images. Although a reader usually does not study the kind of stationery used by a company or the effectiveness of its graphics, the physical characteristics nevertheless do communicate a strong impression that can help or hinder the substance of the message.

Spaeth, T. (1991, Winter). Diagnosing corporate identities. *Design Management Journal*, 47–51.

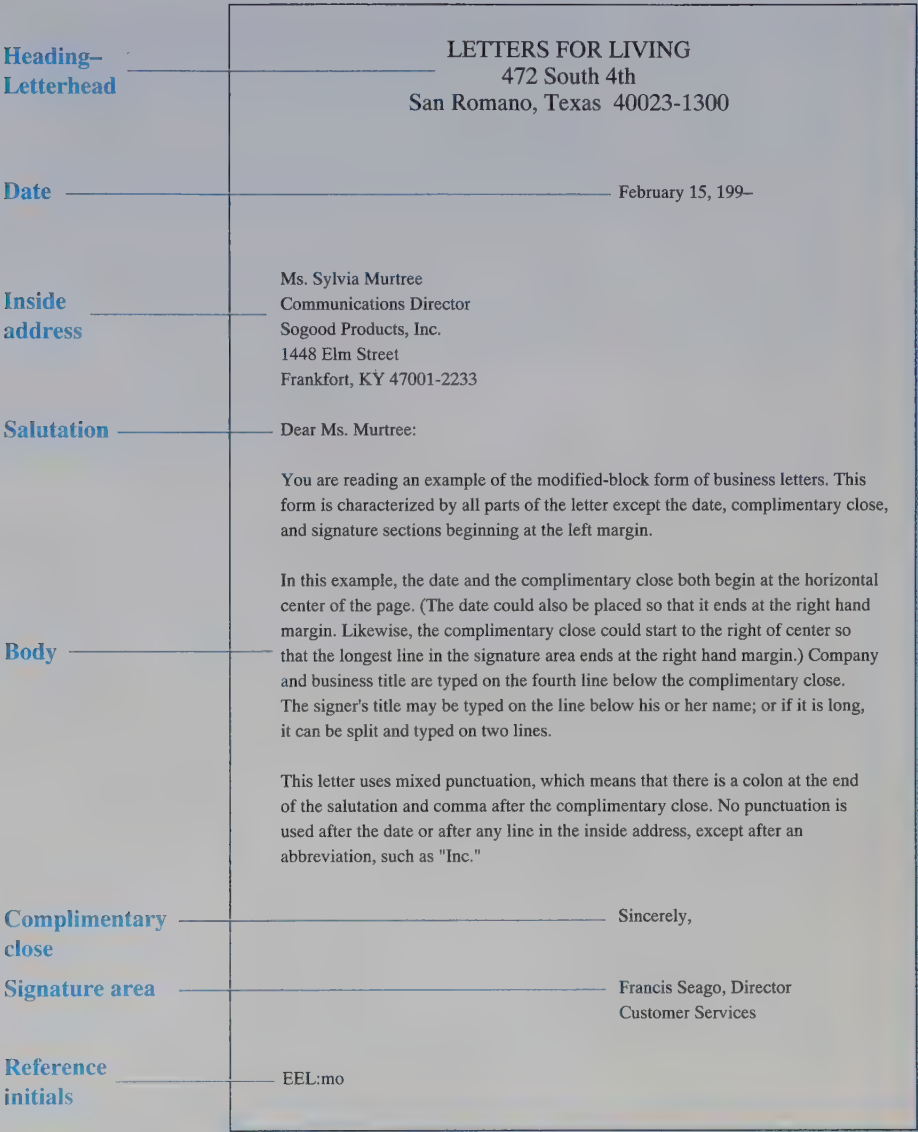


Figure 7.3 Modified-block letter style with mixed punctuation. Length: medium; total blank line spaces below the last line of a letterhead to the date and to the inside address vary, depending on the length of the letter.

year—3 May, 1997. As companies globalize, more people write out the month to avoid confusion.

The inside address should begin with the addressee's name preceded by a courtesy and/or professional title.

2. Inside Address

Always blocked at the left-hand margin, the inside address includes the name and address of the individual, group, or organization to whom you are writing.

Order of items is (1) courtesy title, (2) name, and (3) executive or professional title, if any. All parts are typed single-spaced.

Courtesy Title and Name. If the addressee has no professional title, such as Doctor, Reverend, or Professor, the traditional courtesy titles are Mr., Mrs., Miss, or Ms. When in doubt about a woman's preference, use Ms. plus her own first name and surname. Current trends suggest Ms. as the courtesy title for all business and professional women regardless of their marital status unless they have a professional title that takes precedence. For guidelines on abbreviations of titles and other items, such as names of streets and states, see "Abbreviations" in Appendix B.

After the courtesy title, include your addressee's full first names or two initials and surname. When you do not know whether the initials are for a man or a woman, you can use Mr. or Ms. for the courtesy title or omit the courtesy title altogether.

Executive or Professional Title. Depending on the length of lines, the executive or professional title may be typed on (a) the same line as the addressee's name, (b) the second line preceding the company's name, or (c) a line or two by itself, as in the following examples:

- a. Mr. John Trimmer, President
General Construction Company
Larson Building
1380 Adams Street NW
Chicago IL 60623-1122
- b. Ms. Marietta K. Worthington
Treasurer, XYZ Corporation
P.O. Box 91467
Augusta GA 30915-1234
- c. Dr. Marlotte Lim, Sr.
Human Resources Officer
Esso Singapore Private Limited
1 Raffles Place
Singapore 0104

3. Salutation

Salutations are typed on the second line below the inside address and two lines above the body of the letter.

The salutation is typed on the second line below the inside address, two lines above the body, and even with the left margin. Both traditional and comparatively recent salutations are included in the following list, all of which much be appropriate for the first line of the inside address.

- a. Dear Mr. [Or Ms., Mrs., Miss] Doe—When the first line of an inside address is the name of an individual.
- b. Dear John [Or Mary or nickname]—When you'd address the individual this way in person and when it is appropriate for you to do so in your letter.

- c. **Dear Koo Hong Chuan,**—Most often used in Asia; family name first, then given name, then comma.
- d. **Dear Manager [or Executive, Human Resources Director, Admissions Director, or an appropriate variation]**—When the first line is a position within an organization and you have no name.
- e. **Dear Ladies and Gentlemen [or Members of . . . , Committee Members, Professional Women, XYZ Fraternity, Admissions Office]**—When you are addressing a company, a group, or a department and you don't know a specific person to contact.
- f. **Dear Customer [or Homeowner, Executive, Student, Occupant, Member of . . .]**—For messages that omit the inside address such as sales letters or announcements.

4. Body

Most letters are typed single-spaced, with two spaces between paragraphs, before and after the salutation, and before the complimentary close.

Generally, the body of all letters should be typed single-spaced, with double spacing between paragraphs, before and after the salutation, and before the complimentary close. Figure 7.3 indicates where all blank line spaces are in that letter. A short letter could be double-spaced with additional blank line spaces before and after the date and within the signature area.

When the body of a letter is two or more pages, each page beyond the first is headed by the addressee's name, page number, and date. This information is typed at the top of the sheet with the same margins as the first page.

5. Complimentary Close

The most popular complimentary closes in American letters are the following (notice that only the first word is capitalized).

Sincerely, [most popular]
Sincerely yours, Yours sincerely
Very truly yours, Yours very truly
Cordially,

When the letter is informal, additional complimentary closes are often used, such as Warm regards, Best regards, and Best wishes. Do not be surprised to see letters from the U.K. or Asia closing with Faithfully yours, or Faithfully; tradition influences their use of that closing.

6. Signature Area

You can include in the signature area several identifications: name of your company, your signature, your typewritten name, and your business title. If printed on the letterhead, your company name need not be typed after the complimentary close. However, if you wish to include it, type it in capital letters a double space under the complimentary close, as in the Westwood company example below.

Your signature is pen-written above your typed name, which appears three to five lines below the company name (if included) and the complimentary close. The typed business title usually follows the typed name.

Very truly yours,	Sincerely,	Cordially,
WESTWOOD FILMS, INC.		
<i>Jennifer Wenthe</i>	<i>Stuart Stanton</i>	<i>Steven</i>
Jennifer Wenthe Marketing Manager	Stuart Stanton Human Resources Director	Steven Grant President

Usually the signature is the same as the typed name. An exception occurs when you use your reader's first name for the salutation, in which case you will usually sign only your first name above your typed name, as Steven Grant did in the example above.

7. Reference Section

The reference section may include information about the message composer, the typist, and sometimes word processing data.

Your initials as the composer of the message along with those of your typist usually appear at the left margin on the same line with the last line of the signature area (your name or title) or one or two lines below that, as in Figures 7.3 and 7.5. Common forms are

ML0/mb	ML0/MB	ML0:mb	ML0:MB
--------	--------	--------	--------

Use of word processing systems adds another dimension. Disk information is often included as in the following:

HWH<3>:jr	[HWH is composer; disk 3; jr is typist]
jc[JNT VJ<6>	[jc is composer; title on disk; disk 6]

If someone other than the signer of the letter composes the letter, practice varies regarding reference initials. Many firms show on the file copy the initials of the signer, writer, and typist (KLM:JC:tr). The original to the addressee may omit all or only the writer's initials to avoid showing that the signer did not compose the letter. At present, there is no universally recommended way to include references.

Optional Parts of the Letter

An attention line is useful when you want your message to go to a certain department or when someone other than the addressee will take care of your message.

When appropriate, any of these optional parts can be included: (1) attention line, (2) subject line, (3) enclosure(s), (4) copy notation, (5) file or account number and mailing notation, and (6) postscript.

1. Attention Line

When you want to direct a letter to a particular person or title or department in an organization, you can use an attention line. It is useful in the following contexts:

- Placement of the attention line is usually between the inside address and salutation, with a blank line before and after it. It may be flush with the left margin, indented with the paragraphs, or centered. See Figure 7.5. for an example of flush with the left margin.

Considered part of the body of the letter, the subject line helps tell your reader at a glance what your letter is about. It also helps in filing. The subject line may include or omit the word *subject*. It is usually placed on the second line below the salutation and centered (Figure 7.4), or it may be placed flush with left margin (Figure 7.7). The typing may be capitals and lowercase and underlined (Figure 7.4) or all capitals (Figure 7.7).

To remind whoever prepares your envelope for mailing that something is to be enclosed, the enclosure notation is usually typed a single or double space under

Heading	24 South 3rd Ave. Olaf MN 33407 February 6, 199—
Inside address	Mr. Steven Boggs 264 Vista Avenue San Francisco, CA 94330
Salutation	Dear Steve:
Subject line	<u>Subject: Resort Reservations for March</u>
	The room reservations you requested for the month of March have been taken care of. We have given you the Snow Suite—two rooms with a kitchenette. You should be comfortable there, and the expected ski conditions are excellent. The enclosed brochure tells you about the services we have added since you were here last.

Figure 7.4 Illustration of heading with typed return address on plain stationery; also, inside address, nickname in salutation, and centered subject line.

DIGIGRAPHICS, INC.**222 49th St.****City, NY 10012-0000**

May 2, 199-

REGISTERED MAIL

Mr. Kevin George, Consultant
Office Supply Corp.
111 Computer Notices Building
460 River Street
Chicago, IL 60045-6677

Dear Mr. George:

DIGIGRAPHICS, Inc. can supply you with forms for all kinds of business letters. This full-block letter is typed single-spaced with a blank line between paragraphs. Every line begins at the left margin. "REGISTERED MAIL" is a double space from the date.

Many firms prefer this format because of its simplicity and ease in setting up on computers or word processors. The writer's company name may be typed under the complimentary close, as here, or omitted.

Other accepted forms of reference initials could be used with this letter style. Also, the "REGISTERED MAIL" notation could be typed at the bottom, a double space after the reference initials. The postscript, handwritten or typewritten, would then be placed a double space under "REGISTERED MAIL."

Sincerely yours,

DIGIGRAPHICS, INC.

Andrea Forman, Manager
Customer Service Department

MB/mo

Figure 7.5 Full-block letter style, with mixed punctuation. Length: short.

the reference initials. This notation also alerts the addressee to check for enclosures. One enclosure is a unit that can consist of one or more pages. For example, a cover letter with a two-page resume enclosed is only one enclosure. When more than one item is enclosed, you should indicate the number: "Enclosures 3" (See Figure 7.6). For an attachment, that word may be typed in place of "enclosure."

When the enclosures are especially important (checks, legal documents, or blueprints), it is desirable to list in the enclosure notation exactly what the enclosures are (Enclosures 2-Policy #9595 and #32805).

When persons other than the addressee will receive a copy of your message, you note by writing “c,” “pc,” “copy,” or “cc” followed by the names of these persons just below the reference initials or the enclosure notation.

4. Copy Notation

When you want persons other than the addressee to receive a copy of your letter, the names of these persons should be typed just below the reference initials or the enclosure notation, whichever is last. Type “cc” before the copy notation names if you are sending them a carbon copy. Type “c,” “pc,” or “copy” if it is a photocopy. Recipients’ addresses may be included after their names.

When you do not want the addressee to know that other persons are getting a copy of the letter, type “bc” (blind copy) or “bpc” (blind photocopy) and the recipients’ names *on the copies only*.

5. File or Account Number and Mailing Notation

To aid in filing and quick retrieval for both the sender’s and reader’s company, some firms require that file, loan, or account numbers be typed above the body of the letter.

Mailing notation words such as Special Delivery, Certified, or Registered Mail, when applicable, may be typed a double space below the date line and at least a double space before the inside address, as in Figure 7.5. An alternative placement is below the last notation. For instance, the Registered Mail notation could be placed a double space under the reference initials and a double space above the postscript.

6. Postscript

To emphasize a point already in your letter or to include a brief personal message unrelated to the letter, a postscript, typed or handwritten (with or without “P.S.,” “PS,” or “PS:”) may be added below everything else typed on the page. (See Figure 7.5.) But with today’s rapid word processors, the postscript is falling into disuse.

If you have occasion to use several notations after the signature area, the initials RCMP may help you remember the proper order for arranging them vertically at the left margin: reference initials, enclosures, copy notation, mailing notation, postscript.

Letter Layout

Most American business letters use mixed punctuation, with a colon following the salutation and a comma after the complimentary close.

Although layout or format of the letter is primarily the typist’s responsibility, it is covered briefly here to give you a basis for choosing the styles you prefer. Some companies have adopted a common word processing software package (that even includes punctuation) so that all their letters are uniform regardless of dictator, department, or secretary.

Punctuation Styles

Open and *mixed* punctuation are the two forms most used in American business letters. In open punctuation, no line of any letter part (except the body) has any

punctuation at the end unless an abbreviation requires a period. In mixed punctuation, a colon follows the salutation; a comma follows the complimentary close.

Foreign writers, especially those in Asia and Great Britain, use a comma in place of a colon after the salutation. They argue that colons are too formal. Tradition in the United States suggests a comma in personal letters even though colons are used in business letters.

Letter Styles

Business letters are usually arranged in one of the letter styles described briefly below and in Figures 7.3 to 7.7.

- 1. *Full-block* (Figure 7.5). Every line begins at the left margin. This is a common format because it is quick and easy to set up.
- 2. *Modified-block* (Figure 7.3). The date, complimentary close, and signature sections begin at the horizontal center of the page or are placed so that they end near the right-hand margin. Attention and subject lines may be indented, centered, or begin at the left margin, where all other parts begin. This letter style is used often and is attractive on the page.
- 3. *Modified-block with paragraphs indented* (Figure 7.6).
- 4. *AMS (Administrative Management Society) simplified style* (Figure 7.7). AMS has been in use since the 1950s, but is not widely used.

Tips for Letter Placement

Software packages permit instant formatting (indents, spacing, margin width, type style, for example) of material according to the length of the letter or the size of the paper. The following suggestions are helpful for setting up your message on 8½ by 11-inch paper.

Letter Length	Words in Body	Side Margins, Inches	Line Length, Inches	Lines Between Date and Inside Address	Examples
Short	Under 100	2	4½	4–10	Figure 7.4
Medium	100–200	1½	5½	3–8	Figures 7.3 and 7.5
Long	200–300	1	6½	2–6	Figure 7.6

In summary, some software packages for word processing systems have removed most of the guesswork in laying out or formatting a letter. Additional non-verbal cues of the letter’s appearance are its stationery, placement of the standard parts on the page, and envelope. When these are all desirable, the combination will help you send a visually appealing letter.

MEMORANDUMS

In contrast to the letter, which is directed outside your organization, the memorandum goes within your organization. It is the most common form of written

LETTERHEAD

February 6, 199–

Research & Development Department
Futura Graphics Company
114 Fourth Avenue, NE
San Obispo, CA 55577-0000

Attention: Ms. Fenottus

Research Development Team:

Among other formats available for your business letters is this modified-block style with paragraph indentations. The date may be centered or placed to the right of center, so long as it does not extend into the right margin. In this example, the date begins to the right of center.

The attention line here is at the left margin, two lines below the inside address, and underlined. It could also have been centered and typed in all capital letters without underscoring. If you wanted Ms. Fenottus' name in the salutation, you would type her first name or two initials and her surname above "Research & Development Department." Then you would omit the attention line and use "Dear Ms. Fenottus" in the salutation.

Like the date, the complimentary close begins at the center of the page. The company name is omitted, but it could have been included. Also, the signer's name, instead of being at the left, could have been typed in the usual place—or just move above "Creative Director," and reference initials could then have been used at the left margin.

The term "enclosures 3" in the reference section shows that three additional items are being enclosed in the envelope. Each different item is counted as one regardless of the number of pages it has. The notation "c" indicates that a copy is being sent to Mr. Solomon. If you have more than one name, you can list them alphabetically or by rank.

The right-hand margins are not "justified" (even) in this letter, but that is an option you have for this and all other letter styles.

Very truly yours,

George Wells

Creative Director

Enclosures 3
c: Mr. James Solomon

Figure 7.6 Modified-block letter style, with paragraph indentations and mixed punctuation. Length: long.

LETTERHEAD

May 1, 199—

Mr. Louis St. John
P.O. Box 992
Boston, MA 00000-1234

FORMAT FOR SIMPLIFIED LETTER

This letter form, Mr. St. John, has been recommended by the Administrative Management Society as a timesaver when typing business letters. Here are its features:

- It uses full-block form and open punctuation.
- It omits the salutation and complimentary close but—to personalize—may, if possible, use the reader's name in the first and last sentences.
- The subject line is all capitals, omits "Subject," and is typed where the salutation is usually placed.
- The signer's name and business title are typed in all capitals, starting at the left margin at least four lines below the last line of the letter body.
- The typist initials are at the left margin two lines below the signer's name. Enclosures and names of persons receiving copies are on separate lines below the initials.

Mr. St. John, the simplified letter not only saves time but also avoids the risk of selecting an inappropriate salutation—or using "Dear (name)" when the reader is in no way "dear." It is also helpful when you are writing a department and don't know anyone's name or whether its members include men, women, or both.

For most business letters, correspondents prefer to use the traditional forms with salutations and complimentary closes.

JANICE C. PETINA—PUBLIC RELATIONS DIRECTOR

mo
Enclosure
CC: Jon Sanchez, Jennifer Waits

Figure 7.7 AMS simplified style; full-block; open punctuation. Length: medium; side margins: 1½ inches; line length: 5½ inches.

communication between people or departments. The stationery, parts, layout, and envelopes are somewhat different from those of the letters described in the preceding section.

Stationery

Managers using electronic mail (E-mail) send their message from a computer to that of a colleague, eliminating the need for stationery. Or the receiver may print out the message on computer paper. For more permanency, a copy of the E-mail memo is often reproduced on higher-quality stationery. Formal memorandum reports, composed on word processing systems and reproduced on laser printers, may also use higher quality paper. Preprinted memo stationery may include MEMORANDUM and the company's name (but not address). Also, words naming the various memo parts may be included, as in Figure 7.8. Many companies decide on their own format.

Parts of the Memorandum

Standard memos consist of a heading with TO, FROM, SUBJECT, and DATE. On preprinted office forms, the word MESSAGE may also appear. These parts can be programmed to appear automatically with just a keystroke in a word processing system. Optional parts are such items as reference initials, enclosures, file number, routing information, and the sender's department and telephone

MEMORANDUM (Company name)

DATE: _____ FROM: _____

TO: _____ TELEPHONE: _____

DEPT: _____

SUBJECT: _____

For your

Message, Comment, or Reply ☐ APPROVAL ☐ INFORMATION ☐ COMMENT

WRITE IT • DATE IT • SIGN IT

Oral messages waste time, cause annoying interruptions, and are likely to be misunderstood or forgotten.

Figure 7.8 Office interdepartmental memorandum.

number. Unlike the letter, the memo requires no inside address, salutation, complimentary close, or full signature. It is not unusual to sign the memorandum at the end along with a personal, handwritten note. That is more the case with British-influenced writing, in which even a complimentary close is added. Some companies have combination message-reply forms that provide lines for both the writer's and the reader's signatures.

Using the combination *message-and-reply memorandum* form is an especially good time and expense saver for both sender and receiver. A packet of three or more perforated sheets plus carbons (unless special carbonless paper is used) makes up a message-reply packet. Printed instructions at the top or bottom tell the sender and the reader how to use the sheets. Each sheet is divided into two sections, MESSAGE and REPLY. These two sections may be side by side or one above the other, as in Figure 7.9.

Headings

Whether to include a courtesy title after your "TO" heading depends on your relationship with your receiver; you omit your title before your own name.

What you write after the TO, FROM, and DATE will vary with the situation and your organization's practices. A courtesy title such as Mr., Mrs., Miss, Ms. before your reader's name may be used, depending on your relationship with the reader (superior or subordinate) and the degree of formality within your organization. You omit the title before your name. Also, if the message is a temporary message, not to be filed, and if you and the writer work together regularly, you may merely use initials, first name, or nickname after TO and FROM, and use all figures or abbreviations for the date.

Whether you use initials, first names, or whole names, you must sign or initial your memo. Usually your signature is written above or to the right of your printed name. Occasionally, the signature is put at the bottom of the memo.

If the memo will be filed, the names of the sender and receiver should be completely spelled out. If you are sending the same message to several persons, their names or titles, or both, should be typed after TO. If you write to the same persons often, you may have a form called a *routing slip* prepared with their names printed after the TO. When you have only one copy of a document, book, or other important papers that you want everyone in a certain group to read and comment on, circulate a cover memo as in the following:

DATE:	April 1, 199-	Please read and initial the
TO:	John Evans	attached: then send it to
	Jane Brown	the next reader. Last
	Toshi Umeda	reader please return memo
	Susan Kalray	and attachment to sender.
FROM:	Steve Westberg,	Human Resources
SUBJECT:	<u>Request your Suggestions on Attached</u>	
	<u>Policy Manual</u>	

Subject Line

A subject line must make the content of the memorandum instantly clear. One-word subject lines communicate little. The reader does not know whether he or she will be informed or persuaded, asked to do something, or simply to read for information. Busy executives who receive many memos daily desire an up-front,

ABC Company		INTEROFFICE COMMUNICATION	
TO		PLANT/DEPARTMENT	
FROM		PLANT/DEPARTMENT	
SUBJECT		DATE	
Message 			
SIGNED 			
Reply 			
DATE		SIGNED	
PERSON RECEIVING COMMUNICATION: RETAIN THIS COPY FOR YOUR RECORDS (1st page: white)			
ORIGINATOR: DETACH THIS COPY, SEND REMAINING SET, CARBON INTACT, FOR USE OF REPLIER (2nd page: yellow)			
REPLIER: RETURN THIS COPY TO SENDER (3rd page: pink)			

Figure 7.9 Interoffice memorandum packet containing either carbons under sheets of paper or carbon-treated paper with sections for both message and reply.

clear direction to the memo. Thus the deductive, early statement of intent, often including a verb, gives early understanding of later contents, as in the following two approaches.

Informative Subject Lines—note use of qualifiers
Changes in Vacation Schedules
Requesting Leaves of Absence

Family Events During the Coming Year
Announcement of Newly Promoted Colleague

Persuasive Subject Lines—note use of verbs
Employees Must Determine Vacation Schedule by
March 1
Vice-Presidents Should Submit Material for Annual
Report
Leave of Absence Needed

In brief, the subject line should give immediate direction to the memorandum. Later, of course, the specific aim of the memo will appear. But having clarity immediately increases the chance of a reader's understanding.

Layout of the Memorandum Body

The memo body is not centered on the page and is lined up evenly on the left, with a triple space between the last of the memo headings and the first line of the body.

The body of the memo is its most important part because it contains your message. In general, you can use the same guidelines, principles, and organizational plans for the memo as for the letter.

Unlike that of a letter, the memo body is not centered on the page. First lines usually begin a triple space under the last of the memo headings regardless of message length. Left margins are usually lined up evenly below the headings. Single spacing with double spacing between paragraphs is conventional. For memo pages beyond the first, headings are the same as those for the business letter: reader's name, page number, and date. Reference initials are typed a double space below the body at the left margin. Copy notations may be placed after the reference initials or near the top of the memo between the **TO** and **FROM**. If only your business title appears in the **FROM** line, or if the **FROM** line is omitted, you should sign your name a few spaces below the memo body.

■ Communication Probe

It is impossible to completely separate formats of messages from their substance. A business message generally looks different from other kinds of documents because of the nature of the information involved, the purpose of the message, and the identity of the receiver. Shorter paragraphs, headings and other kinds of advance organizers, and an appropriate amount of white space are hallmarks of business documents. Reasons for these kinds of format conventions are twofold: Most business readers want to understand the message quickly, and most business documents are problem-solution-related rather than philosophical. One of the biggest differences between business writing and other kinds of writing is the importance of visual impact.

Munter, M. (1992). *Guide to managerial communication* (3rd ed.). Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall.

Envelopes and Electronic Mail

How your memo is sent to the addressee depends on where you and the reader are located and the degree of high technology in the office. Firms generally have messengers, preprinted company envelopes, or electronic mail. The envelope address contains your name and department in the upper left corner and the reader's name, department, and address according to your organization's procedures.

SPECIAL TIMESAVING MESSAGE MEDIA

Included in this section are various message media that save both the sender and the recipient time. Media that merit discussion here are the newer electronic forms of communication, such as electronic mail (E-mail) and facsimiles (faxes), as well as a few of the older forms, such as telexes, telegrams, and mailgrams. Teleconferencing adds another dimension to electronic communication, enabling a person to attend a meeting in another city without leaving his or her desk.

Electronic Mail

E-mail formats have similarities to both memo and letter formats, with conventions that are still developing as the use of electronic mail expands.

Writing conventions for electronic mail are still emerging, but generally, E-mail is marked by informality and speed. Formats can vary considerably from one sender to another. Receivers have varying comfort levels with messages sent electronically; some receivers always print out the message in hard copy in order to give it their best reading. Over time, the users of E-mail will determine which kinds of formats are effective. At present, E-mail formats are generally a less formal combination of letter and memo conventions, with memo headings for internal and external communications, but often with salutations and closings more like letters. A complete discussion of electronic mail, including ways to use it effectively, is in Chapter 5.

■ Communication Probe

Some researchers have suggested that a writer's relation to electronic communication seems different from a writer's relation to a hard copy of a letter or memorandum. Some writers lose the sense of audience when composing on a computer and thus, lose the inhibitions or constraints that a hard copy provides. So far, there is little censorship in electronic mail, and writers sensing this freedom express ideas that they would not write on a hard copy. Writers need to be aware that even though writing on E-mail seems relatively anonymous and impermanent, there is not only a receiver of the message but also a record of each message that remains on the system for a period of time. E-mail messages can be read by system operators, can be transcribed on command, and can be subpoenaed in a court of law.

Hawisher, G., & Moran, C. (1993, October). Electronic mail and the writing instructor. *College English*, 55(6), 627–643; Ahrens, E. (1992, Winter). The perils of imprudent writing. *ACCA Docket*, 34–37.

Facsimiles (Faxes)

For immediate communication, many organizations use a fax, which is a fast-growing means of sending and receiving messages.

Where there was one fax machine, there are now three, five, or ten. For years, this instrument languished, only to burst forth as one of the preeminent instruments for communicating information—worldwide or down the hall. Basically, the system transmits identical images electronically from the sender's machine to the receiver's. That machine may be a fax machine or a computer with software capable of sending a fax directly from your computer to another computer. All one needs is the telephone and fax number of the receiving party.

Noteworthy also is the Western Union Instant Mail Manager for the Macintosh computer. It is usable for message creation, transmission, and receipt. "Fax for Macs" are delivered worldwide. From your Macintosh you can send messages to multiple fax machines as well as telex subscribers simultaneously by using EasyLink's multiple address feature. You receive immediate information that your fax message has been delivered.

Telegrams, Mailgrams, Telexes

Telegrams, mailgrams, and telexes are older forms of electronic communication, but they are still used by companies that are not hooked into computer networks.

Older forms of electronic communication that operate on the same wires and satellites set up for the telephone system are telegrams, mailgrams, and telexes. These communication media are still used by companies not set up with computer systems, although their use is diminishing as computer-driven technology becomes easier and less expensive to access.

You can still send a telegram within the continental United States and Canada or a cablegram overseas by contacting a Western Union toll-free number listed in any telephone directory. Since charges are based on number of words, conciseness is important. Mailgrams are used when you need to reach a number of people simultaneously in writing on the next business day. They may be sent by various means, but the most convenient is to telephone a Western Union toll-free number. In general, telegrams and mailgrams are less expensive than phone calls, especially if the message must be transmitted a long distance.

Telexes are also electronic messages that use telegraph lines for transmission. A telex message is keyboarded on a word processing system and then sent over telegraph lines to compatible receivers. Many companies, hotel chains, airlines, and other groups communicate directly with their own branch offices by telex.

Teleconferencing

It is often less expensive to bring together people located at distant geographical sites by arranging a teleconference rather than have them physically come together. There are three ways you can make this kind of arrangement:

1. **Audio**—Audioconferencing uses telephone lines to set up a group conference. Everyone in the group is able to speak to everyone else.
2. **Video**—Videoconferencing uses closed-circuit television, in which every participant can see, hear, and talk to others. This form of communication is gaining popularity because of improvement in technology and decreasing costs.

3. *Computer*—Computer conferencing uses computer terminals to link participants. People can send and receive messages in real time (while they are actually sitting at their computer terminal) from other members of the group.

SUMMARY

Forms of your message, as contrasted to its substance, are important for two reasons: (1) You want your receiver to get your points without being distracted by the message's format, and (2) you want your message's format to make your points as easy to understand as possible. Even with your message's format, you need to be aware of your receiver's expectations.

This chapter is your guide to formats of business letters, memos, and the various forms of electronic communication media. The appearance of your business messages gives a strong nonverbal impression to your reader. Stationery, parts, format, and envelopes for business letters (external communication) should follow certain guidelines. For memorandums (internal communication) the stationery, parts, layout, and envelopes are different from those of letters.

Format conventions for the new and developing electronic media are continually changing. E-mail tends to take less formal shapes and to be based on quickness of delivery. Faxes are also immediate and, at this writing, easier to use than E-mail. Older forms of electronic media—telegrams, mailgrams, and telexes—are still used by many companies not yet hooked up to the growing computer networks. Teleconferencing is growing in popularity for companies whose interests are increasingly global.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. *International Telecommunications.* Although the technology exists to link the world through electronic networks, there are problems because of the varying ways countries regulate electronic access and the disparate electronic systems. AT&T and MCI are forging ahead with several proposed global alliances. Do library research on what AT&T and MCI have proposed, what problems the proposals could solve, and what problems they could generate. Report to the class on your findings.
2. *Format Variations Abroad.* Various kinds of standard message formats are different from country to country. For example, resumes in Germany look much different from those in the United States. In pairs, find an example of a message format that is different from the conventional format in the United States. Give an oral report outlining the differences.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. *Condensing Word Counts.* Condense the following 25-word telegram to 10 words or less:

PLEASE MEET ME AT THE PLAZA HOTEL AT 1 P.M. ON JUNE 6, 199- TO DISCUSS OUR PLANS FOR THE UPCOMING CONVENTION OF ENVIRONMENTAL NEGOTIATORS

4. **Investigating Teleconferencing.** Find out from a technology expert in your school what it would cost to set up audio- and video-conferencing equipment. What equipment is needed? What are the costs? What would be the advantages and disadvantages? Write a brief proposal in favor of or against your school's investing in these facilities. If your school already has this technology available, write a report on whether it is a wise or an unwise investment.
5. **Discovering New Technology.** Find an article on electronic mail, networking, the Internet, faxes, or other technological media of communication and review it for the class.
6. **Correcting Format Errors.** Discuss the errors in each of the following letter parts. Each example has one or more faults.

In the heading (of stationery that does not have a letterhead):

- a. 6 February 199-
13128 Van Doren st
Petosky, Mich. 48990
- b. Ms. Louise Masters
99 Vernon Ave.
Billings, Mon. 80841
Jan 13, 199-

In the inside address:

- a. Mr. Jonathon Wills,
4317 N.E. (ave.)
Chicago,
Illinois
- b. Doctor William Sorenson
School of Business Administration
University of the Palisades
LOS ANGELES 99460

Salutations and complimentary closes (mixed punctuation):

- a. Dear Miss Lois Trane
Yours truly
- b. Dear George,
Sincerely yours

c. Dear Sir:

With regards

d. Dear Prof. Charles Cowan

Very truly yours,

In the signature and reference section:

a. [open punctuation]

Very Truly Yours,

Michigan Environmental Assn.

R.M.F./M.O.B.

Ms. Sylvia West

INCLOSURE

President

b. [mixed punctuation]

With warm regards

WESTLAND PRODUCTS GROUP

MOB/RO

Cecil Walker

cc: John Jones

Rs. & Dev.

Good-News and Neutral Messages

I. Organizational Plan

II. Favorable Replies

- A. Answering Inquiries
- B. Granting Requests for Adjustment
- C. Approving Credit
- D. Acknowledging Orders
- E. Granting Favors and Other Requests
- F. Job Acceptance Letters
- G. Goodwill Messages

III. Neutral Messages

- A. Announcements
- B. Transmittals

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

VI. Capsule Checklists for Good-News and Neutral Messages

A message that will receive a favorable or neutral reaction from your reader is usually easy to write because such a message tells your reader something pleasant or offers useful information. These messages are generally organized by the direct approach—also known as the good-news plan.

This chapter suggests an effective organizational plan for favorable replies and neutral messages and discusses the following kinds of letters and memoranda you can organize with this plan:

Favorable Replies

- Answering inquiries
- Granting requests for adjustment
- Approving credit
- Acknowledging orders
- Granting favors and other requests
- Job acceptance letters
- Goodwill messages: appreciation, congratulation, and condolence letters

Neutral Messages

- Announcements about:
 - Sales and events
 - Procedures, policies, and responsibilities
 - Honors and activities of people
- Transmittals

ORGANIZATIONAL PLAN

You can use the direct-approach, good-news plan whenever your message is favorable or neutral to your reader. The plan has three parts:

- 1. First:** Best news or main idea
- 2. Middle:** Explanation, with one or more of the following, when appropriate: all necessary details, educational information, resale, sales promotion
- 3. Last:** Positive, friendly ending, with a clear statement of action desired, motivation to action, willingness to help further, appreciation

You can use the good-news plan if your message is mainly good news or favorable information but also has unpleasant facts. Because the items in the following explanation form the basic core of your message, use your own judgment in deciding which items to include:

- 1. *All necessary details.*** Include all facts, terms, reasons, and other explanations that pertain to the best news or the main idea. Consider, for instance, whether the reader needs specific details on the why, what, when, who, where, and how of the news or main idea.

2. *Educational information.* Include instructions for use and other educational facts about a product or service the customer has bought. Decide how much information is necessary to help the customer get the most benefit from your product or from the relationship with your firm. If you enclose an instruction booklet, a short paragraph in the letter may call attention to certain pages in that booklet.
3. *Resale material.* Include appropriate favorable information about a product or service the reader has already bought or is planning to buy or about your organization. This kind of information emphasizes reader benefits.
4. *Sales promotion.* Include suggestions about other products or services related to those the customer has bought or is considering buying. Including this kind of information will let you be of further service to the customer and provide reader benefits.

FAVORABLE REPLIES

Most persons like good news first in a communication; favorable replies allow you to begin in such a positive manner.

To help build goodwill, a progressive organization replies to all reasonable requests courteously, helpfully, and promptly. If you know there will be a delay, a brief acknowledgment should state the reason and then tell the inquirer approximately when to expect a complete answer. In such a message, you begin with the best news first—information that is useful to the reader or shows you are doing something.

In every good-news reply, your compliance with the reader's request is more important than an expression of gratitude, pleasure, or apology for not being able to deal with the request immediately. Depending on circumstances, you can begin by saying that you have done what the customer asked (the preferred beginning), that you are in the process of doing it, or that you will do it. The material you select for the explanation and ending varies with the circumstances.

The discussion in this section includes guidelines for and examples of favorable replies to requests for information about individuals and products and to requests for adjustment, credit, orders, and favors. It also gives suggestions for writing job acceptance letters and letters of congratulations, appreciation, and condolence.

Answering Inquiries

It is advisable, if possible, to write a recommendation to a specific person.

Among the most frequent non-sales-related inquiries are requests for information about personnel and credit applicants. The following section focuses on letters of recommendation about personnel for jobs and replies to inquiries about applicants who are considered for reasons other than jobs.

When you furnish information about an applicant's qualifications, character, and general conduct, the message should preferably be addressed to the specific person interested rather than "To whom it may concern."

You have a fourfold responsibility when you write recommendations. You must be fair to (1) *the applicants*, so they can get what they are best qualified for; (2) *the inquirers* (prospective employer, creditor, landlord, or whomever),

■ Communication Probe

Although the direct approach for good-news and neutral messages is a major guideline for American and British writing, other countries favor a more indirect, or inductive, approach to messages. In a study of expository writing in Japanese, Korean, Chinese, and Thai, John Hinds discovered that a “quasi-inductive” organization was favored. This kind of approach incorporated not only a buffer at the beginning but also a less linear progression of points, allowing the reader to contemplate the issues and draw his or her own conclusions.

In a separate study of Finnish, British, and American requests, Hilkka Yli Jokipii found that even the British and American conventions differed in that the British prefer implicit, less direct strategies, whereas the Americans aim for explicitness and directness.

Hinds, J. (1990). Inductive, deductive, quasi-inductive expository writing in Japanese, Korean, Chinese, and Thai. In U. Conner & A. Johns (eds.), *Coherence in writing: Research and pedagogical perspectives* (pp. 79–100). Alexandria, VA: Teachers of English to Speakers of Other Languages; Jokipii, H. (1994). *Requests in professional discourse: A cross-cultural study of British, American and Finnish business writing*. Helsinki, Finland: Suomalainen Tiedekatemia.

because they are depending on your frank comments; (3) *your own conscience and reputation*, for integrity; and (4) *the civil rights laws and legal statutes* that cover hiring practices. Discussed now are the expanded good-news outline, recommendations on outstanding candidates, and appraisals on candidates with shortcomings.

Expanded Good-News Plan for Recommendations

The following suggestions are a basis for confidential recommendation letters (or phone conversations) when facts are mainly favorable or neutral:

1. Main idea
 - a. State the applicant's full name and what his or her relationship is to you—employee, customer, friend, tenant, club member. Mention dates, length of time, and type of job, credit, tenancy, or whatever is pertinent.
 - b. Include an expression of pleasure, if sincere, in your statement of purpose for the letter, *replying confidentially to a request*. A subject line can cover part of item b with such words as “Confidential report by request on Gail E. Smith as a prospective field representative.”
2. Explanation
 - a. Answer all questions, direct or implied, unless doing so would be legally risky.

- b. Support your statements of evaluation (excellent, outstanding, etc.) with specific facts about performance record. For a job applicant: (1) Tell specific job duties that applicant performed. (2) Discuss those duties relevant to the position for which the applicant is a candidate, if known. (3) Mention, when desirable, work habits that show personality characteristics.
 - c. If there is negative material, consider the suggestions in the section "Recommendations for Candidates with Shortcomings" below.
3. Ending
- a. Include, if possible, a candid statement of your personal opinion about the applicant's probable fitness for the position or for the lease, credit, or membership in a club.
 - b. Be sure to correlate your opinion with documented facts.

Recommendations for Outstanding Candidates

When everything you want to say is favorable, the requested recommendation can be stated easily and in a straightforward manner, as in the example below:

LETTER 1 *An international marketing director's sincere solicited recommendation to the Executive Committee of his firm about a member of his staff seeking a promotion.*

**Pleasure;
purpose; name;
job length**

I am happy to answer your inquiry about Jonathon Court. Because Jon has worked for me nearly two years as a member of my staff, I know him well.

**Answer to
questions**

During this time, Jon has been the most effective member of my liaison staff. His monthly reports show a keen grasp of the competitive problems we face in each of our international divisions. He has workable, creative ideas for improving our sales, and he works well with people.

**Duties
performed**

Jon has been involved in the last five advertising campaigns in southern Europe, including Spain and Portugal. His language skills are a plus. He has made it his business to learn several of the languages of the countries in which we work, and thus, knows Spanish and Portuguese. This knowledge will be an asset to him as the Director of Market-

ing in Lisbon. He is acutely aware of the problems of cross-cultural communication and is a sensitive host when nationals from other countries visit our home office.

Personality and character

As to conduct, personal habits, and ability to handle himself, this man has no faults, to my knowledge. He will make a real contribution to our international marketing efforts, and I give him my highest recommendation.

Although a few of these statements seem overstated (and could be revised), this person has written a sincere recommendation supported by specific details.

Recommendations for Candidates with Shortcomings

When you are writing a recommendation for someone with shortcomings, you must decide whether to include or omit the negative material. You may be able to give a recommendation without stating the shortcoming. In any case, mention a weakness only if it meets these conditions:

1. It is relevant to the job (or credit, etc.) for which the candidate has applied.
2. It is *sufficiently serious* to affect the applicant's probable fitness for that responsibility.
3. It is a fact, not hearsay or your own personal prejudice, jealousy, malice, or discrimination and *is supported by the record*.
4. It occurred often enough (and recently enough) to be worth mentioning.
5. It answers a specific question asked or implied, and you mention it in a spirit of goodwill based on the preceding four items.
6. It is possible to state it *discreetly and within legal limits*.

Relevant information, tactfully stated, is advisable in recommendations.

Recommendations are incomplete and misleading as personnel reports if they omit truthful and relevant information. Nevertheless, many employers are reluctant to make any negative statement in writing or orally for fear of a costly lawsuit. Others, however, feel they have a moral duty to state what they honestly believe to be true to the questions asked about a former employee. Basically, you should have no fear of stating the relevant facts prudently.

If you are writing a letter of recommendation for a candidate who, apart from one serious shortcoming, is satisfactory, organize your letter so you establish the applicant's more favorable characteristic before you mention the weakness. In letter 2, for example, the negative fact is embedded; the message ends with candid, positive statements. In the subject line, this writer chose the word

“appraisal” instead of “recommendation.” (Four lawyers and an assistant attorney general have declared this letter legally appropriate.)

LETTER 2 *A department manager comments on a former employee who had a serious alcohol problem.*

**Full name and
brief summary**

Confidential Appraisal by Request on
Kevin Haynes

Mr. Haynes worked hard for us as a salesperson in the electrical appliances section for about a year. He was such a dependable salesperson that when the section manager resigned to go to the East, we placed Kevin in charge and found him well-qualified for the job. He was with us 22 months-until June this year.

As section manager, Kevin had much responsibility. Besides ordering all merchandise for the section, he was also in charge of the five salespeople working under him. He was well-liked by subordinates and customers. He had a knack of being tactful and thoughtful with every customer. Because of his personality and his knowledge of the stock, he pleased a good many steady patrons and helped increase total sales within his section.

**Favorable comment before
and after negative**

Kevin's work at the store was entirely commendable for about 16 months. Then he developed what he described as an alcohol problem, which noticeably affected his disposition and his attendance. When I talked with him about the change and I suggested a treatment program, he mentioned serious worries. He tried to lick the problem alone and did so for three weeks. But after he had missed at least a day's work every week for six months, I regretfully had to let him go.

Kevin's other personal habits are good. His personality, honesty, and physical appearance are an asset to any company. He takes an active part in outdoor sports and is in fine health, except for the problem I mentioned. He will quite probably successfully recover from his problem during a helpful professional program.

**Favorable,
job-related
appraisal**

Kevin is intelligent and well-educated (a marketing graduate of Broadway College). Because he knows the electrical appliance business well and has so many other fine qualities, he can be a top-notch depart-

ment or section manager, especially in the electrical field.

Besides recommendations for job applicants, you may sometimes be asked to recommend people for other reasons. Whether the inquirer is considering a person as a tenant on leased property, for membership in an organization, for credit, or an award, you can adapt the expanded good-news plan for recommendations to help you write favorable recommendations.

Granting Requests for Adjustment

Err on the side of the customer; give him or her the benefit of the doubt.

An *adjustment letter* is the reply to a complaint (called a *claim letter*). In general, the best attitude is to give the customer the benefit of the doubt. Most persons are honest in their claims, and it is usually better to make the desired adjustment than to risk losing a customer.

Even though your firm's adjustment policy may be generous, the ultimate success of your good-news adjustment letters depends not only on *what* you say but also on *how* you say it. Always choose neutral or positive language in referring to a complaint, such as "your experience" or "your letter." One additional caution must be mentioned. When you receive letters from foreign customers, remember that their own cultural conventions may affect the tone of their letters. Some may seem demanding, insist upon immediate satisfaction, and threaten to take their business elsewhere. For example, as Asia—especially China—and Eastern Europe become more capitalistic, they are in a position to be more demanding. Know the cultural background of the country from which the writer is requesting an adjustment. Review some of the cultural principles noted in Chapter 3.

The discussion in this section concerns (1) tone of adjustment messages, (2) organization and content when the seller is at fault, (3) when the buyer or a third party is at fault, and (4) when fault has not yet been determined.

■ Communication Probe

Research suggests that readers remember most what comes first or last in a message and tend to forget what falls in the middle. Therefore, the strongest arguments, ideas, or new and important information can be most effective if they are at the beginning or the end. Less important points or discussions of objections can be placed in the middle. A writer should not be limited to one organizational pattern, however. The most important consideration is the audience and what that audience knows about the subject and what his or her reactions to the subject might be. There are no rules for effectiveness, only possibilities. You might move from most important to least in a routine message or from least important to most in order to create power and drama.

Selzer, J. (1989). Arranging business prose. In Myra Kogan (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 37–54). Urbana IL: National Council of Teachers of English.

A considerate and courteous tone is important because the customer may have been irritated or inconvenienced by the situation.

Tone in Adjustment-Granting Messages

Consideration and courtesy are exceptionally important when you grant an adjustment. Because your reader has been inconvenienced, irritated, and perhaps angered, he or she is especially sensitive to the tone of your message. Even when a letter grants a request, its tone can either maintain or destroy goodwill. Consider the following example, in which the antagonistic expressions are underlined:

Poor: Nevertheless, so that we can keep you as a satisfied customer, we are willing to allow you to exchange these toys. [*The motive sounds selfish; “willing” and “allow you” sound condescending and grudging; sentence lacks you-attitude.*]

Better: Because we want you to be completely pleased, we will gladly exchange the toys for you.

When you are definitely at fault, saying “I’m sorry,” “We apologize,” or “Please forgive us” is quite disarming. You are more likely to lose face by *not* apologizing than by doing so. One apology, preferably in the explanation section, is enough for most situations.

Organization and Content When Seller Is at Fault

The discussion in this section helps you plan carefully when granting an adjustment if your company is at fault.

Try to create rapport with your reader in the first paragraph.

Opening Paragraph. Begin with whatever you think the reader will consider the best news. If the customer has asked for something specific, such as a refund, exchange, credit memo, or speedier service, grant or promise immediately. However, if the specific problem makes granting something inadvisable, try to create rapport with your reader in another appropriate way. For example, if a customer has found a bug in a jar of prunes and vows never to buy your products again, you cannot very well begin by saying you are sending another jar of prunes to replace the faulty one! Instead, you might express regret for the occurrence and appreciation for the customer’s thoughtfulness in writing. In the following examples, the first two grant a request immediately, and the last two open with various statements to create rapport with the reader.

Customer’s Request or Complaint

1. That you “eliminate the delays” in your merchandise shipments or risk losing business.

Suggested Opening

You will be glad to hear that we have found a new way to speed deliveries of fresh vegetables to you. From now on, your produce can reach you within two hours

2. That you replace immediately five defective copies of a book needed by May 15.
3. That you refund to a friend the \$30.50 purchase price because of your firm's error. (Your customer bought a birthday gift for a friend. Instead of charging it to your customer's account, your store incorrectly sent the "gift" to the friend c.o.d.)
4. That two special toys ordered 4 weeks ago did not arrive in time for Christmas.

after we receive your order.

Today five copies of [book title] were sent to you by air express, shipping charges prepaid. You should receive them three days before May 15.

(To the customer's friend.) You have had the unusual experience of paying for your own birthday gift that your friend James L. Tomson had purchased for you from our store. The mix-up is due entirely to our error, for which we extend to you our sincere apologies.

(Note: In this case, the refund check is mentioned only after the explanation.)

Please give us the opportunity to restore the Christmas spirit for your children. We want to do the best we can to make them happy with new toys.

You should generally include an explanation of the problem or mistake.

Explaining What Caused the Mistake. When your firm is at fault, admit it frankly. Do not say that "mistakes are bound to happen" or that because of the size of your firm, there will naturally be frequent errors, and do not promise the error will never happen again. Generally, it is desirable to include some kind of explanation. The following examples—from two adjustment grants—help the reader understand how the error occurred:

1. You guessed correctly. Apparently all the order and shipping papers, including the ones that should have been kept for our use, were sent to you. As a result, we have no record of the ordered paint. We are certainly sorry that you were inconvenienced by our slip-up. We always

try to be careful in processing every customer request accurately and promptly.

2. Our research suggests you are entirely right: the air carrier here in Michigan put an incorrect bar code on our shipment to your office in Helsinki. We know the parts arrived late. We have spoken with the air carrier; they assure us that in our next international shipments they will doubly verify the correct address and bar-code number.

Resale. If the person complaining seems to be losing faith in your firm, resale is desirable. If possible, include concrete evidence of your efficient service, safe and correct shipments, or care in providing or selecting high-quality products. If certain steps have been or will be taken to prevent recurrence of the problem, mention them. Sometimes you can honestly state that a new procedure is developed “on the basis of helpful comments like yours.”

Sales promotion is usually desirable in situations involving often-replaced items.

Sales Promotion Material. If a retailer sells only one type of costly product (such as furnaces, home insulation, or roofing), which the average consumer buys only once in a great while, sales promotion material is not necessary. However, if the seller carries a variety of often-replaced items, sales promotion may be desirable. In this case, you want to encourage the customer to continue to buy other goods from you by enclosing coupons or information regarding your products.

Ending Paragraph. For a pleasant close, you may (1) tie suggested action in with sales promotional material, (2) comment on the pleasure the reader will gain from the high-quality new article you have sent, (3) express appreciation that the reader took the time to write, or (4) issue a cordial invitation that the customer continue to come to your firm for top service. Omit negative information, such as an apology (you may have already apologized in your opening) or a reminder of the inconvenience the mistake causes. Do not suggest future trouble or imply that the customer may stop buying from your firm.

Organization and Content When the Buyer or a Third Party Is at Fault

Sometimes it is advisable to grant an adjustment when the buyer or a third party is at fault.

When someone other than the seller is at fault, you may be justified in refusing instead of granting the request. Nevertheless, firms will occasionally grant a buyer's claim even though the buyer or a third party is at fault.

Buyer at Fault. If you decide to grant the adjustment claim although the buyer is at fault, you have two choices for letter organization: (1) Using the direct approach, you begin by granting the request and follow by a tactful explanation that helps the customer understand that mistreatment of the product caused the problem. Your goal is to maintain goodwill so that the customer will continue to make purchases from your firm. (2) If you decide on the indirect ap-

proach, you begin with a neutral statement that creates rapport, such as your appreciation of the customer's promptness in reporting the problem, and follow with a tactful explanation of the mistake. Finally, you grant the claim. The reason for this alternative is that sometimes the psychological effect on the reader is better if you allow the claim *after* you have shown that the buyer, not your firm, is at fault.

Third Party at Fault. Sometimes merchandise is damaged or lost while it is in the warehouse or truck of a third party—distributor, broker, shipper, or someone else. In this case, the third party has the legal responsibility to adjust the claim, and many sellers prefer not to get involved. In shipping materials to foreign customers, the situation is a bit more complex. There are innumerable causes for delay, from the international carrier to customs officials.

However, some wholesalers that sell to small retailers assist them in the claim-filing procedures, or they file the claim directly on behalf of the dealer. In these situations, the direct approach, as described in the section on when the seller is at fault, is usually preferred. You can create not only goodwill but future business if you appear to be helpful to customers and dealers alike.

Organization and Content When the Fault Is Not Yet Determined

When fault is not yet determined, the optimal organization pattern may change.

Sometimes the final adjustment decision cannot be made until the seller determines who is responsible for the mistake. In such cases, letting the buyer know promptly that you are investigating the claim is reassuring, even though you have not yet granted the claim. The best organization is (1) express interest in the problem, (2) assure the customer you are looking into the matter, (3) include brief resale material, if desirable, and (4) courteously state that you will give your reader the facts as soon as they are available.

Approving Credit

When approving credit, follow the good-news plan and include necessary information, resale, sales promotion, and appreciation.

The message telling the customer that you are granting credit often includes all parts of the basic good-news plan—best news first and then terms, resale, sales promotion, and appreciation. Many firms have preset form letters acknowledging credit approval and containing all needed information.

Decision or Shipment in First Paragraph

If the customer has not yet ordered any merchandise on credit, begin with the credit-granting decision and a cordial welcome. If an order was sent with the request for credit, begin with the date and method by which the goods are being shipped (thereby implying credit approval). Make clear the purchase details (name and quantity of goods sent, item prices, freight, and total charge); for more than two or three items, attach an invoice copy. Mention that the shipment has been added to the customer's new account.

Explanation of Credit Terms

In your explanation section, mention briefly the basis on which credit was earned, and clarify the terms. A clear explanation of the credit terms helps re-

duce collection problems later. You must be sure that every new credit customer knows whether your terms are based on invoice date, delivery date, or the end of the month. Consider the following examples:

Vague: Our credit terms are the usual 2/10, net 30.

Better: Under our credit terms of 2/10, net 30, you earn a 2 percent discount if your payment is made in 10 days. [10 days after what?]

Best: Under our credit terms of 2/10, net 30, you earn a 2 percent discount if your payment is made in 10 days, based on invoice date.

A clear explanation of credit terms is important to avoid problems later.

If you place the explanation of the credit terms before the resale and sales promotion, you are more certain the reader will notice them. If you place the terms after the resale and sales promotion, you are emphasizing benefits to the reader of the new credit account. Using the word “grant” reflects a we-attitude, while stating that the customer has “earned” credit communicates a you-attitude.

Be tactful in telling the customer when payments are due. Compare, for example, the poor tone in “we expect you to pay” or “you are expected to pay” with the improved tone in “payments are due within 10 days after the billing date.” In this sentence, the indirect approach is desirable.

Resales and Sales Promotion

International promotions demand an understanding of the culture of the country to which you send the sales promotion.

The credit-granting message should include resale information about the firm’s services, which are customer benefits. Also, it is sometimes desirable to include sales promotion material in the next to last paragraph about such news as forthcoming sales, new seasonal merchandise, or products related to those ordered. Such news encourages the customer to use credit. To keep your letter short, you can enclose a leaflet describing departments and services such as the following:

For the consumer: Free parking, mail and telephone shopping, personalized services for men, home-planning bureau, bridal registry, tearoom, restaurants, child care, gift wrapping, free and frequent deliveries, special discounts or purchase privileges.

For the reader or wholesaler: Nearby warehouses, factory representatives, quantity discounts, free window or counter displays, national advertising, cuts and mats for newspaper and other advertising, repair services, manuals, factory guarantee, prompt and speedy deliveries, research department.

For the international client: Regular quarterly visits by sales personnel, regional distribution office within two hours flight time, two-day courier service from the United States, joint venture agreements with neighboring countries, advisory staff to U.S. home office regarding styles of merchandise, in-place legal firm for legal questions.

Future Service Closing

Close your credit approval letter with statements indicating your desire to serve the customer well in the future or with listings of special services. Inviting readers to a special sale, for example, helps encourage them to use their accounts.

LETTER 3 *A retailer's form letter granting credit to a consumer; applicant's name is in the inside address and salutation.*

Best news, welcome

Welcome to Madson's as our special Regards credit account customer. Your new charge card is enclosed, and we invite you to use it often. This card will identify you at all Madson's stores, so please sign it in ink before putting it into your wallet or purse.

Credit terms

You will receive your statement, soon after the first of each month, showing purchases up to the 23d of the preceding month. Bills on this monthly account are payable by the 10th of each month. (Unpaid bills are subject to a 1½ percent finance charge monthly.)

Resale on store services

As one of our special Regards customers, you will receive announcements of all our sales before they are advertised to the public. You will receive special discounts several times a year as well as coupons for free merchandise. When you wish to shop at home, you can do so conveniently by telephone. Just ask for "personal shopping services," tell your needs to the shopping assistant, and charge your purchases to your account.

Invitation to future use

The enclosed brochure explains the numerous Madson services available for your convenience. Do use them often to save yourself both time and money. We look forward to giving you friendly, courteous service in all our stores for many years to come.

Acknowledging Orders

Acknowledging orders builds goodwill; the acknowledgment must be definite and complete.

An order acknowledgment performs several important functions. It lets the buyer know that the order has been received, is appreciated, and is given attention. It helps build goodwill. Furthermore—and very important—by identifying and accepting the order, the acknowledgment completes a valid contract between buyer and seller. For these reasons, the acknowledgment must be definite and complete.

Orders your firm can fill immediately fall into two categories: first orders and repeat orders. Although acknowledgment for both types should identify the shipment and show appreciation, the message content will be quite different.

Acknowledgment of First Order

The new customer needs to know that the order is being filled promptly and correctly, that it is appreciated, and that because of your products and services, dealings with your firm will be pleasant and profitable.

Include complete information in sending orders; remember the five W's.

Sending the Ordered Items. Usually the best beginning for your first-order acknowledgment is to state what, when, and how you shipped. If possible, state approximately when the shipment should reach its destination. Express appreciation for both the order and the remittance (if you received the latter). If you can fill most of an order promptly and the rest soon thereafter, it is best to begin with what you can ship now or what is already on its way to the customer. Later in the letter explain why and when the remainder of the order will be sent separately. Finally, take care of any needed details about shipping charges and payments.

Resale material on services is appropriate to consumer and retailer; resale material on products is more relevant for the consumer because the retailer is usually familiar with the products.

Specific Resale Material. For the first-order acknowledgment, resale on company *services* is appropriate to both the consumer and the retailer. Resale on *products* ordered is usually more relevant for the consumer than for the retailer because the latter, through sales literature, catalogs, and your sales representative, is usually familiar with your products.

To a consumer, resale material from the manufacturer is sometimes extremely helpful. After placing a large first order with a firm, the consumer may regret having signed the contract, especially when the item purchased is a luxury. The order acknowledgment from headquarters with detailed reader benefits about the product and warranty helps reinforce the buyer's confidence in the purchase.

Include order blanks or information to make the desired action easy.

Looking Forward to Future Orders and Reader Satisfaction. To end the first-order acknowledgment, you can tie suggested action in with resale or sales promotion; enclose order blanks or whatever else is needed for easy action. If you wish, invite the cash customer to fill out and return a credit application form. Avoid suggesting that credit is automatic.

Acknowledgment of Repeat Orders

Provide complete information about terms and delivery date; include expression of appreciation.

Most orders come from repeat customers who know and like a firm's products and services and who do not expect a letter of acknowledgment. Usually the goods can be sent as quickly as an acknowledgment can be mailed. In some cases, standard purchase order forms give complete instructions about terms and delivery date, and they stipulate that the buyer will be notified only if the order cannot be filled as requested. In others, an adequate good-news order acknowledgment is an inexpensive form, a carbon copy of the shipping invoice, or a postcard.

Although most repeat orders are filled with letter acknowledgments, an unusually large order may occasionally warrant a personalized letter. This letter may include appreciation, a statement of how the order is being handled, and perhaps, a few cordial comments about your past relationship and future plans to supply the customer's needs.

Granting Favors and Other Requests

Use the good-news plan: Good news first, relevant comments or explanation next, and a cordial ending.

Whenever you decide to grant a favor, you have a comparatively simple task. Whether the favor is serving on a committee, speaking at a convention, donating money, or lending your firm's equipment without charge, the good-news plan is best to use. Usually all you need is the acceptance first, relevant comments or explanation next, and a cordial ending.

Job Acceptance Letters

Three parts: Accept position and express appreciation; confirm details and ask questions; provide a pleasant closing.

One writing task that will give you pleasure is a letter accepting a job offer. A job acceptance letter is generally short and expresses your enthusiasm for the position offered. It also serves as confirmation of the details of the position, such as your salary and starting date. There are three parts to a job acceptance letter: You accept the position and express your thanks for the offer; you confirm the details and ask any questions that have not been answered; you provide a pleasant closing that expresses your enthusiasm for the opportunity.

LETTER 4 *A job acceptance letter from an M.B.A. student for a summer internship position.*

Good news first

With pleasure I accept your offer to join the Chicago office of McKinsey & Co. as a summer associate. Your hospitality and the time you spent with me have made me eager to begin and excited at the prospect of challenging assignments.

Details of position

According to our telephone conversation, the details of the position include a salary of \$10,000 for the period covering May 15 to September 1, with lodging provided by McKinsey & Co. for May 14 through May 18. If there is anything further I need to know before May 15, you can reach me at (313) 555-9876.

Pleasant close

Thank you for your offer. I look forward to joining McKinsey & Co. this summer and the opportunity to make a contribution to the firm.

Goodwill Messages

Nothing wrong with expressing feelings in a goodwill message.

Goodwill messages are different from the usual business documents in that they express feelings rather than information or persuasion, and therefore can be

more difficult to write. Although it may be tempting to send printed cards, it is always more personal and meaningful to the recipients to send a written note of appreciation, congratulations, or sympathy. Goodwill messages are usually short; they should have a sincere tone and should be focused on the reader.

Letters of Appreciation

Thank you notes should be written whenever someone does you a favor or when an action deserves praise. The notes may be written to customers for their orders, to colleagues for their support, and to individuals for any special favors they have done for you or for your company. The two factors to remember in these kinds of letters are (1) the good-news plan is appropriate and (2) reader focus is essential. By beginning with your good news, you immediately focus on your reader. You should continue this reader focus throughout your letter by such strategies as using the reader's name, choosing positive language, and employing a conversational tone.

Letters of Congratulation

Congratulatory notes should be sent for business and personal achievements and milestones. As in letters of appreciation, they should use the good-news organizational plan and focus on the reader. The following short letter is an example.

LETTER 5 *A congratulatory note on a political appointment.*

Good news first Congratulations, Jennifer, on your recent appointment as assistant chief of staff in the Governor's office! You will bring a great deal of ability, enthusiasm, and sincerity to this position; I was happy to learn of your appointment. Best wishes for your continuing success.

Letters of Condolence

Expressions of sympathy to someone who has experienced grief or misfortune are difficult to write and demand special sensitivity on the part of the writer. The direct approach (in this case, not called the good-news plan) is generally best, and the tone should be subdued and sincere. You should begin with a sensitive reference to the death or other misfortune, and you can include praise for the deceased or reassurance for the person involved. You may offer assistance when appropriate. Although some people type their sympathy notes, most are handwritten on notepaper or personal stationery and most are brief.

LETTER 6 *A sympathy note on the death of a colleague.*

Direct plan Ruth and I were saddened by the unhappy news of Ralph's death. His contributions to our company, to his work with our youth group, and to our community were consis-

tently done with his usual skill. His many friends here will miss his personality and his innumerable contributions.

During these sad days, we offer you our understanding and support. You have our deepest sympathy.

NEUTRAL MESSAGES

The previous section considered messages that are written because someone inquired. This section discusses *unsolicited* messages—specifically, announcements and transmittals.

Announcements

The good-news plan works for most kinds of announcements.

Announcements of good or neutral information should follow the good-news plan. The main idea should come first, followed by an adequate explanation and an ending that is pleasant and positive. Some messages combine an announcement with an invitation, but whether you label them announcements or invitations, you use the same three-part organizational structure.

Included in this section are group and personal announcements about sales and events; procedures, policies, and responsibilities; and honors and activities of people.

Announcing Sales and Events

Whenever you wish to announce a sale or an event (luncheon, conference, celebration, meeting, or other function) about which you need merely to inform your readers, you can use the good-news plan. The opening paragraph should include as many of the five W's as possible—who, what, where, when, why.

An excellent way to build and strengthen goodwill with regular customers is to let them know you appreciate them. For example, Message 1 announces a sale before newspaper publication.

■ Communication Probe

Routine or common documents tend to follow conventional formats, and these formats are useful in that they are generally efficient in providing the necessary information, and they save time. However, writers should not be completely constrained by the usual forms for messages. Some of the most effective messages break the “rules” in the way they are organized. The effective business writer needs to be aware of the conventions of writing and then decide which to observe and which to ignore.

Driskill, L. (1989). Understanding the writing context in organizations. In Myra Kogan (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 125–145). Urbana, IL: National Council of Teachers of English.

MESSAGE 1 Letter: A store's preannouncement to charge customers about a forthcoming sale (processed form without an inside address; salutation is "Dear Customer;" complimentary close is "Sincerely," signature is name of the manager).

Reason: Best news; five W's

Because you are a regular [store name] charge customer, you are invited to a special sale of unusual spring dress values. It is one of Designer Room's greatest dress events. This announcement comes to you now so that you can make your selection during a three-day period before newspaper ads appear.

Displayed for emphasis

PREANNOUNCEMENT SELLING
Wednesday, Thursday, and Friday
February 6, 7, and 8
NEW SPRING DRESSES BY OUR
FOREMOST MAKERS
All priced far below regular

THESE FINE DRESSES such as you will see at much higher prices after this great sale. Every one is a new, just-arrived 199- fashion!

Details

ATTRACTIVE COLORS include whites, pastels, neutrals, and bright shades. You will also find a wide selection of styles-casual and dressy-in various lengths; one-piece and two-piece dresses.

Easy action and motivation

TAKE ADVANTAGE OF THIS OPPORTUNITY FOR FIRST CHOICE AND SUPER SAVINGS! Come in early-February 6, 7, 8-to choose your dress. Prices will return to regular immediately after this outstanding dress event.

Announcing Procedures, Policies, and Responsibilities

Clarity and tone are important factors in messages announcing policies and directives.

Some businesses use "directives" to announce to employees official statements of company policy, procedures, and employee responsibilities. These "directives" are often compiled in loose-leaf policy manuals that can be updated as the need arises. They may cover a wide variety of topics, ranging from assigned parking spaces and office hours to policies about salary increases, retirement benefits, overtime, and treatment of customers.

Two cautions to remember when you write directives are to (1) make your statements absolutely clear to all levels of your employees and (2) avoid an arrogant or threatening tone.

Announcements on policies to foreign customers are often included in booklets. These are either sent to the customer directly or to the legal firm handling policy issues. It is not unusual to present announcements in two languages: English and the language of the foreign customer. Even the military—with its

Some announcements must be written in more than one language: English and the language of the foreign customer.

many foreign locations—has a standard operating procedure (SOP), which is kept up to date,

Some messages about procedures, policies, and responsibilities are not directives. They can be processed announcement letters to customers and others or memos, like Message 2, to employees.

MESSAGE 2 *Memo: Announcement to all employees about enrollment for company insurance plans.*

TO: All Kenmore employees
FROM: Jane L. Wood, Retirement and Insurance Officer
SUBJECT: Open Enrollment Period for Company Insurance Plans
DATE: Sept. 22, 199-

Why, when, for whom, where, what

The annual enrollment period for employee insurance plans will take place between October 4 and 27 at the retirement and insurance office.
During that time, you may

- 1. Enroll in medical, life, salary-continuation, or accident insurance plans for the first time
- 2. Transfer from one basic medical plan to another
- 3. Add previously uninsured dependents to medical insurance plans

Date

Changes and additions made during the open enrollment period will take effect November 1, 199-.

Enclosure instructions

Please refer to the attached individual Insurance Program Summary, which shows the premiums, company contributions, and payroll deductions for plans in which you are currently enrolled. Then read the rest of the attached material, which explains just what to do if you wish to make changes in your coverage.

Offer of more help

Brochures describing the plans and individual counseling services are available at the retirement and insurance office, 4th floor; or phone extension 987 if you wish one mailed to you.

Honors people receive are almost always presented using the good-news organization plan, although the indirect plan can be used when you want to create drama in the announcement.

Announcing Honors and Activities of People

To inform employees and customers about promotions, awards, honors, new appointments, retirements, and other recognition-deserving activities of various persons, it is thoughtful to send announcements.

■ Communication Probe

Several researchers have studied the various forms of corporate communication documents for employees. Haar and Kossack, citing Curtis's 1987 study of Canadian annual reports, state that the sample of 65 reports studied were not understood by 92 percent of the general adult population and 56 percent of the investor population. When the communication messages are internal, dealing with such issues as procedures, policies, benefits, and directives, the possibility of adverse consequences are great, in some cases, preventing employees from taking advantage of information that could help them.

Haar, J., & Kossack, S. (1990, Spring). Employee benefit packages: How understandable are they? *Journal of Business Communication*, 27(2), 185–200.

The first paragraph, which states the good news, often begins with words such as “We are pleased to announce that . . .” or “With great pleasure we inform you. . . .” The second paragraph gives details about the new officer, award, or whatever pertains to the announced honor or activity. Suggested action may be that all join in congratulating the person or wishing the person success and happiness.

Transmittals

A transmittal is a letter or memo that simply sends a document to a reader.

As the name implies, the main purpose of a transmittal is to transmit something, which is usually mentioned in the first paragraph. Transmittals, also called “covering letters,” have many uses. They range from short 5- to 10-line notes to lengthy official letters that accompany, explain, or justify documents. In general, they follow the good-news plan.

For routine business to consumers, employees, or other persons, a cordial, short note is sufficient to transmit one or more items such as a check, policy, passbook, warranty deed, or map. Often processed fill-in forms are used, with various listed items and spaces for checking those that are enclosed. Transmittals that accompany official documents, bids, applications, proposals, or formal reports should be carefully worded letters.

SUMMARY

The good-news plan is effective whenever you answer a request favorably, whether you are giving information, granting adjustments, approving credit, accepting a job, or are involved in any of the other many situations in which you can respond in a way that will please the reader. You may also use the good-news plan for neutral messages, such as announcements about sales and events, procedures and policies, and personal honors and activities. For unsolicited messages, use the good-news plan whenever your message is straightforward and your reader will have a favorable or neutral response. The Capsule Checklists on pages 205–207 briefly summarize the basic plans and various adaptations.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. **Solicited Recommendation for Carla Smith.** You are the purchasing manager for Auto-Tech, Mexico, a subsidiary of Auto-Tech International. You have just received a request from the personnel manager of a large manufacturing company located in Mexico City for a recommendation for Carla Rios, who worked in your department for 1 year until leaving because her husband was transferred to Mexico City. Although Carla had many strengths, you were relieved when she left. Carla was sent to work for you by the Mexican president of the company, who was her uncle. She was intelligent and hard-working, and although she did not do a superior job in her responsibilities, she was fairly competent. The problem was that she was overly assertive and caused dissension in the department by her arrogant and domineering manner. She was not a team player, and even though she did not have the authority to do so, she tried to direct the department according to her own agenda. As purchasing manager, you had many problems trying to deal with her tactfully, and the two of you had many conflicts during the year she was with you. Write a letter of recommendation for Carla, choosing the facts you consider to be important. Because your company is a U.S. company, be sure to consider the legal implications involved.
2. **Product Information.** Luis St. Jean (LSJ) is a famous leather goods house in France with annual sales of \$1 billion in clothing, luggage, and other leather products. As marketing manager for Luis St. Jean, you have received a written request for information regarding your merchandise from the head buyer of Voortman's, an upscale leather goods store located in the Renaissance Center in Detroit. Information requested included types of luggage offered, prices, minimum ordering quantities, and marketing assistance, if any, offered by LSJ. Write a response to the request that includes the necessary information and provides a good promotion of your products.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Good-News Adjustment Letter.** Evaluate the following adjustment letter from a manufacturer to retailer. What do you like and dislike about it? Suggest specific improvements in the tone, organization, accuracy, and adequacy of explanation and resale.

Thank you for telling us of the problem you have had with the suits you purchased.

Some time ago, a batch of material having bad formulation escaped detection by our quality control people. The line inspectors caught most of the finished suits before they were invoiced. However, some were shipped. Apparently your order was among them.

The situation has since been corrected, and we don't believe you will have this problem with a replacement. Accordingly, a special shipping label is enclosed for returning your defective merchandise to us. It will be promptly exchanged upon receipt. Please let us know if we may be of further service.

4. **Evaluate the Following Congratulatory Letter.** What is effective about the letter? What could be improved? Consider tone, organization, and reader versus writer attitude.

Dear George:

On behalf of Tom Pasto and myself, we want to congratulate you on your first anniversary as a Motech dealer. You have done well and your accomplishments have been duly noted.

Your desire to become a Motech Dealer in Savannah, GA, should a position become available, will be given full consideration. Meanwhile, continue the fine performance you have established in Columbus.

In closing, we wish to thank you for your kind words regarding the Jacksonville District and its personnel.

5. **Evaluate the Following Letter.** Consider tone, organization, clarity, and completeness.

Hello, John!

This letter is to inform you of I.C.C.'s membership rates. Since Nov. of 1994 the membership rates have increased by \$5 to \$20. This additional amount goes to the I.C.C.'s endowment fund. Enclosed is a current Renewal Form. If you still want to become a member of I.C.C. you will need to send me an additional \$20 or you may receive a refund. Thank you for your interest in I.C.C. and I look forward to your response.

6. **Compare the Following Three Memos.** Consider completeness, clarity, tone, and organization.

- a. Jack to Bob, 4/23/9-
Booklet Schedule
Johnson now says Saturday sure.

b. TO: RJL
FROM: JS
DATE: April 23, 199-
SUBJECT: HEALTH BOOKLET SCHEDULE

I checked with Johnson and now have a definite promise that the 6000 standard "Your Health" booklets will be delivered Saturday, April 26.

This rescheduling will not affect our production schedules.

c. TO: Dr. Robert Lawson, Vice President
FROM: John Spam, Managing Editor
DATE: April 23, 199-
SUBJECT: Rescheduling of Standard "Your Health" Booklets.

I talked with Thomas Johnson this morning in an effort to reschedule production of 6000 Standard "Your Health" booklets to permit delivery Saturday, April 26.

He indicated at first that such a rescheduling would delay either the "Travel Plans" or the "Vacation Hints" booklets, but after talking with his production manager, he agreed to make the schedule change without delaying our other production.

Thus we can definitely count on delivery of "Your Health" Saturday.

7. Evaluate the Following for Organization and Overall Effectiveness.

Dear Tenants:

We have had some complaints lately about noise, especially at night. The complaints mainly involve the playing of CDs very late and too loud. I know that you like to listen to your music and that you need to relax at the end of your day of classes and homework. Maybe you could put your sound system away from the windows. You might also consider headphones for your listening. It isn't as though this is too serious, but a few people have complained. I just want to keep everybody happy.

8. Good News or Bad? Evaluate the Following for Tone and Organization.

In your letter that accompanied the return of your leather jacket, you claim that the jacket came apart at the seams and that you want to be reim-

bursed for the total cost of the jacket. Please understand, Ms. Appleton, that leather jackets take a great deal of care, and if you give them that care, they will last for many years. The sales tag on the jacket clearly states that it must not be stretched or exposed to high heat or bitter cold. Our alterations team investigated your claim and determined that the seams were indeed not secure and that they would have split apart with little movement. This obviously supports your claim that the damage was caused by a defect in workmanship. Therefore, we are enclosing a check for the complete amount of the jacket.

9. *Advertisement: What's Wrong with the Following Magazine Advertisement?*

February is SALE MONTH and everything in the store will be from 30%-50% off the regular price. Special inventory of designer coats and suits are priced at 50% off, and evening dresses will be up to 70% of the regular price.

This sale only lasts until February 29, so hurry in today for the best savings of the year!

Capsule Checklists for Good-News and Neutral Messages*

A	B
Good-News (and Neutral): General Plan 1. Best news or main idea	Answering Inquiries for Information about Individuals —Letters of Recommendation 1. Best news or main idea a. Applicant's full name and relationship to you, or how you know applicant—job(s) held, tenant, customer, club member, etc. b. Reason for writing (by request)
2. Explanation a. All necessary details b. Resale material c. Educational material d. Sales promotion	2. Explanation a. Answers to questions—direct or implied b. Best psychological order for four-fold responsibility (1) Applicant (2) Person considering applicant (3) Your conscience (4) Civil rights laws c. Specific facts about (1) Applicant's job, duties, conduct (2) Applicant's work or other habits (3) Applicant's personality, etc. d. Honesty and judgment about negatives e. Caution on legal aspects f. Confidentiality g. Offer, phone call
3. Positive, friendly ending a. Appreciation b. CSAD[†] c. EA[‡] and motivation d. Willingness to help further e. DA[§] f. RB[¶]	3. Courteous close a. Candid statement of your personal opinion about applicant's probable fitness for whatever he or she is being considered b. Positive (not negative) attributes at end

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.

[†]CSAD = clear statement of action desired.

[‡]EA = easy action.

[§]DA = dated action, if desirable.

[¶]RB = reader benefit.

Capsule Checklists for Good-News Messages (*Continued*)*

Granting Requests for Adjustment

C	D	E
Seller at Fault (A)	Buyer or Another at Fault (B)	Approving Credit
1. Best news a. Whatever will please buyer most b. Courtesy 2. Explanation a. Brief resale with tactful explanation of error (if desirable) b. Instructions for buyer action, if needed c. Concrete resale on firm, services, or goods, if desirable d. Cautions e. Sales promotion on replacement of return item(s) or on allied goods 3. Courteous close a. Suggested action and expectation of future pleasant use of goods and services. b. EA[†] c. Positive idea; help d. RB[¶]	1. Best news a. Same as C.1.a Get-in-step-with-reader, courteous comment and concern 2. Explanation a. Brief resale with tactful explanation of error, showing seller not at fault b. If use of 1.b above, best news after explanation c. Concrete resale on firm, services, or goods, if desirable d. Cautious e. Sales promotion on replacement of returned item(s) or on allied goods 3. Courteous close a. Suggested action and expectation of future pleasant use of goods and services b. EA[†] c. Positive idea; help d. RB[¶]	1. Best news a. Credit approval (if no purchase) b. Shipment (if goods ordered) (1) Description (2) Quantity (3) Prices, costs (4) Method, charges c. Courtesy 2. Explanation a. Basis for credit; compliment b. Credit terms; payments, discounts, limits c. Resale on services (1) <i>Consumer</i>: parking, shopping services, departments, conveniences, deliveries, price benefits (2) <i>Intermediary</i>: warehouses, discounts, selling aids, advertising, guarantees, repairs, deliveries d. Resale on product choices e. Sales promotion? 3. Courteous close a. Expectation of pleasant service and orders (not greedy) b. Suggestion action c. EA[†] d. RB[¶] e. Courtesy; suggestion of further help, if pertinent

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.

[†]CSAD = clear statement of action desired.

[‡]EA = easy action.

[§]DA = dated action, if desirable.

[¶]RB = reader benefit.

Capsule Checklists for Good-News Messages (*Continued*) *

F Acknowledging First Orders	G Granting Favors	H Announcements	I Transmittals
- Best news - Shipment details - Description - Quantity - Prices, costs - Method, charges - Thanks for remittance and/or order - Explanation <i>For credit customer</i> - Basis for credit—compliment - Credit terms; payments, discounts, limits <i>For cash or credit</i> Resale on services same as E.2.c. (1) and (2) Resale on products ordered; highlights on special features—adapted to buyer <i>For cash customer</i> Perhaps credit application form enclosed, with invitation to return it for consideration.	- Best news - Acceptance of favor, request - Courtesy - Explanation - Pertinent comments, and details regarding favor—what is being or will be done, etc. - Questions, if necessary, pertaining to favor	- Best news; main idea. When appropriate; - Five W's (all or most); reader in first and all other paragraphs - Statement of pleasure, compliment, congratulations - Admission of errors, with good news - Explanation - Details to emphasize, reader benefits, if possible <i>In admission of error</i> - Explanation, apology, emphasis on sincere desire to serve well - Resale on firm, products, or services, as appropriate	- Best news; main idea - Transmittal of specific item(s) - A concise reason - Courtesy - Explanation, if needed - Comments - Instructions
- Courteous close - Expectation of pleasant service and orders (not greedy) - Suggested action - EA[†] - RB[¶] - Courtesy, suggestion of further help, if pertinent	- Courteous close - Cordial, pertinent comment; perhaps a forward look, good wish, compliment, or request	- Courteous close - CSAD[†] - EA[†] - DA[§] - RB[¶] and/or offer of further help - Courtesy	- Courteous close - CSAD[†] - EA[†] - DA[§] - Offer of further help or other items or RB[¶] about items transmitted

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.

[†]CSAD = clear statement of action desired.

[†]EA = easy action.

[§]DA = dated action, if desirable.

[¶]RB = reader benefit.

Written Communication: Major Plans for Letters and Memos

Chapter 9 | Bad-News Messages

Chapter 10 | Persuasive Written Messages

Bad-News Messages

I. The Right Attitude

II. Plans for Bad-News Messages

- A. Indirect Plan
- B. Direct Plan

III. Negative Replies to Requests

- A. Answering Non-Sales-Related Inquiries When the Information Is Undesirable
- B. Refusing Adjustments on Claims and Complaints
- C. Refusing Credit
- D. Acknowledging Orders You Cannot Fill Now or at All
- E. Declining Invitations and Requests for Favors

IV. Unfavorable Unsolicited Messages

- A. Announcing Bad News About Prices or Services
- B. Penalizing for Nonconformity to Rules or Procedures
- C. Conveying Other Bad News

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

VII. Capsule Checklists for Bad-News Messages

“Difficult,” “hard to compose,” and “brutal” are a few of the comments often heard in connection with writing bad-news messages. Few persons find pleasure in expressing negative news. But sometime during your career, you will have to send a message that your reader will find disappointing or unfavorable. Composing a statement that creates and maintains goodwill toward you and your organization and at the same time conveys bad news will require a great deal of ingenuity.

In Chapter 8 you learned about the ingredients needed to compose and send a good-news communication. Here you learn the various sections of the negative message. A bad-news message varies from a good-news message in structure, tone, and information. With bad news, there is less tolerance for mistakes in communication.

As with other chapters in this book, we include relevant communication probes. Instead of checklists within the chapter, a detailed checklist for bad-news messages is included at the end. Specific topics relating to bad-news messages focus on the need for a right attitude, suggest plans for bad-news messages, and include various examples of unfavorable replies and unsolicited negative messages.

THE RIGHT ATTITUDE

In negative messages, your tone will help determine your effectiveness.

Everything you learned in preceding chapters about the communication process, consideration, and courtesy toward your reader or listener applies to bad-news messages. In negative messages, it is important that your *tone* be appropriate. Because the right attitude will improve the tone and thus the effectiveness of your message, keep the following suggestions in mind when you write bad-news letters and memos:

1. Put yourself in the reader's place. Your goal is to convince your reader that your decision, although contrary to his or her request, is fair, necessary, reasonable, and possibly even to his or her advantage in the long run.
2. Avoid using company rules or policy with no further explanation, as in such statements as “It is against company policy to do as you have asked.” Include, if possible, the *customer-benefits and reasons* that are behind your rules and policies.
3. Assume that the customer wants to do the right thing, even though she or he may be mistaken. The following expressions show confidence in the reader:
 You have every right to expect high quality in . . .
 You are probably wondering how you can . . .
 You understand that . . .
4. Single people out when you praise them; put them in a group when you criticize. Mention mistakes by using impersonal constructions.

Single out:

You have made an astute choice,
 Ms. Edwards.

As a group:	People sometimes misinterpret the terms of the warranty.
Impersonal:	Some of these figures need to be rechecked.

5. Be courteous and shield the reader's pride.

Tactless:	If you had read the instructions clearly stated on the label, you would have known not to put the garment in hot water.
Tactful:	Water will not typically damage the garment. However, hot water will discolor it, as is stated on the label.

6. Talk with, not down to, the reader.

Condescending:	We are willing to look into this matter for you.
Agreeable:	Thank you for taking the time to tell us about . . . We always appreciate . . .

All the above suggestions apply equally to dealings with international clients. Be especially watchful for words that accuse, point out errors, condemn actions. Chinese businesspeople, and for that matter, many cultures in Asia, will sense a loss of face. An overt condemnation early in a communication will produce resistance to your explanation. Choose your words carefully, and apply the above six suggestions with great care.

PLANS FOR BAD-NEWS MESSAGES

Every bad-news message has an underlying objective: to present the unpleasant facts in such a way that the reader will consider you fair and reasonable and, preferably, remain a friend of the organization you represent. Your choice of message plan is influenced by the circumstances—your purpose, the reader's probable reaction, your relationship to the reader, and the facts in each case. You have two organizational choices: the indirect or the direct.

Indirect Plan

Suppose you have been waiting for a reply to your request for something you want from a business firm—a refund or a loan important to you. How would you react if the reply began with a negative statement similar to these:

Most often, you will use an indirect organizational approach for bad-news messages.

- We regret [we are sorry, wish to state] that we are unable to refund your money on the merchandise you ordered from Scandinavian Outlets, LTD.
- Your application for a loan [refund] has been denied [refused, rejected].

Most people will feel more receptive toward your company—and you—if your reply opens with some kind of agreeable statement. Then insert an explanation followed by the negative news, additional explanations, and a courteous close. Some letters begin with agreeable news, are followed by the negative news, and end with suggestions for the future. Here we consider the first structure.

1. Buffer
2. Explanation and analysis of circumstances
3. Decision, implied or expressed, with resale and/or helpful suggestions
4. Friendly, positive close

- We appreciate your letter telling us about your problems with the merchandise we shipped you six months ago.
- Thank you for giving us the opportunity to consider your loan application for financing your proposed home purchase.

People appreciate hearing some explanation before the bad-news decision, especially if it seriously affects them. A good rule to consider is “Give good news quickly, but take more time with the bad.” Thus, while the good-news message often follows the direct approach, the bad-news message usually follows the indirect approach. The bad-news, indirect plan has the following suggested organizational structure:

1. Buffer

Buffers should be neutral in tone; avoid misleading the reader into thinking the news is good.

If possible, begin your message with reader-interest information. Your buffer should be pleasant, relevant, honest, and neutral in tone. Avoid statements that might mislead the reader into thinking you are granting the request; they merely set the reader up for a letdown. Apologies are unwarranted if your firm is not at fault.

The following are ways to begin a bad-news letter:

- a. *Agreement.* Agree with your reader on something, if possible (perhaps business conditions, costs, or any other pertinent item).
- b. *Appreciation.* Thank the reader (for a check, information, application, request, inquiry, cooperation, or whatever applies).
- c. *Assurance.* Assure the reader of your careful consideration and honest explanation of all available facts about the problem.
- d. *Compliment.* Try to compliment the reader on something good about his or her past record or request (sincerity, careful listing of facts, or other).
- e. *Cooperation.* Show a sincere desire to be as helpful as possible.
- f. *Good news.* If you can grant any part of a request, and you think your reader will be pleased, begin with that good news.

- g. *Neutral courtesy.* Keep your opening paragraph noncommittal. For instance, if you must announce a price increase or service decrease, use a neutral word such as “change.”
- h. *Understanding.* Show you understand or sympathize with the reader’s problem.

2. Explanation and Analysis

Explanations are often crucial to the effectiveness of a negative message.

Include honest, convincing reasons why the matter must be handled differently from the way the reader wants it. If the matter is routine or obvious (for example, a clerical error), an explanation is unnecessary. We stated earlier that the explanation can be placed *before* the decision, a usual position. You can also place that explanation *after* the negative news. Regardless, remember the following suggestions:

- a. Try to convince the reader you are acting in his or her best interests in the long run or according to a policy that is enforced equally for all. Avoid the insincere: “Much as I would like to . . . however. . .” Also avoid reasons that suggest benefit only to your firm.
- b. Explain courteously all relevant facts behind your decision. Mention first the favorable factors, then the less favorable ones.
- c. Show that the request has been carefully considered for the reader’s benefit as well as your company’s.

3. Decision, Implied, or Expressed, with Resale and/or Helpful Suggestions

To make the decision clear, positive, and concise, you have these alternatives:

- a. If the reasons are so clear that your reader will conclude you *must* refuse the request, you can omit negatives entirely and make the bad-news decision clear by implication. For example, if you are already scheduled as a luncheon speaker in Sydney on May 6, you do not need to say “Thus, I can’t attend your luncheon in Brussels that day.”
- b. If an implied decision might be misunderstood, express your decision clearly near the end of the explanation. Be careful not to mislead or otherwise cause uncertainty regarding your decision. The best place for a negative decision is in the middle of a paragraph, and never in a paragraph by itself. Avoid “must refuse,” “cannot grant,” and similar negatives.
- c. If you can, offer a constructive suggestion, counterproposal, compromise, or alternative course of action. By emphasizing what *can* be done, you may clearly imply what *cannot* be done without actually using negative language.
- d. If desirable, resell the reader on your company’s services or policies.

Endings should be positive, with reader-friendly requests, assurances, and reader benefits.

4. Friendly, Positive Close

End on a positive note, with one or more of the following ideas:

- a. Offer assurances that you appreciate the reader as a customer (or as an interested inquirer and possible future customer).
- b. Invite future patronage, cooperation, suggestions, or compliance with the decision. Include mild, no-pressure sales promotional material if you think the reader would respond favorably.
- c. Make clear whatever action is required, when to do it, and how to do it easily if you need the reader's approval or if the reader must take action.
- d. Express continued interest, service, and reader benefit, or sincere wishes for the reader's success with alternatives. Do not repeat the bad news. Avoid such statements as "I trust our decision is satisfactory" and "Let us know if you have any further problems."

Direct Plan

Although you can use the indirect bad-news plan for most unfavorable messages, certain situations may warrant the direct approach. Your choice depends on the

■ Communication Probe

The use of an explanation in a bad-news message in order to maintain goodwill has been addressed in sociolinguistic studies. Much of this research has considered the ways in which people reduce the social threat common in bad news by avoiding personal responsibility and by using face-saving techniques. In a 1990 article by Campbell concerning bad-news messages and speech act theory, five categories of strategies for refusing requests were presented:

1. Deny that an item requested exists.
2. Deny that you are the right person to whom to address the request.
3. Deny that the requested act is a future act.
4. Cite reasons for your inability to grant the request.
5. Cite reasons that the request is not beneficial to the person making the request.

A sixth strategy discussed by Campbell is to cite reasons for your unwillingness (as opposed to your inability) to grant the request. All these strategies attempt to create goodwill and protect the reader's pride. Their effectiveness, however, depends on the reader's perception of them as merely "politeness" tactics.

Campbell, K. S. (1990, Fall). Explanations in negative messages: More insights from speech act theory. *Journal of Business Communication*, 27(4), 357-375.

A direct approach can be used when the message is routine, when the reader is known for preferring directness, or when the message is urgent.

context and on the particular circumstances. The direct approach may be effective if you have one of the following:

- A routine matter on which the reader is likely not to be seriously disappointed or emotionally involved, especially a message between employees of two business firms or within the same firm
- A reader who is known to prefer reading the bad news in the first paragraph
- An urgent message that should be called to the reader's attention forcefully, as in the late stages of a collection procedure

If you use the direct approach, the pattern is the same as the direct good-news plan, except that the opening contains bad instead of good news.

1. Bad-news decision (with or without a brief buffer)
2. Explanation
3. Appropriate, courteous ending

Most examples of bad-news replies and unsolicited messages in this chapter are organized by the *indirect* approach, referred to simply as the bad-news plan. For examples of the messages organized according to the direct approach, look for the words *direct plan* in the title.

■ Communication Probe

One type of communication message that often concerns bad news is the performance appraisal. These appraisals take both oral and written forms and are used in many companies for the purpose of improving employee performance and increasing productivity. Although companies often provide forms for the written portion of their appraisals, they are not easy to write, and the difficulties have increased over time. The reasons for the problems have to do with attitude and personality evaluation, areas in which a form is little help in describing performance.

The issues involved in writing or orally giving a negative performance evaluation are the same as other bad-news communication issues: how to give the bad news while motivating the worker to improve. In addition, however, the forms used for both written and oral appraisals can impede the process and make the job more difficult. Since performance appraisals are so common, they are worthy of further research to study the unique problems of expressing negative performance aspects in a formal and somewhat artificial format.

Ewald, H. R., & McCallum, V. (1989, September). The performance appraisal: A crucial business process and product. *Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication*, 52(3), 39–47.

NEGATIVE REPLIES TO REQUESTS

This section focuses on negative replies to requests for information about non-sales-related subjects, adjustments, credit, orders, and favors.

Answering Non-Sales-Related Inquiries When the Information Is Undesirable

Occasionally you may have to write bad-news answers to inquiries about matters not relating to sales. In most cases, your reply may follow the bad-news approach. In some cases, the direct plan or another alternative may be desirable.

Honesty, tactfulness, and caution are necessary when responding to a request for a recommendation for a person about whom you have unfavorable information.

When you receive a request for a recommendation regarding a person about whom you have only unfavorable information, you have these alternatives:

1. Call the inquirer on the telephone and discuss the matter. Be careful that what you say is not slanderous.
2. Write a brief refusal note similar to the following:

On the basis of my experience with Janice Bailey, I am sorry that I do not have sufficient information to recommend her for the position for which you are considering her.
3. Write an honest, frank, confidential, legally appropriate letter using the bad-news plan. Because of libel laws, it is imperative to be cautious and scrupulously accurate. (See also the comments regarding recommendations in Chapter 11, Short Reports, and in the discussion of legal aspects in Appendix C.)

The best overall policy is to be honest, tactful, and aware of your fourfold responsibility—to the applicant, to the addressee, to yourself, and to civil rights laws. Omit any statements you cannot verify in a court of law!

When you are writing to someone in your own organization about a routine matter with which the reader is not emotionally involved, or when you know your reader likes the bad news up front, the *direct* approach is appropriate, as in the following example.

MESSAGE 1 *Memo in direct-plan format for bad news about facilities availability.*

TO: Bill Holmes
 FROM: Cynthia Warren
 SUBJECT: Need for Alternate Conference Room

Bad news

Today Joe Garbani from the Facilities Department told me that the Conrad Room, which we scheduled for the conference we're hosting next month, will be under construction during the period in question.

Details

As an alternate, Joe suggested using the Mayfair Room, which is bigger and more luxurious than the Conrad. Its less con-

venient location can be handled with clear directional signs.

Action request

If you approve, I'll go ahead and make arrangements. Joe needs to know by next week if we want the Mayfair. Could you give me a call by Wednesday afternoon?

If you write for a nonprofit organization that receives many requests for free information, you may, to cut correspondence costs, devise a bad-news form letter listing the most recurring negative facts. The following letter has a "Dear reader" salutation.

MESSAGE 2 *Form letter to handle a nonprofit organization's multiple inquiries for which many answers may be bad news.*

Buffer: Thanks and reader benefit

Thank you for your recent inquiry. In the interest of replying promptly to the hundreds of requests we receive—and for economy—your request and all others are answered by this form letter.

Facts: Implied decisions

1. The item or information you requested is
 - ___ a. Enclosed.
 - ___ b. Out of print. Copies are in many libraries.
 - ___ c. Not yet available; will be sent later.
2. ___ Your request will be filled as soon as our supply is replenished.
3. ___ The free supply of this report is exhausted. Copies may be purchased from [name and address] for ____.

Suggestions for future action

If the check mark for your request is 1.c. or 2, you can depend on us to send the promised material as soon as possible. If your request has other check marks, we wish you success in finding the desired items elsewhere.

[Signature]
[Name and title of writer]

Refusing Adjustments on Claims and Complaints

When you refuse a request for adjustment, helpful material to include—besides your buffer and explanation—is resale, constructive suggestions, and sales promotion where appropriate.

The following discussion focuses on two kinds of unwarranted customer claims for which you may have to write a refusal: (1) the customer is at fault regarding a product and (2) the customer is mistaken in a complaint about an account or a service.

When the customer is at fault, special tact must be used in rejecting requests.

The Customer Is at Fault Regarding a Product

Often customers who claim free replacement or repair of a malfunctioning product are at fault because they violated instructions for using it. Or a customer might return as “new” an article that cannot be resold because of something the customer did wrong. The next two examples illustrate satisfactory adjustment refusals in such cases.

Misuse of a Product. Notice that in Message 3 the writer calls attention to the user’s mistake indirectly and shields the reader’s pride. The letter does not say “You violated the instructions” or “You obviously didn’t take care of the product.” Instead the message includes a logical explanation, an implied but clear refusal, and a constructive suggestion.

MESSAGE 3 *Letter from the customer service manager of Quick Cut Lawn Mower Company refusing to replace free a rusted, malfunctioning lawn mower.*

Buffer: Agreement, appreciation	When you buy a Quick Cut lawn mower, you are right to expect high quality. We appreciate your returning the lawn mower for our inspection so that we can meet our goal-satisfying your needs with quality products.
Resale; assurance of guarantee	Each of the thousands of Quick Cut lawn mowers we sell is guaranteed to give you the service for which it was designed. We provide an instruction booklet with each mower to simplify its use and care.
Reason for breakdown	As stated in the instruction booklet, the lawn mower you bought must be stored in a dry place while not in use. Our service department inspected the mower and discovered rust on the motor, which would prevent the mower from running properly, and rust on all the exterior parts. The rust is caused by exposure to the weather over long periods of time. Storing your mower in a dry place, such as a garage or tool shed, will prevent these problems from occurring in the future.
Implied refusal	
Constructive suggestion	Our repair shop will be happy to remove the rust from your mower and put it in working order. This will cost you approximately \$90. If you prefer, you may take the mower to any Quick Cut lawn mower dealer for the repairs. A list of dealers in your area is described in the new instruction booklet we have enclosed.
Easy action; reader benefit	After you have decided which alternative best meets your needs, fill out the en-

closed card and check whether you want our shop to repair your mower and return it or whether you want us to return it to you for your own repairs. Either way, you can have many years of dependable service from your Quick Cut lawn mower.

Unsalability of Return Product. Some products, such as prescription drugs and undergarments, cannot—because of state or national statutes—be accepted for return after they have left the store. In such cases the explanation is easy. However, sometimes a customer may try to return a damaged product or one owned for so long that the store can no longer resell it. In this case, a tactful, detailed letter such as Message 4 may be necessary.

MESSAGE 4 *Letter from the manager of a Hong Kong fabric distributor refusing to accept a returned bolt of silk.*

Buffer: Assurance; thanks

To please our customers is the foremost aim of the Hong Kong Fabric Distributing Company, LTD. Thank you for writing us explaining your wishes about the bolt of silk fabric you purchased two years ago.

Reader benefit; facts about return policy

We want you and all our customers to enjoy the confidence of knowing that any purchase from us is for fabric of outstanding quality and that it is clean, fresh, and new. Bolts of fabric may be returned any time within six months of purchase provided it is in clean, resalable condition.

Findings in this case

To maintain the high standard on the goods we sell, we carefully check returned fabric before it is placed for sale. Our examination of the silk you mailed to us revealed large discolored spots on some sections and mold on others, indicating storage in a damp place.

Implied decision

Because cleaning would render the silk "used" to anyone wishing to purchase it, the bolt of silk is unacceptable for resale.

Helpful suggestion

Our staff can arrange to have your fabric cleaned for a charge, or if you prefer, we will return it to you for your own cleaning arrangements. Although there is no guarantee that spots of this kind can be removed completely, we will do everything possible to help you feel pleased with your fabric.

Easy action

Please check and mail your preference on the enclosed card. Your fabric is an es-

pecially beautiful design, and it should, once cleaned, make a lovely garment or other item.

The Customer Is Mistaken About an Account or a Service

In addition to refusing adjustments on return merchandise, you may also have bad news for customers who make erroneous claims resulting from a variety of intangible grievances. Among them are unwarranted claims about their account balances and unjustified gripes about various aspects of your firm's service. Many firms now handle most of these complaints by telephone whenever possible.

When claims are unjustified, the explanation for the misunderstanding becomes important in order to maintain reader goodwill.

Unwarranted Claims About Account Balances. When customers think you have made an error and you find your records are correct, you must give the customers the bad news that they owe more than they claim. You need to assure them that you have carefully rechecked their records and want to cooperate fully. Be sure to explain each additional charge clearly because your readers may have forgotten that a purchase or late charges were added or that some past checks were returned by the bank for various reasons. If the matter is too complicated for a phone explanation, a letter will be more helpful, with a tabulation of figures or a photostatic copy of the record.

Unjustified Gripes About Company Services. Careful and tactful explanation is necessary to establish your company's accuracy and to resell the reader on its usually high-quality service. For instance, the printer who is wrongly accused of misspelling a name on the customer's stationery may have to send a copy of the customer's original handwritten order showing the identical spelling. Professional cleaners may reduce customer complaints by sending a printed note such as the following, with a cleaned garment or rug that has unremovable stains:

We've tried and tried, but find that the stains on this [item name] cannot be removed without possible injury to the color or fabric. This has been called to your attention so that you will know that it has not been overlooked.

If a customer does complain, a detailed oral or written explanation may have to include specific facts about the extra care and time the experienced workers skilled in modern spot-removal processes took. Likewise, similar procedures are desirable in other types of business to help answer complaints about their services. The message should convince the customer that the firm has earned the fee and must charge for an honest job.

Refusing Credit

Even when refusing a credit application, you should try to keep the reader's goodwill and, perhaps, continued business on a cash basis. A person's credit reputation is important. Thus, a credit manager has responsibilities to make sound, informed decisions concerning credit.

To avoid risk of a lawsuit and unfavorable publicity, a credit manager must be careful about what he or she writes and how reasons are expressed. Refusals

Most refusals use the bad-news organizational plan.

■ Communication Probe

Studies in giving negative feedback suggest that it is most effective when the grammatical first person or third person is used rather than the second person. An overuse of the pronoun “you” when the reader is at fault or is receiving bad news adds a confrontational tone to the message. Research also suggests that neutral language helps with a reader’s acceptance of the message. The tone of a message is very easily influenced by the number of negative words and the number of formal, Latinate words. That’s why word choice and sentence construction are powerful tools in designing messages and should be considered carefully when sending bad-news messages.

Brinko, K. T. (1993, Sept./Oct.). The practice of giving feedback to improve teaching. *Journal of Higher Education*, 64(5), 574–593; Hoffman, R., & Kocar, M. (1989, Sept.). Introducing objectivity in evaluating writing assignments. *Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication*, 52(3), 25–26.

of both retail and mercantile credit are usually organized by the bad-news plan, although their contents differ. Some credit departments use the telephone for all refusals. If you work in such a department, you will find you can apply many writing principles in this chapter to your oral refusals.

Retail Credit Refusals

For various reasons, approving credit for some customers may be undesirable. Also, sometimes a customer who currently has credit must be told that further credit purchases will be stopped until the credit balance is reduced or paid in full. Other decisions may involve people new to your city, those involved in divorce actions, young people who have not yet established a credit record, and others.

Opening Paragraph. The refusal usually begins with a buffer that refers to the firm’s appreciation or careful consideration of the reader’s request for credit or to his or her interest in the store, or to both.

Explanation. Explanations in retail credit refusals vary considerably; here are four ways of handling the reasons for refusal:

1. Reason is omitted entirely (see Example 1).
2. “Insufficient information” is the only reason given (see Example 2).

EXAMPLE 1 *No stated reason. An unhelpful refusal.*

Decision After careful consideration, we find that at this time it would be better for you to continue your purchases from us on a cash basis.

EXAMPLE 2 *Insufficient information. A popular retail credit refusal method.*

Explanation As you know, the usual custom before opening a new account is to get information that will serve as a basis for credit. Such information as we have thus far obtained is insufficient for us to pass favorably on your request at this time. If you feel there are other details that would favorably affect your credit, you are welcome to call on us so that we can consider all the facts.

3. Factors considered in evaluating credit applications are stated without indicating specifically which apply to the reader (see Letter 1).
4. Specific reasons are stated (see Letter 2).

LETTER 1 *List of factors usually considered. A retail credit refusal inviting reapplication and a layaway plan.*

Buffers: Thanks Thank you, [reader's name], for your recent inquiry regarding the status of your credit application.

**Explanation:
List of factors
considered** A number of factors are taken into consideration when reviewing an application. Length of time at one residence and employment are of vital importance—as well as income, assets, and the payment record of current and past obligations.

**Implied decision; assurance;
invitation** You are assured that all the above available information has been carefully analyzed in your case. Your circumstances may improve in the future, at which time we would be pleased to reconsider your request for credit.

**Reader-benefit
invitation to
purchase; no
mention of cash** In the meantime, we invite you to save on your clothing purchases at Forman's regular everyday low prices and frequent sales. Also, of course, you're welcome to use our easy layaway plan for bigger purchases.

LETTER 2 *Specific reasons: inadequate income. Personal-type loan refusal.*

Buffer: Compliment; favorable points You are to be complimented on your desire to provide the best possible housing for your family. Also, both your loan application and your credit report indicate that you have maintained a steady employment record. This too is commendable.

**Explanation:
Reasoning from
general to specific**

In mortgage lending, however, extensive studies have revealed that a certain relationship between a person's income, fixed monthly expense, and loan amount should exist to make a loan advisable. Our maximum loan is 2 1/2 times the annual income, or payments may not exceed 20 percent of the monthly income. Since your income at present meets neither of these requirements, you can understand why we feel that an additional financial burden will not serve your best interests.

Suggestion

If you would like to stop by my office, I will be happy to go over with you the minimum requirements for a small loan. This discussion might help you in setting and planning for your desired goal for home ownership. As time goes on and your income increases, you will be able to improve your financial position to the point where we can help you buy a new and larger home.

Future help

Feel welcome to come in any day between 9 and 5. We sincerely want to help you reach your desired goal.

At times, your explanation should not include specific reasons, especially if the reasons suggest that your reader has undesirable characteristics.

The first three approaches can be easily adapted by credit departments that find it necessary to use form letters because of a large number of applications (often over a wide geographic area). Because of similar names among the thousands of individual requests, mix-ups and errors do occur. Thus credit managers for firms that handle numerous requests find it safer to omit specific reasons, especially those that pertain to undesirable character or poor pay habits. From the customer's standpoint, the refusal that omits the reason entirely is the least helpful. The "insufficient information" reason and the list of general reasons are considered by some customers to be unclear or insincere. Nevertheless, methods 2 and 3 are usually acceptable under certain circumstances, provided the constructive suggestion is diplomatic and helpful.

The fourth method of refusing credit—stating specific reasons—is desirable when the following conditions exist:

- The situation requires a personalized, typed reply (as in a request for a large loan).
- The reason is not poor (dishonest, unreliable) personal character.
- The desired relationship between the credit department and the applicant is somewhat personal.
- The applicant cannot come for a personal interview and is likely to be offended with anything but an individual, helpful letter.

Such letters are usually longer and harder to write than the first three types. When they are tactful and accurate, however, they are highly appreciated by the recipient because they indicate what must be done to earn (or restore) a good credit standing.

Some large firms use printed forms with courteous opening paragraphs and then a list of several (perhaps 20) reasons for credit refusals. In front of each reason is a small square with checks in the squares that are applicable to the reader. These forms may also state the applicant's rights according to law.

Try to use positive language when stating an unfavorable decision.

Decision, Resale, Suggestions. When stating your decision, avoid such negatives as "did not approve," "unfavorable," "does not meet," "must decline." Instead of stressing what is wrong, suggest whenever possible how the situation can be improved. You can often combine resale and constructive alternatives with the decision or ending paragraph. Depending on the circumstances, the applicant may be invited to take one or more of these steps:

1. Come to an office to discuss the case if the applicant has questions or thinks an error has been made
2. Apply again later when conditions have improved
3. Contact another lender or credit agency that you name
4. Examine the record at the credit bureau and write any needed corrections
5. Use the layaway plan or another suitable credit plan
6. Continue buying from the company on cash or c.o.d. basis

Ending Paragraph. The suggested action ties in with one of the above suggestions and, if possible, includes a reader benefit. Compare examples 1 and 2 above with the personal Letter 2. (Example 1 suggests buying on a cash basis. Because some customers consider this suggestion obvious, or even offensive, you can avoid referring to cash by wording the last paragraph in a way similar to that in Letter 1.)

Mercantile Credit Refusals

Wholesale or mercantile credit is credit extended by one business firm to another. The preferred organizational pattern for these credit refusals is the bad-news plan.

For the buffer, you have choices similar to those used in retail refusals—appreciation and assurance of careful consideration.

The most noticeable difference between retail and mercantile credit refusals is that the latter are generally more candid regarding the reasons for refusal and are individually word-processed. The decision is based on the firm's financial statement plus other credit ratings. These ratings may be by Dunn and Bradstreet, special rating agencies, creditors, and/or sales agencies of the wholesaler or manufacturer considering the applicant. As with retail credit, the emphasis should be on what is positive rather than on what is wrong now.

A mercantile credit refusal may include one or more reader-benefit suggestions, especially for a reader who is inexperienced in business.

■ Communication Probe

Many of the concepts covered in books regarding bad-news messages contradict the accepted guidelines for business and managerial writing. Those guidelines, or “rules,” state that you should be direct, use simple language, and write short sentences. A bad-news message, however, often comes loaded with context, in which your relationship with the reader, your reader’s opinions, and your own position are extremely important. In many of these bad-news situations, you must break the rules of directness and brevity and choose language that cushions your message and softens your tone. You must be tactful without being manipulative, and you must tell the truth. As in all effective messages, a bad-news message must be appropriately reader-oriented.

Fahner, H. (1990, October). The 10 commandments of memo writing. *Sales & Marketing Management*, 85–87; Fielden, J. (1989, April). Clear writing is not enough. *Management Review*, 49–52.

1. Reduction of apparently excessively high inventory by special means
2. Ways to build up customer’s volume of sales (and working capital, if pertinent); perhaps offering the assistance of your firm’s sales representative
3. Advantages of modest buying, local financing, and cash discounts
4. Cash purchases—smaller, more frequent orders
5. Cash on delivery or cash with orders earning discount privilege
6. Review of the applicant’s credit situation at a future time

One good test for any letter is what your reaction would be if *you* received it. Would you feel offended if you were the retailer? Would you buy from the wholesaler? Does the writer of the refusal seem sincere and interested in helping you?

Acknowledging Orders You Cannot Fill Now or at All

If you have good news, state that first before communicating your bad news.

Whenever you get an order that you cannot fill immediately or in the way the customer expects, your acknowledgment will be at least temporarily bad news. This section discusses bad-news acknowledgments regarding incomplete or vague orders, back orders, and substitution orders.

Incomplete or Vague Orders

If a customer omits necessary information on an order, you usually cannot process it. Telephoning or writing to the customer is always better than risking errors and annoyance.

If the order lists some items that you are able to send now, mention them first. If not, begin with a buffer—usually short resale on the product for which the order is incomplete, appreciation for the order, and if a first order from a customer, a welcome. Then, before you request the missing information or payment, state a reader-benefit reason—that you want to be sure to send exactly what the customer wants. Avoid such words as “you forgot” or “you failed to.” Include explanatory facts that the customer needs to complete the order, such as sizes or color choice available. If a letter (instead of a phone call) is necessary, include pictures, catalog numbers, sketches, swatches, and other helpful items when appropriate. Make customer action easy, and assure prompt shipment, if possible.

Orders for Out-of-Stock Items to Be Back-Ordered

If your stock of an ordered item is temporarily depleted and you expect a new shipment within a reasonable time (1 or 2 weeks), you can usually back-order and assume the customer would rather wait than cancel the order.

As with the incomplete-order acknowledgment, your main goal in the back-order letter is to keep the customer sold on your product and to serve him or her well. Because of the necessary delay, your message should be organized by the bad-news plan.

Your buffer can be resale on the ordered item (to reinforce the customer's confidence in her or his choice) and appreciation.

Your explanation should focus on the positive aspects of the date the goods will reach the customer. Omit such negatives as “cannot send,” “out of stock,” “exhausted,” “won't have any . . . until.” If possible, include a reason for your being out of the item so the customer will not think your firm is inefficient. If such reasons pertain to popularity or exceptional demand, this strengthens your resale and the customer's desire for the item. In your action-getting close, positive suggestion is useful. The best way for the customer to show approval of the back order is to take no action. Thus, back-order acknowledgments often include the positive.

Communication Probe

The language used by an organization communicates an identity that is not always positive. All types of company language, from the name of the company and its products to the wording of its most mundane forms, reflect the attitudes and style of the company's management and those who help create its written communications. A letter to a client or customer reveals much about the attitudes of the company. If you look at one message from a company, you will see that it suggests values in the way it handles tone, sentence constructions, and word choices. All processed messages should ideally show what the organization wants to communicate about itself regarding its values and attitudes.

Morris, K. (1991, Winter). Corporate language: Creating a verbal identity. *Design Management Journal*, 37–41.

Shipment will be made as soon as we receive the new supplies, unless you instruct us to the contrary.

If the wait may be unreasonably long, ask the customer to let you know (perhaps by an easy-action reply card) whether your shipping on the later date is acceptable. Your emphasis whenever possible should be on acceptance, not cancellation. Sometimes a bit of sales promotion material on seasonal or related goods is appropriate, if it is clearly for the reader's benefit.

A short message such as Letter 3 is sufficient for a temporarily out-of-stock item.

LETTER 3 *Acknowledging a customer's order on an item to be back-ordered.*

Buffer

Thank you for your order of the Special Issue of the Gutierrez guitar. At \$365, it is an exceptional value.

Resale: Explanation

The demand for this deluxe version of the famous Gutierrez guitar has far exceeded our most optimistic expectations. We have reordered twice from the manufacturer in Barcelona, Spain. The latest shipment will be delivered within 10 days and will be sent out to you immediately.

Decision: Delivery date; reader benefit

You should receive your Gutierrez guitar before May 1 and will be able to enjoy its fine workmanship and beautiful sound. Enclosed for your interest is a catalog of guitar-related products should you ever need any additional items.

Orders for Out-of Stock Items for Which You Suggest a Substitute

When you get an order for a certain model or brand that you cannot supply soon enough by back order or that has been discontinued, you can often suggest a substitute by telephone.

Usually it is safer to ask permission to substitute before you ship, as in Letter 4, especially if the customer must pay a higher price for the newer line. (Unfortunate shippers who have sent large substitute shipments without permission have sometimes had to pay express charges both ways for rejected merchandise returned by a displeased customer.)

LETTER 4 *Suggesting a substitute in place of an ordered, discontinued item.*

Buffer: Brand resale; thanks

Many thanks for your order on April 30 for a Koolco window air conditioner. You can be sure that your decision to buy a Koolco was a decision to buy the best in the industry.

**Explanation for
new model (sub-
stitute)**

Last year the Koolco engineers designed a new model window air conditioner. This latest model has several improvements and new features our customers have been asking for. For this reason, we now stock the new model exclusively. Though it's possible that Keller Air Conditioning and Heating may still have the model you ordered, we believe you will want our newest model after you check these improved features:

Reader benefit

- Voice-activated temperature control, allowing you to change the temperature without getting up from your desk or chair
- Quieter motor with heavy-duty sound-proofing around the cabinet
- Ability to cool either outside or inside air
- New, smaller size to allow more window space

Easy action

For all these advantages, the new model is inexpensively priced at only \$195 installed. To give me your approval for shipment, just call me at (212) 555-4567 any weekday between 8 and 5. I'll have your new Koolco air conditioner on its way to you the same day.

Reader benefit

You may also take advantage of our new no-payments-for-30-days policy. You'll be happy you bought the new Koolco air conditioner.

Notice that the buffer begins with appreciation and general resale information, emphasizing the strongest point of reader appeal that the two products have in common—the Koolco brand.

The explanation and bad-news decision stress what the firm *does* have instead of what it does not carry any longer. After this positive news is announced, the new substitute is introduced with a mention of its merits. Only then is the bad news communicated that the ordered item is unavailable. One good way to do this is to state that you now stock the substitute exclusively (if true), but do not use the word *substitute* because of its negative connotation. If the substitute is a different brand instead of merely another model of the same brand, do not mention the ordered item by brand name more than once. If you mention where the ordered item can be obtained, subordinate that statement in a dependent clause, as in Letter 4. If the price of the substitute is higher, be sure to state adequate selling points to justify the difference. If your substitute is lower in quality but an excellent value because of price or other reasons, stress these benefits.

The ending of the letter should ask for authorization to send the substitute or explain why you have already sent it. Make clear to the reader that the item

comes on trial and subject to the receiver's approval. Sometimes substitution is also made in rush orders for similar, same-price, inexpensive items or when the company absorbs the price difference.

Declining Invitations and Requests for Favors

The bad-news plan is usually the most appropriate for declining invitations and requests for favors.

Customers, noncustomers, and employees may extend invitations or request various privileges or favors that you may have to refuse. Some of these requests are business-related; others are nonbusiness and personal.

Among the numerous business-related favors that customers ask are changing requirements or payment due dates, borrowing your company's equipment or premises, seeing your firm's confidential material, getting special reduced rates, or skipping several payments on a contract. Requests concerning nonbusiness activities may involve donations of your time, money, property, or other assistance.

The bad-news plan is usually the most appropriate in many of these refusals. As always, good judgment is necessary in choosing your buffer, your explanation, helpful suggestions, and friendly close. Message 5 is an example of such a letter refusing a request to speak at a conference.

MESSAGE 5 *Letter: A refusal to speak at a conference.*

Buffer: Appreciation

The International Marketing Association has a great deal to offer business people, and I have enjoyed the annual conference for several years. I appreciate very much your invitation to be the keynote speaker for this year's conference in Helsinki on June 5.

Reason

The date of the conference is, unfortunately, during a two-week period when I will be in Frankfurt for meetings with my firm's distributors. I did make an effort to reschedule these meetings, but I was unable to do so. I regret not being able to address this important forum and having to miss the conference itself.

Implied refusal

Suggestion

May I suggest that you contact Eleanor Forman, our newly elected vice-president in charge of brand-name marketing for Europe? She is eager to become more involved in the IMA and has interesting experiences related to this year's conference theme, "Selling the American Name Abroad." I am enclosing her address and phone number in case you would like to contact her.

Cordial wishes

You have my best wishes for getting the right person. The conference plans look terrific.

Bad news is often communicated in the direct organizational plan whenever the matter is routine between departments of the same firm. The following memo deals with bad news directly:

MESSAGE 6 *Memo—Direct plan: Refusal of a requested specification change in an airplane factory.*

TO: J.R. Lowry DATE: April 30, 199-
 FROM: J.S. Thompson
 SUBJECT: Food and Beverage Elevator
 REFERENCE: RPD-5244-12, dated 2-15 [year]

Refusal

As shown on page 5 of the specifications, paneling for elevator walls remains a valid requirement. Thus the referenced request to use paint instead of vinyl paneling is unacceptable.

Explanation

Because of the particular uses for this elevator and the expected altitudes for flights, it is necessary that all walls have the extra protection of the exact vinyl as in the specifications, instead of mere coats of paint.

Request

Will you please, therefore, see that the paneling requirement is met, according to specifications.

Negative replies to requests in situations such as responding to sales inquiries, claims and adjustments, credit requests, orders you cannot fill, or to invitations or favors can effectively use either the direct or the indirect approach. You should always remember to keep the needs of your reader in mind and try to show reader benefits, even when your message is unfavorable.

UNFAVORABLE UNSOLICITED MESSAGES

If the bad news is routine, you may choose to use the direct organizational plan; however, if your readers will be disappointed or angered by the news, use the indirect plan.

You may sometimes have to send bad-news messages that are not in response to inquiries. This section illustrates unfavorable announcements about prices and services, rules and procedures, plus miscellaneous bad news. You are generally wise to use the bad-news plan whenever your readers will be disappointed or angered by your message. However, when you write to employees or other business associates on routine matters, you may use the direct plan.

Announcing Bad News About Prices or Services

When your firm finds it necessary to increase prices or cut services to customers, a buffer opening followed by reasons before stating the negative decision will help break the news gently, as in Message 1.

MESSAGE 1 *Letter from a wholesaler announcing limitations in services.***Buffer: Neutral courtesy**

In reviewing the past year's business and trying to plan for a future in which Appalachiicola Shrimp Brokers, Inc., can continue to give you good service, it has become evident that some modifications must be made.

Reasons

Expenses in the shrimp wholesale business have been constantly increasing without corresponding increases in profit margins. Rather than increase prices, the following changes will become effective on July 15 of this year:

- (1) Free delivery will be continued only on orders of at least \$350. Orders for a lesser amount will be sent by United Parcel Service, and shipping costs will be added to the invoice.
- (2) Collect telephone calls will be accepted only in cases where we have been in error.

Fairness to customers; courteous invitation

A decision on these changes was made after careful analysis of our costs in relation to service. We feel sure you will agree that these changes are fair. If you have any suggestions as to how we may improve our product and service, please let us know.

In contrast to the buffer opening of Message 1 to customers, you can use bad-news, direct-approach openings similar to the following when you announce the same decisions to your employees:

So that Appalachiicola Shrimp Brokers, Inc. can continue to give good service without a general increase in prices to our customers, the following restrictions in delivery and telephone services will become effective July 15 this year.

Even for employees, however, you should follow the bad-news plan when they are likely to be personally affected or seriously disappointed by your decision. Suppose, for instance, that your company management has decided to close the employee cafeteria food service mornings and evenings and keep it open only during noon hours. To partially offset this decrease and to provide for changing employee food preferences, the snack bar service will be increased. Message 2 illustrates a poor way to announce these changes to employees; Message 3 is a good way. Notice the difference in subject lines.

MESSAGE 2 *Memo—Direct plan: A poor, negative, incomplete bad-news announcement to employees about decreased cafeteria service.*

TO: All employees of XYZ
 FROM: Camilla White, Food Services Director
 SUBJECT: Closing of Cafeteria for Breakfasts and Suppers

Starting next Monday, March 15, there will be no more breakfasts or suppers served in the cafeteria.

This facility will hereafter be closed every morning and afternoon. Lunches will be served in the cafeteria only between 11 a.m. and 2 p.m.

However, to provide continuing service to our employees, the snack bar will be open from 8 a.m. to 5:45 p.m. and will offer a wider selection of food.

MESSAGE 3 *Memo—Indirect plan: An improved version of the preceding bad-news announcement to employees.*

TO: All employees of XYZ
 FROM: Camilla White, Food Services Director
 SUBJECT: Changes in Company Snack Bar and Cafeteria Services

Buffer: Reader benefit

To keep food prices at their present level, in spite of rising costs, and to meet your changing needs, the snack bar and cafeteria services will be modified starting Monday, March 15.

Reasons

Changes are necessary because during the past three years fewer employees have been eating breakfasts and suppers in the cafeteria, and the cost of operating it has steadily increased. So that you can continue to benefit from both low prices and good-quality food, we are altering the services and believe you'll like them.

Employee benefits

Decision: Favorable changes first

Snack Bar Service—The snack bar will be expanded to offer a wider selection of food than ever before. From the semi-self-service counter and the vending machines you can choose:

Packaged	Fruits, juices	Sandwiches
cereals	Soft drinks	Hamburgers
Doughnuts	Ice cream	Salads
Rolls	Pies, cake,	Soup
Coffee, tea,	candy	Potato chips
milk, hot		
chocolate		

Decision

Cafeteria Service—Each day a lunch special consisting of a hot main course, salad, dessert, and drink will be served, as before, for less than \$5. The cafeteria will serve only lunches.

New Hours—Effective March 15:
 Snack Bar—8 a.m. to 5:45 p.m.
 Cafeteria—11 a.m. to 2:00 p.m.

Employee benefits

In addition, the cafeteria doors will remain open between 8 a.m. and 6 p.m. for those of you wishing a meeting place during work breaks or a place to enjoy food brought from home or the snack bar.

Future look: Invited action

You are invited to use these facilities whenever you can. They are available to you at no extra price on snacks or lunches. If you have any suggestions on the new cafeteria or snack bar services, please jot them on a slip of paper and drop them into the suggestion box at the cafeteria door.

Penalizing for Nonconformity to Rules or Procedures

Announcements about penalties for deviating from required procedures or disregarding previous notices often begin with the bad news. The direct plan should be used especially when the situation is urgent or when the writer wants the reader to be sure to read the main idea, as in Message 4, signed by the editor of a business magazine.

When the message is urgent or of great importance to the reader, use the direct plan.

MESSAGE 4 *Letter—Direct plan: Form letter announcement about a lapsed subscription.*

Main idea

This letter must be my final farewell since your subscription to [name] has been suspended.

Explanation

It has been almost half a year since your subscription to [name] lapsed. We've continued to mail you issues as a courtesy to a valued Founding Subscriber. But we can no longer continue this courtesy.

Invitation

You are a valued subscriber. I invite you to return the enclosed renewal notice and continue our relationship. Don't miss out on the valuable information [name] brings you—helping you to run a more successful business and be more well-rounded as a professional.

Reader benefit

Each issue of [name] is packed with useful information on legislative trends, envi-

ronmental ideas, community relations projects, new marketing opportunities, and morale building ideas. With [name] you're part of something larger than yourself, something that can make a difference in the world. You're part of a vigorous and influential movement of people who are changing the way business does business.

Final request

You are needed. To survive and thrive, [name] needs the support of our most valuable friends: our Founding Subscribers. Please say you'll stay. Send us the enclosed renewal notice today.

Easy action

Conveying Other Bad News

When you have made a mistake, it is often best to admit your error in the beginning of your message.

You may have to write other bad news or unsolicited or solicited messages. As a rule, you can handle most of them well by the bad-news plan.

One exception to the usual rule for customer bad-news letters is when you must confess that you made a mistake that is not in the customer's favor. In such cases, it is often better to admit your error in the opening, as in the next example.

MESSAGE 5 *Letter—Direct plan: Announcement of an error in billing.*

Tactful lead to bad news

Giving accurate service to you and all our customers is always our goal. Therefore, we apologize for the mistake in billing on the floor tiles we shipped to you last week.

Details

The correct amount of the shipment of tile was \$20 a box for the 10 boxes you ordered, or \$200. We billed you for only 8 boxes, or \$160. We overlooked the additional two boxes because they were shipped a day later than the other eight.

Request: Easy action; goodwill

May we ask you to send a check for the additional \$40? Just slip it into the enclosed stamped envelope and mail it. You can be sure we'll do our best to see that you get accurate service in the future.

Letters of resignation should include a reason, appreciation for people you are leaving, and a cordial ending.

The letter of resignation is another bad-news announcement you may have to write. It should include your reason for resigning (ill health, better position, or whatever), appreciation and pleasant comments about people you are leaving, perhaps a statement of regret, definite effective date for the resignation, and a sincere, cordial ending. Whatever the position from which you are resigning and whatever the reasons, you must consider your readers and your relationship to them before you decide to organize by the direct or the indirect plan.

An opening for the indirect approach might begin like the following:

During the past four years, I've greatly enjoyed working with the many fine people of our organization.

If your readers are busy and you think they would prefer reading the main idea in the first paragraph, you may choose the direct plan. This letter might begin with a sentence like the following:

With reluctance and regret, I must ask to be released from my position as . . .

Whatever your organizational plan, you should write a tactful, reader-focused message that is sincere and generates goodwill.

SUMMARY

Whenever you write bad-news messages, whether you are replying to a request or initiating an unsolicited message, you have two choices:

- Indirect organization format 1: Buffer, explanation, decision, positive close
- Indirect organization format 2: Buffer, short explanation, decision, longer explanation, positive close

■ Communication Probe

One study of annual letters to stockholders indicates that positive words occurred more frequently than negative words even when the financial news was bad. This phenomenon is called the "Pollyanna hypothesis," a universal tendency to state news positively more often than negatively. Another study on annual letters to stockholders confirmed that the news was presented positively even in bad financial years. However, choices in the subjects of sentences and in verb structures gave clues regarding the financial well-being of the company. In bad years, subjects were more often inanimate nominal groups, such as "operating results" and "fiscal 1988," whereas in good years, subjects were more often human, such as "we." Passive constructions were used more often in the bad years than in the good. Altogether, current research suggests that a company's external bad-news messages are created to reflect as positively as possible on the personal accomplishments of its management.

Hildebrandt, H. W., & Snyder, R. D. (1981, Winter). The Pollyanna hypothesis in business writing: Initial results, suggestions for research. *Journal of Business Communication*, 18(1), 5-15; Thomas, J. (1996). Discourse in the marketplace: The making of meaning in annual reports. *Journal of Business Communication*. (Forthcoming)

Either approach is workable. Using the direct plan (decision, explanation, positive close) is governed by your understanding of the cultural situation and the relationship between you and your readers.

Your reader is always the most important factor to consider when constructing your bad-news messages, and you should always try to provide some reader benefits. The tone of your message is also crucial in maintaining your reader's goodwill. Many suggested plans for bad-news messages are in the 13 Capsule Checklists on pages 244–247. These checklists review both organizational approaches; they adapt the indirect plan to eight kinds of bad-news messages and suggest choices of either direct or indirect plan on three kinds of announcements.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Refusing a Claim from an International Customer.*** You are the owner of a small but exclusive leather boutique located on Fifth Avenue in New York City. You have just received a letter from Monsieur Jean LeFevre of Cherbourg, France, asking for a replacement of an expensive leather valise or his money back. Included with the letter is a package containing the valise. According to the letter, the valise was damaged on the flight from New York to Paris. The fine leather was scratched across the front; the leather was not torn through, but the mark was ugly and discolored.

According to M. LeFevre, the valise was damaged because the leather had not been properly conditioned during production. Because of the high cost (\$450), he wants a refund or a replacement.

You have examined the valise and determined that it was properly conditioned during production and that the scratch was made by a hard metal object. You cannot know for sure that the damage was done by luggage handlers, but it is possible. The scratch could be repaired by reconditioning the leather, but you do not want to do this without M. LeFevre's permission.

Write a letter to M. LeFevre turning down his request for a refund or a replacement. Explain why you are not liable. Offer to repair the valise, but make sure he understands there is no guarantee of the result.

2. ***Letter to Charge for Mailing a Magazine Overseas.*** For many years, your company has been sending free copies of a glossy magazine, "*Discovery*," to anyone who requested to be on your mailing list. The cost of this publication is about \$3.10 each issue. In an effort to pare expenses, your firm's directors have suggested charging for postage on those magazines sent outside the United States. This number is sizable because you have readers in several European countries, in Hong Kong, and in Africa. Write a pleasant letter explaining the new policy.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. ***Refusing a Claim.*** You are manager of the adjustment and claims department in Apex, a small apparel store with a relatively low volume of busi-

ness. Because of its low volume, it is the store's unwritten policy to grant few refunds and replacements on items returned more than 30 days after purchase.

A customer, Ms. Annette St. John, recently returned a cardigan sweater with which she was dissatisfied. The sweater was blue knit, size 36, and contained a label that indicated that the sweater was "wash and wear but must be washed by hand using a mild detergent." Ms. St. John decided to return the sweater because after she had washed it in her washing machine several times, using the wash-and-wear cycle, the sweater had shrunk. She had no record of when it was purchased because she had misplaced her sales slip. However, she stated that she thought she had bought it about 2 months ago.

The customer argued that the label on the sweater said wash and wear and that the store should be accountable.

Write a letter to Ms. St. John, 4301 Drury Lane, St. Paul MN 55862, refusing the request for a refund or a free replacement on the knit sweater because the instructions said specifically to wash the sweater by hand. You believe the garment was not properly laundered. However, provide some other alternatives in your reply so that Ms. St. John will be inclined to forget about the requested adjustment. You might offer an inducement such as an invitation to a special customer sale or a discount on another purchase.

4. ***Refusing an Adjustment on a Bill.*** You are customer service director for the telephone company in your region. One of the letters you must write today is a refusal to Lars Blint, a student at Central Community College. Here is his letter:

The enclosed bill from you for \$81.90 contains long-distance calls that I won't pay for. Apparently someone in your office got numbers screwed up and charged my account instead of someone else's. I know I made eight of the calls on this bill, but the other two I didn't make. I don't know anyone in those towns, and therefore, I refuse to pay the \$20.75 charges on them.

Your bill says I supposedly made those calls on June 18. Well, that day I'm sure I didn't make any long-distance calls because I was busy planning for the celebration party I had that same night. It was a special event. I didn't see anyone using my phone that night either. Anyway, whoever made the calls should have to pay for them, not me.

Enclosed is my check for \$61.15, which I think is in full payment of what I owe you.

Your operations staff members have thoroughly investigated this claim. Your highly accurate equipment registers every call, whether it is directly dialed or placed through an operator as a collect call. The two calls Mr. Blint questions were placed at 9:35 P.M. and 10:03 P.M., June 18; each was directly dialed; one was 20 minutes long, \$9.60, and the other 25 minutes, \$11.15. The number from which these calls originated is definitely that of

Lars Blint. As every phone book states near the front under “long-distance information and rates,” any calls dialed must be billed to the number from which the call is made. Thus Lars must pay for the entire bill, including the \$20.75 unpaid balance. Can you include one or two helpful suggestions for him? (Perhaps because he knows the date, time, town, length of each call and the cost of each, he could check among his June 18 guests to see who placed the calls.) Your staff even checked all equipment and operations records and found no equipment problems recorded for June 18.

Write Lars Blint, 1852 Seventh Avenue (make up his town and ZIP), a tactful refusal that will keep his goodwill and, you hope, get his full payment before your company has to disconnect his telephone.

- 5. Refusing Credit.** You are the manager of a clothing store located in a small university town in Minnesota. You offer a very good selection of styles for college students and for young professionals. In addition, you offer such services as a 30-day return policy, a lay-away policy, and an in-house charge account. Because of the difficulties in collecting payments from students, you have a policy of not granting university students charge accounts. They are, however, free to use your lay-away plan and your 30-day return policy. Also, you offer regular discounts and free catalogs of your merchandise.

You have just received a letter from a student who has been refused a charge account at your store. He is angry about this policy and wants to know why he shouldn't be an exception to your rule. You might consider his request if he were truly an exceptional case, such as a professional who is returning to school for a limited time but who has a regular income. However, he has not included any information that would help you make that decision.

Write a letter to the student explaining your charge account policy. Decide whether you want to encourage him by asking for some financial information regarding his ability to pay his bills. Be sure to mention the benefits to him offered by your store and try to create goodwill.

- 6. Cutting Off Credit.** Mr. and Mrs. Kevin Deland have been your credit customers at Brown's department store for the 5 years they have lived in your city. Their account shows that average monthly purchases are about \$50, and until 2 years ago, their account was almost always paid on time. During the past 2 years, however, the payments have not been made when due. The account balance is no more than \$500, and no payments have been received for 4 months.

In today's mail was a letter from Mrs. Deland, which said that she had tried to purchase some furniture last week, and the salesclerk told her that the items could not be charged. She left the store in an angry mood, and this letter from her is the result. Among the points mentioned are two that are important: (1) She threatened to take the matter up with the local better business bureau and the local credit bureau, and (2) she said that she would never again purchase anything at your store.

Write to Mrs. Deland and explain why her recent credit purchase was turned down. Remind her, for example, of the current balance in the account and of the credit terms she agreed to when the account was first opened. Point out that neither the better business bureau nor the credit bu-

reau will take any action because your store has broken no laws. Mention anything else that will support your position. You should not resort to threats, but you should encourage immediate payment of the account so that it can be reopened for her future convenience.

You will also want to include, as best you can, some statement of goodwill or a statement concerning her future as a customer of your store. This is not, of course, the time to try to sell her anything, but you can remind her of the quality of your merchandise, the several convenient locations, the customer announcements that go out before sales are open to the public, and similar points. Tact and firmness are important, but so is your effort to regain the Deland family's goodwill.

7. **Rejecting a Job Applicant.** You are the supervisor of the R&D department of a small information technology company. You have received a letter from Jonathon Smart applying for a position with your company. Smart is currently with ABC Computers, for whom you are completing a project. It was Smart's favorable recommendation that got you the contract, and you hope, with Smart's help, to continue to do business with ABC in the future.

Smart's background is impressive with an education from the University of California at Berkeley and 10 years experience in research and development. He is well-known and favorably regarded.

Some discreet inquiries reveal why Smart is eager to leave ABC and why you do not want to hire him. He has an abrasive and difficult personality that keeps him from being effective with higher management and generates resentment from those working under him.

Write Jonathon Smart a letter that firmly closes the door but that, as far as possible, will keep his goodwill.

8. **Rejection Letters.**

Letter A:

Dear Alice:

I wanted to thank you for interviewing with XYZ and wish you the best for your career. If I can be of any assistance to you, feel free to call.

Regards,

Letter B:

Dear Mr. Janison:

Thank you for your recent letter expressing your interest in undergraduate summer employment opportunities with UNOX Capital Markets. Unfortunately, at the present time, no summer positions for undergraduate students are available.

Enclosed you will find our brochures describing the programs we offer for full-time employment for your future reference. Once again, thank you for your interest in UNOX.

Good luck in your job search.

Sincerely,

Letter C:

Dear Mr. Horatus:

It was a pleasure to discuss with you your interest in possible employment opportunities with ABC Company.

As promised, we have reviewed your background and your expressed career objectives in view of our current requirements. In addition, we have carefully compared your attributes with those of other candidates interviewed. Based on this comparative assessment, we have regretfully elected not to extend an offer of employment to you.

Although we can no longer consider you further at this time, we hope you will be successful in obtaining a position.

Sincerely,

9. Bad-News Announcement. You are president of the Central Building Garage, Inc. Your company manages a 400-car garage used by business executives who occupy the Central Building. Because of steadily increasing operating costs (mainly wages), you have found it necessary to increase the monthly parking rates to \$106 a month (instead of the former \$96). This increase will become effective February 1, 199-.

For the past 2 years you have been absorbing the increased operating expenses, but you cannot continue to do so any longer. After several conversations with Mr. P. L. Brown, vice president of Commercial Properties, Inc., the Central Building's owners, who lease to the business firms in the building and from whom you lease your garage facilities, you received permission for the rate increase. Now you must write two letters:

- a. To Mr. Brown, telling him your decision about the monthly rate and effective date. Inform him that you will notify all parking customers before a certain date. You might restate briefly the reason for this increase, refer to previous conversations, and show appreciation. Will you organize by the direct or indirect plan? Why?
- b. To all customers who have been renting monthly parking space from your garage. This increase comes to them as a bad-news surprise. Give

them whatever details you think they will appreciate having. Will you organize the same way as for letter a? Why or why not?

10. Refusal Letter.

Dear Central City Economic Club:

I must refuse your invitation to be the keynote speaker at your upcoming year-end banquet. My schedule is overcrowded with such events, and I find myself unable to accept any others.

I trust you will understand my refusal.

Sincerely,

- 11. Annual Report Project.** Review the first paragraphs of the Managers' Messages of four annual reports. Find reports that reflect both good performance years and bad performance years. Study the differences in language in the paragraphs in the good-news years and the bad-news years, noticing the use of personal pronouns, nonhuman grammatical subjects, and length of paragraphs. Present your findings in a short presentation.

Capsule Checklists for Bad-News Messages*

Bad News		
A	B	C
General Plan (Indirect)	Exception (Direct)	Answering Non-Sales-Related Inquiries When the Information is Unfavorable
1. Buffer a. Agreement b. Appreciation c. Assurance d. Compliment e. Cooperation f. Good news g. Neutral courtesy h. Understanding	1. Main idea a. Bad-news decision, sometimes with a brief buffer and/or reason	1. Buffer <i>For unfavorable recommendations</i> a. Applicant's name; relationship b. Reason for writing; reply by request <i>For other inquiries</i> c. Appreciation d. Assurance e. Understanding
2. Explanation a. Necessary details—general to specific b. Favorable, then unfavorable facts c. RB† reasons d. Emphasis on desired goal	2. Explanation a. Necessary details—general to specific b. Emphasis on desired goal	2. Explanation a. Answers to all questions b. Pertinent facts (favorable and unfavorable) c. Caution on legalities d. Confidentiality e. Offer, phone call
3. Decision—implied or expressed—with resale and/or constructive suggestions a. Embedded statement of bad news—with suggestion of what can be done b. Helpful counterproposal, plans, alternatives c. Resale d. Sales promotion	3. Decision omitted (already in B.1.a). Resale and suggestions often unnecessary and omitted; sometimes: a. Helpful counterproposal, plans, alternatives	3. Decision—with constructive suggestions <i>About applicant</i> a. Honest nonendorsement b. Possibility of changes since you last saw applicant <i>About other non-sales-related inquiries</i> c. Same as A.3.a and b
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. Application b. Invitation to future action c. CSAD‡ d. EA§ and motivation e. DA¶ f. Willingness to help further g. RB† h. Good wishes i. Courtesy	4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close. Sometimes: a. Appreciation b. Invitation to future action c. CSAD‡ d. EA§ and motivation e. DA¶ f. Willingness to help further g. RB† h. Good wishes i. Courtesy	4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. Ray of hope for improvement b. Willingness to help further c. Good wishes

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.

‡CSAD = clear statement of action desired.

†EA = easy action.

§DA = dated action, if desirable.

¶RB = reader benefit.

Capsule Checklists for Bad-News Messages (*Continued*)*

Refusing Credit		
D	E	F
Refusing Adjustments on Claims and Complaints	Retail Credit	Mercantile Credit
1. Buffer a. Agreement b. Appreciation c. Assurance d. Cooperation e. Neutral courtesy f. Understanding g. If granting a part is good news, opening is on that part	1. Buffer a. Agreeable comment b. Appreciation c. Assurance d. Brief resale on product and/or firm e. Incidental reference to the order, if any	1. Buffer a. Agreeable comment b. Appreciation c. Assurance d. Brief resale on product and/or firm e. Incidental reference to the order, if any
2. Explanation a. Logical statement of reasons b. General RB[†] procedure, policy, instructions, guarantee c. Resale interwoven d. Education on use e. Impersonal facts on buyer's mistake	2. Explanation - Choice of a. No reason b. "Insufficient information" reason c. List of all usual reasons d. Specific reason(s): with RB[†] and emphasis on desired goal	2. Explanation a. Specific reasons b. Favorable, then unfavorable, facts c. Emphasis on desired goal
3. Decision—with resale and/or suggestions a. Impersonal, expressed or implied, but clear refusal; positive language, perhaps RB[†] b. Clear indication if you are returning product c. RB[†] suggestion(s) for using rejected product and/or another d. Resale on product, service, and/or firm	3. Decision—with RB [†] counterproposal and suggestion(s) a. Embedded statement of bad news—with suggest of what <i>can</i> be done b. Suggestions (1) Conference (2) Other lenders (3) Future review (4) Other credit plans available (5) Layaway (6) Cash or c.o.d. buying	3. Decision—with RB [†] counterproposal and suggestion(s) a. Embedded statement of bad news—with suggestion of what <i>can</i> be done b. Suggestions (1) Inventory reduction (2) Sales or capital increase (3) Local financing (4) Cash or c.o.d. buying; smaller, frequent orders (5) Help of sales representative (6) Future review
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. CSAD (tactful suggestion without urging)[‡] b. EA[§] and DA[¶] c. Positive forward look d. RB[†] and satisfaction e. Courtesy	4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. Invitation regarding a suggestion; CSAD[‡] b. Forward look c. Resale d. RB[†] and EA[§] e. Courtesy	4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. Invitation regarding a suggestion; CSAD[‡] b. Forward look c. Resale d. RB[†] and EA[§] e. Courtesy

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.

[‡]CSAD = clear statement of action desired.

[†]EA = easy action.

[§]DA = dated action, if desirable.

[¶]RB = reader benefit.

Capsule Checklists for Bad-News Messages (*Continued*)*

Acknowledging Orders You Can't Fill Now or at All

G Incomplete or Vague	H Back Orders	I Substitutions	J Declining Invitations and Requests for Favors
- Good news, if any, and buffer - Shipment details, if sending anything - Buffer: short resale on vaguely described item(s) - Brief order acknowledgment (date, item) - Appreciation - Welcome, if new customer	- Good news, if any, and buffer - Same as G.1.a - Buffer: specific resale or ordered depleted item; no mention of depletion - Brief order acknowledgment (date, item) - Appreciation - Welcome, if new customer	- Goods news, if any, and buffer - Same as G.1.a - Buffer: broad resale embodies both substitute and ordered item; omits differences - Brief order acknowledgment (date, item) - Appreciation - Welcome, if new customer	- Buffer - Appreciation - Compliment (to reader) - Assurance - Agreeable comment
- Explanation - RB[†] reason for requesting missing information - Facts about choices available (sizes, colors, models) - Descriptive enclosures	- Explanation - Approximate date goods expected to reach buyer - Reasons unavailable now (RB?)[†] - Resale	- Explanation - One or two merits of substitute (S) before revealing unavailability of ordered item (O) - Sales point on why we carry S exclusivity	- Explanation - Facts and (sometimes personal) reasons leading to refusal
- Decision—with resale and/or suggestions - See 2.a, above—implied decision - Perhaps brief resale on the item(s) in general	- Decision—with resale and/or constructive suggestions - See 2.a above—implied decision - Possibly mild sales promotion on allied item(s) to be shipped with back-ordered item - Perhaps brief resale on back-ordered item	- Decision—with resale and suggestions - Unavailability of O—in positive terms (exclusively stock S—if true) - Passive statement on where O may be bought - Price and quality justification of substitute; RB[†] - Sales promotion	- Decision—with resale and/or suggestions - Clear, tactful decision, implied or stated; emphasis on the positive aspects (desire to help, etc.) - RB[†] suggestions—when, how you <i>can</i> help - Alternative sources of help to reader
- Positive, friendly, appropriate close - CSAD[‡] - EA[§] - DA[¶] - RB (prompt delivery?)[†] - Courtesy	- Positive, friendly, appropriate close - If shipment in reasonable time: no action; assumption that back order is OK - If longer: CSAD[‡]; EA[§]; DA[¶] - RB[†]	- Positive, friendly, appropriate close - If S is already shipped: assurance of money-back “shipment on approval”; RB[†] - If S is not yet shipped: CSAD[‡]; EA[§]; DA[¶]; RB[†]	- Positive, friendly, appropriate close - CSAD[‡] - EA[§] - DA[¶] - Good wishes - RB[†] - Courtesy

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.

[‡]CSAD = clear statement of action desired.

[†]EA = easy action.

[§]DA = dated action, if desirable.

[¶]RB = reader benefit.

Capsule Checklists for Bad-News Messages (*Continued*)*

K Announcing Bad News About Prices and Services	L Penalizing for Nonconformity to Rules or Procedures	M Conveying Other Bad News
1. Main idea or buffer a. If routine (or reader not emotionally involved), B.1—(direct plan) b. Otherwise, A.1 buffer (1) Agreeable comment (2) Neutral courtesy (3) Brief resale	1. Main idea or buffer a. If routine, urgent, or reader not emotionally involved: bad-news decision, sometimes with reason (direct plan, B.1) b. Otherwise, A.1 buffer (1) Agreeable comment (2) Neutral courtesy (3) Compliment on past (4) Hint of urgency or need for change	1. Main idea or buffer a. Same as L.1.a b. Same as L.1.b
2. Explanation a. RB [†] reasons and analysis of increasing costs, etc.	2. Explanation a. Details about the requirements b. Reasons leading to the penalty	2. Explanation a. Details on what is wrong
3. Decision—with resale and suggestions a. Effective date of new plan b. Clear statement and itemizing, if needed c. Enclosures or examples, if helpful d. Resale on your firm products, services, prices	3. Decision—with resale and suggestions a. Clear, tactful statement of what will happen unless reader meets requirements b. Suggestions for eliminating penalty in future c. Forms and deadlines	3. Decision—with suggestions a. What needs to be done b. How to do it
4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. Forward look b. Resale c. Invitation to action d. CSAD [‡] e. EA [§] f. RB [†] g. Courtesy	4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. CSAD [‡] b. EA [§] c. DA [¶] d. RB [†] e. Assurance f. Good wishes g. Courtesy	4. Positive, friendly, appropriate close a. CSAD [‡] b. EA [§] c. Goodwill d. Courtesy

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.

[‡]CSAD = clear statement of action desired.

[§]EA = easy action.

[¶]DA = dated action, if desirable.

[†]RB = reader benefit.

Persuasive Written Messages

I. Organization of Persuasive Messages

- A. Direct Request Organization
- B. Indirect Request Organization

II. Persuasive Requests

- A. Requests That Require Time or Personal Contributions
- B. Requests About Products or Services
- C. Requests for Claims (Complaints) and Requests for Adjustments
- D. Requests for Changes in Policy
- E. Requests for Changes in Performance
- F. Requests from Employer to a Reference
- G. Requests from Employee to a Reference

III. Persuasive Sales Letters

- A. Suggestions for Writing Solicited Sales Letters
- B. Suggestions for Writing Unsolicited Sales Letters

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

VI. Capsule Checklists for Persuasive Requests

Persuasion has one core purpose: Get your reader to support, believe, and act in your favor.

Persuasion played only a minimal role in the issues discussed in preceding chapters, but many situations call for well-thought-out persuasive writing, the focus of this chapter. Many times you want your readers to do something: You wish them to act, to accept a point of view, to follow your wishes, to respond, to change, or to not change. In short, you desire a response from your message receiver.

It makes little difference how persuasive messages are classified. For ease of discussion, here we briefly review two common strategies of organization for persuasive requests, discuss seven kinds of routine persuasive messages, and summarize the persuasion techniques needed in solicited and unsolicited sales letters. The chapter concludes with three detailed checklists: general persuasive requests, favors, and other persuasive requests.

ORGANIZATION OF PERSUASIVE MESSAGES

Direct Request Organization

For the routine, more personal request, use the direct-request format. There is no need to keep the reader in suspense. This direct-request (deductive) approach has three parts:

1. **Main idea**—Your request or question, statement, and reason
2. **Explanation**—Evidence and details needed in order that your reader can respond precisely
3. **Courteous close**—Politely asking for whatever action is desired

Routine personal requests can use immediate, up-front statements of the main idea.

Of the two methods of organization—direct and indirect—the direct approach is easier: You state your request up front, explain why you need a favorable response, and end with a courteous close. Several of the seven routine persuasive examples that follow our indirect request discussion are of the direct request type.

Indirect Request Organization

Situations that are more complex, more difficult, a bit out of the ordinary are not routine; they take more effort. In fact, the favor you ask may precipitate some objection; you will have to supply evidence and data to support your request. Therefore, nonroutine persuasive requests—like the bad-news letter—most often use the indirect approach.

1. **Explanation**—Buffer opening
2. **Main idea**—The core of your request, your concern
3. **Courtesy close**—Polite ending with last request for action

Indirect requests (main message not up front) mean the writer must first get the reader's attention.

Your assumption in using the indirect approach is that if your request were stated directly at the beginning, it would be unwanted or undesirable news to your reader, who then might react unfavorably. Instead, prepare the reader and

offer facts suggesting that your proposal is beneficial or useful. Remember: Your reader often is not expecting your message.

Persuasive letters or memorandums usually have four parts, often referred to as the AIDA formula for sales presentations:

- A—Attract the reader's *attention*.
- I—Arouse the reader's *interest*.
- D—Create *desire* and convince the reader.
- A—State clearly the *action* the reader needs to take.

Do not worry about the order of the AIDA structure: It is more important to be aware of the rationale behind the various parts.

Although *attention*, *interest*, *desire*, and *action* are listed here as distinct steps, they are usually combined or blended smoothly into your persuasive message. Do not worry so much about the precise order; do focus on giving thought to the principles in each of the sections.

In fact, the persuasive-request plan may also be referred to as the four P's: promise, picture, prove, and push. We also include (within parentheses) other terms for the parts in the following discussion.

1. Attention: First Paragraph (Promise, Start)

Begin by getting reader attention. You are really answering the reader's question of "What's in it for me?" Search for a point that is close to the reader's interests or needs. Avoid speaking of yourself and your organization.

Open with Agreeable Comment or Assertion

To encourage someone to run for office:

Few persons realize the need for improved leadership. Over the years your comments have been read with interest and support.

■ Communication Probe

Much writing is impersonal and objective. At times such writing is desirable, as in technical manuals or impersonal descriptions on how to operate machinery. But because much business writing is persuasive, it must project a personal "voice." Here the reader must be kept precisely in mind; here he or she must be made to feel that behind the writing is a human being, that a live, interested person is sending the message. Thus in seller/buyer relationships this "voice" seeks to give the buyer a sense of trust. Interestingly, this trust is established, according to one author, through the personal "voice" of the writer/seller in the message.

Corbett, E. (1989). What classical rhetoric has to offer the teacher and the student of business and professional writing. In M. Kogen (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 65–72). Urbana, IL: National Council of the Teachers of English.

To ask for a change in grade:

Fairness was a term all of us learned during the last semester. I have tried to practice it daily

Open with Sincere Compliment

To ask someone to speak, without a fee, to a local group:

With pleasure our members read a review of your recent speech before our local Rotary Club. Even that short review raised our desire to have you speak to our [name of club].

To ask someone to speak, without a fee, but using a sense of humor:

I know you believe in free speech; how would you like to give one for that amount?

Open with Direct Request for a Favor

To complete a questionnaire:

One Dollar

Yours to Keep

We need your input. Our enclosed questionnaire will take about five minutes of your time. We're sincere in sending along a small sum to cover that time.

To become a member of a task force:

John, we need your advice. You've been a member of this community for over 30 years. With that opening you can guess at my request for your joining us for the [name] committee.

Open with a Question

To join an exercise group:

Have you read the company's latest health letter? Did you note the benefits of exercise, even for those under 30? Sixteen of us are getting together three times a week in our fitness room. We'd like to have you join us.

To look at an enclosed folder:

How many people have in place a retirement plan? Do you have such a plan? Studies suggest that less than 25% have consulted a retirement adviser. With our company's average age of 48, there are some of us who feel the enclosed information can be useful.

2. Interest and Desire: Middle Paragraphs (Picture, Chain)

Build upon the theme stated in the attention-getting opening; begin to think about creating interest and desire in the reader. Suggest what your project, product, or service is and what it will do for the reader. Consider doing two things:

- *Describe its physical characteristics*—important features, construction, appearance, performance, beauty, functions.
- *Relate its value or benefits to the reader*—For instance, will your request bring comfort? Entertainment? Safety? Health? Recognition? Financial rewards? Show the reader how your proposal gives one or more benefits such as the following:

Appreciation (by others)	Pleasure
Approval (by others)	Popularity
Beauty or attractiveness	Position of authority
Cleanliness	Prestige
Comfort	Pride
Convenience	Profits
Cooperation	Protection for family,
Customer satisfaction	business, self, or others
Distinctiveness	Provision for the future
Durability	Recognition
Efficiency	Reduced work
Enjoyment	Relief from fear
Entertainment	Respect
Extra earnings	Safety and security
Fair treatment	Satisfaction of helping
Friendships	others (altruism)
Good reputation	Savings
Health	Self-preservation
Improvement	Solution to a problem
Love of home, family, others	Success
Money and other valuables	Thrift habit
Peace of mind	Usefulness

Evidence is the rational part of persuasion; unsparingly use those supports as part of your persuasive strategy.

Clearly, you need proof, evidence, or data to go along with the benefits noted above. Use examples, quotations, comparisons, statistics, tests, samples, guarantees, or similar information to support your position. Give evidence that your statements are true, reliable, and accepted by others.

Physical Characteristics and Value of Project

To get someone to try a product:

For the past two years our foot pedal has been under review: we placed it in university facilities, local hospitals, and two locations overseas. Data on those positive results (wear and tear, maintenance costs, customer satisfaction) are included in the following table. Our most important

conclusion is this: 78% of the users rated the product as "very satisfactory." We'd like you to try our new foot pedal over the next 30 days.

To request funds for a summer camp:

Character building, friendship, lifelong friends, and fun are the main values we associated with our summer camp. Over 150 young people join us each summer. Many return for a second year. And as you might expect, the tuition we charge the families of those young people does not cover the costs. We need your help.

Direct and Indirect Reader Benefits

Search out both direct and indirect personal benefits for readers to help your persuasion.

Interest and desire in the reader are generated when you show the direct or indirect benefits of agreeing with your position. Again, it makes little difference whether you call the positive results direct or indirect. What does matter is that you show, as vividly as possible, benefits to your reader.

To show direct benefits (direct impact):

- Company name will be included in the program bulletin.
- Favorable publicity to individual will occur.
- Goodwill for company will result from our working together.
- Improvements will occur in our community.
- Personal benefits will occur to individual directly.
- And many others.

To show indirect benefits (indirect impact):

- Future contacts with members are a possibility.
- Potential is present for additional sales.
- Exposure will help for future political offices.
- Happiness will be brought to other persons.
- Sense of loyalty will be strengthened.
- And many others.

3. Action: Last Paragraph (Push, Hook)

If your presentation thus far has engaged your reader's attention, arousing interest and desire, then now is the time to request action. You need not feel embarrassed to ask for your reader's acceptance; most readers know a final request is coming. Make that action clear, easy, and dated, if necessary.

To get someone to send a financial gift:

The AIDA formula may be used when asking for financial assistance.

So what can you do? We hope you'll sit down and send us a check as the year comes to an end. The benefits will be immediate: to the children and to all of us interested in giving guidance to young people.

■ Communication Probe

Both technical and mechanical changes influence writing. Take for example the rather simple process of storing documents in the vertical file, begun in the latter part of the nineteenth century. Then came carbon copies, multiple copies, and even some suggestions for writing and keeping records. What is the implication? One scholar suggests that our current electronic mail systems affect not only storage of documents, but also their structure, content, and style. She avers that we are already becoming more informal in writing. There may be a trend in business writing toward briefer and less formal communication.

Yates, J. (1985). From press book to pigeonhole to vertical filing: Revolution in storage and access systems for correspondence. In G. Douglas & H. Hildebrandt (eds.), *Studies in the history of business writing* (pp. 145–163). Urbana, IL: Association for Business Communication.

To renew a subscription to a book club:

Because you're a former subscriber, and if you act within the next three weeks, we'll do this: offer you a free book plus send you our classical book-club selections each quarter. We sincerely hope you'll accept our offer.

PERSUASIVE REQUESTS

Now that we have discussed the two main organizational patterns for persuasive written messages, let's apply the two organizational patterns to seven more common, routine kinds of persuasive writing. Although there are more than these seven, these illustrations are applicable to other kinds of routine persuasive writing as well.

Requests That Require Time or Personal Contributions

When you approach an individual to do something or contribute funds, you are asking that they give up some of their time or money, or both. And the basis for your request is that your receivers do possess knowledge of certain topics or are capable of giving both mental and physical effort to your cause. Here are two examples.

MESSAGE 1 *Letter of invitation for speaker to address convocation.*

Direct request (attention)

By unanimous vote, the Directors have asked that I write you to be our convocation speaker on May 7, 199-. That convocation is for our 800 students who have

achieved high distinction in their studies at our university.

Background

Two young students, who sit on our planning committee, placed your name in nomination with full support of the university's student council. Thus you were our only nominee to be the convocation speaker on May 7, 199-.

Persuasive details (interest desire)

We are fully aware of your busy schedule. However, your recent book on the issue of urban environmental problems could serve as the basis for a timely statement on our campus. As you vividly state in your book, you feel the concerns of the environment will have to be carried forward by the young people of the future. Our convocation and dinner that evening of young people and university faculty would provide both a formal and informal setting for your remarks.

Details

We are prepared to cover all travel and hotel costs while on campus. I personally will pick you up at the airport.

Easy action (action)

Please let us know by February 1, 199-, your decision on giving the convocation lecture. I will then be in contact with you concerning other details.

With sincerity we look forward to your positive response.

MESSAGE 2 *Letter asking for donation of money or other tangible valuables.*

Many people are reluctant to part with material goods. Thus, all that you have learned about persuasion, data and evidence, and reader benefits must be brought to bear when requesting financial help. Note the various appeals and the AIDA plan used by the company vice president addressed to all members of the corporation.

TO: All employees of Starbright
FROM: Carol Schmidt, VP Human Resources
SUBJECT: Yearly appeal for the local United Fund
DATE: September 25, 199-

Attention

Our recent newspaper articles leave little doubt about the needs of our community. In fact, volunteer organizations, along with our churches and synagogues, are already making their own contributions of time and money.

Interest

Because we are one of the larger employers in this community, more is expected of us. We

Desire

did well last year: we made our goal of 100% of the employees contributing to the UF. Each of us sets the figure our conscience dictates, but I sincerely hope that you could increase your contribution this year. Our company goal is \$134,000.

Action

Please return the enclosed pledge card indicating the amount of your contribution for this year. Your support is needed this year more than ever. I personally thank you in advance for your gift and wish you well in your daily work in our company.

Requests About Products or Services

Products or services are among the most common forms of persuasive requests.

As a consumer or as a business or professional person, you will have occasions to seek a response from your reader. As a seller you are interested in promoting your product or services; as a consumer you are interested in making sure those products and services meet basic requirements.

Persuasively Requesting Purchase of Product

Notes to customers who have not used your services or brought your product for a period of time can also be organized in the direct request pattern. These notes are called miss-you messages.

Catalog firms, especially, send reminders to customers who have not ordered their merchandise for a long time. So do book clubs. Even auto dealers send reminders that it is time for a car tune-up or perhaps time to consider a new vehicle.

REQUEST 1 *Miss-you letter from a catalog firm.*

Attention

Our order department has not heard from you for a long time.

Desire

And that troubles us. We know many other catalogs also come to your home. But as you know, for over 10 years you have been a desirable customer. We appreciate the trust you've put in us.

Easy action

If there is anything about our products or services you are dissatisfied with, we would like to know. Please drop us a note—why not write directly on the order form which is in the enclosed catalogue—and let us know how to serve you better.

When writing persuasive notes to employees, be aware of the legal implications of your message. Choose your words carefully.

Persuasively Requesting Information from Seller

All receivers of a request for further business or some kind of involvement should be eager to reply. Strange as it may seem, some sellers are late in re-

sponding or do not respond at all. Such a request—even via the Internet—can be simple. “Please send me your most recent catalog so that I can place an order.” “I’m considering attending the evening program of your school; please send me your undergraduate catalogue.” Here is a more detailed request:

REQUEST 2 *Reaction to a news story in a local newspaper.*

Direct request My family and I have searched for an exercise bike for my invalid mother. The story in the Mind and Body section of [local newspaper, date, and page] suggests your product might work well for us. All we saw was a picture of your Exercise Bike. Therefore, we need a little more information.

1. Which institutions now use your bike?
2. Can a partial invalid get on and off the bike alone?
3. Does the bike come assembled?
4. What guarantee do you offer?
5. What is the cost of the product?

Easy action Probably some of the above questions are answered in a brochure; I would be pleased to receive your responses within the next two weeks.

Persuasively Requesting Internal Employee Action

Because “quality management” is extensively used today, companies are deeply concerned about how to improve their relationships with employees and customers. Persuasion is needed to convince the reader that the information requested is necessary and worthwhile.

REQUEST 3 *Memo seeking feedback on computer hardware.*

TO: All employees
 FROM: Manager, Systems Division
 SUBJECT: Request for your views concerning computer hardware

Background For the past two months a committee has researched, tested, and evaluated various computers. Our single goal was to arrive at a recommendation as to which product would benefit all of us the most.

Easy action We now need your input. Attached is a list of the five computers we have evaluated: the attached sheet lists both their strengths and weaknesses. In order to get a tally of your preferences, we ask that you complete the brief evaluation form and return it, anonymously, to your supervisor by September 17, 1999.

Requests for Claims (Complaints) and Requests for Adjustments

All agree: Never write a letter in the heat of anger.

Unhappy customers—those dissatisfied with a product, service, or policy—are often quick to request a correction. Often such communication is written in the heat of anger. But we recommend a more temperate approach. Remember, most companies wish to please customers.

Persuasively Requesting an Adjustment

REQUEST 4 *A customer approaches a local savings and loan requesting a financial adjustment.*

Attention

Thirty-six years. That's the amount of time I have enjoyed a working relationship with your organization. In fact, both of my children also have accounts with you. We've been pleased over the years. But something happened last month that I'd like to call to your attention.

Supporting data

On November 16, 1991, I called your loan office and asked what the final payment on my loan would be if I were to pay it off entirely. Ms. Hicks said it would take an hour or so to arrive at the precise figure and would call me back.

[Here would appear a two-paragraph summary on the financial data such as interest charges, administrative help, and other matters Ms. Hicks orally reported previously.]

Supporting data

On November 18, 1991, I sent you the amount requested to completely pay off my loan. On December 8, 1991, I received a statement that indicated I still owed \$27 for interest charges.

My intention is not to pay those charges inasmuch as the final figure given me on November 16, 1991, was carefully examined by Ms. Hicks; she assured me her figures were correct.

Easy action

I would appreciate a response to this note and an interpretation for those additional charges of \$27.

REQUEST 5 *Request for a refund or an exchange.*

Attention

For the last 12 years we have purchased many of our Christmas clothing gifts from your catalogue. They have been reliable, have worn well, and have consistently met our standards for excellence.

■ Communication Probe

One of the classic theories of communication was developed by Stephen Toulmin. It later developed into analytical measures applicable to managerial communication. Toulmin's theory—expressed in his model—suggests that claims (also called declarations, assertions, positions, resolutions, propositions, affirmations) are of three types: fact, value, or policy. Oversimplified, he suggests that (1) message senders begin with a claim. In turn this claim is supported with (2) data (evidence such as examples, statistics, credible sources, comparisons, and so forth). Last, he proposes that message senders use (3) a warrant, explanations that imply a relationship between the data and the claim via general beliefs expressed in phrases as “because of” or “since” or “given that.” A result of such a process, suggests Toulmin, is that message receivers can be persuaded. Application of this model to managerial persuasion suggests that business messages can be evaluated for their potential effectiveness.

Rogers, P. (1994). Analytic measures for evaluating managerial writing. *The Journal of Business and Technical Writing*, 8(4), 380–407; Toulmin, S. (1958). *The uses of argument*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Details

Over the phone, on November 6, 1997, I placed an order for your traditional calf-high hunting boots. There were in green in size 9. The size I received on December 1, 1997, was size 8.

Easy action

Within this express package I have enclosed the wrong-size boots. Please send me the correct size 9 as I requested, in the same color and with the same soles. If this is not possible within two weeks, I request a refund of \$56.

Persuasively Requesting Credit

Money matters often demand your exposing some personal and confidential information.

Many credit applications are handled routinely. However, on some occasions you may seek a special credit privilege requiring you to persuade the lending institution for variances from their regular pattern. You will need to convince the financial institution that you are dependable and reliable.

Sometimes applicants' requests for credit are turned down. If you are one of those persons, you would like to know why.

REQUEST 6 A request for credit after an initial turndown.

Attention

My mailbox continues to be filled with letters from organizations that wish me to use their credit card. In fact, that is the way I received your initial invitation to use your card and services.

Aim	However, your form letter of March 7, 199-, refused me a Revolving Credit account. Certainly I was unhappy with that decision and request a further explanation. To assist you in coming to a positive conclusion I have included additional information.
Supporting details	[Information about employer, years of service, salary.] [Assets and liabilities as printed on computer form.] [Names of references who could be contacted.]
Easy action	Be assured that my payments would occur promptly. That is the method I use with my other credit card. Your card allows me to use it abroad, where I spend several months of the year. With pleasure, I look forward to a favorable decision.

Requests for Changes in Policy

Effecting change in a policy can take considerable time. Be prepared with logical and organized evidence.

Besides requesting nonroutine adjustments for credit, at times you may need to persuade a company to make other exceptions to its usual policy. Or you may wish to persuade individuals to change their actions, or to give employees a pep talk, hoping to improve their future performance.

Here you request a change from an established pattern; you try to seek a variation from an established policy.

REQUEST 7 *An employee's persuasive request to allow more choices for retirement funds.*

Direct request	For many years our company has successfully allowed its employees to invest in two funds: the Strategic Bond and the Strategic Stock Funds. I feel it is time to allow us more options.
Organized data	First, three other companies in the area now allow investments in Fidelity, The China Fund, the Europe Fund, and others. A comparison of the rate of return from those funds surpasses what we have received this past year. Second, we have grown considerably in the number of employees from when the plan was first started. There is no doubt in my mind that the company would increase morale if employees were given another investment choice.
Recommendation	In the interest of continuing our cordial relations between management and employee, I respectfully suggest action al-

lowing us more investment options for our retirement funds.

REQUEST 8 *A traveler's request to a hotel for a lower prepayment.*

Attention

For 18 years I have stayed at your hotel during my visits to Vienna. And during that time your location on the Ringstrasse allowed me the privilege of either walking or taking the street car to the Opera or the outdoor concerts in Staatpark. In short, you can see that I was pleased with my visits to your hotel.

Aim

I would like to continue doing so. But your policy of demanding a prepayment of \$500 in advance seems excessive and unnecessary.

Organized details

First, I have certainly established a reputation for paying my bills on time. At no time was I in arrears or late in my payments.

Second, my company has been approached by another nearby Vienna hotel with a tempting offer that does not include the prepayment feature.

You have in the past explained your policy to me, and I understand that. But I can assure you—and for all the other persons with whom I work in my company—that they prefer your hotel. The one hindrance is your requirement of the rather large prepayment amount.

Courteous close

I sincerely hope you can make an adjustment in your policy.

Requests for Changes in Performance

In personal matters, it is a positive idea to follow an oral discussion with a written summary of that discussion.

Persuasion is needed when you need to convince individuals to change their performance. Requested changes could include personal appearance, habits annoying to others, or even business practices. Elaborate monitoring scales and measures of individual performance are increasingly common. But following most oral evaluations, a written letter or memorandum summarizes the situation and also creates a paper trail. When writing such a note, Checklist 10.1 will help you avoid some common faults.

REQUEST 9 *A summary statement sent to an employee after a formal oral evaluation.*

Common agreement

Our visit of a week ago cleared up, I think, some of the misunderstandings re-

■ Checklist 10.1 Avoiding Negative Words in a Performance Letter

1. Watch overuse of negative terms: “disturbed,” “agitated,” “stupid,” “misinformed,” “horrified,” “senseless,” “punishing,” “destroying,” and others.
2. Avoid overuse of “I” and “we.”
3. Go slowly and avoid a domineering attitude.
4. Omit threats to the message receiver.

garding your work effort. As you and I both agreed, we will meet with more regularity to avoid future misunderstandings.

Summary and details

Let me summarize our agreements, open to your amendments after receiving this note:

- To limit the number of personal phone calls per day to two
- To avoid bypassing the supervisors in the shipping section
- To begin evening business classes at our local school

These three items appear to be where major improvements must occur. Please let me know whether the above three points parallel your understanding or whether they are unclear.

Courteous close

I look forward to an improved working relationship.

Requests from Employer to a Reference

Employers desire feedback, often in written form, from individuals who know something about a prospective employee. Keep in mind that the receiver of your message may have no desire to respond. You must persuade your reader to react. A series of questions often can be the basis for your request to a reference.

1. Be specific. It is better to include too much information in your request than a general, incomplete inquiry.
2. Word your questions in a neutral way; avoid influencing the answer.
3. Number your questions and use a separate paragraph for each one.

4. Phrase the question to go beyond a simple “yes” or “no” response. If you have a questionnaire, it is acceptable to include “yes” or “no” responses.
5. Use a rating scale if you ask for an evaluation of a person, product, or service.

You can also enclose, as do many schools and universities, specific criteria to which the reference gives a numerical value, as in the following:

Please check (1 to 5, high to low) each of the following criteria. If you feel you have no opinion, please use DK (don't know).

	1	2	3	4	5
Gets along with others					
Oral communication ability					
Written communication ability					
Ability to solve problems					
Thorough in his or her work					

REFERENCE *Employer personal request concerning a job applicant.*

EXAMPLE 1 *[In this example and others, we have omitted the introductory parts of the letter.]*

Your name was given to me by Ms. Sadie Barron, who is applying for the position of Account Manager in our firm.

We are looking for a young person to handle our European accounts who has a good command of English as well as a working knowledge of at least one foreign language, preferably German. To arrive at a final decision for the position, I would appreciate your responses to the following questions:

1. How long was she in your employ, and for what reason did she leave?
2. How was she received by other members of her work group?
3. Is her German competence adequate for either speaking or writing?
4. Are there any problems you foresee if she is asked to spend considerable time in Germany?

Please include any other information you feel is needed in our evaluation of Ms. Barron.

Your response will be treated confidentially. Our selection committee would appreciate a response within the next two weeks.

Requests from Employee to a Reference

Your teachers are prime candidates for writing reference letters; your authors as teachers firmly suggest: Give them background information.

Who are desirable references? To whom would you, as an employee or a student, turn for an evaluation letter? Most likely your teacher(s) would be your first choice, followed by supervisors in your current position, professional friends, religious leaders, and many others who you feel can evaluate you successfully. Some persons may not want to write a letter on your behalf; your task is to persuade them to do so.

Assume you will ask a former or current teacher for a letter of recommendation. First check to see if the teacher (or other reference for that matter) is willing to provide information. Then—either in person or in writing—do the following:

1. State why you are communicating and what the recommendation is for.
2. Include some summary information about yourself; you need to refresh the referent's memory. For example:
 - a. Courses studied; class with the teacher
 - b. Grades in major and minor area
 - c. Positions held and companies worked for
 - d. Examples of leadership qualities

■ Communication Probe

There exist many kinds of writing genres; some are audience-specific, others applicable to just about anybody. Much business writing is persuasive and specific. Indeed, in many business messages persuasion is the core purpose. Thus a primary difference between business and some other writing genres is the preeminent importance of adapting the message to the reader. It is the reader, the member of the audience, who determines the format, the content, the organization, and the tone. Assessing the audience of a business message, whether internal or external, demands great skill and sensitivity on the part of the writer. The result is that persuasive writing is demanding, especially when asking someone to do something for you. A business writer must know the basic fundamentals of writing and have experience in writing those business messages. Both components assist business writers in feeling comfortable about writing in the business genre.

Corbett, E. (1989). What classical rhetoric has to offer the teacher and the student of business and professional writing. In M. Kogen (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 65–72). Urbana, IL: National Council of the Teachers of English.

- e. Activities outside the workplace
- f. Goals and objectives for your future

Your closing should state to whom the letter or form is to be sent, along with the due date. Many organizations often include preprinted envelopes and ask for the referent's signature directly over the flap of the envelope. Above all, be courteous in your request to a reference; he or she must be persuaded to write a letter of support on your behalf.

REFERENCE

EXAMPLE 2

405 N. State St.
[City, State, Zip]
November 29, 199-

Professor Carl Renny
3260 Rumley Hall
State University
[City, State, Zip]

Dear Professor Renny:

Introduction

In the final weeks of the term, you said you would be pleased to write a letter of support for your students. This note thus asks for a letter of recommendation to the Rapid Motor Company, where I am applying for the position of Buyer.

Body (background)

Three years ago you were management professor for the course LHC 560. My grade in that course was a low B. Since completing that course and my other college work, I have worked as a Purchasing Agent for the Technical Supply Co. There I handled all the accounts that had yearly business with us of at least \$1 million. My supervisor was pleased with my work. In fact, he is writing a letter on my behalf to the Rapid Motor Company.

My reason for leaving the Technical Supply Company is that advancement opportunities at the moment are limited. Thus I have submitted my application for a senior Buyer position at Rapid Motor Company.

Action request

Enclosed with this note is a formal evaluation form, along with an envelope addressed to the Senior Buyer. Professor Renny, I value your comments. Would you please complete the brief enclosed form

along with a brief reference letter. I appreciate your sending that information before the deadline of December 19, 199-.

Sincerely,

Randy Gutfleish

Enclosure

PERSUASIVE SALES LETTERS

The two kinds of sales letters are *solicited* (the organization is invited to respond to sales messages) and *unsolicited* (the organization sends out an uninvited message to sell a product or service). Here we focus briefly on the former and in depth on the latter.

Suggestions for Writing Solicited Sales Letters

Responses to solicited sales letters begin, if possible, with good news.

With solicited letters, the organization has one central goal: to get responses quickly to someone's request for information. Checklist 10.2 is a basic format for the solicited letter; also see the capsule checklists at the end of the chapter.

EXAMPLE 1 *A solicited response letter from a foreign subsidiary.*

Positive opening

With pleasure we received your letter. And it is with further pleasure that we are able to open a foreign account with our Singapore bank. All the necessary forms to initiate that account are included with this letter.

Response to questions

You requested further information concerning our ability to purchase stocks for your account, arrange international loans, and oversee the handling of your payroll. All these activities can be handled through our international banking section. Unfortunately, we are unable at this time to purchase local stocks; that can only be done through your account executive in the States. As you know, the large share offering of Singapore Telecom stock for foreign investors was handled in this manner. Often a foreign investor must also pay a premium above the local stock offering price.

Benefit to reader

Please accept this note as an initial response to your letter. You will be interested to know that our bank already has over 130 American firms doing business with us. It would be our pleasure

Easy action

■ Checklist 10.2 Responding to Solicited Letters

1. Opening paragraph [Use the good-news approach.]
 - a. Answer the inquirer's questions favorably.
 - b. Indicate that the requested material will be sent.
2. Body
 - a. Answer additional questions.
 - b. Provide educational, resale, or sales promotion information.
 - c. Be truthful about negative information.
 - d. Arrange your answers so your positive responses are at the beginning and the end; embed (put in the middle) your weaker or negative comments.
3. Action ending
 - a. Make the action easy.
 - b. Suggest benefits to reader.
 - c. Focus on the positive.

to work with you as well. When you have completed the enclosed forms, please return them and we will begin establishing your account. If you have further questions, our fax number is 82 123456 or you can call me directly at 82 567890.

Suggestions for Writing Unsolicited Sales Letters

Composing unsolicited sales letters is often a team effort of several different functioning areas within an organization.

“Cold turkey,” “over the transom,” or “prospecting” are terms connected to letters initiated by the seller and sent to potential customers. Your mailbox is filled with these kinds of letters. Resistance is often strong. Thus writing unsolicited letters demands superior writing skills. Often you will work in conjunction with a marketing department or even an ad agency; they will make recommendations about the mailing lists, the timing, the core theme, and the visual presentation of brochures and accompanying material.

Your task—even before beginning to write—is to be firmly in control of the following issues:

- Know the central selling point: Decide if the purpose is to (1) make a direct sale, (2) stimulate a future sale, or (3) win back lost customers.
- Understand whether the audience is general (thousands) or a small niche (specifically selected).
- Know every detail about your product or service.
- Be aware of the enclosures and timing.
- Give thought to the length of your letter.

The basic guide for the organization of your sales letter is the AIDA formula: *attention, interest, desire, action*. Although the following discussion focuses separately on each part of the AIDA plan, the parts need not always be in sequence, nor need all parts be in every letter. Creativity—foremost in the eyes of marketing departments—should govern the direction of your letter.

Attract Your Prospect's Attention

Realize this: You have only a few seconds to catch your reader's attention. Consequently, one principle shouts loudly: Keep the opening short. Short paragraphs look easy to read and might encourage the reader to continue. Here are possible beginnings:

Opening Techniques

Comparison or story

Event in reader's life

Rhetorical question

Enclosed gift

Product fact

Surprise question

Challenge statement

Illustration

Your neighbor may already own one. No wonder she's getting all those favorable comments. [*appeal to women considering buying a new small car*]

A graduate! Congratulations! Your success automatically permits a low-cost insurance rate. [*appeal to recent college graduate*] What's the main characteristic of leaders today? [*appeal to reader's ego and sale of leadership seminar*]

It's a screen saver! [*appeal to complete a questionnaire and establish a mailing list*]

More than 12,000 subscribers. One of the largest in the U.S. [*appeal to reader to subscribe to periodical*]

New landscaping! How does a year to pay sound? [*appeal to landscape a yard at favorable payment terms*]

Alaska! Hawaii! Tokyo! Yours, when you return the enclosed lottery number. [*appeal to join a travel group*]

Clichés are a turnoff; avoid them.

Of course, there are many other ways to get attention. But avoid time-worn and cliché openings, keep away from exaggerations unsupported by truth, and certainly avoid any falsehoods for which you could be legally liable.

Arouse Your Reader's Interest and Desire

Now you “picture” your product and tell the readers what your product or service will do for them. You develop your central theme, your core selling point. You place great emphasis on the reader and what your product will do for him or her. At the same time, you are interested in creating a desire, pointing out the positive features of the product or service.

EXAMPLE 2 *Stating benefits of early landscape planning.*

Two of our customers last year were the top two winners in our local "Outstanding Yard" contest. In addition, they also gained special care in root fertilizing of trees and spring pruning. You too could enjoy those benefits.

Our offer for new customers is this: We'll omit all charges for root feeding and pruning for one year. All you need do is work with us in designing a new look for your yard . . .

EXAMPLE 3 *Interweaving benefits with a physical description.*

Sixteen holiday scenes for use with your PC. At this time of the year your computer screen can be as colorful as the decorations in other parts of your home. These winter scenes not only give you a pleasant visual effect, but save your computer screen.

All you need is Windows 3.1 or later, and 4 MB of memory.

Return the enclosed card and the Holiday Scenes will be yours by return mail.

EXAMPLE 4 *Convincing readers through others' satisfied experience.*

Thirty-two names appear on the attached sheet. Each one was willing to let us use their name as a satisfied customer.

As you go through the list note that they come from all sections of our town . . .

EXAMPLE 5 *Persuading readers through noting experts, authoritative agencies.*

Seals of approval have come from such diverse groups as the Academy of Family Physicians, the American Medical Association, and the Association for Better Health. Such support is not given lightly, nor readily.

Receiving their support is an early guarantee that our medical services to you will be ethical, honest, and caring.

EXAMPLE 6 *Convincing readers through free trial.*

You've got two weeks to use these clip-on sun glasses. Try them while walking, jogging, driving, and the other things you do. At our risk.

If for some reason—any reason—you're not satisfied, send them back within 10 days. What could be fairer?

EXAMPLE 7 *Convincing readers through a guarantee.*

Your money back in three weeks if you're not satisfied!

To be honest, only 4 percent of our customers have returned our product. That enviable record tells you we're here to serve you—and thousands of others.

The preceding examples are some of the more common methods of interesting and convincing the reader; here is an additional list of persuasive approaches:

- Develop central selling point and list of benefits.
- Include testimonials of satisfied users.
- Include samples of the product.
- Make payments simple to do and understand.
- Suggest how features affect your readers' time, money, health, family.

Induce Reader Action

Action endings should be clear; placing benefits at the end is acceptable.

Leave your specific action request until the end. Surely your readers will know your intent—they are not dense—but it is still up to you to make the final action easy. Remember these five points:

- State clearly the action you desire.
- Make the action easy.
- Date the action (when desirable).
- Offer inducements to act by a specific time (when desirable).
- End with one final reader-benefit plug (when appropriate).

To induce the reader to act within a certain time, you can use one or more of the following methods.

■ Communication Probe

A thoughtful statement on preparing written material for readers appears in a journal directed toward insurance practitioners. Therein the anonymous author asks whether our documentation of data, in support of a product or service, should be changed. The argument is made that we must review how we now transfer information, perhaps turning to this concept: Humans most efficiently absorb information via pictures, sound, organization, color, and intuition. Should the written word be used less in transmitting information? The author's response is that we give more effort to interactive video and oral presentation. This concept is worth thinking about.

(1995, February). Technology is changing . . . shouldn't documentation change too? *Insurance & Technology*, 30–31.

■ Communication Probe

This probe is different from previous probes used in this text: It is a collection of pithy statements that capture thoughts relevant to persuasion; they are well worth remembering when persuading:

- My idea of an agreeable person is one who agrees with me. *Samuel Johnson.*
- A soft answer turns away wrath. *Proverbs 15:1.*
- Think as wise men do, but speak as the common people do. *Aristotle.*
- The more you say, the less people remember. *Anatole France.*
- Men govern with words. *Benjamin Disraeli.*
- The greatest problem in communication is the illusion that it has been accomplished. *George Bernard Shaw.*
- Getting the facts is only half the job; the other half is to use them intelligently. *Unknown author.*
- Nothing astonishes persons so much as common sense and plain dealing. *Ralph Waldo Emerson.*
- The worse the news, the more effort should go into communicating it. *Andrew S. Grove.*
- Many a good idea has been smothered to death by words. *Unknown author.*
- If I had eight hours to chop down a tree, I'd spend six sharpening my ax. *Abraham Lincoln.*
- One of the best ways to persuade others is by listening to them. *Dean Rusk.*

EXAMPLE 8 *Credit cards.*

For the moment don't send any money. We know your credit card has been approved. Just sign the enclosed order form and we'll bill your credit card directly. Please fill in completely your credit card number and expiration date.

EXAMPLE 9 *Easy payments.*

Your family can enjoy filtered air in time for the holidays. Here's our deal: Send us a down payment of \$50 and we'll arrange for monthly payments of \$10. No hassles, no fuss.

EXAMPLE 10 *Gift.*

Our gift is already enclosed: a suncatcher to attach to your window. Send your order in and we'll send you another one. Free.

It is brutal, but the success of a letter can be seen by the number of responses it generates.

Here are some other ways to end with action:

- Free trial of the product.
- No obligation to buy.
- Higher earnings.
- Special price for a limited time.
- Join with others who already are satisfied.
- No salesperson will call.
- Names will not be sold to other firms.

In sum, writing effective and persuasive sales letters is difficult. Some letters may take weeks to perfect. But financial returns can be great. Good selling presents the benefits and the proposition in such a way that the readers become convinced and “sell themselves.” Achieving your goal requires careful editing and rewriting, but the results can well be worth the effort.

SUMMARY

Much business writing is routine; such writing occurs daily and is often in the direct-request format: deductive, up front—direct in stating a request. That organizational format is used more with more personal, routine requests for action.

Indirect organization is often used when the persuasive situation is more complex. Here the structure is similar to a bad-news message, giving more effort to the beginning of a message prior to asking for an action.

There are numerous kinds of persuasive requests, each using either the direct or indirect structure. Such structures are applicable to requests requiring time or personal contributions; requests about products or services; requests on claims and requests for adjustment; requests for changes in policy and performance; and requests from employer to a reference and employee to a reference.

Persuasive sales letters take time to compose and write. Of the two main types—solicited (the organization responds to a request) and unsolicited (the organization sends an uninvited request to buy a product or service)—the latter is more demanding to write. Using the AIDA formula (attention, interest, desire, action) is applicable here.

Useful checklists for all the above topics are found throughout this chapter.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises of an International Nature

1. **Request.** You are vice president of Kalends Consulting, Inc. You are planning a seminar to be held in New York City on May 1, 199-. The title of the seminar is *Swimming in Strange Waters: Dealing with National Environmental Legislation in International Business*. You want to invite Silvio Berlusconi, former Prime Minister of Italy, to be your keynote speaker. If he cannot do it, you intend to invite Werner Watchke, vice president of Mercedes Benz. You are acquainted with both men through work you have done for their companies in the United States. Write to each of these men. Write the *first paragraph only* of your message. How will you begin? What

organizational pattern will you choose for each of them? What kind of tone will you use?

- 2. Problem for Discussion.** Kevin Thompson is vice president of research and development for a small computer software firm, CompWare, Inc., headquartered in Phoenix, Arizona. He has traveled to Mexico City to negotiate a deal with a small Mexican firm, Inez CC LTD, that makes computer chips. Because CompWare wants to buy part of the Mexican company, the negotiations will take tact and finesse.

Kevin has done his homework on the Mexican company and knows that decisions are made more slowly than in the States and that the work pace is more leisurely. Meetings do not usually begin at the appointed hour, and long lunches and social outings are common in doing company business. Therefore, Kevin has planned a 2-week stay and has investigated some good restaurants where he might entertain company officials. For his first meeting with the vice president of development of Inez CC, Kevin thoughtfully arrives a half hour late.

Unfortunately, Guillermo Sepúlveda, the vice president of development for Inez, has also done his homework. So far, all the Americans he has done business with have been extremely time-conscious and wanted decisions made quickly. Therefore, he has already obtained authority from the president to discuss terms and to make the final decision for the deal in the first meeting. He has also, with some inconvenience, arrived at his office on time and has been waiting for Thompson for half an hour. He is somewhat annoyed because his expectations have not been met, and he is confused about why this American is so late.

Discuss the issues of miscommunication in this situation and how they affect the persuasion involved. Which party has the greater burden of persuasion? How should Kevin Thompson handle the situation?

Exercises of a General Nature

- 3. Persuasive Beginnings.** Write the *first sentence only* of a message in the following situations:
- To invite someone to chair a committee
 - To ask a publisher to consider a manuscript
 - To ask someone to complete a survey
 - To ask someone to renew a subscription to a magazine
 - To ask a French retailer to send you a catalog
- 4. Request for a Policy Change.** Discuss the persuasive strategies you would use in the following situations:
- To send a message to the *vice president of facilities* asking for a policy change in company parking to allow part-time workers to use the company parking lot

- b. To ask *company employees* to use another parking lot for 2 weeks in November because of a workshop being given at your place of business

5. **Request to Improve Performance.** At a friend's urging, you hired a young man, Darryl Jenkins, to be your secretary even though he did not have much experience and no recommendations. He has been with you a month, and unfortunately, he is not doing a very good job. He is consistently late for work in the morning and disappears for long periods during the day. The letters he has typed for you are full of errors. He does not seem to be comfortable with the computer, even though most of your company's internal communication is handled by E-mail. And finally, and most frustrating, he has never returned a project you have given him by the deadline. You have spoken with him about these problems, but they still persist. Write a letter to Darryl with the objective of motivating him to change his work habits.

6. **Request for Adjustment.** Several months ago, you bought a Brown-Rite toaster from a local retailer. After a month, the toaster stopped working properly, not browning the bread without toasting it several times. You returned the toaster but were told that you could only exchange it for another of the same kind. Therefore, you took a new toaster of the same kind and hoped for the best. Unfortunately, this toaster worked for only 3 weeks. You returned it again and asked for a refund, or at least an exchange for a different brand. You were told that you could only get another of the same kind. You took a third toaster home and tried it again. After a month, you had the same problem with this third toaster. By this time, you are frustrated and angry. The manager of the retail store will not give you a refund because of "policy," and neither will he let you exchange it for another brand. Write a letter to the president of this large department store asking for a full refund and anything else you think is appropriate for your inconvenience.

7. **Evaluate the Opening Paragraphs in the Following Claims Letters for Effectiveness.**

- a. In line with your policy on consumer satisfaction published in your recent catalog, I am requesting a cash refund of \$45.38 for a toaster I purchased 2 weeks ago for cash. The reason I have directed this request to your office is that your department manager said such a refund would not be possible. [Written to the adjustment department manager.]
- b. In the past year I have ordered nearly \$200 in goods from your store, by mail. Two weeks ago I came there in person and bought a gray overcoat. As I was heavily loaded with packages, I asked the clerk to send the garment to me by store delivery. When the overcoat arrived, I was busy and so I didn't open the package until 2 days ago.
- c. Never in my life have I been treated so rudely as I was the other day in your store, by two jerks you call employees. I tell you, the way I was in-

sulted gave me a good indication of what kind of people you're hiring these days. I'm so mad—I will never go back to your store again.

8. Evaluate the Following Letters for Tone, Organization, Clarity, Accuracy, and Effectiveness.

a. From a business firm in Detroit to an airfreight corporation in Pittsburgh:

Re your airbill #54663, we originally shipped this same amount of mdse. to Cincinnati UPS (United Parcel Service), got overnight delivery, and it cost only \$15. Now, your shipment from Cincinnati to us took over 15 days to get to us, and you want \$48.36. Now, if you want to rebill and charge ICC surface rates, we will pay you, but if you think 15-day delivery is air express . . . better check the rubber bands on your airplanes or start feeding those pigeons better.

b. From a landlord to apartment tenants:

It seems some of your typing late at night disturbs some tenants. Perhaps when all is quiet, it is easier to hear.

I was wondering if you type on the nook table—as that is bad because the table is fastened to the building. A felt pad will help if you do not already have one. The university bookstore has them just for that purpose.

I know your typing is very important to your schoolwork; however, I would like to keep everyone happy.

9. Letter—Incorrect Billing by Fast Freight Corp. You are the accounting department manager of Hanson's Flowers, a reputable florist. Today, April 5, you received a \$106.50 bill from Fast Freight Corporation, 947 Columbus Building, Indianapolis, IN 46288-3344. The bill shows two deliveries—airbills #18694 and #25479—unpaid since January 20 and February 9, respectively. You have canceled checks and invoices showing that both these shipments were paid when delivery was made. In fact, your firm always pays freight when it arrives. You resent the computerized statement across the bottom of today's bill: "THIS IS OUR FINAL REQUEST BEFORE REFERRING THIS TO A COLLECTION AGENCY. REMIT NOW." This is the first billing you have received. Your firm's general manager has decided that as of today he is switching to another airfreight company that is more careful in their bookkeeping. He says that any company this careless in keeping records probably is just as careless in handling freight. Write the general manager of Fast Freight Corporation after you have determined your purpose and what evidence you need to enclose with your message. Remember to use good judgment in the tone, organization, and content of your letter.

Capsule Checklists for Persuasive Requests*

A Persuasive Requests— General Plan	B Persuasive Requests for Favors	C Other Persuasive Requests for Adjustment, Credit, or Changes
1. Attention (<i>promise; start</i>) a. Introduction of relevant reader-benefit or reader-interest theme—centered on reader, not on writer's organization b. Envelopes and letterheads sometimes specially designed for the message	1. Attention a. Sincere compliment b. Questions c. Agreeable comment or assertion d. Basic problem e. What has been done about a problem f. Frank admission of a favor	1. Attention a. Preferably an agreeable assertion or a principle used as major premise b. Sincere compliment c. Question d. Basic problem e. Frank admission of a favor
2. Interest (<i>picture; chain</i>) a. Introduction of project, product, service, or problem; description; central selling point b. Appeals—direct or indirect reader benefits: appreciation, approval, beauty, cleanliness, comfort, convenience, cooperation, customer satisfaction, distinctiveness, durability, efficiency, enjoyment, entertainment, extra earnings, fair treatment, friendships, good reputation, health, improvement, love of home and others, money and other valuables, peace of mind, pleasure, popularity, position, profits, recognition, relief from fear, safety, satisfaction of helping others, savings, self-preservation, and others	2. Interest 3. Desire a. Necessary physical description of project b. Facts, figures, and reader benefits to convince reader that his or her contribution will be enjoyable, easy, important, beneficial—directly or indirectly (1) In request for speaker: date, day, hour; place; function; topic; talk length; audience size, interests; honorarium; expenses; special attractions; appeals (2) In requests for donation: problem; needs; past, present methods of meeting needs; costs; reader contribution; benefits; appeals (3) In request for cooperation: problem; facts, suggestions, committee, etc., to help meet goal; reader's part; benefits; appeals c. Positive handling of negatives and probable objections for favors that: (1) Require time, knowledge, or effort (2) Ask donations of money or other valuables (3) Urge cooperation on goals and projects d. Enclosures (brochures)	2. Interest 3. Desire a. All necessary facts and details pertaining to request for adjustment, credit, or changes in policy or performance—interwoven with reader benefits and appeals (as in A.2.b) b. Description as needed by the reader to see that his or her firm is responsible (if applicable) and that the request is factual, logical, and reasonable
3. Desire (<i>prove; chain</i>) a. Development of description, benefits, central selling point, request, appeals; perhaps with an enclosure b. Appropriate handling of possible objections c. Conviction (1) "Outside" proof; perhaps with enclosures (2) Price and terms when needed and appropriate; perhaps in enclosure		

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.

Capsule Checklists for Persuasive Requests (*Continued*) *

A	B	C
Persuasive Requests— General Plan	Persuasive Requests for Favors	Other Persuasive Requests for Adjustment, Credit, or Changes
4. Action (<i>push, hook</i>) a. CSAD [†] b. EA [‡] c. DA when desirable [§] d. Special inducement when desirable e. RB [¶] (often tied in with opening statement)	4. Action a. CSAD [†] b. EA [‡] c. DA when desirable [§] d. Special inducement when desirable e. RB [¶] (often tied in with opening statement)	4. Action a. Logical conclusion based on the major premise and the clearly stated facts; then same as B.4

*All lists include possible content. For any one message, choose only the pertinent and appropriate items.

[†]CSAD = clear statement of action desired.

[‡]EA = easy action.

[§]DA = dated action, if desirable.

[¶]RB = reader benefit.

Written Communication: Reports

Chapter 11 | Short Reports

Chapter 12 | Long (Formal) Reports

Chapter 13 | Proposals

Short Reports

I. Suggestions for Short Reports

- A. Developing the Main Sections
- B. Outlining the Major Sections
- C. Including Other Desirable Sections

II. Informational Memorandum Reports

- A. Conference Reports
- B. Progress Reports
- C. Periodic Reports

III. Analytical Memorandum Reports

- A. Steps in Preparing an Analytical Personnel Report
- B. Recommendation-Justification Reports

IV. Letter Reports—Informational and Analytical

- A. Informational Letter Reports
- B. Analytical Letter Reports

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

Short reports are both a bane and a blessing: Busy executives dislike the number of short reports, yet they like them because they are *short*. Even President Lincoln asked members of his cabinet to give him short written reports; then he could review their remarks—and weigh the options.

Short reports, then, inform and analyze; they are often presented in memorandum form. A short report is concise, accurate, unbiased, all inferences depending on supporting evidence to help readers make an informed decision. Chapter 6 is a general guide for planning and organizing effective business messages, regardless of their length. Short reports need less detailed introductions, numerous transitions, abundant visuals (see Appendix A), elaborate headings, involved appendixes, micro subdivisions, and excessive formality. Short reports therefore are often used in business communication; some are even sent via E-mail.

This chapter begins with basic suggestions for short reports: *developing* and *outlining* the main sections and noting other possible *inclusions*. Next is a discussion of the memorandum format for *informational* and *analytical* reports. The chapter ends with suggestions for the informative and analytical *letter report*.

SUGGESTIONS FOR SHORT REPORTS

Developing the Main Sections

As with oral communication, the short report includes an introduction, body (or discussion, or text), and terminal section (summary, conclusions, recommendations). Checklist 11.1 is an overview of those three sections.

Outlining the Major Sections

Report outlines may be the basis for headings within the report.

After you decide what the major sections of your report will be, devote time to your headings and subheadings. (Our comments here are also applicable to long reports, as explained in the following chapter.) Of course your outline will help you see the relationship between topics, enable you to compare proportions and headings, and let you check for loopholes and logical order. In organizing your outline, you must determine the types of headings, the degrees of headings, and the parallelism in the headings you will use.

Types of Headings

You can choose from *topic*, *complete sentence*, *imperative sentence*, or *variant* headings. Topic headings are the most commonly used.

Topic Headings

History

Background

Alternative

History of the
Problem

Background Issues

(Use nouns or short
phrases.)

■ Checklist 11.1 Developing the Main Sections of Short Reports

1. Introduction
 - a. Some of these elements (defined in Chapter 6) may be included if desirable: purpose or aim (always), authorization, sources, scope, definitions, background, limits, brief mention of results, list of topics (layout) to be discussed.
 - b. If a report's introductory elements are stated in one or two short paragraphs at the beginning, the title "Introduction" is usually omitted.
2. Body (discussion, text)
 - a. *Present all relevant facts accurately and impartially.* Do not let your personal feelings and prejudices affect the facts.
 - b. *Organize* your report by the inductive plan or the deductive plan; western businesspeople prefer the deductive method.
 - c. *Emphasize important ideas* by showing details, placing them in prominent positions (with the highest degrees of headings that are appropriate), and using stylistic means such as capitalization, underscoring, boldface, italics, more space, and repetition.
 - d. *Include visual aids*—graphs, tables, pictures—whenever they will help clarify information for your readers (or listeners).
 - e. *Use headings* to guide the reader through the report, but write your sentences and paragraphs so they can stand alone—as if the headings did not exist. In short reports use no more than two or three degrees (levels) of headings.
 - f. *Use topic sentences* for most paragraphs, and *use an introductory paragraph at the beginning of a major section* that contains two or more subdivisions.
 - g. *Apply the seven-C writing principles.* Throughout, make your writing easy to read. Use understandable words, sentences averaging 16 to 20 words in length, concrete nouns, few adverbs, few adjectives, and paragraphs whose average length is about seven typewritten lines.
3. Terminal section (summary, conclusions, recommendations)
 - a. Remember that *a summary condenses the text, conclusions evaluate and infer from the text, and recommendations offer specific courses of action.*
 - b. *Do not include any new material* in the terminal section of the report.
 - c. Usually *list summary points in the same order as topics are discussed in the text.*

Complete Sentence Heading	Alternative	
Preparation Is Essential When Outlining	Writers Should Take Time When Preparing for Outlining	(Include a subject and verb.)
Imperative Sentence Heading	Alternative	
Take Time to Outline	Prepare Ideas Before Writing	(Begin with a verb; subject can be omitted because "you" is understood.)
Variant Heading	Alternative	
Taking Time to Outline	Preparing Before Outlining	(Could begin with a participle.)

Formats of Outlines

After you determine the wording for your headings, next choose a way to show the degrees of importance for your ideas. Three options are available.

Numeral-letter combination is popular in businesses and schools. Less popular in U.S. businesses is the *decimal system*, occasionally favored by foreign companies and used in scientific and technical reports. The *letter-numerical combination* is used by those who prefer letters before main headings and do not need in their reports the additional degree that is possible with Roman numerals. Figure 11.1 shows three common ways to number heading degrees.

Some writers place their first-degree headings in the middle of the page: in capital letters, in boldface type. Others use different options. Your authors, for example, used a similar format when preparing the manuscript for this text:

First-Degree Headings
(Capital letters, placed at left margin)

Second-Degree Headings
(Bold, left margin, with prose beneath beginning at left margin)

Third-Degree Headings
(Indented, with prose beneath beginning at left margin)

Fourth-Degree Headings
(Indented and underlined, with prose beneath beginning on same line as fourth-degree heading)

Fifth-Degree Headings
(Indented, with prose beginning on same line as fifth-degree heading)

Numerals and letters are popular in U.S. reports.

Be consistent in heading format throughout the report.

	Degree of Heading	Numeral-Letter Combination	Decimal System	Letter-Numeral Combination
Introduction	1st	I.	1.0	A.
	2d	A.	1.1	1.
	2d	B.	1.2	2.
	1st	II.	2.0	B.
	2d	A.	2.1	1.
	3d	1.	2.11	a.
	3d	2.	2.12	b.
	2d	B.	2.2	2.
	3d	1.	2.21	a.
	3d	2.	2.22	b.
	4th	a.	2.221	(1)
	4th	b.	2.222	(2)
	5th	(1)	2.2221	(a)
	5th	(2)	2.2222	(b)
Text/ Discussion	1st	III.	3.0	C.
	2d	A.	3.1	1.
	3d	1.	3.11	a.
	3d	2.	3.12	b.
	2d	B.	3.2	2.
	3d	1.	3.21	a.
	3d	2.	3.22	b.
	1st	IV.	4.0	D.
	2d	A.	4.1	1.
	3d	1.	4.11	a.
	3d	2.	4.12	b.
	2d	B.	4.2	2.
	3d	1.	4.21	a.
	3d	2.	4.22	b.
Summary/ Conclusions/ Recommendations	1st	V.	5.0	E.
	2d	A.	5.1	1.
	2d	B.	5.2	2.

Figure 11.1 Three ways to indicate heading degrees in report outlines.

There is little magic in using the above scheme. What *is* important, however, is consistency. Once you select a scheme to indicate levels of topic importance, stay with that format throughout your report. (See Checklist 11.2.)

Parallelism in Headings

For parallel—and consistent—construction, all headings of the same degree within any part of an outline should be parallel to one another. That is, they should have the same grammatical form: all nouns, all phrases, or all clauses or sentences.

■ Checklist 11.2 Five Cautions Regarding Headings and Subheadings

- 1. Place the most important ideas in the highest degree of headings.
- 2. Try to balance the sections regarding the number of headings. For instance, if one section had nine subsections and another section had none, the proportion would be lopsided.
- 3. Have at least two subheadings if you divide any topic; for example, if you have A.1, you need A.2, never A.1 alone.
- 4. Use about three to seven main points in a report. Too many or too few could be annoying to the reader.
- 5. Avoid using the report title as a section heading.

Parallel (All Topic Headings—Phrases)	Parallel (All Imperative Sentence Headings)	Not Parallel (Topic, Variant, and Sentence Headings)
Kinds of headings	Choose heading types	Heading types
Formats of outlines	Select outline formats	Selecting outline formats
Purposes of report	Maintain current reports	Reports must be current

Including Other Desirable Sections

Many short reports are in memorandum format, the most-used form in internal business communication.

Often the short report is in memorandum form. Other forms may be a letter or a shortened form of a long report. Memorandum and letter reports often use a subject line, often restated in the introduction, before moving to the body of the report. A shortened formal report may have prefatory and supplementary parts as well. Visuals may also be used (see Appendix A), but too many may add unnecessary length to a short report.

Subject Line

Short, precise, subject lines often include a verb to give immediate sense of direction to the reader.

For directional clarity, consider adding a verb in the subject line. In so doing, you give the reader an immediate up-front sense of direction for the deductive, direct report. Some companies have a preprinted form for memorandums, in which little space is left for a subject line; they may therefore prefer a brief subject line, permitting the idea to be developed in the document. Contrast the following examples:

Brief Subject Line	More Complete Subject Line
Recent changes	Retirement age changes in Brazil's labor code [inform]
Intellectual property	Suggestions for informing Brazil's courts on matters of intellectual property rights [inform and analysis]

■ Communication Probe

Courses in report writing—rated highly by business graduates—are similar to, yet in some respects different from, the report writing requirements of other professionals. Let's face it: Not all business students enter the world of business; some will be professionals in other areas of work. One such area growing across the country is social work. Here is a "business" geared to helping people—a working environment aimed at improving the lives of others. Social workers, for instance, write many reports. Yet, the kind of reports demanded in their world of work is similar to the types discussed in this chapter: observational reports, interview reports, and summary projects. One researcher has concluded that three cautions are applicable to social workers: Avoid judgmental tone; decrease use of the passive; and use more parallelism. All these suggestions are also applicable to the report writer in the world of business.

Reep, D. C. (1989, March). Report writing for social workers: Special needs in the business communication course. *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication*, 52(1), 29–31.

Brief Subject Line

LEXIS services

Attrition

More Complete Subject Line

Recommended changes in our using company's
subscription to LEXIS services
[*analysis and persuasion*]

Report on employee turnover [*inform*]

Including some visual elements of a long report can improve the visual persuasion of a short report.

Prefatory and Supplemental Parts

In some situations a short, comprehensive, important memo report or letter report is more impressive if it has some of the prominent features of a long report. If your report is, for example, five or six single-spaced typewritten pages long and has several attachments, consider using a title page, a transmittal letter or memo, the report body (typed in single or double space), plus an appendix for the attachments. In the appendix put material that belongs in the report but would clutter the text and is not vital to its development or presentation.

Using Visuals

Often, the longer the report, the more visuals. However, if you have extensive statistics in a short report, some of that data may be clarified by using the traditional three types of charts: pie, bar, and line. (See Appendix A for a discussion of visuals and examples that illustrate their use in either written or oral communication.) Our suggestion is this: In a short report, use visuals sparingly. If you do use them, it is your choice whether to include them in the text proper or as supplementary material.

INFORMATIONAL MEMORANDUM REPORTS

The central purpose of informational reports is to inform and to summarize information, similar to the speech to inform (Chapter 15). Obviously, these reports vary widely in content, depending on type of business, purpose, topics discussed, and readers' needs. Although there are many kinds of informational reports, the following examples illustrate three general kinds often used in organizations: conference reports, progress reports, and periodic reports.

Conference Reports

Topics for conference reports range from summaries of personal sales call conferences to write-ups of meetings attended by hundreds of persons. For example, an advertising account executive may write a conference report (contact report) after every meeting or phone call between the ad agency and a client. Its purpose is to record all decisions and discussions. A credit or collection manager or account executive may make similar reports after conferences with clients. Likewise, many other employees as well as executives may be responsible for writing reports after any significant conferences with individuals or committees. *The text of such reports is usually organized by topics discussed or presented simply in a chronological progression.* Some firms have standardized headings for the often-written reports to ensure that the same information or main topics are recorded in all of them.

How you organize your material is closely related to your content; try to link content and form.

In Report 1, which follows, assistant sales manager arranges *by order of time*. This report—to the sales manager—uses first-, second-, and third-degree headings.

■ Communication Probe

Although this text focuses on three macro divisions of report writing (conference reports, progress reports, and periodic reports), it is still the memorandum and letter that carry the burden of written business communication. One study concluded that those two forms were the most used in on-the-job writing, followed by step-by-step instructions, general instructions, forms to be filled out, and proposals. Another study supports the memorandum-letter dominance, but suggests that reports within a bank, for instance, were of this nature: reports of telephone calls, memos requesting services or information, reports of investigations, reports about a prospective client, and others. We infer that the memorandum is heavily used as the major format for shorter reports.

Anderson, P. (1985). What survey research tells us about writing at work. In L. Odell & D. Goswami (eds.), *Writing in nonacademic settings* (pp. 3–83). New York: Guilford Press. Redish, J. (1989). Writing in organizations. In M. Kogen (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 97–124). Urbana, IL: National Council of Teachers of English.

MEMO REPORT 1 *Assistant sales manager's report on regional conference organized by topics.*

TO: Martha Cook DATE: April 10, 199-
FROM: Andrew Weichman SUBJECT: Report on Open
 Houses and XL
 Promotion
 Programs

The following is a report on the items we discussed during our April 10 meeting in [city] regarding our XL product. Topics pertain to the scheduled open houses and our promotional programs. The names of those who were asked and agreed to be responsible for the various parts of these plans are listed in the right-hand column below.

EVENTS AND PROGRESS

Open House

Here is the tentative schedule that was established for three events.

Employees' Meeting-Thursday, July 30. Ruth
Families will be invited and sandwiches April
and refreshments provided.

Ribbon-Cutting Ceremony-Friday,
July 31. Dignitaries to be invited need Jack
to be agreed upon. We generally agreed Donaldson
that this occasion presents an excep-
tional opportunity to publicize the
growth of new and nonpolluting industry
in our state. . .

Promotional Programs

The discussion regarding our Promotional Programs focused on two brochures, an advertising and direct-mail campaign, and identification signs.

The XL Product Brochure. After we Bill
reviewed this product brochure, rela- Campbell
tively minor changes were agreed upon.
Another draft will be sent to Bill
Campbell for approval before setting
type.

Introduction Brochure. We agreed Erick
that a brochure to familiarize our Brown
customers with the operation of the XL
will be desirable. We agreed that the

procedure used formerly in materials, showing photographs of the various personnel, will be a good approach. . .

SUMMARY

The following open houses have been tentatively scheduled for these dates: July 30-Employees' Meeting; July 31-Ribbon-Cutting Ceremony; and August 1-Distributor Event.

The promotional program is to include: a slightly changed XL product brochure, an introduction brochure, expanded advertising and direct mail, and special signs for XL products plus buildings and property. . .

c: Aprill, Brown, Campbell, Donaldson

MEMO REPORT 2 *A conference report organized by sources.*

TO: Dan Johns Date: October 16, 199-
FROM: Roy Weber
SUBJECT: Summary of Singapore Training Planning Conference

My attendance at the Singapore Training Conference took place over two days, September 12 and 13, at the Park View Hotel. Our format included presentations by each of the regional training directors followed by discussions. The following report summarizes the comments of the regional training directors.

Ms. Olive Reardon's Opening Statement

Ms. Reardon opened the conference, introduced the regional directors, and set the following goals for the meeting:

1. Determine the needs assessments of employees from each of the regions produced.
2. List suggestions for which new courses now on the market would meet those needs.
3. Get information from the United States as to which of their courses might fit into our Asian culture and our individual subsidiaries.

Mr. T.K. Lam's Report

Representing Korea, Mr. Lam handed out a printed report of his employee needs assessment. . . . He concluded with suggestions for new courses to meet the needs expressed by employees in his country.

[Additional statistical data presented along with course listings.]

Ms. Charlotte Lim's Report

Ms. Lim indicated that she has previously sent her report concerning Hong Kong in advance and thus had only new course suggestions to make.

[A listing of the three new courses followed.]

Ms. Olive Reardon

After discussions, Ms. Reardon concluded the sessions with a plan of action which could be followed for the next six months:

[Included was a listing of six suggestions.]

Progress Reports

Most progress reports move inductively, via the organizational structure of what is topical or chronological.

As the name implies, progress reports show "progress," accomplishments, or activity over time or at a given stage of a major assignment. The organizational plan is usually inductive, including topics similar to these:

- Introduction (purpose, nature of project)
- Description of accomplishments during the reporting period
- Unanticipated problems (if any)
- Plans for the next reporting period
- Summary (overall appraisal of progress to date)

Following is a report submitted on behalf of the chairperson of a governmental committee asked to investigate what the position of the United States should be regarding high-definition television (HDTV). The committee simply supplies information and concludes without offering a recommendation. In short, the report is informative, using second-, third-, and fourth-degree headings.

MEMO REPORT 3 *An inductive report [shortened example].*

Date: 16 July 199-

TO: Carl Fornell, Vice President
 FROM: Shirley Adams, Chairperson
 SUBJECT: Progress report on options that the U.S. government might consider for HDTV (high-definition television)

On behalf of the HDTV committee we present this progress report on the question: What should the U.S. policy be regarding the future of HDTV?

Background and History

Development of HDTV began in Japan over 20 years ago as a joint effort between NHK (Japan Broadcast Corporation), Sony, Panasonic, and Ikegami. Their intent was to increase the number of lines of reso-

lution to 1.125, a system incompatible with the U.S. system. . .

Europe sought to improve transmission using existing TV systems and decided to develop HDTV over time. Their approach was to use the Multiplex Analog Converter (MAC) compatible with existing television sets. . .

Possible Influence of HDTV on the U.S. Economy

The issue of U.S. participation in the HDTV market has attracted the attention of U.S. policy makers, broadcasters, and electronic companies for two reasons:

Technological issues

1. HDTV-related integrated circuits
[details and statistics]
2. Large picture displays
[details and statistics]
3. New manufacturing technologies
[details and statistics]
4. Broadband switching technologies
[details and statistics]

Commercial and trade issues

Options Available to the United States

United States policy makers have a high-tech dilemma on their hands. Many electronic industry analysts think HDTV will be to the nineties what computers were to the eighties. Thus, a central question is, which system should the States use and begin developing?

Foreign standards

1. The Japanese system . . .
2. The European system . . .

U.S. standards

Evaluation of U.S. Options

1. Develop its own American-based technology via a consortium

Considering many criteria, one of the options available to the United States is to develop a

consortium of companies that already produce high-quality electronic products. Such a "helping hand" allows a pooling of money and resources. . . .

2. Adopt foreign standards

To not develop a system in the States will allow foreign nations to determine the future direction of HDTV, and thereby to remove jobs from the United States. To accept a foreign pattern would increase the speed of development in the United States. The decision involves viewing either the Japanese or European models

3. Do nothing

According to researchers, HDTV will revolutionize the electronic industry. And following this pattern will decrease the amount of up-front funds needed for research and development. . . .

Summary

Our report began with viewing the history and background of HDTV. Out of that history arose implications for U.S. industries and their effect on four commercial areas. Of course the question to be answered is this: Which of several transmission systems should the United States adopt? We viewed the major foreign standards and considered standards suggested by the Americans, the Japanese, and the Europeans. . . . We conclude our task by noting that we have simply informed; the ultimate direction for U.S. participation in HDTV is left up to the policy committee.

Periodic Reports

Periodic reports are as numerous as there are business organizations; it is more important to know what they do rather than what they are called.

Some periodic reports are written to correspond to the company's fiscal year. Others may be written weekly, monthly, quarterly, or annually, or in other regular recurring periods.

When a memorandum report is written each month about the same department and to the same readers, an introduction and terminal section are unnecessary. Many business firms use printed forms and standardized headings for the text section of such reports.

One company's chief executive officer—who shall remain nameless—insisted that all foreign subsidiaries reporting to the home office in the States limit their quarterly report to *one page*. In fact, the report could be done in half a page if the news was favorable; if unfavorable, one page. And then writers were to include only the reasons for the unfavorable situation and the way it was being handled.

Most organizations—business, government, religious, athletic, and even business schools—write annual reports to summarize activities and financial af-

■ Communication Probe

A key word today in writing is the term *collaborative*. Even though no definition is accepted unanimously, the process may involve planning the document and peer review before and during the construction of a manuscript. The end product should result in a document produced by a group of individuals. Although much of one's writing is solo, suggestions for producing reports—and the kind of reports—apply as well to work produced collaboratively. Research suggests that as many as 74 percent of technical and professional writers worked collaboratively, and as many as 87 percent of writers in a workplace concluded that they sometimes wrote collaboratively. Therefore, collaborative writing plays a role in producing a report.

Faigley, L., & Miller, T.P. (1982). What we learn from writing on the job. *College English*, 44, 557–569. Ede, L., & Lunsford, A. (1986). Collaborative learning: Lessons from the world of work. *Journal of the Council of Writing Program Administrators*, 9, 3, 20.

fairs. For some small concerns the report is exceptionally short, consisting of perhaps a brief transmitted letter with one or two pages of financial statements. For other organizations, especially corporations that must report to their stockholders, the annual report may begin with a top official's letter report. Sometimes the letter is the entire report (perhaps eight or more pages). If not, then the report body discusses operations and activities. Checklist 11.3 gives general guidelines for preparing informational reports.

■ Checklist 11.3 Informational Reports

1. Be aware of the purpose: Determine whether the person requesting your report wants to make the decision or a recommendation from you.
 - a. You offer no recommendation.
 - b. You offer a recommendation.
2. Know how to conclude: Ask yourself: Will I simply summarize (a review of what was covered), or will I end with judgments, conclusions (inferences from the presented data)?
 - a. You summarize.
 - b. You conclude.
3. Use neutral, unbiased language: Is your language nonjudgmental, or does it betray a firm point of view?
 - a. You are neutral in word choice.
 - b. You choose persuasive words, sentences.

ANALYTICAL MEMORANDUM REPORTS

A pure analytical report has one central purpose: To analyze a situation or issue.

Informational memorandum reports search out and make known to the reader data and evidence. Those reports clarify; they try to omit a recommendation. An analytical memorandum report, now to be discussed, seeks to analyze a situation or problem; it may end with or without a specific recommendation. Our following detailed discussion suggests a step-by-step analysis of a personnel situation, ending with a conclusion without a recommendation. Thereafter, three ways of organizing a recommendation-justification report are illustrated.

Steps in Preparing an Analytical Personnel Report

The Helen True case is illustrative of the genre of most analytical reports: Analyze, analyze, analyze. Then know the wishes of the report requester: Does he or she desire a recommendation or not?

Assume that Gene Mohr, manager of your bank's head office savings department, has asked you (assistant manager of the personnel department) to help find a replacement for a teller who is quitting work and moving to another city. Fifteen people applied for the job. Ultimately, you narrowed your list to the five best applicants. Then you wrote to their references for recommendations. After receiving the replies, you chose the three best-qualified candidates. Your task now is to evaluate each of the three in a memo report to Mr. Mohr. He likes you to analyze the facts for him—and rank the applicants—but he wants to make his own recommendations and decision. Here are the facts about the three applicants:

Helen True: One year of business college; high school graduate with a 3.0 (out of a possible 4.0) grade-point average; completed in high school an office machines course with a grade of B; typing, 60 words per minute; arithmetic aptitude, excellent; neatly groomed for business appearance; excellent references—"highly dependable, courteous, and honest"; excellent health; 11 years of business experience—all with one company.

James Mace: High school graduate with a 2.6 GPA; completed in high school an office machines course with a grade of C; typing, 50 wpm; arithmetic aptitude, good; fairly neat and well-groomed; good references—"dependable, tactful"; good health; 6 years of business experience with two different firms; two years' military service.

Beth Astor: One year at the local four-year university, with a 3.1 GPA; high school graduate with a 3.2 GPA; completed in high school an office machines course with a grade of A; typing, 65 wpm; arithmetic aptitude, excellent; very neat, well-groomed; references—"good worker but has difficulty getting along with others"; fair health; 3 years' business experience with three different firms; attendance irregular in 2.

With all these figures facing you, where do you begin? One way is to group these facts under headings representing the *criteria* (Chapter 10) you will be using to measure the three people's qualifications. Notice that if you merely group them by their names as in the above list, comparisons are difficult. After some juggling, you decide that all the data fall under the headings of "Education and Skills," "Personal Qualifications," or "Probable Permanency with Bank." (Many times, when organizing, you have material that could fit under more than

■ Communication Probe

As an adjunct to justification, persuasive writing, it is interesting to note that when asked to defend their positions orally, men displayed a more argumentative attitude than women. That is, based on gender, females were less prone to advocate positions on controversial issues or verbally attack others. Furthermore, in a related study (Infante and Gorden, 1985), this same predisposition toward argumentativeness was perceived favorably by both superiors and subordinates: the perceived credibility of the individual in the workplace increased.

Darus, H. J. (1994, June). Argumentativeness in the workplace: A trait by situation study. *Communication Research Reports*, 11(1), 99–106. See also Infante, D. A., & Gorden, W. I. (1985). Superiors' argumentativeness and verbal argumentativeness and verbal aggressiveness as predictors of subordinates' satisfaction. *Human Communication Research*, 12, 117–125.

one heading: Health is an example. So you organize such material the best way you can; in this report it can fit under "Personal Qualifications" or "Probable Permanency with Firm.") You can now arrange the backgrounds of the three applicants in a working table like the following, in rough-draft form:

	True	Mace	Astor
Education and Skills			
Education	High school graduate 1 year business college	High school graduate	High school graduate 1 year at university
Grade point	3.0	2.6	3.2 in high school 3.1 at university
Arithmetic aptitude	Excellent	Good	Excellent
Typing	60 wpm	50 wpm	65 wpm
High school grade in machines	Grade B	Grade C	Grade A
Personal Qualifications			
Appearance	Neat and well-groomed	Fairly neat; well-groomed	Very neat and well-groomed
Dependability	Excellent	Good	Fair; but good worker
Compatibility	Excellent	Good	Fair; difficulty working with others

Probable Permanency with Bank			
Number of jobs	1	2	3
Years of work	11	6 plus 2 military	3
Health	Excellent	Good	Fair
Attendance record	Excellent	Good	Fair (irregular in two firms)

Now you can begin to analyze and interpret the material. Suppose your interpretation results in the following ranks and points for these candidates (assuming you decide to assign 6 points for first place, 4 points for second place, and 2 points for third place):

Criterion	True		Mace		Astor	
	Rank	Points	Rank	Points	Rank	Points
Education and skills	2	4	3	2	1	6
Personal qualifications	1	6	2	4	3	2
Probable permanency	1	6	2	4	3	2
Total score		16		10		10

From this analysis Helen True wins first place, and although Mace and Astor are tied for second place in scores, it is obvious that Mace is ahead of Astor in two of three criteria. Thus he wins second place, and Astor third.

Your next step will be to write the report, in rough draft. Then you will edit it and revise wherever desirable. You will use the inductive organizational plan because Mr. Mohr told you he preferred that plan for all memo reports.

With that groundwork completed, you begin to write—first the *subject line*, which should contain no more than five to seven words, preferably. You decide on “Evaluation of Three Teller Applicants.” Then you write the introduction, next the major divisions of the text, and finally the terminal section.

Introduction

The following list of introductory elements could be included in this particular report:

Element	Comment
Authorization	Mr. Mohr asked you to assume the assignment.
Purpose	To evaluate the three applicants' qualifications for one opening as teller.
Background	From 15 applicants you selected 3.
Methodology sources	You used application blanks, test scores, your own interview notes, and recommendations from references.
Plan of presentation	You will develop the text according to the three criteria for a teller.

Brief statement of
your decision

Optional. You may tell Mr. Mohr that Ms. True ranks highest of the three candidates, or wait to tell this in the terminal section. Your choice will depend on what you think Mr. Mohr prefers.

When you put these five elements into words and sentences, you might have an introductory paragraph such as one of the following:

On July 25 you asked that I prepare an evaluation of candidates for the position of your retiring teller. That analysis is complete, and the following report is my response. On the basis of four criteria (company test scores, screening of initial applications, personal interview with each applicant, and recommendations from references), 3 candidates have been chosen from the 15 who applied. In evaluating the candidates, I have placed major emphasis on (1) education and skills, (2) personal qualifications, and (3) probable permanency. In view of my analysis, Ms. True ranks high for consideration.

[For the reader who will resist your deductively stated decision, you may wish to move inductively, as in the following:]

Following these opening comments is the report you requested on July 25 concerning the evaluation of candidates for a teller as a replacement for the employee who is resigning. Four criteria were used in selecting the final candidates: company test scores, screening of initial applicants, personal interview with each candidate, and recommendations from references. Three of the fifteen applicants met these criteria: Ms. Helen True, Mr. James Mace, and Miss Beth Astor. Additionally, on the basis of their education and skills, personal qualifications, and probable permanency, these names come to you for consideration as probable employees with our bank.

Main Divisions of the Body or Text

You will use three main sections for your text—one for each criterion. You will study the working table and analyze the facts. If your reader wants all the details, you will include each table section or a variation of it within the text. Assume that you now decide to change the sequence of the sections within the table. “Probable Permanency” will be placed first; “Education and Skills,” second; “Personal Qualifications,” third.

The following discussion concentrates on the section labeled “Probable Permanency.” Your procedure for the other two sections will of course be similar. What are the most important facts you can pull from the table? Avoid saying in sentence form before or after a table everything that is already in the table; repe-